

**THE SECOND LANGUAGE LITERACY PROCESS  
IN THE LANGUAGE ARTS/LITERATURE CLASSROOM:  
A SOCIOCULTURAL CONSTRUCTIVIST PERSPECTIVE**

**BY**

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Requirements for the Degree of

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## DEDICATION

For English Language Learners

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**ABSTRACT**

English language learners (ELLs) develop second language literacy by engaging in meaningful tasks. I investigate second language learners' literacy processes, focusing on meaning construction in literacy activities and on teacher and peer interactions. I suggest how learning a second language can be improved, not only by dialoguing among texts, learners, and social contexts, but also by focusing on literacy in the language arts/literature class. Also, I explore what strategies second language learners use to engage in literacy.

This research was conducted in a language arts/literature classroom at an elementary school. Three 2<sup>nd</sup> graders and one 3<sup>rd</sup> grader who learned English as a second language participated. The study included observations, interviews, documents, and reports using the verbal protocol. Three avenues of data analysis obtained a rich and cohesive analysis, and resulted in an understanding of the second language literacy development process.

Four cases of data collected from October 2003 through December 2004 indicated measures of development, portraying the second language learning processes ethnographically and indicating influential factors for ELLs' learning processes with a

holistic view. Ethnographic viewpoints allowed us to see their genre of life. The verbal protocol showed us how ELLs' thinking processes occur while making meaning . ELLs use strategies differently depending on the materials at hand, the level of the task, their language proficiency, and their cultural orientation. They also use their strategies differently depending on the cultural relevance of the stories. Twelve strategies emerged from the data. Two main themes from qualitative research described how ELLs' second language literacy process occurred and was meaningful in engaging literacy with the text.

There are three implications for educators. First, through what I call the ethnocentric filter system, which filters new information based on the learner's ethnocentrism and ethnic identity, ELLs integrate ethnic identity and ethnocentrism into the meaning-making processes. Second, responses to reading literacy showed insight into how to utilize various materials such as culturally relevant and nonculturally relevant stories. Third, second language literacy development included reading processes in oral language development. Hopefully, educators will better understand ELLs' lives and second language development processes to create better curricula for them. Also this study might be integrated into creation of appropriate reading strategy instruction.

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## CHAPTER 1

### INTRODUCTION

The increase in the number of students of cultural and linguistic diversity in the United States has placed tremendous demands on schools and curricula and has pedagogically challenged teachers. The persistently high failure and dropout rates among these students are also clear (National Center for Educational Statistics [NCES], 1997). For example, the NCES's (2000) report on dropout rates and the number and distribution of 16- through 24-year-old dropouts by background characteristics showed a 44.2 % dropout rate among recently immigrated Hispanic students (those who were born outside the 50 states and the District of Columbia). They can be assumed to be an example of English as a second language (ESL) learners in this study. Literacy ability is the most important part of the second language learners' academic success; literacy ability also grants empowerment to those who are a minority in the United States to become active social beings in society. Because the second language learners are at the center of these public education issues and because these students are significantly different from first language learners in many ways, understanding the ESL learners' literacy development process will facilitate the provision of not only curricula but also effective teaching methods and strategies.

We as educators need to be aware of what happens now to the second language learners from culturally and linguistically diverse backgrounds who study in the school context. As we try to understand and approach them in a proper way, we can assist them

in developing their literacy skills for their academic and social success in a social context by exploring their language development process.

Learning a second language involves learning four types of language skills: listening, speaking, reading, and writing. English language learners (ELLs) themselves feel culturally and linguistically alienated in school contexts and struggle with the power of language in the classroom as a social setting. Establishing academic success and empowerment based on their literacy ability in school contexts is a crucial factor for second language learners in developing their self-identity in the school context.

Some research calls for students to be active participants in a learning community (Gutierrez, 1995), for bilingual students to be involved in book writing projects (Langer, 1997), and for separate challenging programs for the lowest achieving ELLs (Walsh, 1999). Such research provides important ideas for understanding ELLs and providing effective programs for them. However, without understanding ELLs' literacy development process in a deeper way, we as educators cannot assist them in an efficient and effective way.

While reading these research studies, I became interested in exploring the second language literacy development process in the classroom as a natural setting. Literacy is a fundamental tool for communication, negotiation, and constructing meaning in context. The understanding of the literacy development process is very important in assisting second language learners in their adjustment as well as their successful academic achievement in their new society and community.

Literacy is a complex phenomenon (Holdaway, 1997), and when considering literacy teaching and learning, researchers and educators should take into account the

nature and uses of language (Chomsky, 1965), interpersonal and intrapersonal relations (Bakhtin, 1986), sociocultural differences (John-Steiner & Mahn, 1996; Perez, 1998; Vygotsky, 1978), learning in general, and the learning of young children (Goodman, Y., 1980; Smith, 1997). There are different approaches to the investigation of the nature of literacy, such as the psycholinguistic approach (Vygotsky, 1986), the sociolinguistic approach (Halliday, 1978), and literacy reading theory (Pearson & Stephens, 1992). These perspectives have been influenced by the philosophies and studies dominating the historical context in which each model developed. A huge literacy mountain range has been developed by linking each literacy mountain to the others above it.

### My Literacy Focus

Recently, in order to gain a deeper understanding of the second language learner's literacy development process in a social context, the sociocultural constructivist theoretical framework has been elaborated upon and illuminated. Knowledge is not an individual tenure but is socially shared and emerges from participation in cultural activities, from the sociocultural perspectives (Cole, 1991). Tobin and Tippins (as cited in Windschitl, 2000) said, "scholars have synthesized the cognitive and sociocultural constructivist perspectives, claiming that knowledge is personally constructed and socially mediated" (p. 104).

*Literacy* has been defined as "the ability and the willingness to use reading and writing to construct meaning from printed text, in ways that meet the requirements of a particular social context" (Au, 1993, p. 20). In addition to this formal definition, we as educators may meet various definitions of literacy from the traditional views to current multiple definitions of literacy.

For a greater understanding of the situation under discussion, I am extending the definition of literacy from the printed text to include the transaction between the reader, the text, and the social context simultaneously in this study. Literacy may be considered as *meaning making* (Goodman, K., 1984) or *dialogue* (Bakhtin, 1986), as we need multiple perspectives to develop deep discourse; a single lens or stance for the reading and writing processes is not sufficient to explain the total process involved in second language literacy.

### Purpose of the Study

The purpose of this study is to investigate second language learners' literacy development processes from a sociocultural constructivist perspective. The focus is on meaning construction in literacy activities and on interactions or dialogue with teachers and peers in the classroom as a social context. My goal is to understand how learning a second language can be improved not only by interacting and dialoguing among learners, texts, and social contexts, but also by focusing on literacy within one content area, the language arts/literature classroom, rather than within the ESL classroom. I examine the effectiveness of integrating language and content in teaching ESL by exploring the language arts/literature classroom as a relevant content area. Also, I explore what strategies second language learners use while they are engaging in literacy.

I consider how second language readers construct meaning in dialogue or a reading context from the perspective of meaning construction among the readers, the text, and the social context (Halliday, 1978). Readers in the construction process use the relationships between meaning making, interpretation, and transaction as they dialogue by themselves, with texts, and in social contexts. At this point, as second language



learners interact or cooperate with peers and teachers in the classes within the *zone of proximal development* (ZPD) as a critical distance (Vygotsky, 1986), they can conceivably develop their second language efficiently and effectively. Also, reading and writing in content areas is considered a powerful way to teach the second language in the classroom (Richard-Amato & Snow, 1992; Snow, M. A. & Briton, 1997). Relevant research in this area suggests that second language learners are able to develop their second language naturally and spontaneously while they are involved in reading and writing activities (Richard-Amato, 1996).

### Research Questions

Based on my tacit knowledge and on formative theories (LeCompte, 2000), I address the process of second language literacy development by exploring the following research question:

What is the learning process involved in second language literacy development of English language learners in their language arts/literature class in an elementary school setting?

The following three subquestions further enabled me to answer this main question:

1. How do English language learners move toward literacy in English as a second language in the language arts/literature class?
2. What strategies do English language learners use while reading stories?
3. How do English language learners interact with their teacher and peers in acquiring their literacy skills in the language arts/literature class?

## Theoretical Framework

### *Sociocultural Constructivism*

My theoretical framework for exploring second language literacy development is based on sociocultural constructivism (Halliday, 1985; Vygotsky, 1978). Sociocultural constructivism is developed from constructivism. Generally speaking, constructivism includes cognitive constructivism (Bruner, 1990; Piaget, 1979) and sociocultural constructivism (Halliday, 1985; Vygotsky, 1986).

Constructivism is based on the individual developmental process. In the constructivist view, meaning making is based on the individual; learners make sense out of what they already know (Schallert & Martin, 2003; Windschitl, 2000). Learning language and literacy comes from what the learner can put together in response to his or her learning and reading processes. The learner constructs meaning and understands ideas or things through his or her own process. Thus, the essential view of the constructivist perspective is an individual's meaning construction. In this view, to construct meaning is to build a new idea or concept from one's knowledge.

Piaget (1979) explored constructivism based on a learner's developmental process; one of the major ideas connected with cognitive constructivism is that meaning is rooted in and indexed by personal experiences. To Piaget, the processes of learning and mental development are independent of each other. Cognitive constructivist research and practice as described is mostly oriented toward understanding the individual learner.

Learners are constructing meaning both from their own past experience and from interaction with others within a social context (Windschitl, 2000). With guidance,

learners develop and exchange meaning with teachers or peers to make sense of what has happened.

Thus, learners can develop their language and literacy by themselves and through interaction with others. They receive new information and help for developing their language and literacy as a result of growing up with other people and within social contexts. Their language and literacy will be developed through interaction with others within a particular context. Learners are not only constructing meaning; they are also associating with it. The learners negotiate meaning about what is going to take place.

Cobb (1994) asserted that sociocultural constructivism and sociocultural learning describe how knowledge has social and cultural as well as individual components and how these components cannot be viewed as separate in any meaningful way. This view states that meaning making is constructed in the social context and is constructed out of what an individual learns in all the cultures in which he or she participates. Sociocultural constructivism places emphasis on how the individual is influenced or how learners can describe learning from the perspective that the individual is influenced by the social environment.

More specifically, “individuals construct knowledge in the presence of others who both constrain and enrich the environment through the use of tools such as language conventions and accepted practices for creating and judging knowledge” (Windschitl, 2000, p. 99). There is a natural connection from a constructivist to a sociocultural constructivist perspective by way of the assertion that language can be interpreted only in terms of the context in which it occurs.

My focus from the sociocultural constructivist viewpoint is on how an individual and the groups in which the individual participates influence the meaning making that takes place. Au (1993) found that from sociocultural constructivist instruction, children can be provided scaffolding (Cadzen, 1988; Gibbons, 2002) by the teacher while the learner is engaged in a meaningful task. Nieto (1999) explained the sociocultural perspective on learning and education as follows: “Learning develops primarily from social relationships and the actions of individuals that take place within particular . . . contexts” (p. 2). According to Vygotsky (1978), the way in which this takes place is that the learner is always engaged in interactions with others, and the internalization process is supported by the other people around the learner. The internalization process is quite personally constructed. I consider the internalization as an “Aha” moment when the learner has made the content his or her own. It also reflects the learner’s own meaning making and interpretations.

A sociocultural constructivist perspective involves a detailed analysis of the conversations that are taking place, of all the students in the learning situation, and of all they are bringing to the situation. The focus of attention might be the learner, but it always begins by situating the learning in the sociocultural context.

Indeed, “it is the cultural situatedness of meanings that assures their negotiability and their communicability” (Bruner, 1996, p. 3). Recently, in order to gain a deeper understanding of the second language learner’s development process in literacy in a social context, the sociocultural constructivist theoretical framework has been elaborated upon and illuminated. Within the sociocultural perspectives, knowledge is personally constructed and socially enriched.

### *Development: The Sociocultural Constructivist Perspective*

For understanding *development* in my study, I use Vygotsky's (1978) paradigm of a genetic foundation for understanding literacy development as a mental process as well as dynamic changes. Blanck (1990) termed Vygotsky's psychology *genetic*, in the developmental sense. The term genetic can be captured only through studying its origin and development. Blanck explained the internalization as a process using Leontev's (1978) idea that "the internalization process is not simply the transferal of an external activity to a preexisting internal stage of consciousness but the process through which said internal stage is formed" (p. 47). My focus is on the second language literacy development process that occurs when students are participating or engaging in literacy events.

In mental processes that I term *development*, Vygotsky (1978) considered the individual's social and cultural evolution and ontogenic development. Children develop their attention, perception, and language ability from the low mental process that is natural to the high mental process through interaction with adults or peers in the sociocultural context. After affirming the social, cultural, and historical nature of the higher mental processes, Vygotsky studied a developmental process as ontogenic, evolving its dynamic changes of the individual's social and cultural evolution in education (Moll, 1990).

### *Sociocultural Perspectives in Literacy*

Literacy is defined not just as the multifaceted act of reading, writing, and thinking, but as constructing meaning from printed text within a sociocultural context (Erickson, 1984; Gee, 1992; Snow, C. E., 1983). According to Perez (1998),

“Understanding literacy as the construction of meaning within a sociocultural context attempts to account for aim, purpose, audience, text, and the context in which reading and writing occur” (p. 4).

Sociocultural perspectives of literacy (Heath, 1986, 1992; Moll, 1992) argue that writing, reading, and language are not isolated and decontextualized; nor are they generalized skills separate from specific contents, contexts, and social-communicative purposes. Rather, there are multiple literacies (Scribner & Cole, as cited in Perez, 1998, p. 23). Literacy expands as a kind of value system for communication and interaction for specific purposes within sociocultural perspectives.

Literacy practices are culture-specific ways of knowing. Literacy is defined in as a set of social activities involving written language in terms of its function and context, that is, the ways that people use literacy to achieve their goals in a variety of sociocultural contexts (Gee & Heath, as cited in Perez, 1998, p. 22). Within an overall sociocultural approach to literacy, learning to read and write are constituted as acts of knowing, reflected as values, or situated as discourse within a given cultural and social context.

Sociocultural constructivist approaches to literacy instruction include the process approach to writing (Graves, 1994), literature-based instruction (Morrow & Gambrell, 2000; Raphaël & Au, 1998; Richard-Amato & Snow, 1992), *whole language* (Freeman & Freeman, 1997; Goodman, K., 1986), and balanced literacy instruction (Au, 2003). These approaches and philosophies are consistent with a sociocultural constructivist paradigm (Au, 2003). The popular term whole language derives at least partly from a concern for keeping language whole and in the context of functional use (Goodman, K. & Goodman, 1990). The whole-language approach for teaching reading and writing is illuminated as a

natural process (Goodman, K. & Goodman, 1990). Goodman, Y. (1980) believed that children learn or acquire literacy naturally in a meaningful context. Goodman described language development as

natural whether written or oral. It develops in a social setting because of the human need to communicate and interact with the significant others in the culture. It develops in response to the creative, active participation of the individual trying to understand and make sense out of the world in which he or she is growing.  
(p. 3)

Learners can internalize literacy skills and knowledge through social interaction as a natural process in a meaningful social setting. This process requires a degree of engagement between learners and literacy events.

I also use the word *engagement* in terms of readers' emotional experiences being central to their literacy experience in this study. Emotional engagement in the literacy events is reflected in readers' responses, as they become engaged or involved in the fictional world as distinct from their own (Britton, 1970). Other studies have explored readers' willingness to seek out texts and judge characters positively (Thomson, 1987). Researchers have explored how engagement is related to story understanding and liking (Beach & Hynds, 1996). Engagement within literacy events is explored as the *degree of dialogue* (Bakhtin, 1986) with the texts and within the social contexts in this study.

#### *Sociocultural Constructivist Perspectives in Second Language Literacy*

Whether ELLs have developed fluency in their native language or not, encouraging and allowing children to access their cultural and linguistic knowledge and skills in school literacy tasks will facilitate the process of becoming literate in English (Au, 1993; Perez & Torres-Guzman, as cited in Perez, 1998, p. 26). Language and

literacy are socially constructed; that is, language and literacy users construct and interpret the meaning of language within social interactions (Wells, 1986).

At this point, as ELLs interact or cooperate with peers and teachers in classes within the ZPD (Vygotsky, 1978) as a critical distance, they develop their second language effectively. Also, reading and writing in content areas is considered a powerful way to teach the second language in the classroom (Richard-Amato & Snow, 1992; Snow, M. A. & Briton, 1997). When ELLs are involved in reading and writing activities, they are able to develop their second language literacy in a meaningful context (Richard-Amato, 1996).

In sociocultural constructivism, Vygotsky (1978) defined the ZPD as “the distance between the actual developmental level as determined by independent problem solving and the level of potential development as determined through problem solving under adult guidance or in collaboration with more capable peers” (p. 86). Gallimore and Tharp (as cited in Moll, 1990, p. 184) advocated that “teaching can be said to occur when assistance is offered at points in the ZPD at which performance requires assistance.” Teachers or peers can help ELLs via guidance through dialoguing with them during literacy events. Various theories and methods for understanding and assisting second language literacy development are explored. Strategies for developing second language and literacy are also emphasized.

Cadzen (1988) and Gibbons (2002) explored *scaffolding* as a teaching strategy for ELLs based on the ZPD. Gibbons explored *scaffolding* as the “temporary, but essential, nature of the mentor’s assistance in supporting learners to carry out tasks successfully” (p. 10). John-Steiner and Mahn (1996) developed *collaboration learning* from



Vygotsky's idea in a classroom setting. K. Goodman (1986, 2003) also explored the whole-language approach for developing the second language as a natural process, based on sociocultural constructivism.

Literacy practice through subject matter is a useful method; as an ELL naturally tries to understand and engage in reading literacy through the meaning construction process. According to M. A. Snow (1992), "For young children, cognitive development and language development go hand in hand. Language is a tool through which the child comes to understand the world" (p. 27). As ELLs learn by engaging in reading activities in content areas, they can improve not only their comprehension and meaning construction but also their English. ELLs can get comprehensible input (Krashen, 1985) in content and learn English as a means to study subjects. I explore teaching ESL in the content area of the language arts/literature class as a setting for deeper interaction and language development.

### Significance of the Study

Investigating ELLs' literacy development as a learning process will provide insight for educators to assist ELLs in the classroom as a social context. Also, the findings of the study encourage teachers to explore new methods or strategies for teaching ELLs to enhance their curriculum. The results of the investigation of reading strategies via verbal protocols will support teachers in integrating the findings into effective reading instruction. The results of the study will support teachers in creating cognitive strategy instruction.

This investigation of ELLs' second language literacy development could help teachers understand ELLs and guide teachers in approaching them in an efficient and

effective way. Material selection, including culturally and nonculturally relevant materials, should be coordinated to create a proper curriculum. Understanding the variability of ELLs will provide teachers with insight. Especially, the findings of the study show that children from East Asia have a strong ethnic identity. Examining their *ethnocentric filter system*, which I identified through the study, will provide ways to approach these children to enhance their second language literacy process. The study results will also empower ELLs, offering an appropriate multicultural curriculum to help them become critical thinkers.

### Definition of Terms

For the purpose of clarity, I offer the following definitions for terms and concepts used in the study.

English language learner: A learner learning English as a second language.

Ethnic identity: “One’s sense of belonging to an ethnic group and the part of one’s thinking, perceptions, feelings, and behavior that is due to ethnic group membership” (Rotheram & Phinney; as cited in Knight, Bernal, Garza, & Cota, 1993, p. 224).

Ethnocentric filter system: A filter system that filters new information based on the learner’s ethnocentrism and ethnic identity.

First language: The first language that the learner acquired.

Reading Strategies: Those strategies that “active, thoughtful readers use when constructing meaning from the text” (Pearson & Stephens, 1992).

Retrospective protocol: participants are asked to report on the thoughts they had while they were completing the task. This protocol is performed immediately after the completion of a task (Gamps, 2003). In this study, I used the retrospective protocol with a hint of think-aloud protocol.

Second language: Any language that the learner learned after learning his or her first language. For the purposes of the study, the students' second language is English.

Think-aloud (concurrent) protocol: "Concurrent reports are on-line accounts of the contents of working memory" (Pressley, M., 2000, p. 172). Readers are asked to "think-aloud" or "talk aloud" while they are working on their tasks.

### An Outline of the Dissertation

The dissertation is organized into seven chapters. The study begins with chapter 1 as an introduction. Chapter 2 presents a review of the relevant literature. In chapter 3, I provide a detailed description of the research design of this study as a method. The results of the study are provided in chapters 4, 5, and 6 focusing on research methods. In chapter 7, I discuss a summary of the findings and the implications of the study.

### *Chapter 1: Introduction*

This chapter provides an overview of the study including the purpose of the study and the research questions. I also provide the study's theoretical framework based on sociocultural constructivism.

## *Chapter 2: Review of the Relevant Literature*

This chapter provides a review of research studies relevant to this study. The main focus is literacy and second language literacy. Second language learning theories and strategies are also explored.

## *Chapter 3: Method*

This chapter provides a description of the study design, the site, and the participant selection procedures. Verbal protocols, including think-aloud and retrospective protocol, are explored. Finally, I explain how I develop the details of my research design, procedure, rationales, and materials.

## *Chapter 4: Holistic Views of Second Language Learning: Four Cases*

A holistic view of second language learning through the four cases is presented in this chapter. This compilation of the four cases will help the reader understand the participants' second language learning process. Each case includes a brief description of the participant and his or her second language learning process focusing. Each story shows family background, language use at home, home literacy, schooling history, the reader's reading behavior and habits, his or her perceptions of reading, his or her self-concept as a reader, and a discussion of the case. I also provide the two teachers' profiles.

## *Chapter 5: Reading Strategies*

In this chapter, I analyze the ELLs' reading strategies via verbal protocol analysis. The findings from the four participants' verbal protocols are presented here. Twelve reading strategies emerged inductively from the participants' verbal reports. The details of reading strategy is discussed in chapter 5.

### *Chapter 6: Findings From the Research Methods*

In this chapter, I present the findings from the qualitative research methods. Two main themes emerged inductively. (a) ELLs and identity and (b) ELLs' dialogue in second language learning.

### *Chapter 7: Summary of the Findings and Implications of the Study*

In this chapter, I provide a summary of the findings. I also discuss the three main discussions of the study: (a) ethnic identity and ethnocentrism through meaning making process, (b) ELLs' responses to reading literacy, and (c) second language literacy development. Recommendations for future research follow.

## CHAPTER 2

### REVIEW OF RELATED LITERATURE

#### Literacy

The term *literacy* has had many meanings and definitions (Langer, 1991). The traditional meaning of the word *literacy*—the ability to read and write (Procter, 1999, p. 830)—appears innocent and obvious. Literacy as “the ability to read and write” situates it in the individual person rather than in society.

The ability to read and write is the goal for all students. Au (1993) defined literacy as “the ability and the willingness to use reading and writing to construct meaning from printed text, in ways which meet the requirements of a particular social context” (p. 20). Au also explained students’ willingness as an important factor in their demonstrating existing literacy skills and in their learning new skills. Au emphasized literacy as a matter of will or feelings from reading or writing skills in meaningful tasks.

The literacy development process of this study can be reflected via various theories and multiple perspectives in the classroom setting. I believe literacy is not a simple phenomenon, but is interwoven with various theories and multiple perspectives as a matrix, and I will create a new paradigm.

Reading and writing is a natural process that most students can readily acquire when they are given a classroom environment for learning to read and write that makes full use of the natural reading activities surrounding the child (Goodman, K., 1986; Ovando & Collier, 1998). In other words, students can participate in reading and writing

activities naturally. In this perspective, literacy can be explored as the ability to read and write as part of a natural process in a social context.

The definition of literacy has developed from the ability of reading and writing to literacy as thinking and meaning making (Goodman, K., 1987), because literacy conveys or constructs meaning and thinking. Various definitions of literacy are explored in this paper within a nonlinear paradigm, because they influence each other, develop by their influences and critiques, and evolve simultaneously and spontaneously. Literacy as dialogue (Bakhtin, 1986), reader response theory (Rosenblatt, 1978), and critical literacy as “re-writer as a reader” (Freire, 1998) are powerful concepts for understanding literacy itself.

For clarification of the term *literacy development process* in this study, I observe through several case studies the literacy development process as more focused on the reading process (Holdaway, 1997) than the writing process, because not only does reading precede writing, but also reading is easy to see in the developmental process of literacy practice. However, I consider the writing process as a product to see the reading process based on literacy activities. Also, literacy cannot be divided between reading and writing, because writing can be significantly influenced by reading, and reading can be analyzed via writing products (Holdaway). I also use the terms *learner* and *reader* interchangeably, because a learner should be a reader while he or she engages in literacy events.

These main concepts for understanding literacy can be used in understanding second language literacy. These various perspectives on literacy still influence not only developing second language literacy skills, but also teaching and learning literacy in the

school setting. Further, these are very useful theories and practices to understand and develop second language literacy curricula as well.

### Literacy as Meaning Making

K. Goodman (1984) defined literacy as *meaning making*. He explored reading as meaning construction, not merely an act of reading and writing, as follows: “Reading is meaning-seeking, tentative, selective, and constructive” (p. 97), emphasizing the importance of inference and prediction in reading using the reader’s existing linguistic and conceptual schemata to get to meaning.

This perspective goes beyond the debate of the thinking-centered and skills-based reading models. K. Goodman (1984) also emphasized reading as a meaning-seeking process: “It is this search for meaning which preoccupies the reader and unifies the use of the strategies and cycles that the process requires. Meaning is both input and output in the process” (p. 112). Thus, reading is a new combination of reader and writer in which the most profound significance of the text is also the creation of the reader.

While meaning making, readers use their background knowledge simultaneously. Smith (1997) asserted, “Reading depends more on what is behind the eyes—on nonvisual information—than on the visual information in front of them” (p. 30). Rumelhart (1980) and Smith considered the reader’s background knowledge experiences related to schema theory for second language learning. Cognitive psychologists believe that reading is a set of processes involving complex mental operations and interactions between the reader and the text and within the reader (Anderson, R. C. & Pearson, 1984).

Thus, there have been many concerned with the readers’ background or prior knowledge and visual information (Smith, 1997) for effective literacy development.



Schema theory (Carrell, 1988; Steffensen, 1982) has been applied to second language and literacy development in the same way. Halliday (1993) underscored how critical language and literacy work is: “The distinctive characteristic of human learning is that it is a process of making meaning—a semiotic process; and the prototypical form of human semiotics is language” (Halliday, 1993, p. 93).

One of the reasons that it does that—why a person’s prior knowledge would influence the new knowledge that he or she would acquire—is related to the meaning construction process in which the learner is learning new information. Schema theory in second language literacy is about how learners construct meaning and make sense of new input from their existing knowledge.

### Second Language Literacy

Second language literacy is a more complex process than first language literacy because there are more variables when second language learners are engaged in literacy in general. According to Bernhardt (1991), reading is a “complex social and psycholinguistic process that cannot be separated into reading components and language components” (p. 32). Bernhardt identified three factors that contribute to second language literacy: literacy variables, linguistic variables, and world knowledge variables. Within a social interaction theory, however, reading is seen not only as a linguistic and cognitive process, but as a social one as well. Learning literacy for the second language learner is seen as a social activity constructed through the interaction of the participants in the classroom. The development of literacy for the second language learner is emphasized as socially defined and produced as classroom events.

*Second language* is defined as a language acquired after the native language (Stern, 1983). Second language is also used to refer to a level of language proficiency in comparison with a primary or dominant language. In many cases, the two terms coincide; the *second* means in many cases *weaker* or *secondary*. Since the second language is acquired later than the first language, the second language proficiency is frequently lower than that of the first language (Stern, 1983). I use the term *second language* to mean “learning a language after learning one’s first language.” In this study, in contrast with Stern’s definition of second language, I think one’s second language skills could be stronger or weaker than one’s first language skills depending on the learner and his or her language proficiency stage.

### *Second Language Development*

To better understand second language development, I explore the significant ideas, frameworks, and models in second language acquisition and learning. These include Ellis’s (1984) second language acquisition framework, Schumann’s (1978) acculturation model, Krashen’s (1985) monitor model, Wong Fillmore’s (1982) sociolinguistic theory, and Cummins’ (1992) developmental interdependent hypothesis. These theories and practices are linked to each other as a mountain range; as such, I explore second language development based on different perspectives and perceptions. Exploring these important ideas and theories in second language learning provides effective resources for the audience to understand second language literacy development in the context of the complexity of second language acquisition (Baker, 1996).

### *Ellis's Second Language Acquisition Framework*

Ellis (1984, 1985) explored a distinction among three parts of the development of second language acquisition: the sequence (the order in which a language is learned), the rate of development of the second language, and the level of proficiency achieved. Ellis suggested that there are five interrelated factors that govern the acquisition of a second language: situational factors, input, learner differences, learner processes, and linguistic output.

First, situational factors refer to who is talking to whom, the environment in which the interaction takes place (e.g., classroom or outside of classroom as a natural setting), and the topic of the conversation. Second, linguistic input includes listening and reading. Ellis (1985) emphasized that providing comprehensible input (Krashen, 1985) is significant for improving second language literacy skills of ELLs. Wong Fillmore (1982) also explored the input of language learning in the classroom in depth. She asserted the effectiveness of social interaction in the classroom as a social context in her sociolinguistic cognitive theory by expressing the importance of the teaching style and peer interaction in various classrooms (Wong Fillmore, 1991).

The third factor includes individual learner differences. Ellis (1992) pointed out the significance of the age at which people learn a second language, aptitude for learning languages, cognitive style, motivation, attitude, previous knowledge, learning style, learning strategies, and personality variables. Lambert's (1974) and Gardner's (1985) socioeducational model also showed the significance of the societal elements—such as attitudes and aptitude toward a language and motivation—in influencing bilingual proficiency.

Another important part of Ellis's (1985) concept was learner processes. He explored the processes from external input to external output. In the latter, Ellis emphasized second language outputs. Ellis explored two areas: evolutionary and not fixed outputs, and context variables regarding where the learner is placed. Baker (1996) claimed that Ellis's framework focused only on language development in the classroom context and did not consider outside classroom factors that may influence language learning. When a student has opportunities to use his or her spoken language outside the classroom, language skills may be considerably enhanced (Baker, 1996).

#### *Acculturation Model of Second Language Learning*

Schumann (1978) explored an acculturation model of second language acquisition based on the idea that a second language learner is adapting to a second language and a new culture simultaneously. The basic premise of Schumann's model is that "the degree to which a learner acculturates to the target language group will control the degree to which he or she acquires the second language" (p. 34). H. D. Brown (2000) followed up on Schumann's model by emphasizing the significance of learning culture. Brown stated, "Because learning a second language implies some degree of learning a second culture, it is important to understand what we mean by the process of culture learning" (p. 182). Brown emphasized the importance of learning culture related to second language learning as follows: "Culture learning is a process of creating shared meaning between cultural representatives. It is experiential, a process that continues over years of language learning, and penetrates into one's patterns of thinking, feeling, and acting" (p. 182). Brown described *acculturation* as follows: "Second language learning involves the acquisition of

a second identity. This creation of a new identity is at the heart of culture learning” (p. 182).

Schumann (1978) proposed important social and psychological factors for learning a second language and culture in detail. Social factors include the social distance between the second language learner and the target language group (the native speakers of the language that the second language learners aim to learn, in this case Anglophones), the relationship between the second language learner and the target language group, shared social facilities, positive attitudes and expectations of each other, and the length of the second language learner’s residency.

Psychological factors in learning a language include possible language confusion; the feeling of stress, anxiety or disorientation from differences between cultures;<sup>1</sup> the degree of motivation in learning a language; and the degree of uncertainty of learners. H. D. Brown (2000) expressed three language functions: a communication function, an integrative function, and an expressive function because language exists as communication and exchange of information and in affiliation with a social group. Language and culture cannot be separated when learning a second language in the social context. Schumann (1978) noted additional psychological factors, including possible language confusion and the feeling of stress, anxiety, or disorientation caused by the difference between the learner’s culture and the target language culture.

Stevick (1976) was concerned with second language learners’ isolation in the process of learning a second language and target culture in the social context. Learners

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<sup>1</sup> “Culture shock: refers to phenomena ranging from mild irritability to deep psychological panic and crisis” (Brown, D., 2000, p. 183).

should learn the second language and culture in an equitable situation. Various culture materials, methods, simulation games, and strategies can be useful for second language learners (Fantini, 1997).

### *Krashen's Monitor Model*

Krashen (1982, 1985) and Krashen and Terrell (1983) proposed teaching English as a second language and learning a second language in the classroom setting. Krashen developed five hypotheses for acquiring a second language—the *acquisition–learning hypothesis*, the *natural order hypothesis*, the *monitor hypothesis*, the *input hypothesis*, and the *affective filter hypothesis*—with the input hypothesis at the center. His five hypotheses are at the center of second language theory and practice and cited as theories of second language acquisition.

*Acquisition–Learning Hypothesis.* Krashen (1982, 1985) explored acquisition as a subconscious process and learning as a conscious process. People who acquire language are aware of only the fact that they are using the language for communication. Learning refers to the conscious knowledge of a second language: knowing, being aware of and being able to discuss the rules. This process enables a learner to know about the second language.

*Natural Order Hypothesis.* The natural order hypothesis was developed based on the finding that acquirers of a given language tend to acquire certain grammatical structures early and others later. The natural order hypothesis explains that the natural order is when second language learners learn a second language according to grammatical structures. It explains that learners acquire the rules of language in a predictable order, some rules tending to come earlier and others later. The order does not

appear to be determined solely by formal simplicity, and there is evidence that it is independent of the order in which rules are taught in language classes.

*Monitor Hypothesis.* The monitor hypothesis implies that formal rules, or conscious learning, play only a limited role in second language performance. The monitor is a device that may operate before language performance. Monitoring or editing may occur before the natural output of speech. Learners try to make corrections to change the output of the acquired system before they speak or write (or sometimes after they speak or write, as in self-correction). This hypothesis has been criticized for being untestable and for its lack of supportive research evidence (Baker, 1996).

*Input Hypothesis.* The input hypothesis explores the idea that learners acquire language by understanding messages or receiving “comprehensible input” (Krashen, 1985, p. 2). If  $i$  represents the current level of competence, learners move from stage  $i$  to stage  $i + 1$ , the next level along the natural order hypothesis, by understanding  $i + 1$ , which is a little beyond their current level of competence. Krashen emphasized that acquisition is the result of comprehensible language input and not of language production. Input is made comprehensible through the help provided by the context. The acquisition occurs naturally and automatically when learners receive enough comprehensible input. The Input Hypothesis requires substantial quantities of comprehensible input.

*The Affective Filter Hypothesis.* The affective filter hypothesis explains how affective factors relate to the second language acquisition process. The filter comprises affective factors such as attitudes toward language, motivation, self-confidence, and anxiety. The affective filter hypothesis captures the relationship between affective variables and the process of second language acquisition by positing that acquirers vary

with respect to the strength or level of their affective filters. Larsen-Freeman (1983) criticized that Krashen did not explain the cognitive processes that underlie acquisition and learning. Krashen's theory also tends to fail to explain variables among second language learners (Ellis, 1985; McLaughlin, B., 1987). Overall, Krashen's five hypotheses have significantly influenced second language theory and practice.

### *Sociolinguistic Cognitive Theory*

Wong Fillmore (1991) explored the interplay of cognitive and social factors among learners with situational and linguistic factors in the classroom as a natural setting. She said that children's interaction with one another depends on two factors. The first is the learner's social style and communication needs. The second includes the availability of speakers of the target language (English in this study) and their willingness and ability to interact with the learner in ways that promote language development. Wong Fillmore also showed the importance in second language input of the interaction between teaching style and the peer composition of different classes.

Wong Fillmore's (1991) model consists of three components: second language learners, speakers of the target language, and a social setting. She explained second language learners as people who realize that they need to learn the target language. Speakers of the target language are people who know it well enough to provide the learner with access to the language. Wong Fillmore also expressed that a social setting is the place that brings learners and target language speakers into frequent enough contact to make language learning possible.

Wong Fillmore (1991) explored three types of processes that come into play in language learning: social processes, linguistic processes, and cognitive processes. Social



processes refer to the interactions that take place for communication. These contacts give learners the opportunity to learn a new language. Linguistic processes involve linguistic knowledge—the phonological, lexical, grammatical, pragmatic, and sociolinguistic knowledge that eventually allows learners to speak and comprehend a new language in a social setting. In cognitive processes, learners synthesize the system of rules in a language and make it their own by internalizing it. Second language learners develop their second language using these three processes simultaneously. Wong Fillmore also examined the variations of the three components: variation of learners, variation of speakers of the target language, and variation of the social setting. These variations of components influence second language learning in the classroom as a social setting.

Wong Fillmore (1991) concluded that social style, social competence, motivation, and attitudes in both learners and speakers of the target language can affect language learning. In her model, Wong Fillmore explored the process of language learning and how variation in the three components can crucially affect the outcome of the process.

#### *Developmental Interdependent Hypothesis*

Cummins' (1992) threshold theory summarized the relationship between cognition and degree of bilingualism. From the threshold theory, Cummins (1992) outlined the *developmental interdependent hypothesis*. Cummins (1984, 1992) explained a distinction between basic interpersonal communication skills (BICS) and cognitive/academic language proficiency (CALP). BICS is said to occur with contextual supports and props for language delivery. Context-embedded situations provide nonverbal support to secure understanding. CALP occurs in context-reduced academic situations (Cummins, 1992).

The distinction between BICS and CALP has been expressed using the image of an iceberg (Cummins, 1984). Above the surface are language skills such as comprehension and speaking. Beneath the surface are the skills of analysis and synthesis. These are cognitive/academic skills, which include proficiency of meanings and creative composition. Cummins explained the reason for minority students' failure in academic situations based on this hypothesis. Their CALP is not developed enough to understand and follow up on the demands of the curriculum.

Cummins (1992) proposed two dimensions for explaining the developmental process: cognitively undemanding communication and cognitively demanding communication. The first dimension refers to the amount of contextual support for the students. Context-embedded communication includes copious cues and supports for the learners. In context-reduced communication, few cues are provided.

BICS are most useful in a context-embedded, cognitively undemanding situation, and it takes 1 to 2 years of instruction for a child to acquire context-embedded second language fluency. In comparison, context-reduced, cognitively demanding communication develops interdependently or interactively by way of a language or both languages, and it takes 5 to 7 years to acquire context-reduced second language fluency. Cummins (1992) expressed that students who are at the context-embedded level in the language of the classroom may fail to engage in the cognitive academic processes of the classroom.

Cummins's hypothesis was criticized because other variables such as culture, social, political, community, teacher expectations, and home factors were not considered (Edelsky et al, 1983; Rivera, 1984); to achieve context embeddedness in a curriculum

situation requires understanding of a child's background. Also, alternative outcomes of schooling such as self-esteem, social and emotional development, divergent and creative thinking, and long-term attitudes to learning were not considered (Rivera).

### *Second Language Reading Process*

Literacy as meaning making (Goodman, K., 1984) is discussed earlier in chapter 2. Understanding literacy as meaning making provides us with insights into the second language literacy process. Second language reading processes are explored in terms of schema theory, intertextuality (Hartman, 1995), reader response theory (Rosenblatt, 1978), dialogic discourse (Bakhtin, 1986; Freire, 1998), and critical literacy (Freire, 1970). These theories address the relationship between reader and text within a social context and are significant perspectives for developing second language literacy as well as for a deeper understanding of literacy development. These perspectives are interwoven as a matrix in literacy practice and help to understand and develop second language literacy in this study.

### *Schema Theory*

Schema theory helps in explaining second language literacy by expanding the cultural content and rhetorical form (Carrell, 1987). Steffensen (1982) and Carrell (1988) examined the role of schema theory in second language literacy. Schema theory was described as an organization of past reactions or of past experiences that directly influence the comprehension and retention of new processes stored in memory. Through this process, the reader can understand new experiences in a passage using his or her background and cultural knowledge. Schema theory began with bottom-up models (Gough, 1972), followed by top-down designs and progress to interactive models

(Samuels, 2004; Rumelhart, 1980). Rumelhart's interactive model, Samuel's automatic processing model, and Kintsch's (2004) construction-integration model emerged from a focus on how bottom-up and top-down interaction shape comprehension. Current models of schema theory focus on the complex and bidirectional interaction between comprehension processes and memory representations. The interactive process between knowledge and structure parallels Spiro's adaptive flexibility view of reading (Ruddell & Unrau, 2004).

The schema perspective views the mind as a highly complex set of cognitive structures that serve to receive, sort, classify, and fold together information about events and objects (Anderson, R. C., 1994; Rumelhart, 1980). By comparing data from the most recent text with preexisting knowledge, an unfamiliar work becomes easier to understand. Especially for the second language learner, schema theory has influenced reading research in significant ways.

### *Intertextuality*

Intertextuality has played a significant role in reading research since the late 1960s. Hartman (1994, 1995) stated, "transpose texts into other texts, absorb one text into another, and build a mosaic of interesting texts" (p. 526). Other texts influence the reader when they are reading a certain text. Intertextuality is a focus on the reader's relationship between past texts and current texts. How do readers create meaning from current texts using past texts? How do readers use intertextual links and connections? Hartmann explored three types of textual-resources location: *primary endogenous* (those within the passage the students were currently reading), *secondary endogenous* (those in passages they had read previously in the study, and *exogenous* (those outside the task environment).

In his study, readers constructed meaning by making three types of linkages while reading the story. Golden (as cited in Hartman, 1995) addressed three concrete linking profiles—*intratextual*, *intertextual*, and *extratextual*—which emphasized the linguistic dimension of text. Kang (1999) explored ELLs’ reading conceptions and their relationship to intertextuality, and Ruddell and Unrau (2004) explored how readers construct meaning from a text. Meanings of texts are constantly constructed, revisited, and reconstructed in readers’ minds through associated networks.

By linking texts, intertextuality is significant for ELLs because they have different language backgrounds and cultural knowledge. Readers associate with past experiences and their background knowledge while they construct meaning through reading. ELLs dialogue with texts by integrating their first language background as well as their cultural experiences for deeper understanding. First language knowledge and reading experiences support ELLs by embedding their cognitive knowledge.

Meanwhile, the definition of text has extended from *printed text* to *genre as a life*. Bakhtin (1986) explored text as “any coherent signs—then even the study of art deals with texts” (p. 106). Halliday (1985) defined text as meaning and explored text as a semantic unit. Halliday started to be aware of text as a continuous process of semantic choice as well as meaning construction in the context.

Bakhtin (1986) explored in depth text as dialogue: “The transcription of thinking in the human sciences is always the transcription of a special kind of dialogue: the complex interrelations between the text, and the created, framing context in which the scholar’s cognizing and evaluating thought takes place” (p.106).

Text, both written and oral, is the primary given of all these disciplines and all through the human sciences and philosophy in general, because text means more than just words. A human act is a potential text and can be understood only in the dialogic context of its time. Therefore, the text can be expanded to genre, author, and other means of communication. Bazerman (1977) also illuminated the power of genre in classrooms, maintaining

Genres are not just forms. Genres are forms of life, ways of being. They are frames for social action. They are environments for learning. They are locations within which meaning is constructed. Genres shape the thoughts we form and the communications by which we interact. Genres are the familiar places we go to create intelligible communicative action with each other and the guideposts we use to explore the unfamiliar. (p. 19)

Intertextuality can now be examined more significantly because the definition of text has changed dramatically. Meyer, Martens, Flurkey, and Udell (1998) stated that emerging readers and writers make links within a text (textuality), between texts (intertextuality), and between texts and contexts (intercontextuality). Texts exist within a context—where they are situated, how they are described, and how they are explored—because the interpretation of text occurs within the context. Also, texts can be developed by a person who is acting and responding in a particular context. From the intertextuality that focuses on the text in the reading events, the reader should be understood as having a main active role during reading activity within contexts. This literacy process cannot be explored as an isolated phenomenon; the complexity of the literacy process must be understood within an associated network of other theories and practices.

### *Literacy in Reader Response Theory*

Reader response theory's emphasis on the role of the reader has resulted in a valuing of individual interpretation. Rosenblatt (1978) built her reader response theory upon Dewey's transactional theory of knowledge. Rosenblatt emphasized the reader's active role of responding to the text while he or she engages in reading activity. Also, the text itself leads the reader toward a self-active process. Our individual experience is the sum of this transaction, and the continuous processing of this transaction is the increasing enlargement of experience.

Beach (1994) advocated reader response theory as "sharing a concern with how readers make meaning from their experience with the text" (p. 1). The reading of a text is an event occurring at a particular time in a particular environment at a particular moment in the life history of the reader (Rosenblatt, 1978). Rosenblatt accounted for the two different kinds of reading, *efferent* and *aesthetic*, based on the reader's engagement in text. Rosenblatt explored efferent reading as purposive reading for knowledge and aesthetic reading as *living -through experiences*. The distinction between efferent and aesthetic lies not in the presence or absence of emotion but in the primary direction or focus of the reader's attention (Rosenblatt, 1978). Transaction occurs when a reader tries to engage his or her local interpretation of the text using his or her total picture of the story and also finds logic in this interpretation. This involves reflecting on, revisiting, and resynthesizing the emerging meaning. Therefore, transaction occurs with text in actuality depending on the reader's cultural and historical background or personal experience.

More recently, the idea that literacy is a dynamic process involving a dialogue, an interaction, or a transaction between learner and text situated in a particular context has

framed much of the research on reading. In this regard, Bakhtin (1986) stated, “There is a degree of dialogue between the reader and text” (p. 111). Depending on the degree of dialogue or transaction between the reader and text, the reader encounters meaning construction, and he or she understands, responds, or transacts. The concept of sequential interaction in hierarchical knowledge structures has been replaced by simultaneous interaction.

### *Literacy as a Dialogue*

Literacy is a dialogue between the reader and the text within a social context. Dialogue is a powerful, essential method of transformation, where the person meets a new concept or the person constructs meanings of the world. Second language learners transact with the text using their own cultural and historical experience. Aesthetic and efferent reading (Rosenblatt, 1986) can be understood as being related to the degree of dialogue.

Bakhtin (1986) defined dialogue as follows: “Two speech works, utterances, juxtaposed to one another, enter into a special kind of semantic relationship that we call dialogic” (p. 118). The reader can dialogue with the author or by him- or herself while he or she engages in a literacy event. Furthermore, Bakhtin described dialogue as follows: “Dialogue may be external as between two different peoples or internal as between an earlier and a later self” (p. 427). Sometimes the reader dialogues right away when he or she finishes reading; sometimes he or she dialogues after waiting a while. Reading must be considered as a dialogue, a way to understand, respond, and interact with text to some degree. Reading response can be explained as a stance in which a person is engaged in a literacy event.



Bakhtin (1986) expressed his views on the culturally and politically embedded nature of cross-cultural communication. His cultural and political context is inseparable from utterances, content, style, arrangement and his discussion of “social and historical heteroglossia” (p. 428), which replicates the building blocks of discourse. Reading starts with a dialogue with text in some degree depending on our cultural background, personal experience, and background knowledge. Focusing on the degree of dialogue, Rosenblatt (1978) developed the reader response theory, and it can be used as the concept for understanding ELLs’ engagement or dialogue in literacy events.

### *English Language Learners’ Dialogue in Literacy*

Engagement in literacy events is a dialogue between the reader and the text in a social context. Bakhtin (1986) said that dialogue can happen between two people or within a single person while participating and engaging in reading activities. Second language literacy development is related to the degree of dialogue among various factors in the particular context. Various levels of dialogue occur based on the degree of involvement or engagement while the second language learner is participating in literacy events.

Therefore, engagement in literacy events may be understood as a dialogue, as a way to understand and interact with various factors to some degree. In addition, depending on the ELLs social situations while they are participating in a literacy event, their attitudes toward characters and evaluation of events may be different and their points of view can change. These different attitudes and changes in point of view cause them to allocate a certain amount of power differently for each character, and this results in different individual interpretations.

Second language literacy ability can influence the identity of a person: Gee (1996) stated, “Discourses are ways of being ‘certain kinds of people’” (p. 110). This includes *discourse* with a capital *D* and a lowercase *d*, which refers to connected stretches of talk and writing that people use to identify and position themselves and others as members of social groups. Because literacy practices are shaped by discourses, literacy can be considered a powerful means to claim a space or establish an identity or voice in various social interactions. The ways of using literacy can have a profound impact on whether a particular literacy event and its concomitant practice are valued (Gee, 1996). Literacy ability can be not only an influence on ELLs’ identity (Gee, 1996), but also to their empowerment (Cummins, 1992). With their different needs and beliefs, ELLs also dialogue and interact with peers or teachers, pattern of interaction, and positions of power or status in the classroom, as well as participating in culture beyond the classrooms.

My focus is on how the ELL’s dynamic shift occurs as a result of interaction with teacher and peers in a particular environment or during a particular task or the activity that is taking place. The degree of dialogue is viewed as a continuum from simple negotiation to critical creation and tells how much ELLs dialogue with text when they read or engage in literacy events.

#### *Critical Literacy: “Rewriter” in a Text*

ELLs are influenced by the culture they grow up in and the language and the concepts that come with it, and we as educators effectively develop literacy events for their second language and literacy ability as parts of the discipline to which they belong.

Freire (1970) examined the critical distance concept from banking education to liberatory education. I follow up on his idea of the reader as a rewriter in literacy events

because the second language reader creates meaning from his or her own reading activity based on his or her historical, social, and cultural principles. I believe that the second language learner should be an active reader instead of a passive reader. Teachers and learners can be partners in liberatory education through communication, because meaning is inherent in the cooperative interaction.

Within a sociocultural perspective, literacy is a set of cultural practices and a product of cultural activity. Thus, what counts as literacy depends on the cultural perspective of the teacher who is identifying, understanding, and evaluating the cultural practices (Perez, 1998, p. 252). Giroux (1988) argued that language and literacy “practices one feature of the dominant culture that schools legitimate in varying degrees” (p. 214).

Critical literacy theorists consider the socioeconomic, cultural, and political relations where literacy occurs. Thus, literacy can be understood in terms of the power allocations under the dominant culture, because the dominant power becomes a “culture” (Nieto, 1999). McLaren (2001) stated, “Pedagogy is distinct from teaching in that it situates the teacher/learner encounter in a wider context of historical and sociopolitical forces” (p.121). Critical pedagogy engages students in learning language and literacy, in analyzing events and situations from different perspectives to understand how these perspectives position students in the world, and in using this knowledge to reposition themselves and thereby act in the world (Nieto, 1999).

Freire (1998) pointed to “the need for reading as a dialogic experience in which the discussion of the text undertaken by different readers clarifies, enlightens, and creates group comprehension of what has been read” (p. 30). Freire dealt with transaction in

depth politically, historically, and culturally more than Rosenblatt (1978). Following Freire's (1998) interpretation of transaction, we are faced with new concepts of the "recreator" of the text he or she reads. A result of Freire's interpretation of reading is that a reader becomes a rewriter, composing a new story while making meaning within the author's authority during the reading.

K. Goodman (1984) advocated Freire's idea of reader as recreator: "Meaning is ultimately created by the reader" (p. 111). Thus, readers construct meaning with respect to their prior knowledge of the topic or content domain (Beach, 1994), previous experience (Smith, 1997), and deep internalization (Vygotsky, 1986). Transaction beliefs are directly related to the construction of a holistic interpretation of the text through understanding and responding within sociocultural and political contexts by the reader, who has multiple sociocultural backgrounds.

How a person or a group interprets written language reflects broader cultural themes. It is not just a matter of the use of culturally based knowledge for interpretation, but rather what is considered to be culturally appropriate norms for how to use written text to construct meaning: when, where, and by whom (Bloom, 1989).

Another expanded view of literacy explored by Freire (1998) includes a critical reading of words and the world. In this view, second language literacy is historical and political, and it takes on a sense of involving power relations among people. Learning to read and write ought to be an opportunity for men or women to know what speaking the word really means: a human act implying reflection and action. Freire (1991) stated,

As such, it is a primordial human right and not the privilege of the few. Speaking the word is not a true act if it is not at the same time associated with the right of self-expression and world-expression, of creating and re-creating, of deciding and choosing and ultimately participating in society's historical process. (p. 253)

Literacy as a strong dialogue is a means for empowering oppressed people (Freire, 1991).

Freire (1970, 2000) proposed that reading involves a constant movement between the reading of words and the so-called reading of reality, or what he called *critical consciousness* (p. 437). Reading entails a critical perception of the world and the transformation of the world through practical action and reflection. Freire and Macedo (1987) said, “Reading the world always preceded reading the word, and reading the word implies continually reading the world” (p. 35). Freire asserted that literacy is the only tool that can empower and liberate people from oppression of the social reality around them.

Developing critical literacy in second language literacy in schools is a way of helping ELLs understand the nature of inequalities in society and how some groups are privileged over others; it is also a way to empower ELLs to work toward positive change in their own lives and in society. Critical literacy requires not just that teachers accept ELLs’ experiences, but also that they help their students of diverse backgrounds understand their own experiences, as well as the experiences of others, in terms of the dynamics of the larger society (Au, 1993, p. 33).

### *Second Language Literacy Process*

ELLs develop the new story of text through a deeper dialogue within the sociocultural and political contexts. “The idea of social context is especially important when it comes to the literacy instruction of students of diverse backgrounds” (Au, 1993, p. 24), because literacy occurs within a sociocultural context. Recall that ELLs are living in a culture different from which they came.

“A goal of second language literacy within a sociocultural theoretical framework would be to assist ELLs in using all their literacy abilities in various cultural contexts to

develop cultural repertoires” (Perez & Torres-Guzman, as cited in Perez, 1998, p. 256).

Literacy has the potential to empower oppressed students and to create cultural awareness (Freire, 1970) and cultural knowledge (Moll & Gonzalez, 1994).

Furthermore, the extent to which their first language and culture are incorporated into the school program is significantly related to students’ academic success (Cummins, 1992). Increasing students’ knowledge, awareness, and understanding toward language and culture are important objectives in helping them become multicultural and empowered in the classroom. Educators teach students with *culturally relevant methods* (Ladson-Billings, 1992, p. 81) to empower them to critically examine educational content and process and determine its role, creating a truly democratic and multicultural society. These methods use students’ cultures to help students create meaning and understand the world. Thus, academic success, as well as social and cultural success, are emphasized by culturally relevant pedagogy. The teacher helps students make connections between their community, national, and global identities using culturally relevant teaching (Ladson-Billings).

In the same way, ELLs can use their *funds of knowledge* (Moll, 1992; Moll & Gonzalez, 1994) as cultural knowledge in their literacy events. Funds of knowledge describes the innovative methods by which the learners’ culture and their cultural knowledge can be approached, through which teachers can empower minority ELLs. These funds of knowledge would be useful resources in the teacher’s instruction for all the students. As students in the classroom who understand various cultures, they have multiple perspectives on the world. As educators get to know ELLs’ cultural background, we are able to guide them effectively (Cummins, 1992; Goodman, K., 1984).

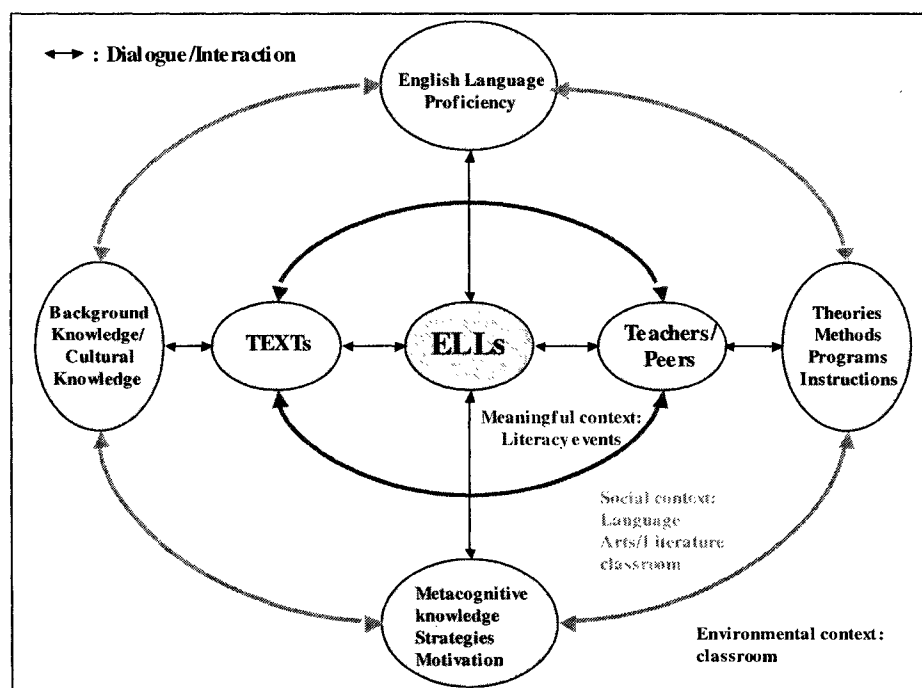


Figure 1. Second language literacy development in contexts.

Figure 1 demonstrates the second language literacy development process in context. The framework in Figure 1 demonstrates the relationships among the ELL, the text, and the context in depth. The concept of dialogue and interaction are explored as their interrelationship, degree of dialogue (Bakhtin, 1986), and stance of dialogue (Beach, 1994) are investigated. There are essential factors that influence second language learners while they are participating and engaging in literacy events in the classrooms.

In the following paragraphs, words in *italics* refer back to Figure 1. I developed this figure as a tool to explore context to better understand the complexity of the learning process and the dynamic dialogue and interaction in contexts.

### *English Language Learner*

The ELLs' active role stands in the center of the second language literacy developmental process. ELLs who have different background knowledge and cultural

knowledge are surrounded by text and teachers/peers in a meaningful context while they are engaging and participating in literacy events.

I developed three contexts: meaningful context, social context, and environmental context, by drawing on the literature and my own experiences. *Meaningful context* is the situation in which ELLs are participating in literacy activities and are engaged in order to understand subject matter in literacy events. Halliday (1978) asserted the importance of context: “Now one important fact about speaking and understanding language is that it always takes place in a context” (p. 13). At this point, students’ second language literacy skills and knowledge can be improved and enriched. Through dialogue, ELLs transact with text in the various contexts, such as the meaningful context and the social context.

*Social context* in the study is explored in the language arts/literature classroom as a content area as ELLs interact with their teacher and peers for learning subject matter as well as language. Teachers and peers assist or guide ELLs by interacting with them within a ZPD. ELLs are also surrounded by a natural environmental context that is the classroom or school.

Within these contexts, the teacher teaches ELLs through various theories, methods, programs, instruction systems, and strategies to help them understand the subject matter as well as to improve their language skills. *Cultural knowledge* and *background knowledge* are important for ELLs in improving their literacy skills, empowerment, and transaction. These factors, which are explored from theories to practices for integrating teaching and learning principles, are significant in helping ELLs in the classroom as a natural social setting.



A change in the teaching methods and learning strategies for literacy practice is necessary to assist ELLs. New strategies and approaches for literacy instruction for ELLs should include not only asking students to search for information in the text, but also encouraging students to articulate how they feel about a story or other piece of literature and how literature may have meaning in their own lives and in society.

The developmental process is also explored. Figure 1 shows the significance of the development process via dialogue and interaction as influenced by the three contexts. Development is a dynamic process through deep engagement, interaction, or dialogue. The degree of interaction and dialogue are crucial for developing second language literacy.

Reading interpretation includes not only the interaction and engagement between the reader and the text but also the context around the reader. As ELLs engage or participate in literacy events, they dialogue with texts and interact with the teacher or their peers to improve their language and literacy skills. By being aware of the developmental process, we as educators facilitate the students in effective and efficient ways.

Sociocultural constructivist theory recognizes the need for cultural knowledge, motivation, attitude, and interaction between ELLs and within their environments. By understanding the literacy development paradigm in depth, we as educators will be able to guide and support ELLs in the classrooms. ELLs should be encouraged to use what they have learned so that creative ideas can be activated by the richly embedded linkage of their own experiences, cultures, and purposes. Being literate is defined not only as being able to read and write the symbols but also as having the ability to do so in a

culturally appropriate manner (Perez, 1998, p. 5). ELLs' background knowledge and cultural knowledge should be enhanced for deeper discourse with text within the sociocultural context. Therefore, the second language learner should be a rewriter or recreator as a reader who has an active role during the literacy event.

### *Second Language Learner*

The term *second language learner* refers to a student who engages in a literacy event using his or her second language in ESL, English as a foreign language (EFL), and mainstream situations. Second language learners may or may not have enough proficiency in English to do well academically in an all English instructional setting.

In the United States, students who either are monolingual in the home language or have some English proficiency but are still more fluent in their home language have, until recently, been referred to as limited English proficient (LEP) students (Macedo, 1994). Since the term LEP has negative connotations, many educators have begun to use the more neutral term English language learner. ELLs can develop the linguistic and academic skills appropriate to their level of cognitive development. As these ELLs gradually become proficient in English, they also enrich their literacy ability through various literacy events; their identities are shifted (Gee, 2002).

K. Goodman (1984) defined the reader as follows: "Since comprehension results from reader-text transactions, what the reader knows, who the reader is, what values guide the reader, what purposes or interests the reader has will play vital roles in the reading process" (p. 111). K. Goodman valued the reader's background and culture as tools for understanding and interpreting in literacy events. Background and culture are significant for ELLs because they construct meaning not only through interpretation of

current input, but also through reconstruction of their past. From the tacit knowledge that consists of explicit information, schemata are established.

Erickson & Schultz (1992) noted that very little educational research has focused on learners with an integrated examination of the social, emotional, and cognitive aspects of their experiences. In the field of literacy, J. A. Vacca, Vacca, and Gove (2000) and others noted that one needs to understand students and what they think about literacy. Several issues are important to consider when trying to understand ELLs' experiences and perspectives. Without understanding ELLs, we as educators cannot approach and teach them in an effective and efficient way.

According to J. A. Vacca, Vacca, and Gove (2000), positionings are shaped by differences between people, such as differences in race, ethnicity, class, gender, ability, age, sexual orientation, language use, and religion. The constructs of identity (Gee, 2002) and subjectivity are important in literacy and language and can influence how the ELL is positioned, as well as his or her success in furthering literacy and language learning. Literacy ability can be one of the most important factors in identifying or positioning ELLs in society. Gee (1996) called these constructs of identity *discourses* (p. 110), and this kind of identity can shift.

### *Variables Among English Language Learners*

Y. Goodman (1980) said that we as teachers need different ways to access different readers. There are first language readers, second language readers, and bilingual readers who have totally different backgrounds, are at different learning stages, and move in different social contexts. The main difference between first and second language readers is the cognitive-linguistic and experiential resources they bring to the reading task,

especially in terms of those variables that relate directly to reading comprehension in English: (a) English language proficiency, (b) background knowledge related to the text, and (c) literacy abilities and experiences, if any, in the first language (Goodman, K. & Goodman, 1978).

There are significant factors that influence ELLs when they are developing their second language literacy: the level of language proficiency (first language proficiency and second language proficiency), metacognitive knowledge as personal differences (cognitive development and cognitive style), and cultural orientation including past experiences and cultural knowledge (Richards, 1997).

Generally speaking, second language proficiency is the most critical factor in second language reading and writing. Clarke (1980) maintained that there must be a basic level of second language proficiency for the reading of any text, and that level varies according to the difficulty of the text. Indeed, many teachers and researchers would agree with Alderson's (1984) statement that "[Readers] will not be able to read as well in the foreign language as in their first language until they have reached a threshold level of competence in that foreign language" (p. 19). ELLs have a different level of English proficiency, and it affects their literacy success in English.

Richards (1997) also noted the importance of differences of metacognitive knowledge among ELLs. Metacognitive knowledge consists of the student's ability to discuss, describe, give rules for, and comment on first language use. For example, Devine (1993) studied a 25-year-old college student, comparing him to a 6-year-old child, focusing on metacognitive knowledge. Since learning the second language often includes instruction in the grammar, structure, and rules of the new language, it is likely that those

with a solid metacognitive knowledge of the structure of their own language better apply such linguistic knowledge to second language learning and reading (Devine, 1993).

In addition, Smith (1997) stated, good readers activate prior knowledge of the text topic by imagining what they know and do not know about the topic, predicting what the text will be about, and generating questions the text might answer. As mentioned earlier, bringing background knowledge and cultural background knowledge to the learning process is important (Moll, 1992; Moll & Gonzalez, 1994; Moll, Neff, & Gonzalez, 1992). K. Goodman (1984) also valued the reader's background and culture for understanding and interpretation in reading activities. Cultural differences are pervasive, and they constitute the largest category of factors that influence second language learning and reading.

Second language literacy is significantly influenced by cultural orientation (Richards, 1997, p. 28). For example, Philips (1972), in his Warm Spring study, noted the different characteristics and cultural backgrounds of Native American students, comparing them to mainstream students. Because Native American students have different characteristics and cultural backgrounds from the other students in the study, Philips explored the reasons Native American students struggle in school in which general public school curriculum and classroom activities are fulfilled. He argued the necessity of different approaches of instruction for successful Native American student literacy in their classroom.

The ELL is surrounded by different contexts in various classrooms, such as the ESL classroom and the mainstream classroom. Therefore, depending on different social

contexts, the second language learner needs variable texts, multiple theories and strategies, and strong degrees of dialogue to develop his or her second language literacy.

### *Teaching Second Language Literacy in a Content-Area Classroom*

Learning literacy in English in content-area classes is crucial for ELLs. ELLs can be motivated not only by topics presented, but also by knowing that they are developing the concepts and skills associated with these subjects: They are actually doing “real” school work instead of merely learning a second language for applications that have yet to be confronted (O’Malley & Chamot, 1997). Literacy practice in a content classroom is not only important for developing academic language skills, but also inherently more interesting to many students than ESL classes that focus only on language.

A second reason for integrating language and reading literacy into content-area teaching is that language is learned most effectively for communication in meaningful, purposeful, social and academic contexts as a social world (Dyson, 1993). In real life, people use language to talk about what they know and what they want to know more about, not to talk about language itself. Through dialoguing with texts and teachers, ELLs engage in reading activities naturally.

Cantoni-Harvey (1987) further underscored this point: “When the learner’s second language is both the object and medium of instruction, the content of each lesson must be taught simultaneously with the linguistic skills necessary for understanding it” (p. 22). Students may need to be specially taught and receive special literacy practice in the context of actual subject-matter learning.

The integration of reading literacy as content with language instruction provides a substantive basis for language teaching and learning. Literacy practice in content areas

can provide both a motivational and a cognitive basis for language learning (Snow, M. A., Met, & Genesee, 1992). Content provides a primary motivational incentive for language learning insofar as it is interesting and of some value to the learner and worth learning. Literacy events also provide a cognitive basis for language learning in that they provide real meaning that is an inherent feature of naturalistic language learning.

Cummins (1992) provided a theoretical framework for considering the integration of language and content instruction. He explored “the range of contextual support and degree of cognitive involvement in communicative activities” (p. 19) in which language tasks may be characterized as context-reduced or context-embedded, and said the tasks addressed through language may be cognitively demanding or undemanding. When language and content are integrated, it is possible to practice language (e.g., colors and shapes) by applying such labels to more sophisticated tasks, such as sorting geometric shapes by one attribute (color or shape only) or by two attributes (color and shape) (Snow, M. A., Met, & Genesee, 1992, p. 28).

Literature-based instruction is a teaching method used in teaching literacy within a content area. Students who receive literature-based instruction demonstrate the ability to transfer knowledge gained from reading to writing (Morrow, Pressley, Smith, & Smith, 1997). They also show better understanding of story structure (i.e., the identification of story plot, theme, conflict, and resolution) than those who receive the basal reading instruction (Morrow et al., 1997) that is used in language arts/literature classes. Students use language and literature in meaningful contexts for developing their literacy ability. ELLs can improve their second language while they are learning subject matter, rather than English itself, in the meaningful context in which literacy events occur.

The classroom environment plays a critical role in comprehension and production (Dyson, 1993). A social setting in which children can learn language naturally should be reemphasized. Children as social beings grow up within a natural setting (Goodman, Y., 1980). The language arts/literature classroom is an essential setting for developing second language literacy. Squire (2003) explored the history of the English language arts:

The term “Language Arts” rose to professional popularity among elementary school teachers at this time, since it suggested the integration of skills and experiences; English, the term still used in the high school, suggested subject matter, and often, subject matter taught in isolation. (p. 5)

Squire also noted that “‘whole language’ and integration of reading and writing dates back to such curriculum efforts” (p. 5).

In an integrated language arts approach, children’s literature is a major source of instruction materials in content-area teaching. The literature provides the opportunity for children to engage in shared oral reading and writing experiences; the teacher uses literature as guided lessons, and there is time given for social interaction with peers during periods of independent reading of literature about subject areas (Goodman, K. 1984; Wells, as cited in Morrow & Gambrell, 2000, p. 576).

In addition, children’s literature on content-area topics provides a wide range of ideas that promote emotional responses, personal associations, imagination, prediction, and evaluation (Smith, 1997). Morrow (1992) found that children’s literature that is related to cultural identity for ELLs who are minority students enhances both literacy ability and interest in reading activity.

Using multicultural literature that is written about various cultural, racial, and historical stories based on different cultural backgrounds in the language arts/literature



classroom provides ELLs with an opportunity not only to learn about different racial and ethnic groups but also to examine their own stereotypes and prejudices. Through reading and discussing the literature, students are able to look into a world that is unfamiliar to them. ELLs of color are able to see a world that is reflective of their own lived experiences. Books provide a way for us to conceptualize the world and locate ourselves in a context of the experience of others, and ELLs can be empowered through literature. ELLs use multiple perspectives to view the world and to understand their place in it as well.

Halliday (1978) advocated *learning how to mean*. K. Goodman and Goodman (1990) followed up on Halliday's idea as follows:

He describes the development of a range of personal/social functions which then stimulate the development of the forms of language. As learners experience the wide variety of functions and forms of language, they internalize the way their society uses language to represent meaning. So, they are learning language at the same time they are using language to learn. (p. 231)

Halliday (1978) had a social theory of language and language learning that Vygotsky (1978) explored. Halliday advocated language use for meaning in a meaningful context. Children are motivated to learn a second language and literacy to communicate effectively within a meaningful context. Teachers in education also see learning language and developing literacy as occurring in all human interactions in a rich cultural context with language as a constructive tool for meaning making.

### *Learning Strategies*

Second language learning may be improved by developing learning strategies. H. D. Brown (2000) defined *strategies* as “specific methods of approaching a problem or

task, modes of operation for achieving a particular end, planned designs for controlling and manipulating certain information” (p. 113). Weinstein and Mayer (1986) explained learning strategies as methods or techniques that individuals use to improve their comprehension, learning, and retention of information.

Oxford (1990) defined learning strategies as follows: “[Learning strategies] are specific actions taken by the learner to make learning easier, faster, more enjoyable, more self-directed, more effective, and more transferable to new situations” (p. 8). In particular, second language learning strategies are crucial because they improve language performance, encourage learner autonomy, are teachable, and expand the role of the teacher in a significant way (Oxford, 1986). Oxford’s (1990) and O’Malley & Chamot’s (1997) research of second language learning strategies significantly influenced not only the enhancement of teacher training programs, but also development of the students’ center program.

#### *Oxford’s Language Learning Strategies*

Oxford (1986) and Oxford and Crookall (1989) explored the importance and effectiveness of second language learning strategies. They also provided the definition and classification of these strategies. Oxford investigated strategies as specific actions, behaviors, steps, or techniques students used to improve their progress in internalizing and using a second language. Factors that influence learning a second language such as motivation, gender, and learning style were examined (Oxford, 1986).

Oxford (1990) suggested a new system of language learning strategies. Strategies are divided into two major classes: direct and indirect. These two classes are subdivided into six groups; the direct class being comprised of memory, cognitive, and compensation

and the indirect class being comprised of metacognitive, affective, and social. This system explored how direct strategies and indirect strategies support each other and how each strategy group is capable of connecting with and assisting every other strategy group.

The *direct* class is composed of memory strategies for remembering and retrieving new information, cognitive strategies for understanding and producing the language, and compensation strategies for using the language despite knowledge gaps. The *indirect* strategies are related to the general management of learning. This class is made up of metacognitive strategies for coordinating the learning process, affective strategies for regulating emotions, and social strategies for learning with others.

Despite problems in classifying strategies, research continues to prove that strategies help learners while they are learning a language (Oxford, 1990). I believe that teachers can benefit from an understanding of what makes learners successful and unsuccessful, and establish the classroom as a place for successful strategies.

Oxford (1990) developed one of the most useful manuals of strategies-based instruction (SBI), a practical guide for teachers based on her strategy classification system. SBI is a learner-centered approach to teaching that extends classroom strategy training to include both explicit and implicit integration of strategies into course content (Cohen, 1987). Students learn how to apply strategies to learning and use of language. Also, for young learners, Chamot and El-Dinary (1999) produced a strategies handbook called the Cognitive Academic Language Learning Approach (CALLA) for teachers in elementary and secondary schools.

### *O'Malley and Chamot's Learning Strategies in Second Language Acquisition*

O'Malley and Chamot (1988, 1997) studied the use of strategies by ESL learners. They divided strategies into three main categories, metacognitive strategies, cognitive strategies, and socioaffective strategies (which include communication strategies). The term *metacognitive* is used in formation-processing theory. Strategies involve planning for learning and thinking about the learning process as it is taking place. For example, there are advanced organizers, directed attention, selective attention, self-management, functional planning, self-monitoring, delayed production, and self-evaluation. The strategy monitors one's production or comprehension and evaluates the learning process.

*Cognitive strategies* are more limited, learning tasks and materials in a specific way. Examples include repetition, resourcing, translation, grouping, note taking, deduction, recombination, imagery, audio representation, key word, contextualization, elaboration, transfer, and inferencing. *Socioaffective strategies* and *communication strategies* are related to social interaction and involve activities. They also include cooperation and questions for clarification. In addition, learning strategies are closely related to the receptive domain of intake, memory, storage, meaning negotiation, and recall.

Chamot and El-Dinary's (1999) recent studies explored learning strategies of ESL learners. Chamot and El-Dinary studied think-aloud techniques to reveal strategic differences between more and less successful learners for the kinds of language tasks they experience in their immersion classrooms from 3<sup>rd</sup>- and 4<sup>th</sup>-grade students. Extensive research has described and classified language learning strategies among ESL students and students of various language backgrounds learning various languages at the

secondary and college level (Chamot & El-Dinary, 1999; Oxford, 1990). Reading comprehension strategies for ELLs are also explored (Chang, 1997; Guthrie, L. & Hall, 1984; Mikulecky, 1991; Olshavsky, 1975; Scotto-Boyan, 2002).

Chamot and El-Dinary's (1999) study offered insight into the language learning processes of elementary school students using a second language as the medium for acquiring new information and skills. This study concluded that ESL learners' own thinking and learning processes seem to indicate that metacognitive awareness begins at quite an early age. This study also provided some initial information about differences in learning strategy use between more effective and less effective young language learners. Across age levels, good language learners seem to be adept at monitoring and adapting strategies, whereas poor learners cling to ineffective strategies.

#### *The Cognitive Academic Language Learning Approach*

CALLA is designed to develop the academic language skills of ESL learners in upper elementary and secondary schools, the "language minority students at the advanced beginning and intermediate levels of English language proficiency" (Chamot & O'Malley, 1994, p. 9). CALLA is intended to meet the academic needs of these types of ESL learners (O'Malley & Chamot, 1988). The CALLA model includes three components in its curricular and instructional design: topics from the major content subjects, development of academic language skills, and direct instruction in learning strategies for both content and language. O'Malley and Chamot (1997) explored content-based curricula, academic language development, and learning strategy instruction based on learning strategies research.

The theoretical approaches and models mentioned above support the premise that second language literacy is actively and socially constructed while meaning making in meaningful literacy events. To understand the second language literacy process, I designed a research method that included qualitative research and verbal protocols.

## CHAPTER 3

### RESEARCH METHODS

The main focus of this study was to use a sociocultural constructivist perspective based on qualitative research to investigate second language learners' literacy development as a learning process in the ELL's language arts/literature classroom. I also wanted to review ELLs' verbal reports to examine how they use reading strategies and how they make meaning in a social context while engaging in meaningful tasks and to describe the second language literacy development process while engaging in meaningful literacy events. I also examined how ELLs interact with peers and the teacher in acquiring their literacy skills. It was hoped that sufficient strategies would be articulated to assist educators in designing instruction in reading comprehension. This chapter describes the following: (a) the context of the study, including a brief description of the selected school and classroom context; (b) the participant selection process; (c) the study's methodology, including research design, verbal report protocols, and the verbal report protocol processes; and (d) a detailed outline and description of the methodological procedures and an account of the methods of data analysis.

#### Context of the Study

##### *Site*

The selected school was an urban public school located on the northeast side of a large city in the southwest United States. The school includes kindergarten through grade 5. About 602 students are enrolled in GO elementary school, approximately 73.6% White

non-Hispanic, 11.4% Hispanic, 5.9% Asian, 4.1% African American, 2.2% Native American, and 2.8% other ethnicity (APS, 2005). Of the 602 students, 9.3% were on the free or reduced lunch program, and most of the students lived in an upper-class socioeconomic environment.

### *School Philosophy*

The vision of the school is “Today’s Learners—Tomorrow’s Leaders” and the school mission statement is “Learning for Today and Tomorrow.” To achieve this vision and mission, the school has established six school goals, including reading, math, writing, and technology. GO Elementary School used the Baldrige Criteria for Performance Excellence to achieve these goals and exceed the Apple Public School Performance Counts expectations for the school (APS, 2005). The school developed community support for the children’s learning process, and parents’ involvement was strongly encouraged.

### *Parental Involvement*

The school focused on creating strong parent and community involvement. The goal was to have the parents, students, educators, and community work as a team to strengthen the school, families, and children’s learning. As planned and implemented, the strategies included improving communication methods, sharing ideas on how parents could work with their children at home, and using parents’ feedback to make decisions on school improvements (APS, 2005).

For the 2004–2005 school year, a new teacher with an ESL endorsement, Ms. Lopez, joined the GO elementary school staff. She had taught in elementary school for 13 years in several rural area of the state and was very impressed by parents’ involvement in



the school. She compared the parents' involvement to that of the school in which she used to teach:

I've never seen a school that had this much parental involvement. It's amazing. It's a wonderful for the kids and for the school, because the downside of being a school that is in the wealthier part of town is that they don't qualify for the same kind of funds that the schools that have high poverty do qualify for. So they have to be more creative in schools like this about how they're going to raise money for the school. (ML-4)

She addressed the importance of parents' involvement in children's schooling. She explained three levels of parents' involvement: *nonindividual involvement*, *individual involvement*, and *volunteering involvement* as reflecting her own experiences with different schools. She said that this school had a high level of volunteering involvement. She believed students' success in schooling in this context is related to increased parental involvement.

Ms. Lopez also addressed the significant relationship between family education background and parents' involvement. She said, "The education of the families is higher. Most kids in my class come from families that are—I would say—white collar workers. A lot of them are professional people" (ML-5). In her experience, most of the students had a highly educated family background. That is why their parents (especially the mothers) could volunteer at the school. For example, when I met Kyle's mother, she was working at the library as a volunteer. Ms. Lopez added, "It's amazing because you see the privileges that these kids have and their experiences, for example, in traveling. I mean they've been all over the world. I mean they have a tremendous wealth of experiences that they bring with them from home" (ML-5). She felt that this family involvement and children's family background was very important in this school.

### *School Curriculum*

GO elementary school offered many special programs and resources for the study of specialized curriculum outside of the classroom, such as physical education, arts, environmental education, computer lab, and the ESL tutoring program. The school's curriculum revolved around interdisciplinary units centered on core themes. The curriculum was based on Apple city and MM state standards and frameworks as well as on the school's established guidelines. The teachers themselves were responsible for enhancing the curriculum as well. The curriculum was based on an active learning approach and engaging the children with educational experiences. Along with the general curriculum, teachers were encouraged to individualize their instructions based on the teacher's and the students' personal strengths. At the grade 2–3 level, the language arts/literature program was based on thematically guided comprehension lessons (McLaughlin, M., 2003), incorporating much of the social studies curriculum. The ESL program worked as a pull-out program. For example, Yanton used to come to Ms. Green's language arts/literature class in this program, although he was a 3<sup>rd</sup> grader. Ms. Green and Ms. Lopez prepared special programs to match the ELLs' various levels of English proficiency.

### *Classroom Context*

The main site of this research was the language arts/literature classroom, which provided meaningful contexts and special curricula for ELLs. The classroom was a mixture of ELLs and mainstream students. For example, Ms. Green had 5 ELLs out of 25 students in 2003–2004. Ms. Lopez had 8 ELLs out of 26 children in 2004–2005. The participants in this study were enrolled in this classroom and had 4 blocks of language

arts/literature classes each week. I observed the language arts/literature classroom once or twice a week during the research period from October 2003 through December 2004. I also spent considerable time in other content classes such as the Social Studies, Science, and Math classes.

### *Reading Instruction*

To better accommodate individual learning strengths and weaknesses in the classroom, the teacher occasionally divided the class into smaller reading groups. To develop a collaborative working environment, the teacher used such teaching methods as pair work, group projects, and individual focus. The ESL teaching environment established in the small group side enabled more individualized instruction while fostering group dialogue, peer interaction, and cooperative work. Teachers' reading instruction was implemented in the class based on the basic school curriculum outlined earlier in this chapter.

Children in this classroom interacted with peers very often. Ms. Green encouraged them: "Please ask two friends if you have questions in this project before you come to ask me." However, children still lined up in front of her with various questions. This showed the free atmosphere in the classroom. She usually gave a group project to students whenever she needed to do individual work with the ELLs. While she interacted with the beginner ELLs (e.g., Yanton and Yuko), others came to ask her questions about their own projects. Thus, her individual work with ELLs was often interrupted, but Ms. Green did not mind at all. However, it did seem that working with beginning ELLs challenged her in organizing her time.

Guided reading lessons entailed silent reading and reading aloud, dialogue about text meaning, characterization, vocabulary, elements of text language, various reading strategies, and written responses to specific questions. The students wrote reading responses to the literature in their journals. There were many books available in the classroom for individual reading and the students took advantage of them regularly. Those books covered diverse topics and were written on various reading levels. Some were bilingual, written in English and Spanish. The teacher encouraged students to use a dictionary and allowed them to go to the library in pairs to find sources while working on their own projects. They were also encouraged to seek help from capable peers.

#### The Participant Selection Process

My selection criteria were based on several pilot studies of my population and consisted of three elements: students in grade 2 or 3 who were (a) ELLs who had their own first language and culture, (b) had learned English for no more than 3 years, and (c) were enrolled in the selected language arts/literature classroom. I selected 4 ELLs as participants, including three 2<sup>nd</sup> graders and one 3<sup>rd</sup> grader, via purposive sampling (Merriam, 1998), through ongoing observations in 12 elementary schools in Apple city. It was a challenge for me to decide about my participants in this study, because I was aware of my questions related to the literacy development process within the social context. Before beginning the study, I secured Institutional Review Board (IRB) and Research, Development, and Accountability (RDA) approval from my university and the school for this study. All names used in this study are pseudonyms.

Participants in this study were all enrolled in the same language arts/literature classroom in GO Elementary school. Three students were 2<sup>nd</sup> graders and one of them

was a 3<sup>rd</sup>-grade student. All of them had learned English as a second language, although one of the participants was born in the United States.

The main reason for focusing on 2<sup>nd</sup> graders as the target population of the reading research is that verbal report and reading strategy studies have been done with young adults, college students, and professional adults. This study examines verbal protocols as a research tool in reading education for young children. Some research has been done with children by Scotto-Boyan (2002), with 4<sup>th</sup> graders, and Chamot and El-Dinary (1999), with 3<sup>rd</sup> graders, but I could not find any research using verbal report protocols with 2<sup>nd</sup> graders and examining their learning and reading strategies. I believe that 2<sup>nd</sup> graders are able to use their cognitive, metacognitive, and socioaffective strategies while reading stories. I chose the language arts/literature class as a meaningful context because this context gave me the opportunity to explore the children's interaction while the reading process occurs in a meaningful context. Once again, my intention in this study was to investigate the second language learners' language literacy development process from a sociocultural constructivist perspective in the language arts/literature classroom as a content area based using qualitative research methods.

To investigate second language literacy development, the participants should have studied or learned English for no more than 3 years. The pilot studies that I conducted indicated that factors that influence their reading and writing development can be well observed in ELLs who have studied English for no more than 3 years. The participants' English language learning histories are presented in Table 1.

Table 1

*Participant English Language Learning Histories as of January 2004*

| Original    |             |            | Schooling in the | Level of English        |
|-------------|-------------|------------|------------------|-------------------------|
| Participant | Nationality | ESL Period | United States    | Proficiency             |
| Jae-min     | Korean      | U.S. born  | 2.5 years        | Fluent speaker          |
| Kyle        | Japanese    | 2 years    | 1.5 years        | An intermediate speaker |
| Lilly       | Mexican     | 10 months  | 7 months         | A beginner              |
| Yanton*     | Swedish     | 2 weeks    | 2 weeks          | A very beginner         |

\*Yanton arrived in the United States in January 2004. This information is as of our first meeting in February 2004.

Both boys and girls were included in the study. The focal students' first language and culture were addressed in the selection process of the populations under study. By describing their second language literacy development in a mainstream language arts/literature classroom in elementary school, I discuss their second language literacy development process. Two teachers, Ms. Green and Ms. Lopez, were involved in the study (see chapter 4).

### Methodology

#### *Specific Methods for the Literacy Development Process*

Reading is "both a cognitive and a social/linguistic process" (Bloom & Green, 2002, p. 412). It is also clear that interest in individual reading processes has been flourishing. The questions concern both the cognitive (psychological) aspects of reading and attitudes and conceptualizations about reading and learning to read (sociocultural aspects), and they reveal how reading processes occur. Present research focused on ELL

readers, their reading processes, and their reading strategies using qualitative research methods and verbal protocols (Guthrie, L. & Hall, 1984).

To better investigate the literacy development process, I used specific methods based primarily on qualitative research including verbal protocols. These multiple methods are useful for exploring specific ELLs' literacy development processes. These methods provide for multiple angles and help ensure the trustworthiness of the study. A multimethodology approach is encouraged for reading literacy research in order to understand the literacy development process in literacy events (Beach, 1994; Harste, 1994). I analyzed all the data that came from the participants' verbal reports, which were elicited through verbal protocols, as well as the abundant data collected through observation, interviews, documents, and my field notes.

### *Qualitative Research Design*

As qualitative research builds on the reader's tacit knowledge, presenting a holistic and lifelike description, it provides an effective vehicle to demonstrate the interplay between researcher and participants. Listening to ELLs' voices is a natural way to address their developmental process in literacy events. Exploring their verbal reports allowed me as a researcher to see situations in which ESL students communicate and express their understanding and experiences.

Listening to ELL students' voices underscored the in-depth profile of their literacy learning process. Frake (1967) stated, "people construct their world of experience from the way they talk about it" (p. 132). By listening to and analyzing the ways in which the participants interacted with various texts and within social contexts, what they think during the literacy activities, and why and how they engage in the literacy events, I

explored the ELLs' portraits, their second language literacy development processes, and the classroom interaction phenomena.

Qualitative research supported the understanding of specific phenomena, the participants' emic voices, and their own stories (Patton, 1990). The themes emerged naturally. Inductive data analysis was used as a process for making sense of field data (Lincoln & Guba, 1985). Relying mainly on qualitative methodology allowed me to develop patterns and themes in order to describe ELLs' experiences, their reading strategies, their literacy development process, and their own stories.

### Verbal Reports and Protocol Analysis

Verbal reports and protocol analysis offer the opportunity to develop a detailed understanding of reading and the reading process as a thinking process (Afflerbach, 2000; Pressley, M. & Afflerbach, 1995). The main question of the protocol is "What's on your mind?" while reading stories. The protocol provides the thinking process while making meaning through the text. Afflerbach (2000) investigated the history of the verbal protocol from the works of Aristotle and Plato to current research phenomena, and he addressed the protocol as a very powerful means to describe the cognitive, metacognitive, affective, and social aspects of reading. Verbal protocols include the think-aloud (concurrent) protocol and the retrospective protocol (Ericsson & Simon, 1984/1993).

Verbal reports and protocol analysis are used in medical (Duncker, 1945) and mathematical problem solving (Polya, 1965; Celedon-Pattichis, 1998). Increasing interest in the use of protocol analysis was supported by detailed characterizations and categorizations of human problem solving (Newell & Simon, 1972), which is related to reading research as strategic problem solving. Reading comprehension research has



explored the cognitive and metacognitive revolution of reading (Chang, 1997; Mikulecky, 1991; Olshavsky, 1975; Scotto-Boyan, 2002).

Ericsson and Simon (1984/1993) provided critical analysis of the methodology of verbal protocols and protocol analysis. They discussed the descriptions and applications of concurrent and retrospective protocol analysis. They also recommended the effective and specific methodological procedure of using the think-aloud (TA) and retrospective protocols as simultaneous verbal protocols.

Afflerbach (2000) also summarized the advantages of verbal reports and protocol analysis as follows. First, verbal reports and protocol analysis provide access to the constructive and responsive processes that comprise reading. Second, protocol analysis allows examination of important but often neglected reader characteristics, including motivation and affect. Third, protocol analysis provides valuable information on a range of processes related to reading, such as instruction, assessment, discussion, and teacher decision making (p. 165). They said that the verbal protocol should be an effective and efficient means to examine the reading process, assessments, and reading strategies. Use of the think-aloud protocol tended to improve reading strategies and teaching methods (Keene & Zimmermann, 1997; Tovani, 2000).

Ericsson and Simon (1984/1993) provided strong evidence of the prospective trustworthiness of protocol analysis. They also suggested using the concurrent protocol or retrospective protocol depending on the researcher's purpose, and recommended the method of using the concurrent protocol with the retrospective protocol to complement each other.

Gamps (2003) explored the differences and similarities between the concurrent and retrospective verbal reports as tools to better understand the role of second language tasks, asserting that concurrent protocols are not the only type of verbal report available to researchers. Gamps agreed with Ericsson and Simon's (1984/1993) recommendation of using both protocols to better conduct research.

In Ericsson and Simon's (1984/1993) final thoughts, "the comparisons of concurrent and retrospective reports—are in substantial agreement in sharing that the reports are mutually consistent" (p. 371). Also, they concluded that "more important than the fact that there is some variability is the equally prominent fact that there is great stability of the successive protocols in terms of strategies and representation" (p. 372). They said that there might be "local" differences between the two protocols, but that these differences hardly affect the results of a study.

#### *Advantages of the Verbal Protocols*

Increasingly, the interrelationships and interdependences of strategy, skill, response, motivation, and interests in the social context are observed in reading research (Keene & Zimmermann, 1997; Pressley, M. & Afflerbach, 1995). Verbal protocols provided good insights into the reading process (Armbruster, Echols, & Brown, 1983; Gass & Mackey, 2000). What readers verbalized while engaged in the reading process can provide insight into the individual participants' learning and reading strategies and comprehension processes (Afflerbach, 2000; Alderson, 1984; Cohen, 1987; Mikulecky, 1991).

Afflerbach (2000) explained that the benefits of verbal reports and protocol analysis are that they show the relationship of cognitive psychology and literary response,

and the usefulness of verbal reports for theory building, as better understanding the diverse reading strategies and processes. The verbal protocols also allowed the description of cognition, metacognition, and socioaffective cognition, as well as reading strategies, while describing on-line constructively responsive reading (Pressley, M. & Afflerbach, 1995). Verbal protocols may provide the window to see the reader's thinking process while reading occurs.

### *Types of Verbal Protocols*

Olson, Duffy, and Mack (1984) proposed three different types of think aloud protocols as verbal reports: *sentence-by-sentence talking*, *selective talking*, and *after-the-fact talking*. According to Olson et al., sentence-by-sentence talking is the most basic form; the participant is asked to talk after each sentence in the text. Selective talking means that participants talk only at particular points in a text. After-the-fact talking means that participants talk after reading all their materials. They discussed after-the-fact talking as one of the TA protocols.

Scotto-Boyan (2002) explored her research method in her dissertation: “concurrent verbal reports were obtained through thinking aloud in a group context. The reports were considered concurrent because the subjects were asked to think aloud immediately after reading a page of text aloud” (p. 97). She addressed the retrospective method as a TA process as well. Ericsson and Simon (1984/1993) explored verbal reports including the TA and retrospective protocols. They referred to *after-the-fact talking* as a retrospective protocol. Gamps (2003) also discussed verbal reports including concurrent and retrospective verbal reports as tools to investigate second language tasks.

### *Think-Aloud Protocols*

The TA protocols were developed to capture children's reportable mental processing as they worked on familiar types of school tasks. Emig (1971) developed TA protocols for exploring composition aloud as follows: "A composition aloud is a writer's effort to externalize his process of composing somehow reflects, if not parallels, his actual inner process" (p. 40). She explained that three interesting questions could be asked about this particular, and peculiar, form of verbal behaviors. Questions include questions of characters, their behaviors, and provocative hypotheses to account for these behaviors.

Teachers helped to identify appropriate reading and writing tasks for the TA interviews of the 3<sup>rd</sup>- and 4<sup>th</sup>-grade elementary students (Chamot & El-Dinary, 1999). Oxford and Crookall (1989) investigated language-learning strategies using the TA protocol. Olson et al. (1984) examined TA protocols as an effective research tool for studying the comprehension of connected text and the reading process. They illustrated the use of TA protocol data in the analysis of the comprehension process by discussing a series of studies that they conducted. They provide a conceptual scheme for the reading process by suggesting the think-out-loud protocol as follows.

The major focus of the TOL (think-out-loud) data will be on the processes responsible for integrating the semantic representation of an individual sentence into the various cognitive structures being constructed during comprehension. These data should reveal the kinds of strategies used by readers in accomplishing these tasks, the kinds of knowledge sources employed, and the kinds of representations constructed. (Olson et al., 1984, p. 257)

The TA protocol is useful for exploring the literacy development process as well as learning strategies (Anderson, N. J., 1991; Chamot & El-Dinary, 1999; Olson et al., 1984;

Oxford, 1986; Oxford & Crookall, 1989). Several studies focused on reading comprehension and the reading process (Barnett, 1988; Davis & Bistodeau, 1993; Hartman, 1991; Langer, 1990). The TA protocol has proven to be a useful research method for investigating comprehension and interpretation. Langer (1990) investigated the approaches the reader uses in developing an understanding of both literary and informative works. In his dissertation, Hartman (1991) used TA protocols for interviews to investigate intertextuality in multiple passages with 8 readers. Celedon-Pattichis (1998) used the TA protocol to explore language use in specific word problems in an ELS/Mathematics class. Lytle (1982) used TA protocols to examine 12<sup>th</sup>-grade readers' transactions with text.

Olshavsky's (1975) study was designed to identify the types of reading process and reading strategies of 24 students by using the TA protocol. Mikulecky (1991) also used the TA protocol in her dissertation to investigate comprehension strategies of bilingual Russian readers in two languages.

#### *Limitations of the Think-Aloud Protocol*

When I developed the research method for this study, I realized three significant issues about implementing the TA protocol for my study. First, the sentence-by-sentence protocol was not suitable to investigate the meaning making process while reading occurs. If readers read sentence by sentence, it would be very difficult to see their meaning making as a whole process and it would be difficult for the readers to use their strategies as a great matrix. For example, in my study, Kyle did not understand the word "Visa" when reading the first part of the story, but he deciphered the word meaning through the reading as a whole, not sentence by sentence.

Second, the purpose of my study is to investigate participants' meaning making through their reading strategies. I was aware of the researcher's influence on their meaning construction process as identified by Olshavsky (1975). For example, when using a selective reading protocol (such as red dots), the selection may not only restrict the reading, but may also convey the researcher's influence by revealing the researcher's intention to the participants.

### *Retrospective Protocol*

Ericsson and Simon (1984/1993) referred to the retrospective report as "a durable (if partial) memory trace is laid down of the information heeded successively while completing the task" (p. 16). Scotto-Boyan (2002) reported that "retrospective reports are believed to come from one's short-term memory, hence are reliable, if the time between the task and reports is short" (p. 60), agreeing with Ericsson and Simon's ideas. Gamps (2003) also asserted that "retrospective protocols are typically performed immediately after the completion of tasks, and participants are asked to report on the thoughts they had while they were completing the task" (p. 203). Afflerbach and Johnston (1984) also commented that retrospective reports are produced after a person performs experiential tasks offering insight on the performance of the task.

Kormos (1998) used the retrospective protocol to investigate verbal reports in L2 speech production. Also, Izumi and Bigelow (2000) examined the interrelationship between output and second language acquisition. In her dissertation, Scotto-Boyan (2002) investigated 4<sup>th</sup>-grade students' reading strategies after reading segments of text in a group setting. Technically, this is a retrospective protocol, but she called the method a TA process because in her sense it was concurrent.

### *Limitation of the Retrospective Protocol:*

Retrospective protocols may draw from short- and long-term memory depending on the length of the task performed and the amount of time between the end of the task and the beginning of the verbal report. Nisbett and Wilson (1977; as cited in Ericsson & Simon, 1984/1993, p. 27) addressed two main issues with the retrospective protocol. Their first concern was, “People often cannot report accurately on the effects of particular stimuli on higher-order, inference-based responses” (p. 26). Their second concern was that “the subjects, when asked questions about their cognitive processes, frequently do not base their answers on memory for specific events at all, but ‘theorize’ about their processes” (as cited in Ericsson & Simon, 1984/1993, p. 27).

Afflerbach and Johnston (1984) pointed out that probing questions “have the effect of increasing the explicitness of the reports and, hence, the reliability of the reports” (p. 312). Well-prepared questions are suggested to better capture readers’ thinking process while reading stories.

### *Suggestions*

Ericsson and Simon (1984/1993) answered Nisbett and Wilson’s qualms about retrospective protocols,

The accuracy of verbal reports depends on the procedures used to elicit them and the relation between the requested information and the actual sequence of heeded information. Invalid reports, like those discussed and obtained by Nisbett and Wilson, may be due to lack of access to thoughts (their aim), inadequate procedures for eliciting verbal reports, or requesting information that could not be provided even if thoughts were accessible. (p. 27)

Ericsson and Simon's suggestion was very helpful for me in developing my verbal protocol. They reminded me of the importance of the researcher's aim, concrete procedure, and attention.

Ericsson and Simon (1984/1993) demonstrated only minimal differences between the concurrent protocol and the retrospective protocol, "the retrospective reports resemble each other as closely or more closely than they do the corresponding concurrent protocols" (p. 371). They also suggested that "the protocol study, while only a single example of verbalized data from highly skilled performance, should demonstrate the feasibility of examining the stability and adaptation of processes under varying conditions" (p. 371).

I chose several short-story picture books and two chapters on different topics of a story book for the verbal protocol because I was concerned with the student's memory trace. Also, I modified my verbal protocol, including retrospective protocol with a hint of concurrent protocol focusing on the purpose of my research. I also used probes to enhance the insight of the study. I mainly conducted the retrospective protocol immediately after the completion of the task. Ericsson and Simon (1984/1993) explained the advantages of both methods, noting that the use of concurrent protocols collects data as the processing task is being performed while recognizing the benefits of retrospective protocols as complementary data. Gamps (2003) advocated Ericsson and Simon's recommendation of research methods, emphasizing the use of the retrospective protocol. A detailed description of the verbal protocol used in this study follows.



### Verbal Protocol Used in This Study

To investigate ELLs' second language literacy strategies, I used a verbal protocol in this study. Ericsson and Simon (1984/1993) favor a more open-ended method of letting participants react retrospectively to their experiences. Participant's verbal reports using the verbal protocol conveyed their use of reading strategies while reading the selected stories. Following Ericsson and Simon (1984/1993), my study focused more on the retrospective protocol while collecting data, but still used the concurrent protocol to examine second language literacy development in the ELLs' reading strategies. Ericsson and Simon (1980) stressed the risk of subjects' fallible memory when discussing their cognitive experiences. I chose short stories to decrease this risk.

As an important methodological point, I realized that retrospective reports should be collected immediately after the completion of the task. The verbal protocol in this study is close to the retrospective protocol, but still grasps the moments when the thinking process occurs (Erickson & Simon, 1984/1993; Gamps, 2003; Pressley, M. & Afflerbach, 1995). Participants spoke to their thinking process while they were reading and asked me questions as they came up. My intention was to create a more comfortable environment and procedure for them while making meaning in a natural context.

A practice session of the verbal protocol was observed. Participants had one session to practice thinking aloud before conducting the verbal protocols for this study. The ELLs in this study were able to practice thinking aloud while reading the story during the practice session. The open atmosphere helped me gain insight into their thinking process. I explained to the participants my interest in learning what children think about as they read. Because I was unable to see what goes on in a student's mind

during the reading, I explained, the reader needed to verbalize his or her thoughts aloud. I told the students that this activity was called the process of thinking aloud.

During all sessions, I tape recorded the participants' perceptions and comprehension of the stories without any researcher's influence or interruptions. With all my consciousness of verbal protocols for reading research, I queried the participants with well-prepared specific questions to obtain their thinking process. I took notes about what was going on during the reading. The participants talked aloud during and after reading (Ericsson & Simon, 1984/1993). The participants were also told that they could ask any questions and request translations if so desired.

Finally, verbal reports were obtained for simple stories. Olson et al. (1984) explained how their studies related to verbal protocols: "The final product of understanding through thinking-aloud data will be an interpreted representation of the essential element to the story" (p. 265). I investigated what the reader was doing while reading each story. The interviews and the verbal reports were tape recorded, transcribed and coded as shown in Table 2.

Table 2

*Coding System Used in the Transcription*

| Code | Meaning                                |
|------|----------------------------------------|
| R    | Researcher in interviews and protocols |
| J    | Jae-min in interviews and protocols    |
| K    | Kyle in interviews and protocols       |
| L    | Lilly in interviews and protocols      |
| Y    | Yanton in interviews and protocols     |
| JM   | Jae-min's mother in interviews         |
| KM   | Kyle's mother in interviews            |
| LM   | Lilly's mother in interviews           |
| YM   | Yanton's mother in interviews          |
| MG   | Teacher: Ms. Green in interviews       |
| ML   | Teacher: Ms. Lopez in interviews       |
| P    | Verbal protocol sessions               |

## Materials: Culturally and Nonculturally Relevant Stories

The selection of materials is very important and was done carefully. The materials include culturally relevant content and nonculturally relevant content, but all of the selections are well formed. Bishop's (1993) guideline was used for selecting materials. I used four to five different stories for the protocol and voluntary written retelling. I defined culturally relevant stories as including the ELL's cultural concepts, events, values, beliefs, and cultural experiences. For example, cultural experiences included the

experience of arriving in the United States. This experience could be very significant for ELLs in understanding the concepts of *cultural shock* and *cultural adaptation* (Brown, H. D., 2000; Schumann, 1978). The stories used in this study are listed in Tables 3 and 4.

Table 3

*Culturally Relevant Stories*

| Title                                   | Author                        |
|-----------------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| <i>Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes</i>    | Margaret Wade                 |
| <i>Woodcutter and Tiger Brother</i>     | Nami Rhee                     |
| <i>I Hate English</i>                   | Ellen Levine                  |
| <i>Pettson and Findus</i>               | Silke Erbert & Sven Nordqvist |
| <i>Family Pictures (Fair, Birthday)</i> | Carmen Lomas Garza            |
| <i>Passage to Freedom</i>               | Ken Mochizuki                 |

Table 4

*Nonculturally Relevant Stories*

| Title                                     | Author      |
|-------------------------------------------|-------------|
| <i>Follow the Dream</i>                   | Peter Sis   |
| <i>Encounter</i>                          | Jane Yolen  |
| <i>Hiroko Makes the Team</i>              | Crennan Ray |
| <i>The Wall</i>                           | Alvaro Cruz |
| <i>Wilfrid Gordon MacDonald Partridge</i> | Mem Fox     |

## *The Stories*

### *Nonculturally relevant stories*

*Follow the Dream* (Sis, 1991): A short story about Christopher Columbus written from the European perspective. Through the intricate and richly detailed pictures, the story explores the 15<sup>th</sup>-century world, giving a thorough description of Christopher Columbus's journey.

*Encounter* (Yolen, 1992): A boy tells of Christopher Columbus' landing in America. This story was written from the Native American perspective. The boy warns the elders of his tribe about the newcomers and their invasion. The elders ignore his warning. Soon the invaders have taken over the land and kidnapped their children. The boy jumps into ocean to escape from them.

*Hiroko Makes the Team* (Ray, 1985): Bullied by her brother and friends, Hiroko feels she cannot do anything. When she decides to practice swimming, they laugh at her. However, through diligent practice, she wins the race.

*The Wall* (Cruz, 1985): Four children want to do something with their extra time. They ask Molly's grandmother and get permission to draw pictures on her wall. Each child draws pictures of the place where they came from.

*Wilfrid Gordon MacDonald Partridge* (Fox, 1989): This is a short story about a little boy named Wilfrid Gordon McDonald Partridge. He lives next to a retirement home. One day, Wilfrid hears his parents saying about how Miss Nancy has lost her memory. The boy wants to know what a memory is and asks to each of neighbors. He collects materials to help Miss Nancy's memory. When he gives them to Miss Nancy, she gets her memory back.

*Culturally relevant stories*

*Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes* (Wade, 1985): In this Chinese Cinderella story, Mei Ping overcomes the hardship caused by her stepmother and stepsister. She meets the prince at the festival and gets married. The author modified the Cinderella story using different subject elements such as silver shoes instead of glass shoes and a goose and goose feathers. The story is illustrated with Asian features and appearance.

*Woodcutter and Tiger Brother* (Rhee, 1988): This short story is a Korean folk tale illustrated in the tradition Korean arts style. A woodcutter outwits a horrible tiger by making him believe that he is the woodcutter's old brother who used to be human. The tiger shows his faithfulness to his mother by bringing dead animals for his mother until her death. This showed the woodcutter's wit. It also shows that Bong-Yang (faithfulness to one's parents) is a primary virtue of the Korean people; human beings and even a tiger believed in spirits.

*I Hate English* (Levine, 1989): Mei Mei has just arrived in New York from Hong Kong. She thinks English is a very lonely language and resists speaking it. She has a hard time adjusting to America. With Miss Nancy, her teacher, Mei Mei learns that she can have the best of both languages and both worlds. This story shows the ELL's journey of language learning and cultural adaptation well.

*Pettson and Findus* (Erbert & Nordqvist, 2001): This is a traditional Swedish children's book. An old man named Pettson was given Findus the cat by a friend. Findus comes up with creative ideas and does funny things in the story, and it made an old and lonely Pettson busy. For example, sometimes he disappears and Pettson tries to find him.

He hides in very funny places. The illustration of the book is very detailed and funny to show Findus's funny behaviors.

*Family Pictures: Cuadros de familia* (Garza, 1990): This is the story of Carmen Lomas Garza's girlhood in Kingsville, Texas: celebrating birthdays, making tamales, and going to the fair in Mexico. Fourteen episodes are illustrated in a narrative way, focusing on each of the traditional parts of Mexican American culture. The Spanish-English text format is used. The author offers a book that reflects Hispanic people's lives and cultural traditions, expressing a strong sense of family and community.

*Passage to Freedom: The Sugihara Story* (Mochizuki, 1997): This is the story of Mr. Sugihara, the Japanese ambassador to Lithuania during the Second World War, as told through the eyes of his son. The father (Mr. Sugihara) issued thousands of visas to Jews fleeing the Nazi soldiers despite rejection by his government. The epilogue tells how the Sugihara family was imprisoned for 18 months by the Soviets. Mr. Sugihara received the "Righteous Among Nations" Award from Yad Vashem, the Holocaust memorial in Israel.

#### *Materials for Each Participant*

All stories for the study are well formed. Two culturally relevant stories were used for each participant. Two nonculturally relevant stories were used for Lilly and Yanton. Three nonculturally relevant stories were used for Jae-min and Kyle. For Jae-min and Kyle, I used two versions of the Christopher Columbus story as one set.

Culturally relevant stories were assigned to each ELL in various ways because the students were from different countries and had different cultural experiences. One of the culturally relevant stories assigned to each participant related directly to the participant's

home culture and cultural concepts through the story. For example, *Woodcutter and Tiger Brother* was assigned to Jae-min, *Passage to Freedom* to Kyle, *Family Pictures* to Lilly, and *Pettson and Findus* to Yanton. I assigned *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes* to the two Asian participants, Jae-min and Kyle, because it was a Chinese Cinderella story.

I also assigned *I Hate English* as a culturally relevant story to Lilly and Yanton, because the Mei Mei's experience of arriving in the United States was similar to these children's recent cultural experiences. The cultural experience is very significant for ELLs, especially their culture shock and language shock (Brown, H. D., 2000). Igoa (1995) explained culture shock as "the child become depressed or confused and let down. If the child compares himself or herself to the 'mainstream' children, he or she may feel hopeless of ever catching up or belonging" (p. 44).

The levels of the materials were also carefully considered in the selection process because each ELL's English proficiency was different. I selected materials based on their English proficiency and cultural orientation.

Furthermore, I used different levels of books for Jae-min and Kyle because I wanted to know their responses to these different levels. They did more verbal protocols than the others so I could see their reaction to various task levels. The use of the materials also varied slightly for each student because each participant had a different level of English proficiency, first language, culture, and cultural experiences in the United States. Table 5 presents the stories assigned to each participant.



Table 5

*Stories Assigned to Each Participant*

| Participant | Nonculturally relevant stories                                                       | Culturally relevant stories                                                                         |
|-------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Jae-min     | <i>Hiroko Makes the Team</i><br><i>Follow the Dream/Encounter</i><br><i>The Wall</i> | <i>Woodcutter and Tiger Brother</i> : Korean folk tale<br><i>Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes</i>      |
| Kyle        | <i>Hiroko Makes the Team</i><br><i>Follow the Dream/Encounter</i><br><i>The Wall</i> | <i>Passage to Freedom</i> : Story based on Japanese history<br><i>Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes</i> |
| Lilly       | <i>Hiroko Makes the Team</i><br><i>The Wall</i>                                      | <i>Family Pictures</i> : Hispanic children's book<br><i>I Hate English</i>                          |
| Yanton      | <i>Hiroko Makes the Team</i><br><i>Wilfrid Gordon McDonald</i><br><i>Partridge</i>   | <i>Pettson and Findus</i> : Swedish children's book<br><i>I Hate English</i>                        |

## The Verbal Protocol Sessions

The question-asking procedure of the verbal protocols was tape recorded and later transcribed. A number of questions were asked in the form of after-the-fact talking immediately after each story. The questions elicited the students' response, understanding, comprehension, experiences, and interpretation of the stories. The four students participated in each verbal protocol session in the classroom after school, in the library, and in their home. The procedure was the same for each session.

### *General Guideline*

These are sample questions for the verbal protocols.

#### *Meaning Construction*

1. What are you thinking as you are reading this?
2. Can you retell the story?
3. What makes you have that meaning?
4. Why do you think that way?
5. Why not another way?
6. What words are most important for this story?
7. What do you mean by this?

#### *Dialogue and Interaction Between the Story and the Reader*

1. How do you feel after reading this story?
2. Why do you feel this way? Which words or sentences in the story give you this feeling?
3. Could you describe the setting of this story?
4. Do you like this story? If so, could you tell me the reason?
5. Does this story remind you of any event in your experience? Tell me the about that.
6. Does this story remind you of any stories you have read before? Tell me the other stories.
7. What do you think about the author?
8. Why do you think the author wrote this story?
9. What parts of the story are most significant for you?

10. Why do you think that part is so important for the story or for you?
11. What do you think of the main characters' behavior?

### *Activities*

Olson et al. (1984) described the verbal protocol as one of the most effective and useful research tools for exploring the mental and reading processes that form the comprehension and meaning negotiation in the literacy development process. The activity guideline for the verbal protocol was developed based on understanding Lytle's (1982), Mikulecky's (1991), and Scotto-Boyan's (2002) prompts to encourage students to respond to literature.

1. *Modeling think aloud while reading a short story.* During the modeling, I modeled how to think aloud while reading stories. For example, "what I am thinking about?" I verbalized the thoughts that came to my mind while reading.
2. *Practicing think aloud.* Participants in this study practiced think aloud after reading a short paragraph of the story. I also asked "What were you thinking about"? As a preparation stage, the practice session allowed the ELLs to practice thinking aloud while reading stories. One short story was used to practice the thinking aloud process.
3. *Informing stage.* I explained the procedure and let them know that they were allowed to ask questions, make any comments they liked, and have any assistance they needed.
4. *Reading.* Participants read a short storybook or a chapter from a longer storybook written in English. They were allowed to talk or verbalize their thoughts and

thinking process during the reading. Translation was offered as necessary. When the students finished reading the selection, they wrote a retelling if they desired.

5. *Verbal reports.* Participants read a short story and verbalized about the story and their thoughts, to expose their thinking process immediately after completion of the task. Prompting questions were used if necessary. Students were encouraged to make comments, ask questions, and write responses during and after the reading. When they finished the oral retelling, the students were asked the specific questions for the verbal protocol.
6. *Processing.* All of the procedures were tape recorded and transcribed. This activity was completed for four to five different stories identified as culturally and nonculturally relevant.

### *Positionality*

During this study, I remained aware of my dual positionality as a researcher and as a second language learner. I also conducted the study as a human instrument or participant-observer (Merriam, 1998). As a researcher and a second language learner myself, I was aware of my important position in maintaining the credibility of this research (Lincoln & Guba, 1985).

However, there are significant benefits, in addition to weaknesses, in my dual position as a researcher and a second language learner. I did research as an insider (Lincoln & Guba, 1985), a second language learner who has lived through experiences (Rosenblatt, 1978) in the United States. My position as a researcher and a second language learner stimulated me to observe, consider, and explore the ELLs' language development in literacy events in more depth. I can also do persistent observations

(Lincoln & Guba) to understand the ELLs' interaction with their teachers and prolonged engagement (Lincoln & Guba) during the study, even though my preconceived notions of the second language experience might hamper my interpretation.

As I mentioned, my dual position was precarious in terms of gaining credibility for this research. I studied as a participant–observer in the language arts/literature classroom in order to better understand language development phenomena and context during October 2003–December 2004. I focused on participants' interaction with peers and the teacher while engaging in meaningful tasks in classroom.

I was familiar with these weaknesses and strengths of my positionality and remained as neutral as possible at every moment, especially in the data analysis stage. I did *peer debriefing* (Lincoln & Guba, 1985) with a person outside of my field who had an understanding of the research topic and children learning. This process exposed my inquiry process to outside scrutiny. The *reflexive journal* (Lincoln & Guba) was also helpful in maintaining credibility. Thus, I developed my positional weaknesses into strengths.

### Data Collection Techniques

My data collection derived from two main avenues: the verbal protocols and the qualitative data collection techniques. The verbal protocols were used to investigate the second language learners' reading strategy use and the qualitative data collection was used to describe the ELLs' second language literacy development process in the social context.

### *Verbal Reports*

The verbal protocols were used to investigate the ELLs' reading strategies while reading stories. Culturally and nonculturally relevant stories were used to conduct the verbal protocols. The activities for the verbal protocols were discussed earlier in this chapter. The audiotapes were transcribed into verbal reports. Verbal reports were collected and archived for the study.

### *Qualitative Data Collection*

I relied on three sources for data collection concerning the literacy development of ELLs in Apple city: (a) I visited the participants' classrooms and homes, collecting field notes as I observed; (b) I interviewed the participants, the four second language learner volunteers, and the two language arts/literature teachers; and (c) I explored the ELLs' documents and reading responses, which they developed in the classroom. My study was conducted for a period of 15 months from October 2003 through December 2004.

### *Observations*

To discover the ELLs' language development process, I visited and observed my focal students' language arts/literature classrooms at GO elementary school in Apple city once or twice a week from October 2003 through December 2004 as a participant observer and I visited each student's home several times. During these observations, I focused not only on the students' language development in literacy activities, but also on the interactions between the teachers and peers in the classroom as a social world. My field notes were a crucial tool in keeping track of information and gathering data. I took notes describing the classroom, the children's activities, and the child-teacher interaction

in as much detail as I could during the observation period. I elaborated on my notes within 24 hours. I also created techniques to “map” the classroom interaction in my study proposal.

### *Interviews*

During the research period, I conducted two interviews with each of the four focal ELLs and two language arts/literature teachers (each of whom is a focal group teacher). The first interview with each participant was conducted in the beginning of the research period, and the second was conducted in the middle of the research period. Interviewing is “a common means of collecting qualitative data” (Merriam, 1998, p. 106). Each interview lasted no longer than 30 minutes and was tape recorded and transcribed. As I interviewed the participants, I focused not only on how the ELLs participate and engage in reading activities, but also on how the teachers interacted with the ELLs in their classes. Each interview was based upon data gathered up to that point and served to clarify, verify, and expand upon findings. I also did a member check for crystallization (Janesick, 1994) using an interview format after I finished the whole interview process.

### *Documentation*

I examined the texts the participants had written in class, such as journals, papers, and tests. All these documents are important in developing a map of the participants’ second language literacy development process through their literacy events and schooling. These documents from the classroom allowed me to listen to the ELLs’ own emic voices and stories and develop thick narrative descriptions.

## Data Analysis

I analyzed the data derived from the interviews (with teachers, with participants, and with the parents), the verbal reports (developed from verbal protocol), the observations, and the documents. Verbal reports were analyzed along the lines of the qualitative research method. Manual data coding of the protocol excerpts was based on inductive analysis following the qualitative research method. I also used the Atlas.ti program for the coding.

### *Verbal Report Analysis*

The verbal protocols were mainly used to analyze the reading strategies used while reading. Olshavsky (1975) explored specific types of data analysis for his verbal reports. Beach (1997) investigated research on response categories, levels, and processes. He explored the category systems I have used to describe the types and levels of the readers' responses. I developed the verbal report analysis based on these researchers' results.

First, the tape recorded responses were transcribed and the participants' pauses and meaningful behaviors were noted. Second, the transcribed protocols were examined and were manually coded as to the clause or clauses with which they corresponded. Also, descriptions of the participant's responses to the clauses were written beside each subject's response.

Third, I entered the transcribed verbal reports into the Atlas.ti program. Fourth, I developed a coding with quotations through Atlas.ti including memos of the participants' responses to the clauses. Fifth, the two coded protocols, the manual coding and the coding developed through Atlas.ti, were compared and contrasted to triangulate the study.



Sixth, the analytical frameworks emanating from the content analyses of the written and oral protocols were used to illustrate types, levels, and quality of responses. These frameworks helped me to see various perspectives on reading process research.

Seventh, I developed classifications of the verbal reports as a taxonomy emerged. Eighth, I developed categorizations of verbal reports. Ninth, I created categorizations of the verbal reports comparing and contrasting participants' reading strategies. Tenth, the categories of the study from verbal reports emerged inductively.

Several analyses were conducted based on Olshavsky's (1975) categorization and definitions. Afflerbach and Johnston (1984) recommended the inclusion of categorizations derived from the students' verbal protocols. These categorizations gave me valuable background knowledge for this study's design, and the emergent categories were improved as a result. I derived the categorizations of the study from the students' verbal protocols by the inductive method based on the qualitative research approach.

### *Verbal Reports and Representation*

All sessions of the verbal protocols process were tape recorded and transcribed. The verbal reports were described as a protocol analysis. Data were analyzed for my general categorizations based on the reading strategies employed. As the categorizations were devised, I further analyzed the verbal protocols to succinctly distinguish the reading strategies. I employed a two-level approach in analyzing the data. In keeping with the theoretical and philosophical research, the analysis focused on the individual readers, their learning and reading strategies, and the themes that emerged naturally from their literacy developmental processes.

A comprehensive profile of each of the four participants as an ELL was compiled because the reading behaviors and processes of an individual are more comprehensible when observed as one aspect of a set of personal characteristics (Carrell, 1989). The profiles revealed each participant's unique identity as a reader as well as an ELL by highlighting the similarities and differences among the participants' reading strategies and meaning construction.

### *Qualitative Research Analysis*

My main research bias in this study stemmed from my position as a second language learner. Through my observations as a participant-observer, my interviews with the language arts/literature teachers, and my field notes, I gathered a generous dataset from multiple sources. For the triangulation of the data collection and data analysis, I used not only multiple sources of data such as observation, interviews, and artifacts, but also multiple methods, such as inductive analysis, member check, and long-term observation, to confirm the emerging findings (Lincoln & Guba, 1985). This process gave a "holistic understanding" (Mathison, 1988, p.17) of the situation to construct "plausible explanations about the phenomena being studied" (p. 17).

L. Richardson (1994) emphasized that "in the social sciences there is only interpretation. Nothing speaks for itself" (p. 500). After gathering data in my pilot studies, I was always faced with the difficulties and challenges of making sense of the data. First, as Lincoln and Guba (1985) discussed, data analysis should be based on unbiased methods using tacit knowledge and the formative theories. My data analysis was based on my theoretical framework and literature review. As I revisited my questions and

theoretical frameworks, I came up with a variety of findings by exploring the verbal reports and other collected data and assembling a taxonomy of items (Merriam, 1998).

Second, by creating taxonomies (LeCompte, 2000) for this research, items were arranged by the specific units forming the basis of coding systems. Discussing Spradley's (1979) ideas of taxonomies, LeCompte and Schensul (1999) explained that they "visually represent the hierarchical ordering of items as well as the linkages and relationships among various items in a domain" (p. 74). These taxonomies are useful in classifying information and may be a critical step in identifying structures in the cultural life in ethnographic studies (LeCompte & Schensul). "Coding qualitative data enables the researcher to recognize and recontextualize data, allowing a fresh view of what is there" (Coffey & Atkinson, 1996, p. 45). When I finished identifying and finding items, I counted the items, recounted the variance, identified relationships, and created patterns using analytical methods.

Third, I reconfirmed the themes and findings through member checking with my participants, by thick description (Lincoln & Guba, 1985), and by crystallization (Janesick, 1994; Richardson, L., 1994) to develop the trustworthiness of this study. I was ever aware of ensuring data credibility, reliability, and transferability (Lincoln & Guba, 1985) for my interpretation and representation. Proceeding step by step, I analyzed the ELLs' second language literacy development process via the inductive methodology (Lincoln & Guba).

Lincoln & Guba (1985, p. 202) defined *inductive data analysis* as a "process for making sense of field data." They also explored two essential subprocesses, *unitizing* and *categorizing*, for inductive data analysis. They explained unitizing as a process of coding

and categorizing as a process involving provisional categories on the basis of “look-like” characteristics based on a naturalistic paradigm.

*Thick description* is a term from anthropology meaning the complete, literal description of the incident or entity being investigated. Merriam (1998) stated that “case studies included as many variables as possible and portray their interaction, often over a period of time. . . . They have also been labeled holistic, lifelike, grounded, and exploratory” (p. 30). Thick description also provides enough description to enable audiences to determine how closely their situations match the research context. Thus, findings can be transferred to them for a deeper understanding and a proper application.

Janesick (1994) explained, “crystallization recognizes the many facets of any given approach to the social world as a fact of life. The image of the crystal replaces that of the land surveyor and the triangle” (p. 392). Coffey and Atkinson (1996) said, “crude understandings of triangulation often imply that data from different sources, or derived from different methods, can be aggregated in some way in order to produce a full rounded, more authentic, portrayal of the social world” (p. 14). Thus, to avoid my researcher bias and to maintain credibility, I maintained triangulation, member check, thick description, and crystallization while gathering and analyzing data for the trustworthiness of the study (Lincoln and Guba, 1985).

### *Trustworthiness*

Trustworthiness (Lincoln & Guba, 1985; Merriam, 1998) was developed at every step of the study. I maintained credibility, which includes prolonged engagement, persistent observation in the classroom, triangulation, peer debriefing with an impartial friend, and member checking (Lincoln & Guba; Merriam). I maintained not only

transferability by doing triangulation and thick description, but also dependability by dialoguing with ongoing naturalistic inquiry and research questions (Lincoln & Guba).

Merriam (1998) also suggested that validity would be established by the triangulation of multiple data sets, multiple research methods, variable “keep-on-going” questioning, awareness of positionality, discourse with research questions, dialogue with literature review, and deep interaction with participants throughout the study. By doing member checks and reviewing the process and findings, I not only established trustworthiness of the study, but also maintained the reliability, transferability, and confirmability of the study (Lincoln & Guba, 1985). The methods and research process also were confirmed with impartial friends.

#### Limitations of Verbal Protocol

Using the verbal protocol to study reading strategies has several inherent limitations. The study was conducted based on retrospective protocol with a hint of the concurrent protocol because participants verbalized their thinking process while and immediately after reading the stories to avoid hindering memory issues.

Vocalization of the students’ thinking process may account for portions of the variation in the findings. The protocol techniques are limited to capturing what participants are thinking while reading stories despite the researcher’s consciousness. The protocol is close to, but not the equivalent of, their thinking process because there might be some differences between their real thinking process and their vocalization. The open-minded setting and the modified research method were designed to minimize this discrepancy.

Participants' language ability was assessed during the process. Participants may have limited their vocalization of their thinking aloud while reading stories, especially given that the participants in this study are ELLs. Their vocalizations might have hampered them because of their language proficiency. For the beginner ELL, using verbal protocols can be very difficult because his or her English proficiency is limited. For example, due to his limited English proficiency, Yanton's mother provided translation to facilitate his verbal protocols.

### Limitations and Significance of the Study

Like most qualitative research, this study should be not generalizable, both because I used a small population for the study and because I did the study in a particular context. The study was conducted in higher socioeconomic area and participants were from various cultural backgrounds. However, the results of the study will be transferable through rich description via the ELLs' emic voices and their own stories in other second language learning contexts. Transferability is established by describing the means for applying the research findings to other contexts (Stringer, 1999). The possibility of applying findings across settings is established through thick description and emic voices that enable audiences to understand and identify similarities between the research setting and other contexts. In addition, it enables other audiences to approach and see themselves or their situations in the accounts presented. Qualitative research was a good means to give us their stories on the second language literacy developmental process.

CHAPTER 4  
HOLISTIC VIEWS OF SECOND LANGUAGE LEARNING:  
FOUR CASES

The purpose of the study was to investigate second language learners' literacy development processes from a sociocultural constructivist perspective. My goal was to understand how learning a second language can be improved not only by interacting and dialoguing among learners, texts, and social contexts, but also by focusing on literacy within one content area, language arts/literature, a meaningful context. My goal was fine tuned to use verbal protocols to examine what strategies second language learners use as they engage in literacy to understand the second language literacy learning process.

In chapters 4, 5, and 6, I address the process of second language literacy development by exploring the following research question:

What is the learning process involved in second language literacy development of English language learners in their language arts/literature class in an elementary school setting?

The following three subquestions aid me in answering this main question:

1. How do English language learners move toward literacy in English as a second language in the language arts/literature class?
2. What strategies do English language learners use while reading stories?
3. How do English language learners interact with their teacher and peers in acquiring their literacy skills in the language arts/literature class?

To understand the second language literacy learning process, I used data from participants' verbal protocols, my observations, the interviews, the students' documents, and my filed notes. A qualitative analysis of the data was performed, allowing the

readers' strategies to emerge from the ongoing analysis. This qualitative analysis helped me see a holistic view of this study, including the verbal protocol analysis and other outcomes through different data sources.

The results of the study are divided into three chapters: Chapter 4 presents a holistic view of second language learning in four cases. Chapter 5 presents the results of the verbal protocol and the reading strategies used. Chapter 6 presents the results from the qualitative research: (a) ELLs and identity and (b) ELLs' dialogue in second language literacy.

In order to explore the holistic view of second language learning, this study was analyzed closely based on data from multiple avenues. There are important social factors that influence ELLs' learning process because they are learning English in a social context. The data for these four cases derive from six main avenues: (a) verbal reports, (b) interviews with the participants, (c) interviews with their teachers, (d) interviews with their parents, (e) documents, and (f) my field notes from my classroom observations and home visits.

#### Procedure for Compiling the Profiles

Each case begins with a brief description of the participant, including family background, language use at home, home literacy, and schooling history. Then I describe the reader's reading behaviors and habits, perceptions of reading in which the reader constructs meaning, and self-concept as a reader while reading. Also, emergent discussion and comments are described and analyzed as subsections where appropriate. I also explored special factors that might influence ELLs' language learning in each case, including their learning environments, literacy activity, conceptualizations of reading and



learning to read, second language literacy development process, and social interaction.

Wong Fillmore (1991), studying individual differences in second language acquisition, found that

The nature of the task, the sets of strategies they needed to apply in dealing with it, and the way certain personal characteristics such as language habits, motivations, social needs and habitual approaches to problems affected the way they attacked it. (p. 220)

### The Classroom as a Social Context

Two classrooms provided the social context for this study, Ms. Green's classroom from October 2003 to May 2004 and Ms. Lopez's classroom from August 2004 to December 2004. This study began conducting data from Ms. Green's classroom. Ms. Green, who has ESL endorsement, teaches ELLs as pull outs in her language arts/literature classroom.

These classrooms had several students who are from different countries, giving her classroom the feel of an international setting. Ms. Green said, "We have so many different languages here at GO elementary school. We have Sweden, we have people from India, Spanish, Italian, all sorts of Asian, so we have a real need" (MG-1). She also explained the pullout program for ELLs in her school curriculum,

Usually I have them in my class, so it's a little bit easier than pulling them from other classes. But usually every year I had about three to four and they've all been different. And we had other ESL teachers here so we try to break it down per grade level. (MG-2)

Participants from Ms. Green's classroom in this study were assigned together into Ms. Lopez's class from August 2004 to May 2005, with the of Ms. Anthony, a principal of GO elementary school.

## Four English Language Learners

When I first met them, three of the students were enrolled in the same 2<sup>nd</sup>-grade language arts/literature class and one student came to this classroom as a pull out student. The 4 ELLs in this study shared some similarities and had some differences. They all had learned English as a second language, and had authentic second language learning experiences in the United States. They also had various ethnic backgrounds and cultures and all different first languages. Jae-min's first language is Korean, Kyle's is Japanese, Lilly's is Spanish, and Yanton's is Swedish. They also have various levels of English proficiency.

In order to interview the participants' parents and do the verbal protocols, I visited each ELL's home. I was able to read their home culture, home environment, and living style in an ethnographic way. In terms of socioeconomic background, Jae-min, Kyle, and Yanton were from the middle class, but Lilly was from a lower-income family than the others. All the families were highly educated, and all family members were significantly aware of the participants' language learning and literacy development process. Therefore, all family members were supportive of this study and wanted to share the outcomes after the study was completed.

## The Cases

### *Jae-min Sees Reading as Brainpower*

Jae-min is an exemplary 2<sup>nd</sup> grader who has a very positive attitude toward the teacher, his peers, and the subject matter in the class. He is very sweet and has a big soft smile all the time. He was very impressive when I first met him. I asked him some questions in Korean, because I already knew he was Korean. He answered in Korean

without any hesitation. Surprisingly, he is fluent in Korean although he was born in the United States. His articulation and pronunciation of Korean were as perfect as that of boys born in Korea. He learned to read and write Korean at the age of 5. When he began learning how to speak English at kindergarten, he had already mastered Korean as his first language. This case reminds me of Native American and Hispanic children who were born in the United States but are learning English as a second language. Everything Jae-min came across seemed to enchant him, especially if it had to do with *Dragon*.

### *Family and Background*

Jae-min lives with his father, mother, and sister, whose name is Yuri. His father came to the United States as an international student and decided to stay. He earned a Ph.D. in chemistry and is now working at one of the research centers in town. Jae-min's mother has a soft voice and is very religious. She did not speak English well, and became passive in social situations. Obviously, one of main reasons Jae-min learned Korean as a first language is his mother's limited English proficiency. Jae-min said, "my mom doesn't know English, so she goes to school just like my dad did a long time ago" (J-6).

Jae-min's mother realized the need to learn English to support her children's education. She said,

I am taking classes because of English. Because I have kids, I have many chances to talk with their teachers and parents at schools. I thought my English is not good enough to interact with them and to help students with whatever they need. (JM-2)

This interview clip shows her focus on her children's education. Jae-min's family was very focused on education and Korean culture.

### *Language Use at Home*

As mentioned above, Jae-min was born in the United States, but his parents taught him Korean as a first language. Jae-min's mother said,

Mostly, He is Korean. We intentionally spoke Korean to him because we were afraid that he might lose his Korean. We (including Jae-min) had a lot of opportunities to speak Korean in New Jersey because there are so many Koreans to interact with. We try to speak Korean at home. (JM-2)

They raised him as Korean. They spoke only Korean at home. Furthermore, "Whenever we went traveling, we played Korean children songs to him, and we tried to teach him Korean as much as we could. S. Lee (1996) noted that in her study, "Korean identity was promoted by Korean parents and by the Korean community in the area" (p. 114). And, our families in Korea send many Korean books, including math books" (JM-2). This interview clip explained not only his Korean learning experience, but also Jae-min's mother's emphasis on teaching Korean language and culture. When I visited his home, his home was surrounded with books written in Korean and rich cultural materials.

### *Home Literacy*

Jae-min's mother explained his literacy activity, "he wrote lots of diary at home." She said,

I keep his diaries. I will show you later on. He likes to write very much. He usually writes and draws every day. What we care about is that we want him to read a lot of books, rather than building up some vocabulary. We go to the public library once a week and check out 4 or 5 books that Jae-min likes to read. (JM-8)

The parents used the whole-language approach as they taught Jae-min to read using a range of stories. He was constantly surrounded by rich reading materials written in both Korean and English. His positive attitude toward reading was very impressive. He had a

concrete idea of “a good reader.” He thought he had to read eight books every day to be a good reader, because he is 8 years old. These eight books included cartoons, picture books written in Korean or in English, magazines, and books he had already read. He liked to read repetitively. He felt it would reinforce him to be a better reader in the future.

### *Schooling History*

As mentioned above, Korean was the main language in the household. Before the family came to Apple city, they lived in a Korean community in New Jersey until he entered kindergarten. In New Jersey, Jae-min had little exposure to Anglophones until the age of five. He learned English as a second language for a short time in preschool and mainly in kindergarten. Jae-min’s English was very fluent, and he had the highest English proficiency of the participants in this study.

Jae-min liked reading and had very good competence in reading in both English and Korean. Ms. Green explained that he had some confusion in verbal transitions and confused *he* and *she*. Interestingly, these confusions are very common in ELLs. For example, Lilly had the same confusion. Ms. Green was also concerned by his fast processing during the literacy activities. Overall, she compared him to other first language learners in his English proficiency. She added that “his English proficiency was as high as a first language learner” (MG-10). Jae-min liked writing and was a good writer, “when he does write, he writes very long stories” (MG-10).

### *Reading Behavior and Reading Habits*

Jae-min’s mother demonstrated that he learned English mainly through his interaction with peers and the teacher in social contexts within the ZPD. According to Lilly’s mother, Lilly learned English the same way in her classroom context. Jae-min’s

mother believed the interaction with peers provided and enhanced his comprehensible input to learn English in a social context. “The school taught English, and he interacted with English speaking kids and teachers. Therefore, we didn’t have to teach him English. No problem at all with speaking English” (JM-2).

Jae-min’s school stimulated him to read more,

Yeah I sometimes read a lot cause our record is to get 100%, 100 reading or above. Ms. Green would say 20 minutes a night—And if we do special projects, we once did a special project on oceans on eels, octopus, and other kinds of thing and some others. I read them. (J-11)

Jae-min was encouraged to read in order to get better grades as well as do projects on specific subjects which are content fields.

#### *Perception of Reading: Reading as a Brainpower*

Jae-min defined reading as “brainpower” through his verbal protocol. (See chapters 5 and 7.) He expressed the concept of reading in a very positive way, indicating that reading is very productive and essential for him. His family influenced him to understand powerful reading as well as reading as a power. His conceptualization of reading and learning to read was positive and powerful. He said that he had to feed his brain to grow and empower.

#### *Conception of Self as a Reader*

Jae-min’s mother noted that “Jae-min felt that he is Korean” (JM-2). This identity affects him while he reads. She explained that “I think the reasons he likes Korea are that we had some opportunities to contact Korean families and Korean cultures by visiting Korea, and we emphasized that he is a Korean” (JM-2). There is no doubt that Jae-min’s parents had a strong influence in his identification as Korean. His identity as Korean

influenced him while reading and comprehending stories. He revealed his *ethnocentric filter system*, which is the filter of ethnic identity (See chapter 7.), as he worked to understand stories. Most of his comprehension of stories is based on his main ethnic identity. While reading stories, Jae-min filtered the stories through his sociocultural value system to comprehend and evaluate them.

Jae-min was also very aware of Korean culture and Korean events in the study. For example, he enjoyed reading *Woodcutter and Tiger Brother*, and agreed with tiger's behavior toward Old Mother. He liked reading the ideas of "be nice to old people" from the book. Feng (1994) stated, "in many East Asian cultures, Confucian ideals, which include respect for elders, deferred gratification, and discipline, are a strong influence" (p. 3). It was based on Confucian ideas, which included respect for elders and discipline. (See Appendix A for background on Confucianism.)

Although Jae-min's mother stated that she wanted to raise him up "100% Korean and 100% American" during the interview, her discipline of Jae-min focused strongly on Korean culture, Asian culture, and the Asian sociocultural value system. For example, his mother noted, "In fact, I want to raise him in Korean ways. When I observe his friendship, I think he interacts with Asian students very well, and he is more comfortable with that" (JM-5). Jae-min was in contact with other Asian children, such as Kyle. They are very close friends. As Kyle mentioned, "He is my best friend in America" (K-5).

*Comments: 100% Korean and 100% American*

Jae-min's mother addressed one significant issue during her interview. She wanted to her children to be "100% Korean and 100% American," (JM-5) a concept she learned through in lectures in New York. She showed her strong beliefs and principles for

her children and expressed her awareness of education. That was a powerful concept for raising her children. Jae-min's mother explored why she wanted her children to be "100% Korean as well as 100% American."

Because we thought we are going back to Korea, we focused on teaching Jae-min Korean and Korean culture. But, now we are going to live in the United States, so he has to learn English and American culture, too. However, he is a Korean forever, wherever he lives. His skin color is different. I want him to be 100% Korean at the same time 100% American. I want him to be a person that fits to both cultures. This is our expectation. (JM-5)

She mentioned that Jae-min needed to fit both societies. However, some challenges were noted in this situation. It did not seem to be easy for her because she was so focused on Korean culture, to the point of expressing an unwillingness to learn American culture. Overall, Jae-min was fluent in Korean and English. He had a very positive and productive attitude in education and reading. Ms. Green said, "Koreans take education very seriously" (MG-6). That offered benefits for Jae-min to build up his scaffolding of positive concepts on reading and the reading process as well as his education.

### *Kyle, the Strategizer*

Second grader Kyle's favorite activity was "doing chess." He was very good at using various strategies while reading stories. For example, one of his reading strategies is his approach to reading a book. He reviewed the cover of the book and went to the last page of the book to figure out the content of story. Then he began reading the new story.

Ms. Green and Ms. Lopez said "He is a very, very smart boy, but he doesn't like writing" (MG-12). They were pretty impressed with Kyle's thinking process and problem



solving. When Ms. Green taught a math problem on the board, Kyle showed his problem solving skills,

Ms. Green, 'I have a new way of doing this.' And he'll come up and say this, 'You can do this, this and this and this.' But most of the time when he does it, he comes up with the right answer. But now he's confused the class, because he's really thought this out and the kids are looking at him like, 'How did he do that?' And he usually comes up with it. But that's just his way of thinking. But like I said, I can't get him to write. He doesn't like to write a story, but if you give him problems, he loves that. He loves coming up with different ways of doing things. (MG-12)

Ms. Green was amazed by his creativeness and unlimited thinking process. Kyle used his strategies in solving problems and comprehending stories, and constantly created new ways to do that. He was an excellent strategizer and was fascinated with creating new ideas. His responses were very informative and critical throughout the study.

#### *Family and Background*

Kyle was born in Japan and came to the United States at the age of 2. After a 2-year return to Japan, they came back to the United States when he was 6 years old. Therefore, his language experiences were quite different from those of other ELLs. He had been in the United States for almost two years when I met him.

He lives with his father, mother, and younger brother. His father graduated from high school and became an electronics engineer in Japan. He came to the United States as a contractor. Kyle's mother is a homemaker who graduated after two years of college in Japan. Her English was fine for communication, reflecting her activity in society. I first met her in the school library, where she was working as a volunteer. They plan to return to Japan in 2 or 3 years. Kyle knew that he would be returning to Japan soon.

Notably, Kyle's personality is very competitive in school. His mother said, "He knows that. It's embarrassing for him to be down a grade" (KM-4). For example, he was very interested in winning games as well as getting high scores in math and spelling tests. For example, he enjoyed reading the story about the swimming race, *Hiroko Makes the Team*, because Hiroko, who is Japanese and a main character, won a swimming race.

#### *Language Use at Home*

Kyle and his family spoke only Japanese at home. As mentioned earlier, Kyle had a very unique experience on language learning. When he went back to Japan, he absorbed Japanese like a sponge. Because Kyle and his family came back to the United States when he was 6 years old, he had been learning English for about two years when he entered this study. His language experience was complicated and it shifted fast. His mother remembered his struggling in language learning, "Kyle get—when we came back here the second time, it was the hardest time for him, because at that time already he knew Japan was his home" (KM-8). Once he recognized his home was Japan and his home language was Japanese, He identified himself as Japanese.

#### *Home Literacy*

When I visited Kyle's home, his mother showed me materials that Kyle was working on in various subjects in Japanese at home. The materials were very interesting for me. Kyle was practicing Japanese in reading and writing. He was also learning all subjects to prepare for his future schooling in Japan. The materials in Japanese were Japanese' language arts/literature, math, and social studies. Kyle complained about studying all the subjects in both languages, when he showed me all his materials, but his expression of pride in his bilingualism was clear.

### *Schooling History*

Kyle's schooling history was unique. Kyle was born in 1995 in Japan and the family moved to the United States in 1997. His family went back to Japan after 1½ years, and came back to the United States when Kyle was 6. He learned Japanese as a first language at home. As his school history showed, his English language learning experiences were unique. His mother remembered that he lost English within one month when he returned to Japan. She explained that he "was like a sponge to absorb Japanese" (KM-8). When he came to United States, he had to learn English again as a total beginner.

Ms. Green remembered his struggling in learning English as a second language during the first period of schooling. Ms. Green also remembered his disturbance during 1<sup>st</sup> grade,

He doesn't seem as focused as like Yuko and Jae-min are, but he's very, very smart. Very, very smart boy and he has great ideas. He doesn't like to write and if I can get him to like to write, he would write great stories cause he can tell great stories. (MG-10)

He also loved to make small jokes. She said he was a little comedian. He had very good ideas and was very creative.

She explained one episodic literacy activity:

I think now his reading scores are going up and so he still reads Japanese and American English books and we had him read, *Swimming*. And he would read one page in Japanese and I would read the same page in English and the kids love it and he's very good at it and he does well on a spelling test. (MG-11)

This activity seemed to encourage Kyle in literacy. Kyle was empowered (Cummins, 1991). Others enjoyed special literacy activities, such as having opportunities to hear Japanese. It turned out as a good activity for building community.

Ms. Green added

And he's also very good at math. His critical thinking skills are very good. Like to problem solve, to really have to think about something and we just played chess with our dads today and he's very good at chess. And he loves that kind of strategy thinking. He's very good at that. (MG-11)

Ms. Green added, Kyle had a tough time in the first semester because he felt he was behind his peers. However, he relaxed after a semester and built up his confidence and self-esteem. He evaluated his schooling as "easier learning" (K-2) in his interview. He liked schooling and looked very happy. Kyle was very smart and had very creative ideas and jokes. He is a strategizer in playing chess, solving problems, and comprehending stories in literacy activities.

#### *Reading Behavior and Reading Habits*

Kyle read books in both Japanese and English in a good balance on a daily basis. Japanese books were still easier for him. He liked the Japanese cartoon magazine that his grandmother sent him every month. However, reading Kanji in the Japanese books challenged him. He said, "Japanese is hard, if you have to read. Lots of Chinese characters in the book" (P8; 140). Kanji is the Chinese writing system (ideographic characters), each sign or symbol stands for the meaning of a word.

His mother said, "he started reading a chapter book entitled 'Capitan and the bunch'" (KM-23). His mother said he was very motivated to read this book. Although she usually chooses the book for him, "Yeah now he likes to read chapter books in English. So after that he started to read by himself. Now he can enjoy storybooks" (KM-24). He reads for 30 minutes every day including storybooks, encyclopedias, and cartoons. She said, "Yes so not only storybooks but some things he reads every day" (KM-25).

Kyle used various strategies while reading stories. He said, “No and Halloween. I read the back of the book. He was going to be a killer in Halloween. And the very last page, I read to know about it” (K-14), as explaining the reason “Because I wanted a little hint before I read” (K-14). He used his strategy as it stimulated his curiosity.

#### *Perception of Reading in Social Interaction*

I observed Kyle’s personality as outgoing. He seemed to be very focused on his peers in the classroom. However, he did not associate with girls in the classroom. He only spoke to Yuko when the teacher asked him to. Kyle’s best friend was Jae-min. They joked around and got along well with peers. He also loved to joke in the classroom. For example, he came to me to make jokes while I was observing the classroom. He did not hesitate to come to talk to me or to anyone, except the girls in the classroom.

Meanwhile, Kyle explored his perception of reading as “I want to be so smart when I get older because some people aren’t very smart when they get older. They don’t get good jobs” (K-4). Kyle had a practical reason to be a good reader and to learn. He was motivated to read to learn and to learn to read.

#### *Conception of Self as a Reader*

Kyle knew that his family was planning to move to Japan 2 or 3 years later, after the completion of his father’s contract. Also, he understood the situation in which he needed to study both languages because of his father’s status. He identified himself as Japanese in the first interview. He said, “I am Japanese, but my brother is American-Japanese, because he was born in America” (K-8).

However, in the second interview, he changed his status from Japanese to Japanese-American based on his language skills and use, because he was able to speak

both Japanese and English. He was very proud of his English proficiency. He identified himself based on his language use. However, perceptibly, he identified himself as Japanese while reading stories. Kyle's mother supported my opinion with "Most important thing for him, because he prays in Japanese, it was really happy for him" (KM-9). Kyle's reading comprehension style and utilization of reading strategies were based on Japanese culture.

*Comments: Kyle's Mother's Misconception of Cultural Differences*

Kyle's mother believed that she was very open minded and wanted to raise her children as "a world person" rather than as Japanese, which is similar in concept to Jaemin's mother's "100% Korean and 100% American" comment. Kyle's mother said,

"No we don't have any—we are really—not square people, so we don't care. Children can choose, but he cries a lot when he remembers his friends, sometimes. We don't make him, 'You are very Japanese,' like that. (KM-10)

By *square people*, Kyle's mother meant people who adhere strictly to their own culture and social values. However, apparently her discipline at home for Kyle was based on Japanese sociocultural values. In fact, she did not recognize differences between the two cultures. To clarify my inquiry, I asked her several specific questions about possible behaviors that American parents might consider normal behaviors. For example, I asked her how she would respond if Kyle touched her face or head. She said, "He shouldn't touch parents' face or head. That is not respectable at all" (KM-12). These differences between her response and her understanding of American culture were very interesting. She thought that she was raising Kyle in an "American style," but she disciplined him in the Japanese sociocultural value system influenced by Confucian ideas. Discipline is an important concept to teach children in Asia.

In another example, Kyle's mother did not like to see kids walking around during instruction, "I don't like Kyle to walk around in the classroom when teacher is talking. I really hate that" (KM-11). Ms. Green's class had an open atmosphere and many children were walking around during the instruction. Other American parents did not mind at all, or they agreed with the concept of an open atmosphere with less strict discipline. However, with my background knowledge of Asian educational discipline, I recognize that the Asian classroom atmosphere is stricter and students are not allowed to move about and do not talk to each other at all during instruction. This interview clip showed her expectation of education.

Jae-min's and Kyle's mothers wanted to their children grow up as a "100% Korean and 100% American" and "world person." J. Lee (1996) explored *Korean dual identity* in her study as follows:

Although parents encouraged their children to learn "American ways" and to accommodate the white majority, the adults also encouraged Korean youth to maintain connections to Korean traditions and people. Korean-identified students stated that their parents wanted them to "remember that we are Korean." (p. 24)

There is a discrepancy between what they seek and what they prepare for their children. The results of this study indicate that Jae-min's and Kyle's mother are focusing more strongly on their cultural concepts and traditions than on the American traditions, and they are not ready to support their children in developing American cultural concepts. Following my observations and interviews, I saw a huge gap between their viewpoint and reality.

Yeah, children raise their hand when they have something to say. I think that's not here—I think too rough to me to accept it. So I want children to when they study, more serious and more calmed down. They should listen to what the teacher says. Don't walk around. (KM-12)

Kyle's mother could not accept certain American culture. She was very Japanese in manner, and she raised her children with very Japanese discipline. This interview clip indicated her influence on Kyle's identity formation.

Having interviewed Kyle's and Jae-min's mothers, I realized the huge gaps between their educational beliefs and American reality. They wanted to raise a child as a world person, but they did not realize differences and similarities between two different cultures; furthermore, they hardly understood the world vision. They wanted to raise their children in the world vision, but they just provided them with their own cultural concepts and social value systems.

*Lilly, Who Wants to Say "No Quiero"*

*Family and Background*

Lilly lives with her mother in a small apartment around the corner from school. Her mother is an editor for an ESL publisher. When I visited her home for the interview, she was working on editing. Lilly's mother shared her work and her background as an educator. She was an EFL teacher in Mexico for 12 years and then became an editor. She shared with me some scripts she was working on. The apartment did not look spacious. As a single mother, she took care of Lilly by herself. She mentioned a few of her financial issues during the interview.

Lilly's mother learned English as a first language in the United States, and she went to Mexico at the age of 16. Lilly's mother learned Spanish as a second language in Mexico and lived in Mexico for 27 years. Lilly learned Spanish as a first language in Mexico. Lilly and her mother had lived in the United States for 10 months when this study began. Lilly had also been learning English as a second language for that time. As a



person, Lilly likes poems and drawing. She said, “I like to draw really much because I want to be an artist when I grow up” (L-9).

While I was conducting the verbal protocol in *I Hate English*, Lilly suddenly spoke to me in Spanish. I was surprised, and asked her the meaning of the words. However, her meaning was clear from her impulsive response.

R: Important stuff, what is important stuff?

L: No quiero.

R: No quiero. What do you mean?

L: I don't want to.

R: You don't want to read?

L: I want to speak Spanish. (P15; 242: 252)

#### *Language Use at Home*

Lilly used to speak to her mother in Spanish, but she just recently started speaking English at home. Her mother was concerned about her English use at home. Lilly's mother said, “I try to switch to Spanish because I want her to practice her Spanish. I don't want her to lose her Spanish. So I try to —” (LM-5). Lilly replied to her, “I am losing my Spanish” (LM-6). Lilly and her mother were concerned about Lilly's Spanish loss. Lilly's mother added,

I kind of try to keep the Spanish and I figured she had enough at school. And now she speaks to me a lot in English. She'll come in and just start speaking to me in English. She won't go to Spanish. So I speak Spanish more now with her. (LM-6)

She also said, “I still think Spanish is more comfortable for her” (LM-14). However, recently Lilly initiated conversations in English, and her mother tried to maintain a balance in both languages, being aware of keeping her language balance in English and Spanish. On the other hand, Lilly's was becoming fluent in English.

### *Home Literacy*

Lilly's mother took her home literacy and reading habits seriously. They usually read three or four times a week at least.

Yeah, we'll read sometimes—usually we'll try to read something from the library in English, but also I've been reading to her in Spanish. Like we read Harry Potter in Spanish. I read it, she can't read that and now we're reading, I have some books that are simple that she could read in Spanish and so I'm having her read those. But she's been reading mainly in English, but the book is in Spanish. But I've been having her read in English, so that term of reading gets better. (LM-16)

Lilly usually chose her own books in the library. Her mother motivated Lilly to read books and to maintain a balance in both languages. At the time of the interview, Lilly usually read books in English.

### *Schooling History*

Lilly was surrounded by people who speak both languages such as Lilly's mother, her grandmother, and her stepbrothers and sisters, and most of her mother's friends in Mexico. Lilly's mother said,

Yeah they lived with me. So she's always known all the people around her, most of them speak both languages. Most of my friends are English teachers too. So they spoke English and Spanish. So I think that's important, because she wanted to learn English. She wanted—it was important, because she was the only one, she would get really mad when we would all speak English and she couldn't understand. (LM-22)

Her mother said, "I think her Spanish is perfect and her English is—she's fluent and talks but she makes mistakes. She is still learning" (LM-23). Lilly learned Spanish perfectly, including reading and writing, before she started learning English as a second language. Lilly was heavily exposed, and already had a motivation to learn English.

Her mother thought Lilly had been very happy recently because she could communicate in English. Lilly had a soft tone of voice and was very quiet and shy in class. Lilly became a good friend of Yuko for a while until Yuko left for Japan.

### *Reading Behavior and Reading Habits*

Lilly struggled greatly for about 6 months. She could not speak English, when she started her schooling. Her mother said, “The only thing she would say was, ‘Can I have a glass of water?’” (LM-1) When I asked her why Lilly could speak that sentence, she explained, “Because it was hot and I left her sometimes with my sister’s nanny and she doesn’t speak any Spanish, so Lilly learned how to ask for certain things, because say she needed water, then she would ask for water” (LM-3).

### *Emergent Discussion: A Matrix of First and Second Language Learning*

For Lilly as a Spanish speaker, I observed some advantages and disadvantages in learning English as a second language. Lilly’s mother described Lilly’s struggle in learning English as a second language. She also mentioned some challenges that impacted her Spanish. She was faced with a mismatch between her prior Spanish knowledge and her English learning. She explained the gaps that she faced in the differences between the pronunciations and spellings in the two languages. Lilly’s mother explained as follows.

So for her it was very difficult. Things like *w* don’t even exist in Spanish. And *wh*—like the other day when she was trying *though* or *thought*. Like *though*, I mean that is, she could not understand why you had a *ough* that you don’t even hear. So that was difficult for her. Now it’s like she looks at it like English. She kept trying to use her Spanish, but her strategies for reading Spanish, she tried to use those in English and they don’t work. Also for spelling, she had to forget her spelling for Spanish. Spanish is very easy. Every letter has one sound. And every letter always sounds. So you never have words that come together and something

is silence, except the *h*, which is silent. I mean in Spanish you do, *c* sometimes sounds *c* and something sounds *k*, but that's the only one. (LM-24)

This phenomenon made Lilly's competence in English unstable. She thought she was not a good reader because of her confusion in pronunciation and spelling when she used her first language skills to learn English. She had to memorize words because of different sounds from one language to the next. Also, Lilly's mother explained another example from Spanish question structure. She said,

Well probably, I mean the structures are similar. You know you have subject and verb—but again questions are different in Spanish, you don't change order of words for questions. And you don't have accents and you don't—and in Spanish you conjugate verbs and English you don't conjugate words. So I can't think of too many. They're kind of different. (LM-25)

However, I observed several benefits from her first language while learning English as second language. Her first language knowledge supported her learning English as a second language such as how to use language and language structures.

Her own language knowledge—I mean how to use language. That's why she could learn to read, cause she already knew how to read. Might have been different if she didn't know how to read. But she knew the idea of what reading is and that words represent ideas and you put them together to represent several—so I don't know. It's interesting. I was surprised cause I expected it to be—to come choppy. Mom, water—and it wasn't. It was, “Mom can I have a glass of water? Please.” (LM-27)

Lilly's knowledge of her first language helped her understand how to use language and how to read. She had already built up her knowledge of language structure and meaning of abstracts including the relationship between meaning and symbols. The last interview clip showed Lilly suddenly started using a complete sentence instead of just a few words after her silent period. Igoa (1995) noted that there is a “silent period

when the children experience the school culture as different from their own and when their inability to communicate with peers is caused by a language or cultural difference” (p. 38). Igoa explored the silent period as it related to the learner’s experiences, which included culture shock and language shock. It is obvious in Yanton’s case. Lilly’s case indicated that the silent period may be understood as relating to the child’s language learning process.

I assume that her knowledge of language structure and language systems in her first language supported her in developing complete sentences instead of going through the single word phase. She began speaking complete sentences using her prior knowledge after her silent period. This fact is very significant to understand ELLs’ language learning development process.

#### *Perception of Reading: English and Spanish Transformation*

Ms. Green demonstrated Lilly’s Spanish to English transformation in her class. That was a very interesting transformation. Ms. Green let Lilly write in Spanish in her class. Thus, Lilly did any assignments in Spanish for the first period of the school year.

Lilly naturally moved from speaking and writing from Spanish to English. Ms. Green noted that this shift occurred 4 months after she came to class.

Lilly did all Spanish writing; she just copied from the board for Aug. Sept. Oct. and Nov. She did all Spanish writing, unless it was on the board, which she knew how to copy. You know transfer it on to her page. And then we would have her mom translate it for us and then we would have her write it in English after that. And then in December she started writing sentences in English. Very basic sentences we would help her with. And then January and February she started writing a couple of sentences and now she’s writing full stories. (MG-4)

Ms. Green let her write in Spanish for 4 months. Lilly knew what her peers were doing. Lilly followed her lessons in Spanish. Ms. Green kept encouraging her to write in

Spanish with “You could do it Spanish” (MG-4). This implied a good teaching strategy for ELLs. Lilly was more empowered using her first language to develop her cognition of the subject matter. In this supportive atmosphere, Lilly felt safer. By herself, Lilly made her transformation from Spanish to English. Ms. Green explained, “I think she felt better in English and she’s been writing more in English now” (MG-7). Lilly’s mother reiterated Ms. Green’s statement, noting that it had happened because of the safe, comfortable environment. These factors support Lilly’s natural language transformation. Ms. Green also used her various strategies for ELLs as follows:

So I like to let them get their ideas down as easy as possible and then we can go back and translate and kind of go through the editing process, sort of speak and have them do it, rewrite it in English. Yuko’s last writing, we had translated and she did very well. I read it to her and then she would read it back. So it was a respond type thing. (MG-5)

Ms. Green used various strategies including visuals, echoing, reading aloud, and hands-on activities for ELLs depending on their level of English. To develop reading fluency, Reutzel and Cooter ( 2005) suggested guided reading including choral reading, partner reading, repeated reading, and sustained silent reading for learners.

Ms. Green developed her own style of guided reading including various visuals such as side words for Yanton and Yuko who were very much ESL beginners. She used echoing (choral reading), reading aloud, and silent reading as a good balanced instruction because of the students’ various of language proficiencies.

Marlow (2002) discussed the importance of reading aloud and choral reading to students. He also addressed succinct criteria for effective oral reading, noting that reading aloud to pupils should develop attentiveness in the listeners. He believed that reading aloud can offer modeling for readers and supports sustained silent reading, which

becomes individual reading. Beck and McKeown (2002) also addressed how to assist readers for successful reading comprehension with reading aloud. Modeling by reading aloud helps students understand what fluency sounds like and is essential to its development.

*Comments: English as a Second Language Development Process*

As an educator, Lilly's mother was very interested in observing Lilly's second language development process.

Because it's been interesting for me to watch it develop. What I was surprised about was is how she just learned huge complicated structures. It doesn't matter how difficult it is—I mean if you teach English to foreign students like I did in Mexico, they would never produce a conditional sentence. They would never use, "I wouldn't do that." They won't say that. It takes them years to be able to produce subjunctives and she just does the whole thing. "Mommy if I do this, could I have that?" I mean she'll use conditional sentences. She'll use complicated structures. (LM-15)

Lilly's mother thought Lilly learned complicated sentences in English very quickly as a result of her immersion in the school context. Lilly received a great deal of comprehensible input from peers in the social context. She learned English as a means to communicate, not to learn the language itself. This indicated how important it is to provide authentic tasks for ELLs in the social context. It could be extended to an evocative context such as literacy events or content fields. ELLs are motivated to learn language to communicate or to understand subject matter in meaningful contexts. These contexts make it very important for them to practice language and develop language skills.

Lilly's mother indicated that immersion gave Lilly a good opportunity to explore and practice English. Lilly felt the need to communicate to do group projects. She was

surrounded by unlimited comprehensible input. Interaction with her peers and the teacher occurred naturally to build up the scaffolding to comprehend the subject matter or do projects. Lilly as an ELL was learning English to do meaningful tasks. Lilly's mother said, of the importance of interaction with peers,

Well I don't think she just learns English. She's just doing everything in English. No one's teaching her English. I mean I don't see that they've taught—I don't see any open over teaching going on. I think it's just the immersion and having the opportunity to practice, to hear, I mean it's the way children learn. (LM-15)

Lilly's mother believed in the strength of immersion when learning a second language. Immersion contexts provided effective, efficient, and practical contexts for the ELL while supplying rich comprehensible input. Lilly was learning English while she was doing content work in English.

Lilly still missed her father and wanted to go back to Mexico. Her mother said, "Yeah but she still wants to go back to Mexico, cause she misses her daddy and her brothers and sisters and her life and her friends. She still misses it" (LM-16). Lilly was attached to Mexico in her mind. She also liked animals such as dogs, cats, and mice. Lilly showed me the books entitled *Mice in the Shoes* when I visited her. She liked this book because it made her remember the mice she had before.

*Yanton, Elaborator*

Yanton and Yanton's family came to the United States on January 27, 2004. When I first met him, he had been in the United States for two weeks. He could not speak a word in English. He barely said "Hi" to me and avoided eye contact. He kept looking at the desk. His eyes were frightened and he looked about to cry, strong indicators of his struggling in language and cultural adjustment. Throughout the study, Yanton's case



provided me with an opportunity to observe a total beginner ELL's progress in his second language learning and reading literacy.

### *Family and Background*

Yanton lives with his father, mother, and a younger sister whose name is Julia. Yanton's father earned a Ph.D. in microelectronics. The family planned to stay in the United States for 2 years and then to return to Sweden. Yanton's mother used to be a PE teacher for kindergarten to 3<sup>rd</sup> graders, and is currently being a homemaker. Yanton's mother explained that students in Sweden start learning English in 3<sup>rd</sup> grade and continue until they finish their schooling. My first visit to Yanton's home was after they had lived in the United States for 4½ months. His mother's English was fine for communication because she had studied English from the 3<sup>rd</sup> grade through finishing her Associates degree.

When I visited Yanton for my last interview with him, surprisingly, he wore a Tae-Kwon-Do uniform, which is one of Korea's traditional sports. His mother explained that he had been taking a lesson for two months. He showed me his forms and talents while yelling "Yahb." The energy from his hands cut the silence. It was very nice. I sensed his confidence in Tae-Kwon-Do performance as well as in his English.

### *Language Usage at Home*

Yanton and Yanton's family speak mostly Swedish at home. However, Yanton's mother tried to use English at home for her children. That was a difference from the other families in this study. When I visited Yanton's house at the end of August, his mother described their current language use.

But now since three weeks ago Julia and Yanton have started to speak English with each other when they're playing. I've heard them in their room when playing. They speak English to each other. I guess it's Yanton's idea because Julia hasn't learned to speak so much. She can understand quite much but Yanton he likes to speak now because he knows that he can do it. So he wants to practice, I guess so. I don't know. I haven't spoken to them about it, but I've heard them when they're playing. (YM-9)

There had been dramatic changes from my previous visit. He initiated speaking English to his sister. His language use transformed from Swedish to English at home. It took 6½ months. I noticed his competence improving along with his English proficiency. Noticeably, the family still mostly speaks Swedish at home. Yanton kept reading books in both Swedish and English.

### *Home Literacy*

Yanton's mother emphasized the importance of reading and literacy at home. She reads for them and with them as a regular activity. She said, "So I used to read one English book and one Swedish book every day for them" (YM-11). At the beginning of the semester, she read the beginner's book in English for Yanton and his sister. She read in English and translated to Swedish for them, because they did not understand any words. Yanton's father disagreed with her teaching method, and he thought Yanton just needed to read stories in English from the beginning without translation.

Yanton's parents read books or magazines at home to model literacy even though they have different ideas of how to teach reading. Reading was a main culture in Yanton's home. She said, "Yeah he likes to read and I keep reminding him to read cause I think it's important" (YM-12). His mother said, "He reads more English when he chooses a book. More often he chooses an English book but when he wants to read a magazine or something, he reads Swedish magazines" (YM-13). He read books in

English to practice English in his own way. However, when he wanted to relax, he chose to read a monthly Swedish children magazine. This indicated that Swedish was more comfortable for him. Yanton read books on a regular basis. On my last visit to Yanton's home, he showed his competence in schooling, and he was not afraid to speak English any more.

### *Schooling History*

Yanton attended his classroom as of February 1. Yanton was assigned to a 3<sup>rd</sup>-grade classroom, but he had to come to Ms. Green's language arts/literature classroom as a pull out student. He was very frustrated and angry for the first period of his schooling.

Yanton's mother explained his anxiety and frustration as follows:

Yeah he's the kind of person that doesn't want to fail. He wants to do everything perfect. And he was quite good in school in Sweden and I guess he got frustrated when he got here and he couldn't do anything. So he didn't want to—he wanted to be as good as the other kids. And I told him, the other kids speak English and you don't, so do the best you can. But I think that was the most important thing that got him frustrated and scared. But he was lucky though because there was another Swedish boy in the class. (YM-5)

Yanton met Simon, who was also from Sweden. Simon had moved to the United States 3 years earlier. Yanton's mother also explained her support for Yanton during the first period of his schooling, "I just open the classroom door and checked if he was okay and stayed for 15 minutes maybe and then I leave and then at lunch maybe I'd come back and just check to see if he's okay" (YM-8). Yanton's mother checked his situation regularly, but not intrusively. Yanton actually had a very hard time adjusting to his new school. For example, he cried very hard a couple of days, screaming at the teacher with frustration and anger. As Yanton's mother explained, Ms. Henry, the 3<sup>rd</sup>-grade teacher, did not know what to do with him. However, she did not send him home. She thought he

needed to learn to calm down and adjust to his new school. Yanton's mother said, "I like her very much too because she gave him extra materials and extra books. And she had him trying to do the same things like the others and she didn't give up" (YM-8). She was also impressed with the teacher's care and extra attention for Yanton.

### *Comments*

Yanton choose books for himself. Yanton liked reading about animals, bugs, and insects. In his room, he had many models of different kinds of animals and bugs arranged in big shelves. He had a big cabinet full of small animal dolls. He had not only a series of bug stories in one big shelf, but also a unique collection of animal and bug storybooks.

Various collections of bugs and insects hung on his wall. Yanton's mother said,

He is very fond of animals and bugs. Especially the bugs. He has back in Sweden a whole book case of books about bugs and insects and that kind of stuff. He used to collect them and he had a huge bookcase with glass doors. He likes insects and that kind of stuff. And he likes to read some science. He wants to know everything about them. so when he read his first English book, he choose some kind of detective, Inspector, it's called—It's about an inspector grasshopper, he was an inspector like Sherlock Holmes and it was kind of adventure, I guess about bugs. (YM-14)

His mother tried to stimulate his interest and motivation to read by providing his favorite topics. Providing books of their favorite topics or subjects would be an effective idea for supporting beginner ELLs.

### *The Teachers*

#### *Ms. Green*

When I visited her classroom in September 2003, Ms. Green's lesson was about writing a poem using sea animals such as dolphins and sharks. She had a big smile and

seemed very cheerful. She developed a liberated atmosphere for children. Some children were working independently or talking to others to do a small group project. It seemed very chaotic on the surface, but I felt that they were doing their projects very seriously and sensed a very safe environment. Children came to Ms. Green whenever they had questions. She used to say, “Guys, please ask two of your friends before you come to me.” Also, she used Miss or Mr. attached to the children’s names whenever she called each student in the classroom. Respect between the teacher and children was evident. That was very impressive.

Ms. Green had an ESL endorsement and had been teaching ELLs for three years out of her 6 years of teaching experience. She had taught kindergarten, 2<sup>nd</sup>-, and 4<sup>th</sup>-year students. She had gone back to school to obtain the ESL endorsement to meet the school’s needs,

And the reason I went back for my endorsement was because there was a real need especially at GO elementary school that we needed—we have so many languages. We have so many different languages here at GO elementary school. We have Sweden, we have people from India, Spanish, Italian, all sorts of Asian, so we have a real need. Just to help them feel comfortable and pick up English and to help them in school is why I went back for my endorsement. (MG-1)

The school had huge numbers of students from different countries or cultures. She usually had four or more students from different countries. At the time in her classroom, she had Yanton, Lilly, Jae-min, Kyle, and Yuko, who was from Japan (she was not included in this study).

Ms. Green felt that most students from East Asia like Jae-min and Kyle respected teachers. Their family also had high expectations as well as a strong emphasis on education. Not surprisingly, Jae-min’s, Kyle’s, and Yuko’s parents took their children’s

education very seriously. She added that those expectations and the resulting involvement affect children's schooling. She also addressed differences between children. For example, she compared Yanton to Yuko. She said that Yuko was ready to go the first day she came to school, but she sensed that Yanton was experiencing strong cultural shock on his first day. "But he was a little more shy. He had a harder time adjusting to the whole, you know, what we call culture shock, with him and he had a little harder time. But now he's very open and his mom is a big help" (MG-7). Obviously, Yanton went through a harder time than Yuko in starting school. I observed critical differences between these two beginner ELLs.

### *Teaching Methods and Strategies*

In her teaching methods or strategies, she used visuals and many hands-on activities, and small group projects for ELLs. Also, she coordinated special teaching methods and strategies for ELLs.

I try really hard to do visuals where they could see what's going on. I make sure that they're in a position where they can see me well. I also in certain areas make sure that they have a friend to work with, with reading and with doing independent reading. But we started very small and just kind of work our way up to their needs. And then I give them individual, right now, my little girl from Japan; we're still working on sight words, you know, so she needs that individual attention. And so just depending on their needs and where they're at with their English, but a lot of it a lot of visuals, modeling on the blackboard, perspectives, so they could follow along. Just so that they can see you know what is going on. (MG-2)

Ms. Green used a range of teaching strategies for ELLs, including visuals, modeling, peer support, and individual attention. For example, she used sight words for Yuko such as household materials including names of home appliances and familiar and frequent words with pictures. She also considered the ELLs' different needs depending

on their stage of English proficiency and learning ability. She explained the importance of visuals,

It has to be, with them, there's got to be a lot of visuals because they've got to be able to associate. Because in their mind they know it as a different word, but when you show them a picture or you show them a word, most of the time, you have to show them the picture what the word means. And then when they get that, then they go on with the word. But there has to be association. (MG-2)

Ms. Green differentiated her teaching methods depending on the student's level. For beginners like Yanton and Yuko, she used materials to figure out household names, pictures of items, and rhyming words. She also used various games and puzzles with rhyming words to stimulate the ELLs' motivation. She also coordinated her teaching with various forms of modeling writing and echoing for reading.

Well depending on their needs and where they're at. Like with Yuko, we're still—we do have like the household names, which are the pictures of items. Even like a spoon, fork and then the word and that's a bingo game and then we do sight words. Words like, the, was, saw, you know just high frequency words. We have a bingo game for that. We have a puzzle that actually has rhyming words. The pieces that go together will rhyme. So Yuko can see cat and hat or that type of thing and then the pictures that go with it. So they're making all the associations about rhyming and then the picture–word associations. And I like to use the white boards a lot, the ones with the markers. So that we can erase and that way I can ask them to tell me a word and I write it down and then they can write it down. So that's modeling. I have some tiles that have words on them and I put them down, mixed up and have them put it into a sentence. (MG-13)

She specially used echoing for Yanton. She added,

And that's where Yanton is at right now. He's working on building sentences and how the words go together to make sentences. And let's see, a lot of echo reading, so that if I read it, I read it and then I have him read it, echo it back. (MG-13)

She adjusted her teaching methods depending on the ELL's needs. She also addressed the advantages from their prior knowledge.

And they've got all this knowledge. That's the great thing, is that they've got all the prior knowledge and so now we're just trying to change their language just a little bit. That's what is hard because they already know this as one thing and now we're telling, you know it's just in English. And that's what makes it easy especially for 1<sup>st</sup> and 2<sup>nd</sup> grade because their knowledge is there but they're still very fast at picking up the English. (MG-14)

She worked to stimulate the ELLs' language learning strategies, which they obtained from their first language literacy skills, to develop their second language. She asserted that their first language skills facilitate the development of their second language literacy.

#### *English Language Learners' Peer Interaction*

I observed ELLs who are surrounded by copious comprehensible input from their interaction with peers and the teacher. The ELLs were learning English as a second language while engaging in meaningful tasks within the ZPD. Peer interaction also became essential for second language learning, providing mutual understanding and similar points of view. For example,

I think because they're getting it from a kid's point of view. They're hearing language. It's almost like kids' language and the kids talk so much. They just talk and talk and talk. And that could be a good thing or a bad thing. I mean Yuko hears so much language and so when they're working together and there's so much talking going on, she's actually hearing and seeing. So as they're talking through their paper, she's hearing that language. We call it, buddy work. Like now I can tell her what we're doing and she can go and do it. But if we're doing a paper, it's too much for her to do on her own. So I will pick a helper for her and they'll come back to the back table and work on it together. So she is understanding a lot more. (MG-15)

Ms. Green noted *buddy work* as a good means for ELLs to get assistance from capable peers. This social interaction would give enough input for ELLs to understand tasks or projects within the ZPD. ELLs in a beginner stage need to have capable peers



who can help or assist. ELLs build up their scaffolding to establish their tasks with capable peers. Cooperative learning provides the essential interaction opportunity. It would be beneficial for ELLs if they had capable peers who had the same first language skills in the same classroom. Lilly had a girl from Mexico when she came to school. Yuko had Kyle who was from Japan. However, Yanton did not have anybody in Ms. Green's classroom, and he had a more difficult time than others.

Ms. Green used various strategies or methods for ELLs depending on their level of English proficiency. She also understood that ELLs used different strategies. She tried to stimulate ELLs' prior knowledge using word activities with visuals on the side. She added her expectation of the reason for using different strategies, "I think depending on the kids" (MG-19). She developed and applied different teaching methods and strategies depending on the children's levels.

### *First Language and Second Language Connections*

Some ELLs used their first language literacy skills while learning the second language. Ms. Green expressed that one of the main connections is *prior knowledge* of language learning experiences and the contents of that knowledge. This is an example of the advantage of teaching ELLs in content areas.

You know with Yuko, I'm not sure how this is helping her, because she does have the prior knowledge of what she knows and I think as she learns English she'll be able to make associations better with her own language, which you know is so different. But maybe there might be some kind of connection she can make. But with her, she's really starting from square one. (MG-2)

Ms. Green noticed many connections between Yuko's first and second languages, but she was not sure how the relationship worked or how to coordinate it because English and Japanese are so different. There are huge differences between Japanese and English,

but Yuko used her prior knowledge in Math. Ms. Green said, “so that’s prior knowledge. But like with a math test. Right and so that’s prior knowledge. Her math from Japan carried right over to here on her math skills, I should say” (MG-2). For example, Yuko made linkages between the new language and her prior knowledge of math. ELLs have different prior knowledge in contents, and they use their prior knowledge constantly.

Also, the language learning experience can help ELLs learn their second language.

Ms. Green added,

The good thing with our second language learners, they are very quick learners. You know I can work with her on one thing one day and the next day, she still has that. She still remembers and so we just kind of keep building. And that’s what we do with her is just a little bit every day. It’s a little building on to what she’s been learning. (MG-20)

Ms. Green used a building metaphor to describe the development of second language skills. Her notion was that ELLs’ knowledge of the first language learning process can be taken into account in learning a second language.

I think because the process of learning language is already done. They’ve already experienced how to learn a language because of their first language. So now that kind of knowledge of what were the strategies they used in that particular situation. They kind of already have those strategies and carry them into their second language. So I think it is a little bit easier to do it younger, because they have just accomplished that. Especially 2<sup>nd</sup> graders, like Yuko in Japan, she’s already gone through the strategies of learning to read, learning to write, all that. Now it’s using what she knew helped her to do it all over again with a different language. Now she’s got to learn to read, learn to write. But she’s already had those strategies that have worked for her. (MG-22)

ELLs already have knowledge of a language system such as the connections between meanings and abstract symbols. Noticeably, the whole process of learning is similar. ELLs’ prior knowledge of literacy facilitates learning the second language. They also use their learning strategies while learning the second language. If they are younger,

they are able to better utilize learning strategies that were just acquired in their first language learning experiences.

*Ms. Lopez*

The first time I met Ms. Lopez was the second week of the fall semester, 2004. She was a newcomer in this school system. She was bilingual in English and Spanish. Jae-min, Kyle, and Lilly were in her 3<sup>rd</sup>-grade class. Yanton used to come to this class as a pull out. It was very nice to observe the participants with a new teacher. She welcomed me with her warmth.

Ms. Lopez, who had an ESL endorsement, had taught for 13 years. She used to teach in a very low socioeconomic context.

I've been working with second language learners for 13 years and I've always worked in schools that were between 85 and 100 percent free and reduced lunch. In other words the population of the school was at a poverty level with a high number of mostly Spanish-speaking students from Mexico. (ML-1)

This environment was new to her. She was amazed by parents' involvement in the school.

Ms. Lopez was very excited to teach in a new context. For example, she described parents' support, the parent volunteers, and international languages which she had in her classroom. She said, "I have been absolutely wonderful [experience with them]" (ML-2). She had Jae-min (Korean); Kyle, Ken, and Yuko (Japanese); Lilly (Mexican); one girl from Pakistan; and two students from India, and Yanton (Swedish) as a pull out.

So it's been a learning experience to me to make sure that I meet the needs of those kids. So one of the things that I do in my instruction, I try to differentiate my instruction and present concepts at a very basic level and then I let the kids take it from where they're developmentally ready for that concept and then we work more or less individual with them. Like for example with Yuko, I'm trying to say to her, because she's just beginning to speak out loud in English and she doesn't like for Kyle to translate for her. I mean she gets embarrassed if he—she

would rather just—. And I work with them in small groups. I taught a combined class including 3<sup>rd</sup> and 4<sup>th</sup> graders for 8 years. So I was really able to teach multiple ages together during that time. (ML-3)

Meeting children's needs was important for Ms. Lopez. She adjusted her teaching methods and strategies depending on the children's needs and levels of English proficiency. This strategy was similar to Ms. Green's. She was also cautious with interaction between the children. She prepared her instruction flexibly and applied various strategies or methods depending on the situation and the groups of children. She facilitated teaching ELLs using visuals, small group work, and coordination of various problem-solving strategies.

For example, when we work with the problem of the day, I introduce it at different levels and we talk about problem solving and how you need to find the best way that you are comfortable with in solving a problem. So there's lots of different ways to solve a problem. It all doesn't have to be the same way. So I try to—we work through everyone's ideas. When we're talking about solving—for example, so what they did, some kids counted by sixes, some kids multiplied. There were different ways to do it. So we talk about all those things. So that if one kid doesn't understand it one way, they might understand it another way. So I try to differentiate my instruction by making sure that I'm using more than one way of teaching. (ML-8)

Obviously, Ms. Lopez considered everyone's ideas in the classroom. She respected different perspectives of solving problems and was open to meeting different needs and finding solutions for each of the students.

### *Teaching Methods and Strategies*

Ms. Lopez used topics that interested the students in small group activities. The topic of interest was explained in small groups. For example, she picked up the topic for Yuko, *Disney World in Japan*. She remembered that Yuko had written a nice story on the topic in Japan. "So I tried to make sure though that I'm checking with every assignment

that they understand what they're supposed to do" (ML-8). She invited students' prior knowledge into her instruction. ELLs' *funds of knowledge* (Moll & Gonzalez, 1994; Moll, Neff, & Gonzalez, 1992) were enriched by her various teaching methods and strategies. Using students' *funds of knowledge* is a method for encouraging students to use their prior knowledge from their home culture. This method appeared to be an effective and efficient way of teaching ELLs.

Ms. Lopez was also inspired to use ELLs' prior knowledge. For example,

Jae-min said, "in Korea we do it this way." So then I'll encourage him to talk about that and share with us how they do something. So I think that by being able to apply it and being able to talk about it, depending on what the situation is that, that helps them to build their knowledge. (ML-15)

Learning was reinforced by connections between prior knowledge and the new language. Jae-min was encouraged to share his experiences in Korea with his peers.

Ms. Lopez adjusted her teaching methods depending on the stages her ELLs were in, "I try to address the different ways that kids learn by hands on, by listening and all those other modalities. And we just moved up from that" (ML-14). Ms. Lopez used many ways of solving problems, utilizing different methods such as "If they're not sure about something. And then I usually explain it to them another way" (ML-9). Ms. Lopez also used many visuals and hands-on activities and took advantage of ELLs' prior knowledge. It was similar to Ms. Green's instruction. She added, "my instruction is varied enough so that they have the opportunity to understand the curriculum as much as they can" (ML-14) to meet the children's needs and their comprehension ability. She also integrated the students' prior knowledge and authentic materials into their learning. For example, she brought her hamster into the classroom to teach desert habitats.

I brought in my hamster and we talked about what habitats are for the desert and they made desert folders and they had to pick a certain kind of cactus. I gave them a choice among several cactuses and they had to be able to draw that and cut it out and label it with the proper name. They just couldn't draw anything they wanted. And so I tried to make things applicable to—for example the fact that we live in the desert, draw their prior experiences and that's why I chose deserts to be my first habitat that we studied because it's the most familiar thing to most of them. And I just try to do lot's of hands-on things with them and partnering. (ML-12)

Connecting children's lives to teaching supports children in evolving their prior knowledge and motivates them to learn. She also considered how to coordinate various teaching concepts within her environmental boundary. She also mentioned the importance of teaching familiarity with children.

She used a range of teaching strategies such as small group activities, reading aloud, and hands-on activities in literacy. She understood that small group activities and peer tutoring could be the main window to meet ELLs' various needs. Reading aloud was used, "We do a lot of reading out loud in here for things like social studies. I read them a chapter book. I read that to them every day."

Ms. Lopez believed in the strengths of bilingualism. For her, bilingualism provided strengths for the ELL to be a strong social being.

I've always felt that it's really, really important to honor their culture and honor their language and their traditions and that they should never ever. Because that's an important part of who they are and what they need to teach their children some day and carry on in the future. And it's okay to be both, but please don't ever forget this because it's such an important part of who you are. (ML-15)

She showed her positionality in bilingualism. She also addressed the significance of having two cultures and language skills. She added that when ELLs appreciate their own culture, they are able to appreciate other cultures; furthermore, they become a stronger person who has strengths in both languages and cultures in the future.

### *Making Connections*

Ms. Lopez showed making connections as a useful tool to teach ELLs. Everything connected to them becomes meaningful and takes account of the engagement. Ms. Lopez asserted that making connections between first language skills and second language learning enhanced ELLs' second language literacy development. She said,

A child is fortunate to have a second language, that's a blessing. Because I really feel like it just expands their ability to learn. You know their connections that they make, even though they may struggle with the second language in the beginning, the connection that they make once they make the transition is a benefit that they'll always carry with them in life. (ML-20)

Making connections to their own culture and first language skills may empower ELLs. She developed her curriculum based on various teaching methods and strategies, using rich connections with children's culture and prior knowledge.

So I think that helping kids make connections using reference materials, taking book walks, making predictions about a story, all those things help them connect to whatever it is that you're doing in the classroom, whether it's reading a new story, social studies, which is very hard for them. So we try to use maps and stories and things like that to help them make connections. (ML-17)

Ms. Lopez highly recommended the use of schema strategies for ELLs. When ELLs made connections to themselves, everything became more meaningful for them. For example, she showed samples of using their funds of knowledge. If topics are related to the ELLs' cultures and languages, the ELLs are inspired in their learning.

In Social Studies, we discussed about different communities. For example in 3<sup>rd</sup> grade we talk about communities in Social Studies, cause like Kyle and Jae-min and Yuko and Lilly, those four for sure have had recent experiences in their home countries that they can share with their class about when they're in school there or—we were talking about open markets in Mexico. Lilly explained the market in Mexico. And Jae-min said, “in Korea they also have open markets. And when we went shopping there, my mom was haggling for prices” and was able to share that with us. So I think those experiences really help them. (ML-17)

If ELLs have had recent experiences in different countries or cultures, it is especially valuable that they share their experiences with peers. It can be interesting to other students that have never had those experiences to hear about open markets in other parts of the world. She used ELLs' funds of knowledge to provide sharing opportunities for them and with others through meaningful tasks in the social context. She used ELLs' strengths, integrating what they already knew with what they needed to learn. ELLs' culture and prior knowledge were invited into the classroom to be shared with others. ELLs and peers are empowered in the social context. ELLs' strengths were coordinated into the curriculum. ELLs' funds of knowledge might illuminate the current curriculum if they share their strengths and knowledge with peers. All students are ready to think critically, to share their appreciation with peers who are from different cultures, to have an opportunity to learn from various cultures.



## CHAPTER 5

### RESULTS OF THE VERBAL PROTOCOL: READING STRATEGIES USED

One of my main foci in this chapter is to answer the second subquestion concerning the investigation of ELLs' use of their strategies via the verbal protocol. A verbal protocol served as an effective and efficient means to investigate second language literacy strategies (Pressley, M. & Afflerbach, 1995). Ericsson and Simon, who said that "verbal reports, elicited with care and interpreted with full understanding of the circumstances under which they were obtained, are a valuable and thoroughly reliable source of information about cognitive processes" (as cited in Aweiss, 1994, p. 242). My analysis of the verbal reports provided a good window for understanding ELLs' reading strategies and reading processes.

#### Verbal Report Analysis: Second Language Literacy Process and Strategies

The strategies in this study were distinguished through the comprehensive analysis of the participant's verbal reports. "The power of protocol analysis lies in the richness of its data" (Hayes & Flower, 1980, p.10). Children's ongoing responses during the reading process—talking aloud while reading stories—offer insights into the individual participant's learning and reading strategies and comprehension processes from the texture and complexity of the spontaneous thinking processes as well as naturally occurring speech (Alderson, 1984; Cohen, 1987; Mikulecky, 1991). Verbal protocols were analyzed in terms of reading strategies and comprehension processes (Armbruster et al., 1983; Gass & Mackey, 2000). The 12 second language reading strategies based on the ELLs' verbal reports are presented in this chapter.

## Categorization of Verbal Reports

During the analysis of the verbal reports, 12 main categories emerged to illustrate the strategies inherent in the participant's verbal reports. Before I started categorizing my data, I examined various categorizations from a range of research. These readings helped me see the big picture while analyzing data, but I was careful to not allow the knowledge to influence me. Twelve main categories emerged from the inductive analysis of the verbal reports:

1. Schema: Connection to Cultural Knowledge and Background Knowledge
2. Schema: Intertextuality
3. Schema: Connection to World Knowledge
4. Inferences
5. Visualization
6. Rhetoric Strategies
7. Identifying Important Ideas and Determining Importance
8. Comprehension Monitoring
9. Questioning
10. Summarizing and Synthesizing
11. Evaluation
12. Socioaffective Strategies in Social Context

## *Emergent Categories of Responses*

Strauss and Corbin (1990) expressed that “the process of grouping that seem to pertain to the same phenomena is called categorizing ... [or] ... open coding” (p. 65). Afflerbach and Johnston (1984) suggested the inclusion of categories derived from

students' verbal reports. To better understand participant's reading strategies, the categories that emerged from their verbal reports are as follows:

*Schema: Connection to Cultural Knowledge and Background Knowledge*

Definition: Readers activate their prior knowledge (schema) for text comprehension. Readers use prior knowledge to comprehend and evaluate new information and stories related to their own memories (Pearson et al. 1992).

*Schema: Intertextuality*

Definition: Readers make linkages from text to text through the meaning making process. Intertextuality "transposes texts into other texts, absorbs one text into another, and builds a mosaic of interesting texts" (Hartman, 1995, p. 524).

*Schema: Connection to the World Knowledge*

Definition: Readers make connections into their world knowledge while reading stories. Their comprehension of stories is significantly interconnected with their world knowledge.

*Inferences*

Definition: Inference is "the strategic process of generating assumptions, making predictions, and coming to conclusions based upon given information in text and in illustrations" (Richards & Anderson, 2003, p.290).

*Visualization*

Definition: Visualization is the "understanding, attending to, and developing a personal awareness of the sensory and emotional images that arise from reading" that

“give students the flexibility and capacity to experience an added depth of interpretation” (Keene & Zimmermann, 1997, p. 141) while reading stories.

### *Utilizing Rhetoric Strategies*

Definition: Readers use their rhetoric strategies to comprehend stories including character analysis, genre analysis, author’s attitude and purpose, setting, and other resources. These strategies are somewhat related to their first language literacy skills.

### *Identifying Main Ideas and Determining Importance*

Definition: To find the essential ideas and importance of the text, readers use their conclusions about important ideas to focus their reading and to exclude peripheral or unimportant details from memory (Keene & Zimmermann, 1997).

### *Comprehension Monitoring*

Definition: Comprehension monitoring explores how the ELL examines and evaluates his or her understanding of the incoming message (Revelle, Wellman, & Karabenick, 1985). I also refer to a sensitivity or awareness of the precedents and triggers of recognition and to knowing how to comprehend (Flavell, 1981).

### *Questioning*

Definition: Readers generate questioning of the significance or veracity of information in the text and the answers they receive in an attempt to comprehend the text. Posing and answering their own questions, readers monitor their comprehension and engage in reading activity (Rosenshine, Meister, & Chapman, 1996).

### *Summarizing & Synthesizing*

Definition: Readers summarize and synthesize in order to better comprehend what they read. *Summarizing* is the process of creating a cohesive and coherent short version of the whole text. *Synthesizing* is the process of integrating that summary with an evaluation of the text.

### *Evaluation*

Definition: Readers evaluate the text based on their sociocultural perspectives, social values, and the pictures and contents of the materials.

### *Socioaffective Strategies in a Social Context*

Definition: Readers mainly use socioaffective domain strategies with peers, teacher, and family while comprehending stories. Social interaction with others and their influences while making meaning are addressed. The affective domain includes ELLs' motivation, interest and emotion.

From the verbal protocol analysis, 12 general reading strategies emerge. Each reading strategy that participants used is analyzed and described in the following sections.<sup>2</sup>

### *Schema: Connection to Cultural knowledge and Background Knowledge*

Schema theory suggests an explanation for the facilitating effect of prior knowledge on text comprehension (Afflerbach, 1990). The ELLs in this study identified

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<sup>2</sup> Each of the verbal protocols was also assigned a project number (P1 to P16) based on the study's plan. Each culturally and nonculturally relevant story was assigned and conducted as a verbal protocol with each of the participants.

and used their prior knowledge while reading the stories. The verbal reports showed that building schema from the known to the unknown helped the ELLs make meaning from the stories. Various forms of connection making were observed in each of the participants. The ELLs connected the stories to themselves in three main categories—their background and cultural knowledge, their textual knowledge, and their world knowledge—while reading the stories. I identified these connections as follows: *connection to self*, *connection to text*, and *connection to world knowledge*.

Schema: connection to self includes connections to one's prior knowledge. Reader's prior knowledge included background knowledge and cultural knowledge (Anderson, R. C. & Pearson, 1984). The reader's background knowledge included his or her experiences, language skills, literacy skills, and personal history.

The ELLs' cultural knowledge included *cultural knowledge* and *cultural experiences* (see terms in chapter 1). In this dissertation, cultural experience includes the *cultural shock* and *cultural adaptation* that the ELLs experienced when they arrived in a new country. There are significant responses related to cultural knowledge and cultural experiences. Verbal reports in this study quickly focused on the ELLs' personal experience as newcomers in the United States. This cultural experience is the ELLs' most critical experience in the new culture of their new country.

#### *Jae-min*

Jae-min made special connections to his personal preferences and experiences while reading *Hiroko Makes the Team*. He said, "I like swimming, that's why I like this story" (P3; 27). His experiences with swimming made this story especially engaging for him as he remembered his swimming experiences. Actually, he wanted to go swimming

badly after reading the story. His personal experience and knowledge of swimming motivated him to enjoy this story.

He also made strong connections with his cultural background while reading *Encounter*, *Woodcutter and Tiger Brother*, and *The Wall*. He expressed his sociocultural values system, agreeing with Tiger's behavior toward his mother, after reading *Woodcutter and Tiger Brother*. In Korea, there is a sense that offspring should take care of their old parents when the parents grow old and need help. We called this *Bong-Yang* 봉양 (奉養) (supporting one's parents faithfully). Jae-min supported Tiger's respectable behavior to his old mother, such as bringing dead animals for her to eat. In another example, he was excited to explain such cultural concepts as Korea, soccer, and the importance of education while he was reading stories. These concepts are very significant in Korean culture and society. He voluntarily drew a Korean flag, a Korean school, and a soccer game in his written response after reading *The Wall*, a story about what to do with one's extra time. In the story, children drew pictures on the wall. Jae-min made connections to the story with a very interesting response that reflected his negotiation with the content of the story. It allowed me to understand his engagement in reading. His prior knowledge was activated and his response reflected his personal interest. (See appendix B.)

- J: It's about Korea where it's like the sky is blue. It's like an easy book. Like kids could read it easily. It's like the sky is blue and the flag is up and the wall is red and you know.
- R: What is the story about? Tell me.
- J: The story is about Korea.
- R: Tell me about your drawing.
- J: This is children going to school and their favorite sport, soccer.

- R: This is playing soccer and then what is this [the part of picture]? Is it a Korean school?
- J: Yeah.
- R: You wrote the word [Hahc-kyo: 학교: school] in Korean in the picture, huh?
- J: I just wanted to. That's why. Cause Korean they just got Korean words I have so much English.
- R: So this is Korea? What are the kids doing?
- J: They're going to school to learn stuff and playing soccer. (P11; 926: 940)

Jae-min revealed his excitement while reading *Woodcutter and Tiger Brother* because he was familiar with the cultural concepts, illustrations, and genre of the story. He said that he already knew the story, but he could not remember from whom or when; it is a very well-known folk tale in Korea. He said, "This is very common folk tale in Korea" (P14; 30). He liked everything about the tale: the story line, the content, the main ideas, the author's manner of writing, and the traditional Korean art style illustrations. He said, "See this is the Native Korean pictures" (P14; 262).

Jae-min also made valuable connections to his background knowledge and to what he had studied in his social studies class while reading two versions of Christopher Columbus. He said, "This one different, I said. Different, different. Are they named the same? NO!" (P9; 580). He had a clear critical understanding of how stories about Christopher Columbus express authors' different perspectives. As a critical thinker, he understood the different perspectives on Christopher Columbus and his own perspective on Christopher Columbus. Jae-min showed linkages to perceptive and informative knowledge using his background and cultural knowledge.



*Kyle*

Kyle brought the world map while reading *Follow the Dream*. He wanted to know the location to understand the story in detail. Like Jae-min, Kyle had already studied Christopher Columbus in his social studies class. He made linkages between these stories and his prior knowledge of Christopher Columbus. As his verbal reports revealed, he was a critical, but practical thinker.

R: Where are you going? Do you want to see the map?

K: I will bring a world map. I don't know the place. This one. [*He brought the big world map.*] (P8; 650: 658)

K: Because I felt something.

R: You felt something from this book. That was a good point.

K: I like this book. Cause, the main character is a boy.

R: That's good. What do think while reading this page?

K: I think myself. I was really surprised when he jumped in the ocean.

R: Why are you surprised? Do you feel good because he was safe or alive?

K: No scared.

R: Tell me, why?

K: He is a boy. I am scared, because he is jumping to water, and people are coming. See. Here. They are bad people. (P8; 662: 678)

He identified with the boy who is the main character in *Encounter*. He reacted to the boy's behavior, as if transacting with him while reading the story.

After reading *The Wall*, Kyle drew the map of Japan. He said, "It's about Japan. Yeah because I want to show them what Japan looks like" (P11; 1275). He wanted to share the map with his friends. Kyle made meaningful linkages to his own background knowledge. Kyle also associated strongly with these concepts which related to Japan and his personal preferences, by using his prior knowledge throughout the reading process.

He demonstrated his evaluation of the story based on Japanese culture and social values. Kyle also made good connections between the stories and his critical knowledge. For example, Kyle recommended to his friends that they read both versions of Christopher Columbus, because “this book [*Follow the Dream*] is very informative, and this one [*Encounter*] has a nice story about a boy” (P8; 425).

### *Lilly*

Lilly showed significant connections to her cultural knowledge and cultural experience. Reading *Family Pictures* stimulated her to remember her experiences in Mexico. She read two short chapters from the book, “Fair” and “Birthday.” She remembered similar events from Mexico. She transacted deeply with these stories, remembering her own experiences with her family. She dearly missed her father, brothers, and sisters, who are still in Mexico. The most predominant response was related to her own experiences with her father.

R: What were you thinking when you read this chapter about birthday?

L: I remembered about my 6<sup>th</sup> birthday party. I remembered about it. It was a long time ago. There was a big space, because it was my grandmother’s house and there were people all around it. It looks just like my birthday party. [*She looked at the picture for a while.*]

R: It looks just like your birthday party. That’s nice. Just like your story. Tell me about this story.

L: It’s about a girl and its birthday and it’s her little brother’s birthday party too. And you have to hit the piñata with your eyes closed.

R: Have you done that?

L: Yeah that’s what you always do in Mexico. They put you a little thing and they turn you around three times and they sing a little song, that’s kind of, *dale, dale, dale, pegale asina, porque si no le das pierdes el camino*. It’s like hit it, hit it, it’s kind of hard to translate it. It was my grandmother’s house. My dad was there too. I missed him. (P13; 104: 136)

Lilly was deeply engaged in her memory of her birthday with her family in Mexico while reading the story. She missed her father deeply. She also spent some time explaining her own personal experiences in Mexico. Her cultural experiences and events actively motivated her to engage in this culturally relevant literacy event. Her eyes were sparkling while explaining her own birthday and the fair she went to in Mexico. She started singing a song for the Piñata. She showed a high degree of transaction with these stories.

Lilly also made a powerful connection with Mei Mei while reading *I Hate English*. She saw herself in the story of Mei Mei's journey, revealing her *lived-through experience* (Rosenblatt, 1978) of coming to the United States. She became a Mei Mei while comprehending the story; the story became her story. She said,

Because she's from Hong-Kong, she's from Hong-Kong and I'm from Mexico, so if we had to go like to New York or to Apple, we couldn't, because if we had to, we would feel bad because it wouldn't be our place. (P10; 288: 296)

This discourse emphasized elaboration and aesthetic response rather than recounting a story. She transferred Mei Mei's experience to her personal experiences in the United States. She compared Mei Mei's New York to her Apple. Her language issue was similar to the one Mei Mei had. She identified with Mei Mei's resistance to learning and speaking English. Showing her awareness of her Spanish loss, she was very supportive of Mei Mei's position. Speaking Spanish became a key part of her identity. She noted, "I only wanted to speak in Spanish" (P10; 252), as supporting Mei Mei's resistance in speaking English.

R: Why do you like it?

- L: Because she's from another place like I am and when I came here, I only wanted to speak in Spanish.
- R: Just tell me how did you feel when you read this book.
- L: I feel sad. Because it makes me remember of Mexico.
- R: This book reminds you of Mexico?
- L: Because its kind of like, she's from another place and she comes to New York and I'm from another place and come here.
- R: So what are you thinking while you're reading this book?
- L: Mexico. How I used to live in Mexico, how I felt in Mexico, how I spoke in Mexico, everything. (P10; 341: 363)

Lilly transferred the content of a story to the story of herself. After reading *The Wall*, Lilly drew the Mexican flag. She explained, "I draw Mexico. This is Mexican flag. Cause that's where I'm from and that's where he's from" (P11; 87). (See appendix B.)

Noticeably, Lilly stayed centered on the stories *I Hate English* and *Family Pictures*. She understood the stories and made connections with herself. However, she did not expand her transaction moments into critical thinking process or an adoption of a new point of view. Lilly's response was same as Yanton's response, reflecting on Mei Mei's journey and transferring it to herself. Transaction occurred.

#### *Yanton*

Yanton's reaction to *I Hate English* was similar to Lilly's, reflecting his personal experiences. In the same manner as Lilly, Yanton made special connections with *Pettson and Findus* and *I Hate English*. I waited 4 months after I met him to conduct the first verbal protocol with Yanton because of his English proficiency and adjustment to the new environment. His mother also often translated for me during the research period.

Yanton showed his confidence, by developing a reading response voluntarily, while reading *Pettson and Findus*, an English translation of a Swedish story for young

children. Yanton's mother borrowed two books in Swedish and in English from a friend so I could do the verbal protocols. He read *Pettson and Findus* in English. He said, "We have a series of stories, and I have a magazine." He brought the magazines, with his excitement showing on his face, and explained it to me. The magazine included the main characters from the book and had short stories, cartoons, puzzles, and games. He told me that he had already read the same series of books in Sweden.

He also remembered his grandfather while reading *Pettson and Findus*. He explained that Pettson, one of the main characters, was very similar to his grandfather. He said, "My grandfather had a cottage in the mountain just like this." His mother said that the house and environment of the stories are common in Sweden and that his grandfather lives in a place that is very similar to the pictures in the story. He understood the story nicely, despite his weak English proficiency, with support from his background and cultural knowledge.

Yanton also made strong connections to his cultural experience while reading *I Hate English*.

R: Why didn't she want to speak English?

Y: She couldn't speak English. I think she was afraid to speak wrong or something.

R: Oh really? How did you know that? How did you find out?

Y: I felt so.

R: You were afraid to speak English because you were afraid to say something wrong?

Y: Yeah. (P6; 104: 118)

He identified with Mei Mei's behavior, remembering when he came to the United States without knowing the language and the culture. He totally understood Mei Mei's struggle and resistance to speaking English.

Yanton identified his experience through Mei Mei's feelings, her struggles, and her frustration. He mentioned, "Yeah. I know how she feels. I felt the same thing as her when I came to a new country" (P6; 268). He identified with Mei Mei's thought and behaviors, "I understand why she cries, yells to the teacher, and dream of her friends" (P6; 285). He dialogued with Mei Mei, and built up concrete community with her. He became a part of the story with her, interweaving his cultural experiences with Mei Mei's. He reflected himself in her.

Yanton remembered every moment of his experience in coming to the United States. He became Mei Mei and Mei Mei was him while reading the story. Rich dialogue flowered between them. He wanted to let his friends read this story, "So they can understand how I feel" (P6; 175).

Y: I think she couldn't speak English and she wanted to come home to Hong Kong.

R: So you did the same thing? Have you done that or not?

Y: Not yelled but I cried. I understand her very well.

R: So how did you feel at that time when you couldn't speak English?

Y: I wanted to have my mom there so she can—if someone talked to me, she could say it in Swedish.

R: So you can understand Swedish?

Y: Yeah

YM: He wanted me to be there but I wasn't there so often because I have to be with Julia too, cause she needed more help. Yanton had a Swedish boy in his class who could help him [in Ms. Henry's class].

R: Do you like this story?

Y: Yeah.

R: Did you have a dream? About your friends or your grandmother?

YM: He dreamed about his friends in Sweden in the beginning. Yeah, he wanted to go back so he dreamed about his friends all the time. (P6; 180: 224)

R: How did you start speaking English? Now you speak very well.

- Y: I tried to speak and I speak correctly and my friends don't laugh at me when I say it wrong.
- R: That's good. Okay, that's good. Does this story remind you of some event in your experience?
- Y: Yeah when I started school. (P6; 268: 275)

Yanton explained his language learning process and the challenges he encountered in the language learning process, "She couldn't speak English. I think she was afraid to say something wrong" (P6; 268). This conveyed his learning process in detail, because he understood Mei Mei's situation from his point of view, reflecting his experience. He overlapped his situation into Mei Mei's behaviors in her situation. He also addressed the importance of peers' feedback on his practicing the second language.

### *Summary*

Verbal reports explained the connections between prior knowledge and story comprehension. Pritchard (1990) found that cultural schemata appear to influence readers' processing strategies and the level of comprehension they achieve. The results of this study also indicated a strong connection between ELLs and cultural schema while comprehending stories to all levels of English proficiency. However, there are some differences in processing, connecting, identifying, and defining cultural and background knowledge among ELLs.

*Connection to self* in this study was understood on two planes: background knowledge and cultural knowledge (although cultural knowledge can be considered to be a part of background knowledge). Furthermore, cultural knowledge in this study is related to their own culture, cultural experiences, and the sociocultural values they had. Cultural knowledge was found to be a very significant factor in second language literacy development.

The ELLs' verbal reports demonstrated that ELLs read stories in aesthetic stance (Rosenblatt, 1978), in which meaning making is associated with higher levels of personal understanding and cultural experiences. The ELLs dialogued with the story to deepen their comprehension of the story.

Furthermore, transaction occurred while the ELLs read a lived-through experience, not only recalling their personal cultural experiences, but also transferring the story into their experiences. These cultural and personal experiences were deeply connected to their meaning-making process. They built up strong aesthetic stances while reading the stories, especially if the stories were related to their cultural experiences. They appreciated the story that is included their cultural experience, and they felt much better after reading it. The ELLs addressed how their struggling became acceptable and understandable, instead of questionable, after they learned that these cultural experiences are common by reading similar stories.

Jae-min and Kyle interacted very actively with their cultural knowledge and background knowledge. Their social and cultural values were highly incorporated in the content of the stories. They evaluated all events and stories based on their comprehension of sociocultural values. They became critical thinkers.

Lilly's memory of Mexico and her Spanish skills were the main caveats for understanding stories. Lilly made valuable connections with her cultural background while reading stories, but she was a very passive reader in evaluating social and cultural values. She made connections with her background and cultural knowledge to understand stories, but avoided evaluating them based on her cultural value system. Lilly also transformed the author's ideas into her own meaning construction. Lilly and Yanton



associated and reflected more with *I Hate English*, which contained cultural experiences similar to their own. On the other hand, Jae-min and Kyle created critical perspectives on two Christopher Columbus stories. They analyzed stories in detail based on their pictures, illustrations, genre, and historical information.

The verbal reports showed the importance of recognition and awareness of cultural experiences in supporting ELLs' language learning process. Lilly and Yanton made rich connections to their cultural knowledge and cultural experiences. Yanton also made significant responses while reading *I Hate English*, as reflecting his own experience.

*I Hate English* was a culturally very relevant story for Lilly and Yanton because they had similar cultural experiences to Mei Mei's. Lilly and Yanton built up strong community with the story. They felt much better and safer after reading this story because they understood Mei Mei's journey and situation, which were similar to their journey to the United States. Yanton also particularly recommended *I Hate English* to his peers. He said that his peers needed to know the struggles and challenges Mei Mei had in not knowing the new language and culture. Yanton wished that his peers could have direct experiences like his own coming to a new culture. This advice might be good for teachers.

ELLs' connections differed depending on the story they were reading. Noteworthy differences among the four participants distilled to two planes. One is their level of English proficiency, and the other is the length of their U.S. residency. On the first plane, the verbal reports showed that Jae-min's and Kyle's English proficiencies were higher than those of Lilly and Yanton. Jae-min and Kyle identified with stories that required a higher degree of cognition, such as the two versions of Christopher Columbus.

On the second plane, ELLs' length of residency in the United States differentiated the ELLs. Lilly and Yanton came to the United States only recently, and they had similar experiences to Mei Mei's. They transacted with the story that included this cultural experience.

This research supports previous research that has established that the reader's perspective strongly influences which information would be recalled from the story (Anderson, R. C. & Pearson, 1984). ELLs' cultural and background knowledge were found to be one of the main ideas for establishing their aesthetic stance. They used their prior knowledge in varying degrees and stances of dialogue. They utilized prior knowledge, from the simple to complex, in comprehending stories. Their empowerment was related to reading stories that are related to cultural experiences, personal events, background knowledge, and cultural knowledge.

#### *Schema: Intertextuality*

Verbal reports showed the ways participants expanded their comprehension of stories by making connections to text in the story. While analyzing the data, three categories emerged from data naturally. These categories were similar to what Hartman (1995) explored, but were slightly different from his. As mentioned in chapter 2, Hartman explored three types of textual resource location: primary endogenous, secondary endogenous, and exogenous. Golden (as cited in Hartman, 1995) addressed three convincing linking profiles: *intratextual*, *intertextual*, and *extratextual*. Verbal reports in this study showed three linkage profiles, intratextual from the primary endogenous resource, intertextual from secondary endogenous resources, and extratextual from exogenous resources.

My categories of the ELLs' intertextuality were slightly different from others, because these categories emerged from the data. My clarifications of the data representation arrived at a meaning-making process. I modified intratextual linkages and intertextual linkages. Intratextual linkages from a primary endogenous resource are those within the story students are currently reading. Intertextual linkages from a secondary endogenous resource are those from stories they had read previously. Finally, extratextual linkages from exogenous resources are those from outside the task environment. Thus, *exogenous* location includes linkages outside of tasks to the same genre of stories or extends creativity to a new story.

#### *Jae-min*

Jae-min used a predominantly intertextual stance by making linkages among stories. He figured out similarities after reading two stories, even when they are very different genres of stories written by different authors. He understood two author's different intentions and purposes. He said, "Cause I found out that this was actually Columbus" (P9: 518). He also compared and contrasted authors' critical points of view and different genres of stories while reading these stories. He confirmed his thought: "This is different, I said. Different, different. Are they named same? No" (P9; 580).

For Jae-min, it was a challenging experience to read two different versions of the Christopher Columbus story, because the same history was illustrated differently and developed into different perspectives. He learned that the same historical event could be explained from different perspectives depending on the author's intention, and argued with my questions related to this matter. He concluded that the differences between the two stories stem from the different authors' intentions.

Jae-min also compared and contrasted two different versions of the Cinderella story and evaluated differences and similarities among them, using his secondary endogenous resources. This showed his intertextual stance from secondary endogenous resource.

J: The shoes. And the father cause the father in Korean version, he stayed the whole time. It is easier for me to understand those kinds of books, because I know the same story. Because it's kind of like that version and only the shoes are different.

R: Oh the shoes are different and other things?

J: It's a Chinese version, it's different from the Korean kind of. But there wasn't a party, there was like a prince who wanted to marry someone and the daughters all like, "You should all go. I should stay." And then all the other girls, let's just say...there are stepsisters who are really bad, and stepmother asked to her clean all the time. She yelled at her. (P2; 365: 374)

Jae-min also explored examples of similarities and differences between two versions of the Cinderella story. He pointed out similarities such as *stepsisters*, *stepmother*, and *Cinderella has to work all the time*. Differences were *father's existence in Korean version*, *party*, and *the shoes*. He understood the two stories by comparing, contrasting, and using his intertextual from secondary endogenous resources.

Jae-min also made exogenous linkages from *Follow the Dream* to another story. For example, he explained *Follow the Dream* by giving an example of another folk tale:

You know like the dragon and the knight and stuff. There's a problem in the story. Like there's a dragon, you know like a princess story and stuff. They take the princess in a castle and locked her way away and then a prince comes and slays the dragon. That's a problem. (P9; 49: 59)

Jae-mi explained the story with examples from other stories in the same genre including subject matters such as *princess and stuff*, *a castle*, and *dragon*, all along with addressing the *problem* of the story.

Jae-min also showed his use of other exogenous textual resources while reading *Woodcutter and Tiger Brother*. Jae-min remembered a similar story from the same genre, a Korean traditional folk tale. He also made good connections using the main characters and subject elements. His cognition was working hard to create new ideas, using prior knowledge from the text.

In addition, Jae-min explained about *Bong-Yang* in Korean culture. He supported Tiger's behavior in taking care of his old mother. Jae-min said,

I don't remember where I heard it, but I know I heard it. The way the tiger did, because if mother get old, they might not see very well. So they can't go to shops and stuff because their eyes are bad. (P14; 240: 246)

This concept is a very important Korean virtue. He did not remember the word *Bong-Yang*, but he understood the concept. Many children's books include this concept to teach it to the children. He remembered a story that contained the same subject element.

Because it's a tiger story. It's kind of like this—wasn't it the next one? It reminded me about this story about this guy who is saving a deer and then this tiger came and said, "where did the deer go?" and then the hunter said, "She went that way" but she was actually in the bag. And then the tiger went that way—We have various versions of tiger stories in Korea. (P14; 280: 290)

Jae-min showed his evaluation of the story based on his social value system. He was a critical thinker who knew how to use social values to evaluate the story. For example, he evaluated *Hiroko Makes the Team*, as "this is good story for children" (P4; 221). He developed strong motivation and interest in reading culturally relevant stories. He developed a critical perspective to make linkages to secondary and exogenous resources based on his own social judgment and cultural evaluation. He also interacted at his own personal preference level and with his own experiences while reading the stories.

Jae-min was clearly a reader who used a logocentric stance, indicating “a linking orientation toward burying oneself in the passage by entering a textual world constructed and largely defined by appeals to the author’s authority” (Hartman, 1995, p. 557). He totally agreed with the author’s intention and purpose of the story. He avoid doubting author’s intention, when I asked him about different perspectives on same historical event as revealing his defensive emotion.

### *Kyle*

Kyle made linkages between *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes* and a Japanese version of the Cinderella story.

I have a Japanese version. Like, make a pretty dress or a skirt. And she had a necklace of the goose feathers and then she ran off to the party. She fell down and that guy, he wanted to—he saw Mei Ping, from him she was so pretty that he wanted to marry her. And after all the normal Cinderella stuff did, she ran away and she lost one of the gold shoe. I mean silver. And he thought that she was stealing it. And then he came to her house and then she wore it, put it on her feet and then she turned into the girl that was on this page. And then he married her. That’s the gross part I hate. (P1; 83:101)

Kyle explored differences and similarities between the Japanese Cinderella story and the Chinese Cinderella story: *shoes, a necklace of the goose feathers*, and the story line. It was very similar to Jae-min’s exploration. When Kyle and Jae-min, as ELLs, faced similar versions of the story, they made connections naturally.

Kyle analyzed stories based on his social value system, and he did not like the ending of *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes*, revealing his gender awareness by stating, “That’s gross part” (P1; 17).

His next move was linking texts to his understanding of two versions of the Christopher Columbus story. Kyle revealed his critical thinking skills by explaining the

connections between two different versions of the Christopher Columbus story as did Jaemin. He was excited to extend his knowledge and point of view by using secondary endogenous and exogenous textual resources. He made intertextual linkages predominantly related to his critical thinking process.

K: I think it was the king of Spain sent the three ships.

R: While you were reading this book, what do you think?

K: Yeah. These are same stories of Christopher Columbus. But, they are different. They are different stories of Christopher Columbus. This book [*Encounter*] didn't say it, but I think they are stories of Christopher Columbus. (P8; 490: 498)

Kyle generated his very critical points of view between two versions of Christopher Columbus stories, by using secondary endogenous resources. He dialogued with the two main characters, Christopher Columbus in *Follow the Dream* and a boy in *Encounter*, while reading the two stories. Kyle showed his interest and motivation in investigating and understanding of the two versions of Christopher Columbus. Kyle took a very critical and practical perspective to understand the textual arrangements, advocating the author's intention and purpose of the stories.

*Passage to Freedom* was also powerful for Kyle, although he struggled to understand the full content of the story. He was not familiar with this genre of story, the autobiography. However, he liked the style of the book, even though he struggled to understand new words such as *Visa*. He especially used primary endogenous resources, when he tried to understand the word *Visa*, because he did not know the word before reading the story. He figured out the meaning by using his primary endogenous resources in the context. In understanding the story, he also used exogenous textual resources between this story and other war stories he had read.

- R: Does this story remind you of any event or any other story for you?
- K: Yeah. One story. I didn't read that book, but my dad read a little bit about the book. I forgot the title. Let me see, I think "Side For Our Father", I think.
- R: Is it a similar story like that?
- K: It's about war. You know like those five people stranded, it's about that.
- R: Why do you think it reminds you of that?
- K: They're both related to war and stuff. (P16; 188: 200)

He remembered another story written about the war. He mainly used an intertextual stance while reading stories by making rich linkages to secondary endogenous resources and nonlinear exogenous resources. He understood the author's purpose, identified with author's ideas, and made critical observations about the author's intention.

At this point, in investigating the ELLs' verbal reports, I divided exogenous resources into *linear exogenous linkages* and *nonlinear exogenous linkages*. Linear exogenous linkages refer to a reader's linkages to personal and cultural experiences, whereas nonlinear exogenous linkages refer to a reader's linkages to the same genre of story and a reader's critical thinking skills as an interwoven matrix of deconstruction and reconstruction of the thought process while reading a story.

### *Lilly and Yanton*

I used the terms linear exogenous resources for Lilly and Yanton because their connection was very linear but was related outside of the task while reading stories. For example, as mentioned earlier, Lilly made linear-exogenous linkages to culturally relevant stories. Lilly was not able to use other linkages such as genre, main idea, or the content of stories while reading. She drew from Mexico after reading *The Wall*. She explained that "Cause that's where I'm from and that's where he's from" (P11; 85). Lilly



also remembered the book *The Day that Snowed Tortillas*, while reading *Family Pictures*. *The Day that Snowed Tortillas* was written about the Mexican culture by a Mexican author. She simply made cultural connections between the two stories. When asked why she remembered the story, she responded, “I don’t know, maybe because the setting is in Mexico” (P13; 240). This connection was very personal and related to her cultural experience.

Yanton made linkages to *I Hate English* similar to the ones that Lilly made. He made a connection from Mei Mei’s dream to his dream. The linkages between Mei Mei’s dream and Yanton’s dream were based on their similar content. Yanton’s mother explained the situation, “You dreamed about your friends in Sweden in the beginning. Yeah he wanted to go back so he dreamed about his friends all the time” (P6; 70: 74). Lilly and Yanton used exogenous resources to make linkages from the text to themselves. However, their linkages were more linear than those Jae-min and Kyle made, they did not show an extension of thinking strategies to develop critical perspectives while meaning making.

Yanton also made linkages between *Pettson and Findus*, a culturally relevant story, and another story. He remembered the other story, “the same style of book is the *Fox Hunter*” (P7; 119). This story came out as a series in which the stories used the same format, characteristics, and style. He liked to read *Pettson and Findus*, because he was able to made rich linkages this story with the other series of stories. Yanton as an ELL was comfortable reading stories of the same genre or with the same characters because he made connections easily, as well as having a background knowledge of the text. This knowledge empowered Yanton while he was reading stories. However, Yanton’s English

proficiency was not ready to build up critical linkages among the stories. He simply made linkages from *Pettson and Findus* to the other series of stories that he had already read in Sweden. However, the data were not enough to evaluate his intertextuality through this study.

Lilly and Yanton seemed to be less confident in building up connections among texts. One reason might be that they did not have enough English proficiency to make these connections. Another might be that they may not have enough room to rethink the stories to relate to others. They were more focused on understanding stories than on creating linkages to other stories. The only way they made connections was by linking to their own personal and cultural experiences using linear exogenous resources. Thus, their exogenous linkages were different from Jae-min's and Kyle's exogenous linkages. Meanwhile, Kyle and Jae-min made efficient and strong linkages including genre connections, content connections, and main idea connections using secondary endogenous resources and exogenous resources. They built up a complex understanding and created a critical matrix while reading.

### *Summary*

*Intertextuality* included connections from various sources, such as content, style, characters, subject elements, and genres of stories. These ELLs used this strategy to comprehend texts, connecting the current story to other texts and other external experiences. Hartman (1995) referred to *intertextuality* as “a discourse of dispersion, not of unity. Intertextual refers to a reader who works toward understandings by openly considering and constructing various textual arrangements” (p. 550). Intratextual linkages,

meaning that connections are made to local text within a story, were observed in a few cases.

I noted intertextual linkages throughout the study. Jae-min and Kyle made great links to primarily endogenous resources (within the text the students were currently reading), to secondary endogenous resources (to the other text), and to exogenous resources (outside the text). As I already explored, Jae-min and Kyle figured out the intratextual linkages of two stories by themselves by making great linkages between two versions of the Christopher Columbus story.

Notably, Jae-min and Kyle generated more sets of linkages focusing on the genre, points of view, and thematic distinctiveness between two Christopher Columbus stories. Noticeably, their linkages were more plural and far reaching than Lilly's and Yanton's.

In the intertextual stance, Jae-min compared or contrasted two stories, making linkages to his critical points of views. He also developed intertextuality between various Cinderella stories, by saying, "It's a good job and it's retold" (P2; 101).

The Korean version, the girl, the second daughter is young and then the prince, the glass shoe comes off, when the bell rings. Like in the regular version in American, you know, the prince pulls off the glass slipper. It's like that and then the stepdaughter, the first daughter keeps messing around. They put like more stuff to clean to Cinderella, and then after she's done the mother keeps putting more and then when she leaves and she has to do all the cooking also, but when she finishes, when she has to get something, she walks away from the room and the sister puts salt and stuff in it. So that's why. (P2; 265: 266)

For example, in retelling *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes*, Jae-min clearly explained the differences and similarities among three different Cinderella stories, Korean, American, and Chinese. He developed critical thinking skills by comparing and

contrasting among these stories, expressing the main concepts of Cinderella story. He also addressed detailed contents for persuading his ideas.

In an extratextual stance, ELLs use exogenous textual resources. Hartman (1995) identified this stance; if a reader mainly uses this stance while reading texts, he called the reader *a resistant reader*. Hartman (1995) compared the *logocentric reader* and the *resistant reader*, “whereas the logocentric reader searches for the author’s meaning in a passage, the resisting reader searches for his or her own meaning from the passage” (p. 553). However, as I already mentioned, my perspective on the extratextual stance differs from Hartman’s. I focused more on their linkages to same-genre stories and on their extension of their critical points of view. Thus, I used exogenous textual resources in a positive, not negative connotation. Jae-min made a number of linkages to outside tasks. He made linkages to outside historical events while reading *Follow the Dream*.

He planted the first Apple seed. His real name was Johnny, Wilson, I don’t remember. But since he planted so many apple seeds, people called him Johnny Appleseed. He was the first one to find the seed. And then later on they ate some and then he collected the seeds and then he traveled to the West cause everybody went to the west and in the winter, he didn’t even wear shoes. He just went barefoot. (P9; 306: 316)

As I already mentioned, I have developed a slightly different explanation of this stance from Hartman’s description. If readers use mainly the exogenous resources, Hartman evaluated the reader as *a resistant reader*, which refers to “a reader who systematically worked toward understandings through asserting his or her own authority” (Hartman, 1995, p. 553). He gave the example of *Diane*, one of the participants in his study, as a resistant reader based on her linkages to exogenous textual resources.

My intention in this repetition is to clarify the terms related to the reader who uses great amounts of exogenous textual resources, because the findings of this study indicate that readers used exogenous resources differently from Hartman's understanding. For example, verbal reports indicated that those readers who mostly used intratextual and intertextual linkages were also able to develop extratextual linkages in my study. Simultaneously, I was not able to find a reader who was in an exclusively extratextual stance. Yanton and Lilly primarily used this linkage due to their levels of English proficiency, but they did not deny the author's authority. In fact, they followed the author's intentions while comprehending stories. However, their linkages to exogenous resources were very linear. Furthermore, they made more than just linear-extratextual linkages to their cultural knowledge and cultural experiences. Kyle and Jae-min used this stance several times, but they used other stances as well. They demonstrated their linkages within, between, and beyond the stories.

ELLs who were in an intertextual stance demonstrated their critical thinking skills. The process took shape in their selection, combination, and application of their prior knowledge based on their needs. When interacting among stories, ELLs compared and contrasted to comprehend new text, bringing their background knowledge of texts to bear on the task. They developed unique perspectives to understand texts in historical, political, and critical perspectives within their intertextual stances.

Overall, ELLs made critical and creative linkages to others including primary-endogenous, secondary-endogenous, and exogenous resources. Jae-min and Kyle mostly made linkages to secondary endogenous resources and exogenous resources. They created concrete profiles of intertextual and extratextual linkages. Comparing and

contrasting among characters, styles, contents, and genres evolved as the main subparts of intertextuality. I examined linear-exogenous resources and nonlinear-exogenous resources as emerged terms.

### *Schema: Connection to World Knowledge*

These ELLs' experience with a new culture in a new country learning a second language to communicate stimulated them to learn world knowledge. Notably, their memory of events, issues, or places interacted with each new text. For example, the ELLs in my study enjoyed reading *The Wall* because the content of the story addressed the various countries and cultures that the four main characters came from. After reading the story, Jae-min, Kyle, and Lilly volunteered to draw their own culture and countries, an interesting and unexpected response from these children. Kyle drew his school in Japan, Jae-min drew Korean children playing soccer under the blue sky, and Lilly drew the Mexican flag, emphasizing the eagle in the center. Actually, I chose this book as a nonculturally relevant story because the story is about how children can be creative with their extra time. Meanwhile, the children in this study decided which were culturally relevant stories, making linkages to their culture and cultural experiences. For example, I chose *The Wall* as a nonculturally relevant material, but they interpreted the book as culturally relevant material. The power of readers' roles and their world knowledge from their own original culture and countries were observed here.

These ELLs demonstrated rich world knowledge, including their first language skills, their home countries, and the cultures in which they grew up reading stories. This world knowledge gave them great strength. They reflected their own culture and first language skills to adjust to their new cultural experiences in the new country.

### *Jae-min*

Jae-min showed his positive response to *Follow the Dream*, explaining that it gave him detailed information on world history. Jae-min supported Christopher Columbus's work. "He was just finding new land for the map" (P9; 274), even though he identified strongly with the boy who is the main character in *Encounter*. Also, his reading responses reflected his life goal, "I'm going to travel around the world" (P9; 276), after reading *Follow the Dream*. The adventure story stimulated him to think of traveling the world. This story motivated him to be aware of the world and world history as well.

### *Kyle*

Meanwhile, Kyle put himself and Japan at the center of his world knowledge while reading various stories. Japan was made a place in the center of his world formation. For example, he believed that the Chinese and Korean languages were originally from Japanese, even though this is not true. He said, "Yeah. Like Chinese words and Korean is the only other kind of—like Japan type word" (P1; 429). His world knowledge and world formation were from his center-pole ideas of Japan. Japan took a central position in his world knowledge.

An example comes from *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes*. Kyle believed that the Cinderella story came originally from Japan, went to Korea, America, and China, even though this is not true either. His world knowledge was still limited by his experience. His ideas of Japan as a center pole made me aware of his ethnocentric perception of the world and his formation of world knowledge.

Kyle also remembered the *School year book* while talking about world knowledge. He mentioned, "No. The year book, it has school faces on them. People in this school or

like other. Other country and other classes. Like in Ms. Henry's there's Yanton" (K-17). Yanton represented people from different countries in his world knowledge. He mentioned that he enjoyed seeing the year book because he could see his friends who are from different countries and cultures.

Kyle developed profound and very critical experiences while reading two versions of the Christopher Columbus story. While reading *Follow the Dream*, written from the European perspective, he considered, "I learned that he discovered the—he like helped the world, because they all thought that the world was flat and they thought—they didn't know America" (P8; 8: 14). He gave credit to Christopher Columbus's "discovery of America," by supporting the European perspective that he learned in social studies class. However, while reading *Encounter*, written from the Native American perspective, he wondered about the concept of *Invade*. He claimed, "They came to America without [the Native American's] permission" (P8; 610). He learned a new perspective through *Encounter*, and he developed his critical points of view of the history. Kyle explained that he learned about Christopher Columbus European perspective, but he thought his friends need to read both versions of Christopher Columbus: *Follow the Dream* is a very informative story to learn history and *Encounter* is a very good story for his friends. He expressed his own offended emotion, "Not the land, just the America people" (P8; 229) with his awareness of the story while reading *Encounter*. At that moment, he claimed Christopher Columbus's journey.

His cognitive understandings of critical perspectives on two versions of the Christopher Columbus story were well developed. In sum, Kyle and Jae-min analyzed *Follow the Dream* as a very informative book that they believed was true because they



studied this history from the same perspective in their social studies class. Meanwhile, they evaluated *Encounter* as a nice folk story that had a nice boy of their age as the main character. They analyzed and criticized two different versions of Christopher Columbus historically, politically, and critically.

Jae-min and Kyle made good linkages to the world and their world knowledge while reading stories, especially with the two versions of the Christopher Columbus story that stimulated their thinking process while yielding meaning through this reading activity. Whereas both children positioned themselves in the center for meaning construction, Kyle did so more strongly with himself and his country. They created critical thinking skills by making connections among stories. Yanton and Lilly were not ready to make such strong connections from the text to the world. They focused more on understanding the story in a linear way.

### *Summary*

The most widely used strategy of verbal reports in this study was the schema strategy. The ELLs activated relevant, prior knowledge (schema)—before, during, and after reading the texts (Pearson & Stephens, 1992)—as having connection to self, text, and world knowledge. The ELLs in the study made meaning from their own background knowledge, from cultural knowledge, from textual knowledge, and from world knowledge. The ELLs were very actively engaged, utilizing this strategy while making meanings from stories.

It was clear that their knowledge of the world is formed from their own culture and country. These linkages between their own culture and world knowledge supported them in improving their self-esteem and confidence. The ELLs in my study were proud

of their first language skills and knowledge of their cultures. They held their social value system strongly and used their sociocultural values while reading stories to evaluate moral issues and cultural adaptation to increase their world knowledge. That world knowledge stimulated the ELLs to create critical views of the world. Their critical world knowledge guided them to develop consciousnesses of the world as well as critical thinking skills. Mostly, language proficiency was seen as the most important factor to improve these connections and to improve critical thinking skills.

For example, Jae-min and Kyle, who had relatively high English proficiency, developed their connections to a critical level of thinking skills while reading the two versions of Christopher Columbus story. On the other hand, Lilly and Yanton, who were beginner ELLs, made very few linkages to their world knowledge while reading stories.

### *Inference*

The categories of inference emerged from each participant's verbal reports in which he or she added interpretations, suggestions, and information to the story. R. C. Anderson and Pearson (1984) defined inferring as "using readers' prior knowledge and textual information to draw conclusions, make critical judgments, and form unique interpretations from text" (as cited in Keene and Zimmermann, 1997, p. 23). Three categorizations of inference emerged in this study and impacted the ELLs' language learning process: *causal inferences*, *relational inferences*, and *global inferences*. Causal inference involves the reader inferring the antecedent or consequences of an action (Keenan, Baillet, & Brown, 1984). Relational inference involves the reader integrating information across sentences to comprehend the story (Richards & Anderson, 2003). Global inference in this study is an extension of relational inference. Global inference

was explained by Johnson and Smith (1981) as global inferences involving memory and strategic comprehension skills, including integrating various factors. Global inference is used in this study as a process of creating a personal meaning from the text, utilizing readers' memory and other comprehension strategies.

*Jae-min*

The story he created after reading *Follow the Dream* was a very coherent and cohesive story of young Christopher Columbus. Jae-min used relational inference to infer the youth of Christopher Columbus after reading *Follow the Dream*. He used his biographical knowledge to connect to Christopher Columbus's young life. Combining his emotion and the information derived from the story, he rewrote Christopher Columbus's journey from his childhood to his adventure in his adulthood. This new story contained a pertinent storyline and reasoning including problem solving. The evidence showed that he was a creative writer, going beyond the story he had read. This excerpt shows his analytical ability and his relational inference skills.

This boy wants to travel all around the sea, but this boy doesn't even have to. He didn't think of any of these kinds of stuff. The thing he doesn't—this is a (inaudible) and over 500 years ago in Italy it looked like this. And then a little boy, Christopher was born and then Christopher Columbus had his own idea when he was he grows up. He dreamed of far away places and watches his dictionary. He was a smart boy in his class and I think that every kid in his class were jealous of him. And he looked at the pictures about adventure and discovery. So when he grew up, he traveled to Europe and this is just the map and he goes to the castle and he says to the king and queen that he wants to go, but he thinks that it's too risky. But they think it's too risky, but they give the kings gold so he was allowed. So they started packing up and they were on a cruise. Six months later on August 03, 1492, he was taking—the cruise were endless. Not that world I just said, the crews were uneasy. Unfamiliar birds and fish and, seaweed frightened them. They wanted to turn around and go home and the crew just keep sailing west. (P9; 148: 178)

In his verbal reports, he made a nice story of the young Christopher Columbus's journey, such as "this boy wants to travel all around the sea." He used causal inferences as follows: "But they think it's too risky, but give the kings gold so he was allowed." He also, used the exact data from the book, "500 years ago in Italy," and he assumed, "And then a little boy, Christopher was born and then Christopher Columbus had his own idea when he was he grows up. He dreamed of far away places and watches his dictionary." There was no mention of *dictionary* in the original story. But he inferred the dictionary from the sentences, "the map and learned how to read a map." Jae-min assumed that Christopher Columbus used a dictionary. Jae-min thought Christopher Columbus might be a strong, goal-oriented person, using his relational inference from the story. He also used global inference, such as "He was a smart boy in his class and I think that every kid in his class were jealous of him." He believed that Christopher Columbus should be smart enough to have that adventure, globally inferencing separated factors resulting in the text.

Jae-min also thought Christopher Columbus got permission from the King and Queen. He utilized causal inference in this instance. Again, he used the exact date, August 03, 1492, from the story to convince his audience. Jae-min combined his prior knowledge of the history of Christopher Columbus and his textual knowledge from the book. He turned his background knowledge into current knowledge from reading stories to make a new creative story by using various inference skills. It was a very creative and critical avenue. Also, he expressed several examples for conveying his thoughts as well as illustrating the process of inference. His awareness of the audience was demonstrated in using the exact data. As a reader, Jae-min had a very analytical and critical point of

view. His causal inference and relational inference were combined to global inference to create a new version of Christopher Columbus.

Jae-min also addressed his cognitive knowledge and cognitive strategy process, by explaining the way he used his cultural knowledge and his inference skills after reading *Woodcutter and Tiger Brother*.

R: What has happened?

J: Well if I know the story—like for example Kyle read the book, he wouldn't know what happened.

R: But you already know this story, so you can understand what happens?

J: Yeah if you know it, you will understand it and you will read it faster. If you don't know it, you'll read it slow because you want to really understand it. (P14; 45: 53)

He understood the usage of cognitive and metacognitive knowledge and on-going strategy processing. He knew how to use his background and cultural knowledge, as expressed by “Kyle read the book, he wouldn't know what happened.” That implied that, because of Kyle's lack of prior knowledge, he would not figure it out. Jae-min understood the role of background knowledge and how to develop inference to comprehend the story. He also mentioned that the reader would read slowly if they wanted to comprehend the story well, because of the reader's lack of prior knowledge.

Jae-min also drew conclusions from the text and lesson to himself. For example, Jae-min summarized *Heiroke Makes the Team* using his inference strategy, “It's important not to make anybody—nobody hurt their feelings. It sounds very nice to read for young readers” (P3; 61: 63). His verbal reports indicated that Jae-min used inference skills to comprehend the story very often by adding his interpretations and suggestions.

### *Jae-min's prediction*

Jae-min predicted the story after reading *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes*. His creative version which was added after reading this story was very interesting.

I just pat her and say, “Hi, you’re mean” and then go away. When I say, “You’re mean,” she’s going to chase me all around and then I’m going to go to the nearest—if there is an airport, I would go to the nearest airport and then go away and then she will never see me. And then when I grow up I’m going to come back and when she dies, I’m going to say to her. First of all I’m going to go away and then go to the airport and then come back later. (P2; 49: 55)

Jae-min used causal and global inference to add a new story after reading the story. The stepmother was very mean. He wanted to tell her about his feelings. Furthermore, he made a short script to explain his thoughts and prediction. Also, he was aware of what would happen next, if he said something to her, because he knew she is very mean throughout the story. This is a good example of causal inference skill. By integrating the story to side factors of the story, he extended his causal inference skill to a global inference skill. He planned how to avoid the risk; he wanted to come back after she dies. His use of inference strategies showed his cognitive knowledge and knowledge process. His cognitive knowledge supported his inference strategy, which was a good balance of causal inference, relational inference, and global inference. He made a holistic meaning from the story.

### *Kyle*

Kyle indicated his strong interests in the two versions of the Christopher Columbus story. He developed his critical points of view while reading these stories, as I mentioned above. He also used causal, relational, and global inference in a good balance

to convey his thoughts and beliefs during meaning construction. For example, he used causal and relational inference while reading *Passage to Freedom*.

- R: Why do you think the author wrote this story?
- K: I think the dad—I think he wrote the story. I think he wanted to tell all about what happened to him.
- R: So what do you think about the author?
- K: The author? The author is the main character.
- R: Do you think he wanted to tell what happened to him? What part of the story was important to you?
- K: I think the best part was he never gave up. He kept on calling the manager of it and he asked two times, but the answer was no. So he meant to help people.
- R: So what do you think about the main character's behavior?
- K: Good.
- R: Why?
- K: Because he tried to help the people. (P16; 101: 119)

Kyle used relational inference to explain the author's purpose for the book. He said, "I think the dad—I think he wrote the story. I think he wanted to tell all about what happened to him" after reading the story. He was somewhat confused between the main character and the author because of the autobiographical style of the story. "I" in the story was a main character who was the father's son. The story, based on a true story, was about the father, a diplomat from Japan. He understood why the main character wrote this book despite his confusion about the style of the story. To explain the main character's behavior, he used causal inference. He thought his behavior was very good, because he tried to help the people. He also addressed the importance of the story, saying, "I think the best part of was he never gave up."

While reading *Follow the Dream*, in order to complete his comprehension of the story, Kyle confirmed his historical knowledge of Christopher Columbus by describing Marco Polo's story. This was an example in which he used his global inference.

Like he wanted to be like Marco Polo except that he had his own dreams. He wanted to see the other side of what Marco Polo saw. He wanted to go to the other side of it. But he didn't know America yet. So he tried to go around. He went to America and he kind of—you know—traded stuff with them. And he like went back, I think. And he like told the people of Spain, I think, the king and queen of Spain that think he was going to make it. I think it was three years later, the king and queen of Spain gave him a chance and he kind of went to—he went back to Spain and I don't remember much. (P8; 172: 185)

Kyle used global inference such as “He went to America and he kind of—you know—traded stuff with them,” although there was no description of trade in the story. He used his knowledge that one of Christopher Columbus's historical advantages was trade. He also tried to use exact data such as “three years later” to convince the audience as Jae-min did. His explanation of Christopher Columbus's adventure was organized systematically, using relational inference from the story he had just read and global inference from what he already knew such as “traded stuff with them.” After reading *Encounter*, he exclaimed about Christopher Columbus's journey, “They took the people from America without [the Native American's] permission” (P8; 610). This showed critical thinking skills.

All stories were meaningful for Kyle if he was able to develop any connections between the stories and his own culture and preferences. This example showed his causal inference while reading *Passage to Freedom*. Kyle said, “Because that way, the crowd wouldn't go faster because if he sleeps at night, he would never get his work done. I think it would take about a month to finish” (P16; 83: 87). Kyle wanted to express his



understanding of the father's efforts to help people. Kyle was impressed with the father's behavior in the story. He understood that the father was able to finish his work issuing Visas to save people because the father did not sleep at night.

Kyle's prediction of the route taken by the Cinderella story was another very interesting example of global inference and ethnocentrism. As I already mentioned, he thought the Cinderella story came originally from Japan, moved to Korea and then moved to China, and then came to America. In his verbal protocol, "Maybe because—I don't know. Because at the time I was born, Cinderella was made, I think. Then it came to America" (P1; 10). In his inference, Kyle centered Japan in his understanding of the story, which revealed his ethnocentrism.

Interestingly, there are some differences and similarities between the verbal reports from Jae-min and Kyle. Their verbal reports indicated their assumptions of how Christopher Columbus was sponsored by the King and Queen.

J: But they think it's too risky, but they give the kings gold so he was allowed. (P9; 166)

K: I think, the king and queen of Spain that think he was going to make it. (P8; 184)

Jae-min thought Christopher Columbus was able to get permission by giving gold to the King and Queen. But, Kyle thought the King and Queen just believed Christopher Columbus's proposal. In these descriptions, Jae-min made a causal inference, but Kyle made a relational inference about the way Christopher Columbus got permission and support from the King and Queen. I also observed other differences. They tried to use exact data from what they already knew. For instance, Jae-min thought the departure took 6 months, but Kyle thought it took only 3 months. They addressed the period differently. However, they knew the benefits of using exact data for the audience.

Jae-min concluded about Christopher Columbus's journey, "Not that word I just said, the crews were uneasy. Unfamiliar birds and fish and, seaweed frightened them. They wanted to turn around and go home and the crew just keep sailing west" (P9; 172: 178)." Kyle, on the other hand, addressed the ending of the story as, "he went back to Spain and I don't remember much" (P8; 186).

Jae-min described his story in detail including the difficulty of the journey. He embedded his story adding emotional interaction, "unfamiliar birds and seaweed frightened them," which was close to the text. He used causal inference, relational inference, and global inference in effective and efficient ways. Overall, Jae-min and Kyle used their inference skills to predict a new story after reading *Follow the Dream*. Jae-min and Kyle used their prior knowledge to comprehend the stories such as *trades*, *August 1492*, and *difficult journeys* from the text.

#### *Lilly and Yanton*

Lilly's verbal reports showed her strong associations with cultural and background knowledge through the study. Lilly used only narrow global inference based on her cultural knowledge and first language skills. For example, most of her inferences were related to her culture, friends, and first language. Lilly narrowed down global inference while reading stories; thus, the definition of *narrow global inference* emerged, but focused only on her cultural knowledge rather than using various comprehension skills.

*Family Pictures*, which portrayed her own culture, were very meaningful for her. She inferred this story from her personal experience. She developed narrow global inference again here.

- L: I think Mexico.
- R: Why do you think Mexico?
- L: Because in Mexico they say lots of those words.
- R: What is this?
- L: Yeah that's like a pueblo in Mexico. Like Tlalpan—that's where my grandma lives. But there it looks like that. Even the streets look like that in Tlalpan—It's a place about 45 minutes away from Mexico. That's where my grandma lives.
- R: Which place is that? Could you tell me slower, so I can get it?
- L: Tlalpan (P13:170: 182)

Lilly integrated *Family Pictures* into her experiences after reading it. She was still very attached to her memory and her friends in Mexico.

- L: Yeah. I just want to go to Mexico, because I miss my brother and my friends and if I go back to Mexico I'll go to the same school as my friends.
- R: So why do you think the author wrote this story?
- L: I don't even know who the author is. Maybe it's like for people to learn languages. That's all.
- R: What do you think about the author?
- L: Maybe he missed Mexico and he wanted to write a book. (P13; 208: 214)

After reading this book, she remembered Mexico because of the content of the story, the Mexican culture the author had in her childhood in Texas. Lilly understood the author's intention with *Family Pictures*, referring to her memory of events she had with father and family in Mexico. Lilly thought the author wrote the book because she missed Mexico, expressing her own emotional experience of missing Mexico. This story reminded her of a birthday party she had with family in her grandmother's house, and a fair she went to with her father in Mexico. She understood the author's intention. Lilly also transacted deeply while reading *I Hate English*, which contained a story similar to her cultural experience in the United States. For example, Lilly expressed "I want to change title. Maybe, Mei Mei's English. Because Mei Mei doesn't want to speak English

and then at the end she speaks English” (P10; 547: 553), using relational inference. She understood why Mei Mei did not want to speak English.

Yanton used a narrow global inference similar to Lilly’s while reading *I Hate English*. This is the only example of one with which he related while reading stories. As beginner ELLs, Yanton and Lilly had trouble with inference skills. However, as they worked with the story in depth, they tried to use this skill.

R: Tell me about Mei Mei?

Y: I think she came from a different country.

R: She understands you very well?

Y: Yeah.

R: Explain to me.

YM: He thinks maybe she has gone through the same thing as he did, when she was little.

R: So now she’s not little anymore?

Y: No. (P6; 196: 210)

Yanton thought the author of *I Hate English* had an experience similar to his. He assumed she came to the United States when she was little. He inferred the author’s purpose of the story based on his or her experience. He made narrow global inference based on his meaning construction related to his cultural experience. He showed his narrow global inference in his association with Mei Mei’s behaviors through the study.

### *Summary*

Inference indicates that the readers are actively participating in reading. They formulate inferences to bring closure to the textual information using their prior knowledge. Three main inferences were observed: causal inference, relational inference, and global inference. I added a subcategory, specifically narrow global inference, for the

case if readers used only their cultural knowledge without connecting other comprehension strategies.

ELLs compared and associated that information with their own experiences and to the total information of the story, and went beyond the meaning of the text to predict and conclude in their own way. They created new stories by using various inference skills while reading the stories. Their background and cultural knowledge involved and encouraged them while using their inference skills.

This section showed strong evidence for differences in the use of inferences between proficient readers and poor readers. The proficient reader, such as Jae-min, used this strategy quite often while reading stories. Jae-min drew conclusions from the text, making reasonable predictions. He also created dynamic interpretations of the text. Kyle used the combination of background knowledge and information from the text. He also made critical or analytical judgments while reading stories. However, Yanton used very little of this strategy due to his lack of English proficiency. This indicated that inference skills need to have a level of language proficiency. However, it also explained how background and cultural knowledge worked to create inference for students who were at a low level of English proficiency. Lilly and Yanton were able to use their narrow global inferences by using their own cultural knowledge and experiences.

Costas (2002) examined the procedure of inference and implication for learning and teaching ESL, focusing on ESL materials and cultural content, listening and reading, and speaking and writing. The results of this section indicated insightful implications for educators to coordinate programs effectively.

The findings of the study indicated that an inference could be a conclusion, even a new creative story, drawn after considering what had been read in relation to one's beliefs, knowledge, and experiences. Inference could be a dialogue between a critical analysis of a text and the reader's background knowledge: a mental or expressed argument with an author, an active negotiation of discourse about what is stated in the text, or critical and analytical judgments of the text. This is the process taking place while the ELLs were making meaning from the text to another level of discourse. The new levels of discourse became part of their knowledge and beliefs. Imagining a new story is a powerful role of inferences and prediction. Notably, Jae-min and Kyle became critical writers while guessing what would come next. Inferences result in the creation of personal meaning.

### *Visualization*

The results of the verbal protocols presented a comprehensible view of the relationships among variables in light of some contemporary theories of imagery and reading. Keene and Zimmermann (1997) asserted the importance of visualization,

Understanding, attending to, and developing a personal awareness of the sensory and emotional images that arise from reading give students the flexibility and capacity to experience an added depth of interpretation. It allows a passionate, individual response and makes the text memorable by anchoring it to personal experience. (p. 141)

Sadoski (1983, 1985) also studied the natural use of imagery in story comprehension and recall.

Through the use of visualizations, the participants in this study were observed in three planes. The first plane was the participants' responses to pictures and illustrations in

the book. The second plane was the mental images and sensory motors created by the participants while reading stories. The third plane related to the relationship between mental images and the participants' reading styles. Hatch, Polin, and Part (1974) addressed that beginning and intermediate ESL readers differ from native English speakers in that they relied more on visual than acoustic cues and focused equally on function and content. Ms. Green's and Ms. Lopez's ideas of the importance of visualization are supported by the research evidence.

### *English Language Learners' Responses to Pictures and Illustrations*

The participants in the study reacted to illustrations and pictures while reading the stories. The verbal reports indicated that illustrations and pictures were important for beginner ELLs to motivate them to read as well as to help them comprehend the story. Jae-min was also interested in reading *Woodcutter and Tiger Brother*, which included traditional Korean art. He explained the special illustration in the book,

R: You already saw all the pictures.

J: Yeah. I liked the pictures.

R: Why do you like these pictures?

J: Because it's kind of Native American kind, only it's Korean.

R: What do you mean?

J: Kind of like Native American, only it's in Korean. It's kind of like those people, only it's in Korean drawing. (P14; 244: 252)

Jae-min showed his interest in Korean traditional illustration and pictures. He identified with Korean traditional drawings and illustrations, explaining his style of reading pictures and illustration.

R: You never thought about what was happening there?

K: Like the pictures are all right about giving it out what is happening.

R: So you can look at the pictures and tell what is happening.

KM: Yeah. He read first and look over pictures. (P16; 232: 238)

Kyle looked over pictures to extend his comprehension of the story. Kyle mentioned that pictures and illustrations in the book were important points for him when he selected the book. Kyle's mother addressed his behavior on selecting a book, "He likes to pick the book from the pictures. But these are not his kind" (KM-15).

Lilly and Yanton used pictures and illustrations to comprehend stories. Lilly said, "Pictures help me to understand the story, if I don't know the story. And, sometimes pictures give me hint of the new words in the story" (L-12). Verbal reports demonstrated that pictures and illustrations supported Lilly and Yanton as beginner ELLs to understand new words or a new story.

### *Creating Mental Images and Sensory Motors*

Jae-min was best at creating mental images while reading stories. He explained that "I'm thinking of the videotape. There isn't a videotape. But I'm just thinking" (P2; 9). He was video taping while reading stories, more than creating images. This was a very powerful comment. Jae-min understood the knowledge of how to create images to enhance his comprehension.

Jae-min explained his concepts of mental images and his mental image process:

R: So when you read this book, could you imagine what's happening there? How can you picture it in your mind?

J: Yeah if it was chapter—the first thing—. Yeah it's a nice book.

R: So why do you like it?

J: I like chapter books. Because it takes longer and they have more adventure. I can go through kind of imagines what I read. I mean the chapter book. Like Harry Potter.

R: So you can imagine what's happening there? Can you do that?



- J: Yeah.
- R: Does it make you interested?
- J: Yeah. (P15; 211: 221)

Jae-min mentioned that chapter books make it easier for him to create mental images. He explained that chapter books are long stories written without many pictures or illustrations. He specifically mentioned the reason that a longer story is good for creating mental images, “I like chapter books. Because it takes longer and they have more adventure. I can go through kind of imagines what I read. I mean the chapter book. Like *Harry Potter*” (P15; 218: 221). This process of creating mental images made him more interested in reading, as with the example of *Harry Potter*.

Perhaps most notable in this regard, Kyle created his mental images while reviewing pictures of the cover of the story as well as the inside of the book. Before I received Kyle’s responses, I thought pictures and illustrations could not support the creation of mental images. Based on my researcher’s bias, I assumed that pictures and illustrations would hinder the process of creating images. However, these participants created images corresponding to pictures and illustrations in the text. For example, Kyle said, “I imagine the next pictures when I saw this picture [illustration of Christopher Columbus of landing moment in America in *Encounter*]” (P8; 728). For example, he created many mental images while reading *Encounter* and *Follow the Dream*, which included many pictures and illustrations on every page. He was very interested in creating artistic images of specific events, while reading the two versions of the Christopher Columbus story. Kyle mentioned rich mental images and images of adventure while reading the pictures and illustrations in the two books.

*Passage to Freedom* also gave Kyle opportunities to create such rich and detailed mental images as, “The person twisting and tossing in his bed. I like to imagine cause then I’ll have another picture that is not in the book” (P16; 240: 244). Kyle’s mother explained,

Yeah he said but he likes more pictures—so maybe they are new for him. He’s not interested in biographic yet and historical things may be new for him. But this is a good opportunity I think to start reading these books. (P8; 702: 708)

Realistic and detailed pictures and illustrations also supported Kyle in creating mental images.

Jae-min and Kyle were also aware that the level of the book impacted their creation of mental images. Jae-min noted that chapter books contained lots of adventures and complicated storylines. Jae-min and Kyle told me that they created various mental images while reading *Harry Potter*. Jae-min read this book in English. Kyle and Yanton read it in their own first language. They all enjoyed creating mental images while reading *Harry Potter*.

They purposefully and spontaneously created rich and detailed mental images while reading stories. The rich and detailed stories lent depth and dimension to the reading, engaging them more deeply and making the text more comprehensible. They created distinctive and unique interpretations of the text, recalled details significant of the stories, and used their images to draw conclusions. They continuously adopted their images as they read.

They used images to immerse themselves in rich and detailed stories, and to create new perspectives on the reading. They invited their motivation and interests while

reading the stories, by creating their images and stimulating sensory motors. These mental images were created more often while transacting with stories.

### *Creating Mental Images and Reading Style*

Jae-min and Kyle also addressed the relationship between creating mental images and reading styles, reading aloud versus silent reading.

R: But you can think while you're reading when you're silent?

K: And I like to imagine or picture it when I am reading silently.

R: Do you like to picture it?

K: Yeah. I make better pictures if I read by myself. (P16; 152: 158)

Kyle expressed his understanding of the relationship between creating mental images and reading style. It felt easier for him to create mental images if he read silently. After reading *Passage to Freedom*, Kyle visualized his comprehension through the story and created more mental images out of the text.

K: I only imagined one.

R: Which one?

K: The person twisting and tossing in his bed.

R: Where he couldn't sleep. Do you like to imagine those kinds of things while you're reading? Tell me.

K: Yeah. I like to imagine cause then I'll have another picture that is not in the book. (P16; 240: 250)

As Kyle read the stories, he created mental images from the text. Kyle also created another picture from the picture in the book. Kyle and Jae-min also mentioned that they are more creative at making images when they read silently than when they read aloud.

The verbal reports indicated that Lilly and Yanton rarely created mental images while reading stories. They used pictures and illustration to comprehend stories, but they were not ready to create mental images. Lilly created very linear mental images while

reading *I Hate English*. She understood this story in depth, by connecting it to her cultural experience. She also drew the Mexican flag after reading *The Wall*.

R: How about the story? Do you like it?

L: Yeah.

R: Why.

L: Because I like to draw pictures.

R: That's great and then so after reading this book, you want to draw pictures?

L: Yeah. (P11; 518: 528)

She created her visualization in a very simple way to show what she felt and missed, as shown her reading response. Yanton was not ready to create any mental images, and I observed no creative mental image responses from Yanton through his verbal reports. However, Yanton mentioned that he created many mental images while reading "Harry Potter" in Swedish.

### *Summary*

Research proved that readers who create visual images while reading, enhance their comprehension (Gambrell, Kapinus, & Wilson, 1987; Pressley, G. M., 1977; Sadoski, Paivio, and Paivio, 2001). As Eisenwine, Flower, and McKenzie (2000) suggested, "beginning readers likely do not engage in the complex process of composing and self-monitoring a kind of mental "movie" when they encounter difficult text" (p. 1). The results of this section indicated that Jae-min and Kyle were actively engaged in creating mental images and stimulating sensory motors while reading. The results indicated that visualizations were somewhat related to the ELLs' English proficiency.

Jae-min and Kyle addressed three important relationships between visualization and comprehension of the stories. First, they created mental images while reading—

pictures and illustrations to develop better comprehension of the story. Second, they thought the level of the book was a critical point for creating mental images. They concluded that chapter books are more conducive to creating mental images. Finally, they discussed the relationship between creating mental images and reading styles including reading aloud and reading silently. They indicated that silent reading is more conducive to creating mental images.

Visualization was reinforced by the reader's prior knowledge as well. Lilly created linear mental images while reading *I Hate English*. Lilly's English proficiency was not enough to create rich mental images. For example, her mental images were related to her cultural experiences. Making linkages between the ELL's rich cultural and background knowledge and the story's pictures or illustrations might be a good reinforcement for creating mental images for the beginner ELL. Yanton did not respond in this section at all. Beginner ELLs mostly used the book's pictures or illustrations to understand the story.

Jae-min, as a proficient reader, created mental images spontaneously and purposefully while reading stories. He developed his images from all five sensory centers corresponding to his emotions and anchored in his prior knowledge. Kyle created a certain number of mental images while reading and while recalling the stories.

### *Using Rhetoric Strategies*

The verbal reports showed that ELLs' rhetoric strategies included *character analysis, genre analysis, author's attitude and purpose, setting analysis, and using resources*. The verbal reports also demonstrated rhetoric strategies somewhat related to their first language reading skills. For example, because Jae-min was familiar with the

genre of *Woodcutter and Tiger Brother*, he understood the content of the story while reading it. ELLs with strong literacy strategies in their first language used rhetoric strategies to enhance their second language reading.

### *Character Analysis*

Verbal reports indicated that analyzing the main characters of the stories supported ELLs' comprehension. Their basic character analyses were derived from two main categories: good people and bad people. *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes* fit well within this simple character analysis. While reading *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes*, they grouped the stepmother and stepsisters as bad characters, and they placed Cinderella in the good person group. This grouping, along with other strategies, facilitated their understanding of the story

Similarly, Jae-min and Kyle were aware of Christopher Columbus's different characteristics from the two versions of the story. Christopher Columbus in *Follow the Dream*, written from the European perspective, was a very good person who discovered America. The Christopher Columbus in *Encounter*, written from the Native American perspective, was described as a bad person who invaded the Native Americans' land. Their understanding extended to the author's intention and attitude to understand the two stories.

Notably, Jae-min identified the shift in Hiroko's character in *Hiroko Makes the Team* and developed a deeper character analysis about Hiroko.

J: She has a weak. Cause every time her brother says something to her, her face falls.

R: But finally what did she do?

J: Her character became strong after her swimming. (P3; 165: 169)

Jae-min's detailed character analysis showed his steps toward comprehending the story. He positioned himself as a critical reader, recognizing that the character might change through the story. Also, he identified that a character's personality might become stronger, as shown in Hiroko's case.

Meanwhile, Kyle analyzed Christopher Columbus's character as a person who was very intelligent and brave. He said, "Smart, he only had a compass and stars to help him" (P8; 375). He admired Christopher Columbus as a hero while reading *Follow the Dream*.

Yanton analyzed characters while reading stories by using such basic terms for personality analysis as *nice*, *funny*, and *kind*. He evaluated the main characters focusing on his understanding of the stories. Yanton also analyzed Pettson, in *Pettson and Findus*, as "An old man is alone and lonely" (P12; 5). He already had background knowledge of this character because he had read the series in Swedish. This background knowledge helped him to understand the story in English. He knew how to analyze main characters, but his comprehension, as well as his descriptions of his thoughts, was limited by his English proficiency.

Yanton also used his first language literacy skills to analyze characters while reading *Wilfrid Gordon McDonald Partridge*. He explained the reason the boy was kind in detail.

R: Tell me about this boy. What do you think about this boy. What do you think about his character?

YM: The first thing that he thought of when you said, about this boy, is that he's very nice and he wants everyone to have a good time. He means so well to everyone and he wants this old lady to feel well. So he's very kind.

R: He's very kind, huh?

Y: Yeah. And he wants to ask questions to everyone. I think he is very kind to ask lots of questions to others for old lady. (P12; 186: 192)

R: How about Findus?

Y: He's funny. He does funny stuff. Do crazy ideas. (P7; 9: 11)

R: How about Ms. Nancy? Do you like her? Tell me about her.

Y: She's so nice. That's all. (P6; 198: 201)

Yanton's character analysis focused on personality. When he got assistance from his mother in translation, he expressed more detailed character analyses. This demonstrated that an ELLs' background knowledge and first language rhetoric skills are related to understanding and analyzing second language literacy. He analyzed characters in very simple terms, such as *funny*, *kind*, and *nice*, but these were very fine descriptions of the characters. Unfortunately, Lilly didn't explore any character analysis through her verbal reports.

### *Genre Analysis*

Jae-min and Kyle identified the conflicts and problems of the stories, comparing different illustrations while reading the two versions of Christopher Columbus. Jae-min also understood the concepts of genre, including problems, conflicts, crisis, and resolution as a story plot after reading *Woodcutter and Tiger Brother*. He also was aware of the formats stories follow:

J: I would read both of them.

R: The same story?

J: Yeah cause Korean ones have one part, like chapter one to five and then five to ten, then ten to fifteen, they make parts. I would read this.

R: Why?

J: Cause it's so much easier to read.

R: Than Korean?



J: Yeah, one chapter and one chapter. (P15; 712: 729)

He preferred to read books chapter by chapter rather than as a whole story.

J: Cause I don't like fears and animals.

R: But it doesn't look friendly, so why do you think they drew something like that? You know sharp teeth and it looks scary.

J: Cause it's kind of like a problem in the book. (P9; 41: 48)

After reading *Encounter*, Jae-min explained that author drew the scary illustrations, such as "screaming bird" and "scary boat," to emphasize the problems or conflicts in the story.

Also, he compared one of the main characters in *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes* to the America version of Cinderella story, "The old lady appears to the main character. Cause the old lady is different from the American version. Cause in the stick, she has a stick and it has like a dragon head on it" (P2; 359: 363).

Kyle's knowledge of the storyline also was apparent as he read *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes*. Although *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes* did not mention any happy ending in the narrative, he recreated the happy ending statement for the story: "And then lived badly ever after. And Cinderella, Mei Ping, she lived happily ever after and that's it" (P1; 107: 109). He transferred his background knowledge of the story to this new story.

Lilly analyzed the content of *I Hate English* only by raising the issue of Mei Mei's English proficiency.

R: So why doesn't Mei Mei want to speak English? She misses Hong Kong or why?

L: I don't know, it never says if she knows how to speak English or not. (P10; 376: 378)

She brought up the critical issue of language proficiency although it was not included in the story. Her analysis of Mei Mei's English proficiency was accurate, the story never did mention Mei Mei's English proficiency. I felt this comment came from her experience.

*Author's Attitude and Purpose*

Jae-min and Kyle recognized the author's attitude and purpose precisely, while reading two different versions of Christopher Columbus.

R: But they wrote different stories about Columbus.

J: Cause they're different people. (P9; 550: 552)

J: It's not the same person who wrote it.

R: Right, so why did they do? It's about the same person. There are not two Columbus. There is only one Columbus in the world history. Why do you think the authors wrote differently?

J: Cause it's just a story.

R: Do you think it really didn't happen? What do you think about it?

J: They're own attitude. (P9; 387: 399)

Jae-min explained the differences between the two stories addressing his opinion, which was that the stories were written by two different authors who have different opinions and perspectives. Jae-min's explanation demonstrated his clear understanding of the author's intention and attitude.

Kyle identified the author's attitude and purpose while reading *Hiroko Makes the Team*. He also addressed the author's intention after reading *Passage to Freedom* as such: "I think the dad—I think he wrote the story. I think he wanted to tell all about what happened to him" (P16; 101). This explanation demonstrated his understanding of author's attitude and purpose.

Lilly and Yanton only mentioned the author's attitude and purpose while reading *I Hate English*. The story was meaningful to them because the story plot was similar to their own experiences.

R: Why did this author write this story?

L: Maybe it's because he had to move to a place he or she wasn't from. Maybe it's that the author wasn't from here and he wrote the story here, cause he kind of felt like he wanted to write a story and he wrote a story. (P10; 527: 533)

Lilly identified the author's intention by focusing on her understanding of the story. Her voice was strong, revealing her support for the author's intention. Yanton also addressed his sincere agreement with the author's intention in *I Hate English*. He thought that his peers would understand him better if they read this story. Amazingly, Lilly also showed her awareness of the audience in her written reading response, as emphasized by her close-up visual representation of the eagle at the center of the Mexican flag.

R: Wow big eagle. Why is this eagle bigger than the flag?

L: I made a bigger one to let you see better. And the eagle is important. (P11; 434: 440)

By zooming in on the eagle in her response, making the eagle bigger than the flag, she composed transactional images for the audience (Unsworth, 2001) to present her visual representation. This showed the interpersonal interaction of social reality such as relations between views and what is viewed.

### *Setting Analysis*

Kyle was the only participant interested in a story's setting. This result matched to his interest in the world map and history. He showed his background knowledge in geography and the world map through the responses. For example, "The setting looks like Japan, China, and Korea—those kinds of types of country" (P4; 192). He recognized

different settings based on cultures and countries. He naturally analyzed the setting of each story while reading it.

### *Using Resources*

These ELLs felt comfortable and developed their confidence applying various resources, including pictures and illustrations, to round out their understanding. For example, Jae-min and Kyle reviewed the cover of the stories, the illustrations and pictures, and the author's and illustrator's names.

K: I kind of remember like the writer, the illustrator.

R: You like that book?

K: Yeah.

R: Who is the author for that book?

K: David Shannon, he wrote that story when he was a little boy.

R: So he wrote that book? How do you know that?

K: It says right here. (P8; 327: 339)

The ELLs reviewed the books using such resources as title, cover of the book, illustration, pictures, and author's name. Pictures and illustrations were the main resource for the ELLs while reading stories. Kyle was an excellent observer who knew how to use various strategies. In addition, memorizing information from the book was a good resource. For example, Kyle remembered the exact pages of specific pictures as well as names of authors and illustrators after reading a story.

Also, the ELLs did not forget to ask their parents, capable peers, and teachers, if they were having a problem understanding new words or the content of the stories. They also used the dictionary if they did not understand a word in context. Interestingly, Kyle sometimes read the last pages of a story before he began reading the story.

K: The sea, ocean. He was there for I think, I think it said—that page.

R: So you like this page? So was this book difficult for you to understand or not?

K: I think it was for 24 days. (P8; 418: 421)

Kyle liked to review the page of explanation of the 24 days of Christopher Columbus' sailing diary in *Follow the Dream*. It was a sailing diary of daily weather, direction, a compass, and speed of sailing with the detailed illustrations.

R: So he spends some time looking at the pictures?

KM: Yes he does. (P8; 718: 720)

Jae-min used pictures and illustrations to understand Christopher Columbus: “But he is just looking at gold stuff. He is just glaring at it and smiling. His smile was not nice at all” (P9; 286: 288). This explanation from reviewing pictures and illustrations in the book supported him in understanding Christopher Columbus in *Encounter*.

### *Summary*

I witnessed various rhetoric strategies while the ELLs were reading the stories, mainly character analysis and utilizing resources. The ELLs used their first language literacy skills to improve their second language literacy, but beginner ELLs' understanding was still limited by their English proficiency. There were no observations from Lilly's verbal reports in this section because she was a beginner in terms of both English proficiency and rhetoric strategies.

Character analysis functioned on two planes, the good person group and the bad person group. However, when Jae-min and Kyle faced two different descriptions of the same person, they extended their understanding by analyzing the author's intention and purpose. They began to understand different perspectives on the same historical event.

Yanton only analyzed the main character and he analyzed characters in simple terms, but he was able to describe character analysis based on his first language literacy skills. Although he was a beginner ELL, he analyzed the main characters well using such simple words as *nice*, *good*, and *happy*.

### *Identifying Main Ideas and Determining Importance*

The verbal reports in this study showed significant relationships among reader, text, and other factors for identifying the main ideas and determining importance. Keene and Zimmermann (1997) referred to determining importance as

finding the essence, in text or in life is the antithesis of denial. Determining importance means revealing that which may be denied or ignored—those key themes and ideas that hide beneath the surface and may go unnoticed if we don't bring them to our consciousness attention. (p. 93)

Jae-min identified the main ideas after reading *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes*, as “It’s important not to make anybody—nobody hurt their feelings” (P3; 173). In a similar manner, Afflerbach (1990) also examined the influence of prior knowledge on readers’ main-idea construction strategies, in investigating readers’ summarization strategies. He stated “readers reported automatically constructing the main idea statement significantly more often when they had prior knowledge” (p. 31).

Demonstrating his ability to determine the importance of the story, Jae-min evaluated the level of the story in relation to education: “it sounds nice to read for young readers” (P3; 63). Jae-min’s prior knowledge of the Cinderella story reconfirmed his judgments and opinions while reading the story.

Kyle also identified main ideas after reading *Hiroko Makes the Team*. His explanation of the story showed his personality. This indicated that the verbal protocol is a good means to examine the reader's personality as well.

K: I want to get a trophy, more trophies.

R: A trophy?

K: A cup, A gold cup.

R: Oh trophy. I see, so you want to get a trophy. Tell me about this story again. How did you feel after reading this book?

K: I felt like I wanted to be a swimming team and maybe—mostly that's the only thing I thought.

R: Okay that's great. What words or sentences do you like here?

K: She won the race. (P4; 90: 101)

K: I wanted her to like win.

R: Oh I see. So you felt good.

K: It makes me excited. Maybe because like hyper. Like I want to see what happens. (P4; 150: 160)

Kyle's identification of main ideas and determining importance of the story showed his beliefs related to the text. He was very interested in winning games and getting trophies. It showed his competitive personality. He also felt excited about what would be happening. Kyle's schema from the content and format of the text was clear. He also clearly demonstrated determining the importance or conclusion, when I asked to him about the importance of the story as follows:

K: "Friendship" in *Encounter*. (P8; 389)

K: "I think when the dad starts to help people" in *Passage to Freedom*. (P16; 204)

K: "So you can read maps to go somewhere" in *Follow the Dream*. (P8; 13)

Lilly tried to understand the main ideas, as well as the main words of the stories, by explaining the main ideas or importance. She used simple words such as *the race*, *Chinese and Hong-Kong*, and *fair and piñata* to demonstrate the main ideas and importance of the story.

L: The race.

R: Good! why do you like it?

L: I don't know. Because I like swimming. I want to win.

R: Do you want to win in the swimming?

L: Yeah.

R: Really?

L: I can win my friends. We make races and I always win a little bit and then I go like (sound: Shee!!!) and I still won. (P5; 61: 73)

L: Chinese, and Hong-Kong.

R: Chinese and Hong-Kong, why?

L: Because it's from another place. Hong-Kong is another place from New York so, she wants to speak Chinese and they want her to speak English, so she came here and doesn't want to speak English, only wants to speak Chinese. (P10; 568: 577)

R: Where?

L: Fair. Because it's like the setting.

R: Sure! Anything else?

L: Piñata. Because they tell a lot about the piñata. (P13; 140: 146)

Lilly identified main ideas and determined importance from her beliefs, opinions, and experiences related to the text. Mainly, she identified meaning if concepts were related to her personal preferences in swimming or other experiences she had had. For example, *the race* was related to her personal preference for swimming; *Chinese and Hong Kong* were related to her reflection of cultural experiences when she came to the



U.S.; and *piñata* came from her culture. Her ability to identify main ideas and determine importance related to her personal opinions, culture, and experiences.

Like Lilly, Yanton also identified main ideas and determined importance by reflecting on his beliefs, opinions, and experiences related to the text.

R: What parts of the story are so important to you or so meaningful to you?

Y: This one.

R: Why? Tell me.

Y: She shouted to Ms. Nancy.

R: How to speak English?

Y: Yeah.

R: Please read for me.

Y: “I want to talk,” she shouted, in English. (P6; 233: 246)

Yanton identified main ideas using short terms, but he described the main ideas very clearly. He identified main ideas well, reflecting of his comprehension of the stories, even though he was very much a beginner ELL.

Y: Mei Mei, English, Chinese and I don’t know more. (P6; 134)

Y: She talked about Chinese. (P6; 157)

R: What is the main word here?

Y: Memory. She remembers things because he gave her things. Because she lost her memory. (P12; 210: 214)

This result indicated that even though he has limited English proficiency, he used his first language literacy skills to identify main ideas. For example, he described the main ideas of each book, such as “She talked about Chinese,” and “Memory. She [Nancy] remembers things because he gave her things. Because she lost her memory.” As a 3<sup>rd</sup>

grader, Yanton identified the main ideas of stories very well compared to others in the study.

I observed a number of decisions identifying main ideas and determining importance from the ELLs' verbal reports. Jae-min and Kyle determined importance based on integration of their purpose and background knowledge while reading stories. As mentioned before, Kyle showed his competitive personality—"winning game" and "getting trophy"—while identifying main ideas and determining importance.

Lilly used simple words to identify main ideas and the importance of the stories, mostly using her cultural knowledge and experiences. For example, she addressed setting, personal preferences, and cultural experiences. This demonstrated that her cognitive abilities were enough to understand the main ideas and determine importance, but that she was not ready to use detailed sentences to describe these complex concepts.

Yanton demonstrated clearly his main ideas on *I Hate English*. This is also the story he transacted with the most, demonstrating that there may be a relationship between degree of transaction and determining main ideas and importance of the story. The ELLs in my study read the stories from their own perspectives, identifying main ideas and determining importance based on their own beliefs, opinions, and experiences.

### *Comprehension Monitoring*

Revelle et al. (1985) referred to comprehension monitoring as "examining and evaluating one's understanding of incoming messages" (p. 654). They studied comprehension monitoring mainly with preschool children, focusing on general monitoring responses, problem-specific monitoring, and sequencing of monitoring and compliance attempts. Flavell (1981) referred to comprehension monitoring as a

sensitivity or awareness of what precedes and triggers this recognition and knowing how to comprehend.

The verbal reports in this study revealed three themes related to comprehension monitoring: *defining known and unknown words*, *lesson as a summary*, and *monitoring meaning*.

#### *Defining Known and Unknown Words*

The ELLs defined important words to monitor their comprehension. Main and new words were identified in various ways, and they used various strategies to understand difficult or new words, including using context knowledge and seeking assistance from capable peers and adults. Table 6 presents some examples of the participants' word definitions.

Table 6

*Definitions of New Words Produced by the ELLs.*

| Name    | Definitions                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|---------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Jae-min | <p>J: Good is like, you're not bad or anything and you're doing the right thing. (P2; 5)</p> <p>J: Spring is right here. Everything warms up. (P3; 229)</p> <p>J: And he said, "You should swim fast so you could win the race." And then her face fell. She's all, sad with a frown. (P3; 71: 75)</p> |
| Kyle    | <p>K: I kind of figured out. It was like this piece of paper that he would sign. Like the part I don't understand is like he signs those pieces of papers that help those other people from like getting killed and stuff. (P16; 25: 31)</p>                                                           |
| Lilly   | <p>R: So you learned this word for the first time in this book huh? "The face fell."</p> <p>L: I always do that when I don't want to do something [showing her facial expression]. (P5; 87: 93)</p>                                                                                                    |
| Yanton  | <p>R: What is memory?</p> <p>Y: Like if you remember things. Something you have done.</p> <p>Y: Something very sad or something happy.</p> <p>R: For you or for him?</p> <p>Y: For me. (P12; 143: 153)</p>                                                                                             |

Jae-min defined key words to comprehend the stories. He described new words to cement his understanding of the story. For example, he explained *face fell* as "sad with a frown." Kyle figured out *Visa* in the context of the story. He understood *Visa* as "And he has to like sign everybody's—I don't know how to read that word" (P16; 15).

Kyle also added his explanation as follows:

I kind of figured out. It was like this piece of paper that he would sign. Like the part I don't understand is like he signs those pieces of papers that help those other people from like getting killed and stuff. (P16; 25: 31)

Lilly used a facial expression to explain *face fell*. Yanton defined *memory* as “Like if you remember things. Some thing you have done.” He identified a *memory* as “Something very sad or something happy,” adding his own perspective. Defining complicated or key words appeared to be a step in the process of monitoring comprehension while reading stories.

However, the ELLs also encountered challenges in understanding words. Kyle said, “How do you say—what is that word—I don't know how to say it in Japanese either. I don't know what I'm going to say. It's kind of hard to” (P8; 140: 142). Also, Yanton did not understand *memory* in English, although he knew the concept in Swedish. Thus, he asked his mother to explain the word. These challenges stimulated the ELLs to not only try to figure them out from the context, but also to ask capable peers or adults for help.

### *Lessons to Self*

ELLs monitored their comprehension by recounting lessons to self while reading stories. Recounting lessons to self was related to their sociocultural value system. The ELLs developed these responses whether having questions from me or voluntarily. Questions were related to the reason why the author wrote a book or what parts of the story were most significant for participants while reading the story. The verbal reports showed that the ELLs defined themselves as learners while reading stories. Table 7 presents some examples of the participants' lessons to self.

Table 7

*Definitions of New Words Produced by the ELLs*

| Name    | Lessons to self                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|---------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Jae-min | <p>J: The important part is, be nice to each other. (P3; 317)</p> <p>J: You asked me. Never make fun of other people when they could do it. You just need a lot of practice. That's all. (P3; 458)</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| Kyle    | <p>K: I think I would tell them that, never spill paint because maybe I would warn them to never spill paint because then you'll waste paint. (P11; 1461: 1463)</p> <p>K: Never make fun of people because you—you could go to a party when you're invited, when the family is invited, but you're not going. That means that you can't just brag that you can't go. So that's why. (P1; 343: 349)</p> |
| Lilly   | No response                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| Yanton  | YM: He thinks he wrote this story to show that children should help the older people. (P12; 12)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |

Jae-min and Kyle tried to take lessons from the stories. They developed concrete ideas of lessons for themselves or others while reading stories. Yanton's response was solidly related to the main ideas of the story after reading *Wilfrid Gordon McDonald Partridge*. I did not observe Lilly's response through her verbal reports. Participants in the study mostly monitored their comprehension by expressing lessons to themselves, mainly obtained by themselves, although sometimes they were practical lessons.

*Monitoring Meaning*

Jae-min and Kyle created advanced critical points of views while reading the two versions of the Christopher Columbus story, demonstrating their metacognitive knowledge process as they explored their comprehension monitoring. Jae-min realized

that the two stories were referring to the same historical person, Christopher Columbus.

He compared two versions of stories based on his evaluation as follows:

- J: First he looks evil. But in the beginning he's all nice but later on, he becomes evil. But in the whole story, he's not all nice.
- R: So which one do you think is a true story?
- J: This one. [He Pointed out *Follow the Dream*].
- R: Why?
- J: Cause it has like real motion pictures. But the main characters are different. That's the problem. (P9; 361: 369)
- J: The same meaning of Columbus but in the second part, they have different characters. (P9; 576: 580)
- J: It's evil, weird, and this one looks all nice.
- R: Do you think this is fair for this person that they wrote differently? It's the same Columbus. Why do you think they made it differently?
- J: This one is different, I said. Different, different. Are they named the same? NO. (P9; 548: 556)

Jae-min wanted to believe that *Follow the Dream* is real, but he still addressed emergent issues between two stories, commenting "they have different characters." Dialoguing with the two stories, he came to recognize the author's intention and purpose. It was an ongoing dialogue to understand the situation, and he confirmed his meaning making by demonstrating, "This one is different, I said. Different, different. Are they named the same? NO!" (P9; 556). He understood the two stories by comparing and contrasting them. Furthermore, he argued with my question, asking why the two stories had different perspectives of Christopher Columbus's historical journey. This was an outstanding argument, demonstrating his positionality as a reader. He also advocated and supported each of the authors' opinions and purposes for the stories. Jae-min's responses indicated his active as well as positive attitude toward reading. He followed the author's

authority in the book and showed his response after reading the story, “It feels nice after reading. It’s funny. The same as usual” (P3; 191), “I think it’s nice” (P3; 253).

Jae-min also explored monitoring meaning construction between English and Korean with *Woodcutter and Tiger Brother*. He said that the Korean version made more sense to him because it is a Korean folk tale, but he thought the English version was easier to read. The Korean version of this story was written in the traditional Korean style and was not easy to read. Interestingly, the Korean version made more sense to him.

R: It helps you learn Korean words? How about the meaning? Is it exactly the same in English or a little bit different?

J: A little bit different.

R: Tell me the difference?

J: See like right here, “the woodcutter cut again” it’s the same but I don’t know how to explain it. It’s hard to explain it. (P14; 212: 222)

Kyle’s comprehension monitoring while reading the two versions of Christopher Columbus was slightly different from Jae-min’s. His points of view on these stories were very critical and practical. Levels and types of tasks were revealed as parts of main factors that influence his comprehension monitoring.

KM: Because “*Follow the Dream*” has the age of Christopher and about Europe. He needs to know about other side of world, about how that works.

K: I thought that he was pretty brave to go see—to go around the world. To the other side of— (P8; 288)

R: So it’s the same kind of event but they talk different. Do they talk the same or different?

K: Different.

R: How is it different between two books?

K: This book is more informative and this more data or—this is part of a different story about this event. (P8; 528: 534)



K: How do you say—what is that word—I don't know how to say it in Japanese either. I don't know what I'm going to say. It's kind of hard to. (P8; 140)

Kyle understood the different perspectives in the Christopher Columbus story as Jae-min did. He recognized the validity of the Christopher Columbus in *Follow the Dream*, "I think because maybe he liked—he really wanted to know if the world was round or flat" (P8; 406). And, he explained the Christopher Columbus in *Encounter* as "Different. *Encounter*, it doesn't say anything about—Christopher Columbus. It doesn't say the word anywhere" (P8; 144: 146). Also, he understood *Encounter* as a story from a boy's perspective, "It was a story about a little boy. Then those guys came, I think the chief was Christopher Columbus" (P8; 176: 180).

R: So you agree that he was brave and he was adventurous, like an explorer. Tell me about that?

K: I think he shouldn't.

R: Why?

K: Not the land, just the American people. (P8; 223: 229)

He showed his disagreement with Christopher Columbus's behavior in *Follow the Dream* after reading *Encounter*. He also justified Christopher Columbus's journey, explaining, "he really wanted to know if the world was round or flat" (P8; 406). Understanding of *Encounter* gave him a challenge as he transacted with a boy while reading the story.

Kyle monitored the two versions of Christopher Columbus from a critical but positive point of view. For example, "I thought that he was pretty brave to go see—to go around the world. To the other side of—" (P8; 396). He liked Christopher Columbus's adventuring personality and his interest, which was revealed in his own personality.

Kyle's mother explained his understanding of *Follow the Dream*, "Because *Follow the*

*Dream* has the age of Christopher and about Europe. He wants to know about the history about how that works” (P8; 288). By monitoring his comprehension, he made his decision to advocate for Christopher Columbus’s work and justify his journey. Monitoring comprehension guided him to understand *Follow the Dream* as a “real history” and *Encounter* as “fiction.” Overall, he was engrossed by the two stories, developing his various perspectives and dialoguing with the two stories to comprehend them. For example, he wanted to let his peers read both stories, as mentioned earlier.

I also observed Kyle’s opinion of gender issues through his meaning monitoring. For example, in regard to *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes*, he said, “I don’t like it because it’s a girly story. I do like boy stories or boy and girl stories” (P1; 29). He had a strong opinion on gender sensitivity while reading stories. It was very consistent and coherent throughout the study. Also, his gender issues influenced his comprehension throughout the study.

He also identified the level of the questions I asked, avoiding the question with “That’s kind of a hard question.” He frequently used various strategies to monitor his comprehension. He compared, contrasted, and evaluated the content of the stories. For example, he differentiated the storylines of two stories. “No time. American, her stuff disappears within twelve o’clock at night. And in Chinese version—No time” (P1; 201: 205). He distinguished “No time” as the time framework of the storyline, because the Chinese Cinderella story did not mention 12 midnight in the disappearance of the magic materials.

Although Lilly and Yanton were faced with their limited English proficiency, they monitored their comprehension in a few stories. However, they monitored their comprehension based on the content of the stories.

R: Oh okay, good. So what do you think about Mei Mei's behavior here?

L: She feels like—I can answer this question, but I don't want to answer it, because I want to speak Chinese.

R: Oh she says she wants to speak Chinese?

L: Yeah. (P10; 539: 545)

Lilly and Yanton developed better comprehending while reading *I Hate English* than while reading the other stories because that story presented lived-through experiences. For example, Lilly said, “She feels like—I can answer this question, but I don't want to answer it, because I want to speak Chinese” showing her transaction with Mei Mei. She monitored meaning, overlapping Mei Mei's feeling to herself. Yanton also monitored meaning, reflecting his emotion.

Y: I knew what memory was before.

R: Then why did you ask your mom about memory? To confirm or why?

YM: He asked me because he didn't know the word for memory in English before. He knew what memory was in Swedish and what it means, but it was a new word. (P12; 268: 272)

Yanton also asked his mother what the English word *memory* means in Swedish because it was new word for him, although he knew the word meaning in Swedish. Similarly, Lilly understood better while reading *Family Pictures*, with which she shared cultural knowledge and experiences. Lilly and Yanton used their background knowledge and cultural experiences to monitor their comprehension.

Comprehension monitoring was defined as a metacognitive process which affected readers, their strategies, and variable tasks (Wagoner, 1983). Results indicated

ELLs' high cognition while monitoring their comprehension in literacy events. They used their strategies depending on tasks and differentiated their strategies, monitoring themselves. Wagoner and others included fix-strategies in comprehension monitoring strategies, but they were not included in this study. It was problematic, because two of participants are beginner ELLs.

### *Questioning*

Question generation is an important comprehension-fostering and self-regulatory cognitive strategy (Rosenshine et al., 1996). Posing and answering their own questions, participants monitored their comprehension and engaged in reading activity. They used questions to identify main ideas, determined importance, and monitored their comprehension in reading.

The ELLs in the study used questioning strategies throughout the reading process. I observed three main planes of questioning: to clarify the meaning, to monitor meaning, and to address one's opinion related to the text to develop critical thinking.

Jae-min used a high degree of questioning related to history and the text. He also used questioning strategy to confirm his opinion and sway his audience (me in this context), "Cause maybe Native Americans might want to go there. But if the map only had America, you would only stay here. Do you know Johnny Appleseed?" (P9; 302: 304). His questioning strategy was used to sway me to his opinion.

Jae-min also used questioning to decipher meaning if he did not know some words while reading. When he first faced new words, he looked at the pictures and tried to find the words in the dictionary. If those strategies failed him, he asked friends about the words. He said, "Usually, I just ask my friend. What does this mean and stuff?" (P15;

70). These responses show how the ELL gets help: Jae-min used questioning to confirm his ideas, to learn the meaning of new words, and to confirm his opinion.

Kyle used questioning strategies fruitfully while reading the two versions of Christopher Columbus and *Passage to Freedom*. These stories demanded a high degree of cognitive and metacognitive knowledge compared to the others, suggesting that the questioning strategies could be related to high-demand comprehension tasks. Kyle tried to comprehend without questioning when he faced a new word; he figured out the word “Visa” in the context without questioning. In that case, he used the hint of context to understand the story, and he made meaning while reading the story.

However, Kyle used questioning to understand the whole story. He brought up main character’s questions to explain the story.

They didn’t tell the story why everybody was coming to that house and not the other houses. Like this boy was asking all these questions, like why are all the people coming to this house and not the other houses, not other families. And the dad takes his time to explain and didn’t tell why or why not or why that house and stuff. (P16; 49: 55)

Kyle also raised questions about Christopher Columbus’s journey to America. He was confused by the different perspectives—European and Native American—explaining Christopher Columbus’s journey. This questioning is very essential to becoming a critical thinker. Kyle mentioned, “In the middle the Spain people took some of the Americans without asking. I was kind of wondering about that. Like why they took the Americans” (P9; 192: 198). He worked for a while to comprehend the story clearly.

Lilly asked simple questions about new words while reading stories, trying to understand the basic story of the text. For example, she asked me new words if she did not know how to read them. Yanton asked his mother the meaning of one word while

reading *Wilfrid Gordon McDonald Partridge*. At the time, I was not sure if his questions were about the English word *memory* or the concept of memory in general. Yanton's mother clarified this for me with,

He asked me because he didn't know the word for memory in English before. He knew what memory was in Swedish and what it means, but it was a new word.  
(P7; 266: 272)

In this way, Yanton transferred his knowledge on the meaning of *memory* in Swedish to English by asking questions of his mother.

The ELLs in my study asked questions on many topics, from simple word meanings to the meaning of the story as a whole. For example, Lilly and Yanton asked just a few questions to understand new words or the content of the stories in English. They clarified meaning by asking questions of capable peers or adults. In addition to those types of questions, Jae-min and Kyle used questions to determine the author's intention or style or the format of the stories. They clearly developed questions to confirm their opinions and thoughts, using a *dialogical thinking* process.

Questioning apparently extended dialogical thinking and the thinking process. Kyle entered into a dialogic thinking process to create critical points of view. According to Commeyras and Sumner (1998), *dialogical thinking* refers to fostering serious consideration of alternative or competing perspectives on significant issues. Also, in teaching, "learn to argue for and against each and every important point of view and each basic belief or conclusions that they are to take seriously" (Paul, 1987, p. 140: cited in Commeyras & Sumner, 1998). While the ELLs were working to understand the stories, they posed questions critically, demonstrating their critical thinking through dialogue thinking and discussion. Furthermore, the ELLs' various levels of questioning

demonstrated their different levels of comprehension while reading the stories. They integrated their background knowledge into new understanding by asking questions.

### *Summarizing & Synthesizing*

The ELLs in the study summarized and synthesized after reading the stories. I differentiate between summarizing and synthesizing. *Summarizing* is a process of summary within a cohesive and coherent short story, of the content of the whole story, and *synthesizing* is the integration of summarizing with evaluation of the text. ELLs summarized or synthesized stories, depending on the level of stories, by reflecting their comprehension skills within their socioaffective domains.

Patten, Chao, and Reigeluth (1986) considered synthesis to be a macro strategy, supporting Bruner's (1960) concept of synthesizing, "understanding [a subject] in a way that permits many other things to be related to it meaningfully" (p. 7). Keene and Zimmermann (1997) explored synthesis as "the mind's mosaic artistry. ... Synthesis is the process of ordering, recalling, and recreating into a coherent whole the information with which our minds are bombarded every day" (p. 169). ELLs in this study responded to various summarizations and syntheses of the stories, when I asked them to retell the story.

The verbal reports indicated that Jae-min summarized the insights of stories by monitoring his meaning construction. Furthermore, Jae-min synthesized the stories by integrating his summary to his evaluation of the other stories—*The Wall*, *Woodcutter and Tiger Brother*, and *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes* respectively below.

Examples of Jae-min's summarizing:

Yeah the Jamaica girl and then he said paint with an exclamation point and then she said, “It’s a great idea.” She said they could paint on her walls, right here. And then they tell the story to their mother, father and Lynn’s grandmother. And Molly’s father and Carlos asked his mother to tell the story all to them and that they were ready. Carlos and—I think it was Carlos and Molly they had to think all week to do that. (P11; 632: 648)

There’s this mom and she’s very old because she played a trick and then the mom—he just pretends that his mom is sick. The one brother was gone for a month and he got turned into a tiger, but it wasn’t true. He didn’t ever say that, or maybe he did, but I don’t know. But the tiger thought the mom was real. And then at the end there are five cubs with black ribbons on their tails and then they started playing around the mothers dome and then after the next page, they bowed down and stuff. (P14; 56: 70)

The story is about Mei Ping and Mei Ping is like a slave and her mother, stepmother thinks she is the beautiful one so she uses her like a slave. She doesn’t like doing all the work and stuff. And her first daughter, she wanted her to be much more prettier than her. She was lonely in the beginning and then but her only friend was the goose and then the goose got killed cause her stepmother found out. And then she ran away and the old lady came right next to Mei Ping and then she told Mei Ping to gather up all the goose feathers and make it into a circle, like a fire ring, those rings that have fire around and then it was like goose like one of those. And then when she was hungry she asked the goose and then she got food. And then also she talked—let’s see—as little bit as possible. (P2; 29: 49)

Expressing his understanding and reflections on the stories, Jae-min summarized *The Wall* nicely. *Woodcutter and Tiger* was a complicated story to summarize because of the complex story line, but he summarized the story insightfully. He got confused about the trick part, “He didn’t ever say that, or maybe he did, but I don’t know” (P14; 60). He understood the content of the story, but he was not sure how he figured it out. Interestingly, Jae-min started summarizing the *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes*, but he never finished. This indicates his low association with the story.

Examples of Jae-min’s synthesizing:

Talk cause talking is important to tell other people that you need something and could you find something and help me. Could you—let’s see—I don’t know about this. (P2; 389: 395)



Because they might not know that it's Christopher so this might be okay. This might be also O or X and this one would be O cause this has landing information and this just has traveling information and it's just different. Like moving, so if you combine these two books together, like this, they would know that it's Christopher. (P9; 267: 277)

Jae-min was a synthesizer while reading stories. First, he synthesized the story, *The Wall*. Second, he synthesized practically, focusing his evaluation on the two versions of Christopher Columbus. He synthesized two stories as evaluating two different descriptions of Christopher Columbus using symbols of X and O. He synthesized *Follow the Dream* as a very informative book. He liked reading *Encounter* because it contained a good story.

He combined the two different perspectives on Christopher Columbus, noting "Like moving, so if you combine these two books together, like this, they would know that it's Christopher." As a synthesizer, he addressed Christopher Columbus's identity by combining both sides of Christopher Columbus. In a clear statement, Jae-min indicated his patterns of understanding and comprehending the stories and explored summarizing and synthesizing strategies.

Also, the verbal reports of summarizing and synthesizing demonstrated the meaning construction process and his comprehension style. For example, Jae-min used O or X to evaluate the story, such as "This might be also O or X and this one would be O cause this has landing information and this just has traveling information and it's just different." Jae-min created his own style of synthesizing the story.

Kyle identified strongly with his socioaffective domains while summarizing and synthesizing the stories. He summarized three stories, *Passage to Freedom*, *The Wall*, and *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes*.

Examples of Kyle's summarizing:

- K: It's about a family that they're surrounded by people, by the metal gate with all the other people that want help from that husband and that family and he helps. And he has to like sign everybody's—I don't know how to read that word. (P16; 13: 19)
- K: It's about painting on the wall. Two girls and a boy like draw on the wall about where they came from and how they lived and just drawing what they did and where they came from. (P11; 1075: 1081)
- K: Okay she—first her dad, I think it was, he died. I mean he died so—the wife died of hers, so the dad of his was so mad that he married another person, another wife and then she died. So he was so mad that he—I think he killed himself.
- R: In this story?
- K: So Mei Ping, she got to the stepsisters, they didn't like her and I think it was the king, it was his birthday and those two stepsisters, they went and made her go and stay in the house, then wait, wait, wait—I know.
- R: Okay so tell me again. You can look at it.
- K: Okay. Okay I'll go where I messed up. She had a goose. She had a goose and that was her only friend and then the goose died. She was so sad she ran to the end of the mountain, I think. And then like an old woman came and said, made like a ring, like a circle with the goose feathers and if she had something to do with it, it will happen, but if she does it so often, a lot, she used to do it very often, because if she does it every day, every time, it would like turn into black ashes, I think, gray and black. And then so then it was time for that birthday party. (P1; 48: 78)

Kyle summarized by recounting the major themes while reading. He did not finish summarizing *Passage to Freedom* because he stumbled on the new word *Visa*. He understood the meaning from the context, but he did not know how to read it. He summarized *The Wall* nicely, showing his engagement of the story. He had a hard time summarizing *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes*, again indicating his lack of motivations or interest in the story. For example, he stopped responding to the story for a while, saying, "Okay I'll go where I messed up." This indicated that he had lost interest and concentration for comprehending the story. This was very similar to Jae-min's response.

He didn't finish his summary of the story either. Kyle called this a "girly" story for girls.

In addition, he avoid my questions,

K: So he was so mad that he—I think he killed himself.

R: In this story? (P1; 51: 53)

He did not answer my question and this was not in the story. Interestingly, Jae-min and

Kyle clearly remembered the goose's magic. They told me that they liked to see magic.

Their explanation of the goose part was very clear, comparatively. This shows the

significant relationship between engagement in and comprehension of the story.

Examples of Kyle's synthesizing follow:

K: It's this girl that getting bullied and the last part, like she practices and practices going like swimming and she is the fastest one. So her teacher asks her to be in the swimming team. That's very nice plot.

R: Really? I like it.

K: And she practices a lot. So she won the race. (P4; 54: 64)

Kyle's responses in summarizing and synthesizing the stories presented important issues for ELLs' reading process. He nicely summarized and synthesized one story,

*Hiroko Makes the Team*. This showed his engagement in the story, by following his

positive responses on such terms as *swimming* and *won the race*.

In contrast, it was quite a challenge for beginner ELLs to summarize and synthesize the stories. Lilly and Yanton demonstrated their summary of the stories only briefly.

Lilly and Yanton's examples of summarizing

L: Because they didn't have anything to do. So they asked Lynn's grandmother and she said to paint something. It's three children that have nothing to do. And they go a Lynn's grandmother and they asked what could they do and her grandmother. She was bored also like them so her grandmother gave them paint. And then Molly said, "paint" at the wall. (P11; 629: 639)

Y: He wanted to know what memory is and then he went to give the things to Ms. Nancy. So Nancy could remember things. (P12; 139: 141)

When Lilly summarized *The Wall*, she discussed the three children and Lynn's grandmother. She also grasped the main storyline, *paint*. Yanton summarized *Wilfrid Gordon McDonald Partridge* briefly, but very nicely. These stories were very much beginner-level stories.

#### Examples of Lilly and Yanton's synthesizing

R: Do you like this book?

L: Yes.

R: Why do you like this book?

L: Because it has lessons.

R: Lessons? What kind of lessons did it have?

L: Two lessons. Never to say things that you don't know. If you're good at or if you're not good at. And never tease someone. Never hurt somebody's feelings. (P5; 9: 28)

Y: It's about Mei Mei from Hong Kong and she moved to New York and she can't speak any English. She doesn't want to speak English and she dreamed about Hong Kong and then she talked with Nancy. Nancy is a teacher and that's all. At the end Mei Mei and Nancy became friends. Mei Mei speaks English. That's all. (P6; 82: 90)

Lilly synthesized *Hiroko Makes the Team* as a lesson to children. She summarized two lessons from the book as, "Two lessons. Never to say things that you don't know. If you're good at or if you're not good at. And never tease someone. Never hurt somebody's feelings" (P5; 9: 14). She synthesized the story as illuminating lessons. Yanton synthesized the story of *I Hate English* solidly and concisely, reflecting his cultural experience. He made insightful statements synthesizing the story, "She can't speak any English. She doesn't want to speak English" (P6; 15: 19). This comment

showed his meaning construction from the story. He synthesized Mei Mei's situation, reflecting his own.

However, Yanton's summary was very simple, but quite clear. He did not synthesize the story until he was able to read it well. His summary and synthesis showed his degree of cognition, indicating that he used his first language literacy skills while summarizing or synthesizing stories in English. Yanton maintained his cognitive synthesis as he read. He was aware of the overall themes of the story and the main components of the story such as character, setting, problem, conflict, sequence of events, solution, and resolution.

A. L. Brown, Day, and Jones (1983) stated readers synthesized in order to better understand what they have read. The ELLs revised their cognitive syntheses as they read, based on their level of English proficiency and cognition within their socioaffective domains. They expressed their meaning-making process, exploring their synthesis after reading each story. Their synthesis mainly included their own expression, evaluation, ideas, themes, recommendations, suggestions, and critical views of their own reading. They summarized and synthesized differently but significantly while reading stories. This process also offered me the opportunity to investigate the meaning-making process firsthand. Furthermore, they synthesized their own reading to enhance their understanding of the story.

### *Evaluation*

Jae-min and Kyle tended to focus their evaluations on the content, style, characters, gender issues, and moral issues while reading both on culturally and nonculturally relevant stories. For example, their favorite sentences are related to their

cultural background knowledge. Also, family influence was embedded in their sociocultural values, although they hardly recognized the influence from family and culture. I observed various evaluations

from simple character evaluation to complicated evaluation related to the genre or content of the story. Four themes emerged from the participants' verbal reports, *sociocultural perspectives in evaluation, gender issues in evaluation, pictures and content of the story in evaluation, and explorations of the two perspectives of the same story.*

#### *Sociocultural Perspective in Evaluation*

The ELLs in this study evaluated events or stories using their sociocultural value system and examined their judgment of moral issues. As mentioned earlier, they tended to divide the main characters into two groups, good people and bad people. As Jae-min and Kyle read *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes*, they easily labeled Mei Ping a good person and the stepsisters and stepmother in the bad group.

Jae-min also closely evaluated *Woodcutter and Tiger Brother* based on the framework and content of the story. He focused on one of the story components, such as *main character, trick, or pictures* in the story.

J: I think it's nice.

R: What kind of things make you think it's nice?

J: Just too many cool books.

R: Because of the story?

J: Because of the woodcutter.

R: And?

J: The trick.

R: Do you like it?

J: That's funny. (P14; 106: 120)

J: It's kind of Native American only that the pictures are Korean. (P14; 153)

As mentioned earlier, Jae-min was clearly able to evaluate the stories based on characters, pictures, events, and moral issues. For example, he agreed with Tiger's Bong-Yang to Mother and identified strongly with traditional Korean societal virtue. In his terms, "their eyes get bad—" (P14); he identified that it is very natural to take care of Old Mother. He also noted that issues of beauty can impact badly on family relationships, after reading *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes*.

R: Is it right or is this—it should be doing that?

J: It's not right.

R: It's not right?

J: Who matters if they're prettier. (P2; 31: 37)

After reading the Chinese Cinderella story, he was not happy with the stepsisters' jealousy of Mei Ping and how it caused them to treat her poorly. Jae-min and Kyle tried to understand the contents of the stories based on their sociocultural perspectives in evaluation. They judged facts that happened in the stories as agreeing or disagreeing based on their sociocultural perspectives on evaluation such as moral issues and sociocultural virtues.

### *Gender Issues in Evaluation*

Kyle's verbal reports strongly demonstrated gender issues. He did not enjoy the reading and did not comprehend well if the story is, in his terms, a "girly" story.

K: Yeah it's a good book for only girls.

R: Do you like it?

K: I don't like it. It's gross. Girly kind of story. (P1; 14: 20)

If he evaluated the story as “girly,” he was unsuccessful in comprehending and engaging with the story because he disliked it. He hardly associated with *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes*, showing his negative connotation of “girly.” His lack of interest and his disengagement resulted in limited synthesizing in his verbal reports of this story. Jae-min also manifested gender issues in relation to such terms as *hugging* and *marriage* in the story. These gender issues were mainly observed in Jae-min's and Kyle's verbal reports. Interestingly, they are from East Asia—Korea and Japan, two countries still permeated with gender differences in societies strongly influenced by Confucianism. This suggests that their sociocultural values are influenced by their home culture.

#### *Pictures and Content of the Story in Evaluation*

Jae-min and Kyle showed a preference for illustration in their evaluations. These are separate quotes from each participant during the verbal protocols.

R: So why do you think they draw like that? They can draw a nice pretty boat. Why do you think they drew a scary boat?

J: I don't know about that but I'll soon find out. But I don't really know why they made this scary boat, but it's pretty much detail. (P9; 51: 53)

J: Because the colors were nice but the book was short. (P2; 355)

K: No they're kind of blurry.

R: Oh you don't like blurry pictures?

K: They make my eyes weird. (P1; 172: 175)

Jae-min and Kyle liked the detailed pictures in *Follow the Dream*. Kyle did not like the picture in *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes*, because the pictures were “blurry.”



Kyle distinguished the content of the stories as it related to lessons for him. For example, he enjoyed *Passage to Freedom* and *Hiroko Makes the Team*. He noted clearly in his evaluation that this was based on his understanding of the main ideas of the story.

K: I think the best part was he never gave up. He kept on calling the manager of it and he asked two times, but the answer was no. So he meant to help people. Because he tried to help the people. (P16; 101: 107)

K: I wanted to change that part. I think I should have wrote in, I learned—I learned that it's fun to swim.

R: Oh okay. That's great.

K: Practice.

R: Practice, okay.

K: That's the only thing I learned. (P4; 176: 184)

Kyle showed his advocacy with “help other people” in *Passage to Freedom*. He also noticed that winning a race comes through practice. Kyle as a reader evaluated characters, events, gender issues, pictures, and content of the stories, expressing his critical points of views.

Lilly evaluated *Hiroko Makes the Team* and Yanton evaluated *Wilfrid Gordon McDonald Partridge* based on their background knowledge. She evaluated the story as, “Oh okay so don't make fun of anybody and the other one was don't tease nobody and the second one like, never to say things that you don't know if they can do it” (P5; 36: 42).

Yanton defined his memory as *floor ride* in an amusement park and evaluated it as happy, after reading *Wilfrid Gordon McDonald Partridge*. Yanton added a short evaluation of author's intention after reading *I Hate English*, “She [the author] has done a good book” (P6; 192). He evaluated the author of *I Hate English* in very positive way,

reflecting his engagement. However, they don't have a specific ethnic value system, which could influence their moral judgments or social values.

### *Exploration of Two Versions of the Christopher Columbus Story*

As mentioned earlier, the evaluation of the two versions of Christopher Columbus's story, *Follow the Dream* and *Encounter*, challenged both Jae-min and Kyle. Jae-min evaluated the illustrations, pictures, characters, and content of the story. He also evaluated the main character in *Encounter*, who is a boy, "He is pretty nice" (P9; 126). He made comments while reviewing the pictures and illustrations of *Follow the Dream*: "I don't know about that but I'll soon find out. But I don't really know why they made this scary boat, but it's pretty much detail" (P9; 51: 55). He mentioned that it had detailed pictures and historical information on Christopher Columbus's journey. Jae-min also wanted to recommend *Follow the Dream* for his peers, not only for the book's level, but also for its information.

- J: Because they might not know that it's Christopher so this might be okay. This might be also O or X and this one would be O cause this had landing information and this just had traveling information and it's just different. Like moving, so if you combine these two books together, like this, they would know that it's Christopher.
- R: Oh they will know who Christopher Columbus is exactly?
- J: Yeah if it's like this and they're like on the second chapter or something, they will read and read and then they will know that that was Christopher Columbus. (P9; 267: 285).

This verbal report from Jae-min indicated his understanding of Christopher Columbus, his complicated and informative evaluation of the two versions of Christopher Columbus.

- J: This one had good story of Christopher Columbus and the pictures are better. It also had information of finding new land for the map. (P9; 166)

J: Cause maybe Native Americans might want to go there. But if the map only had America, you would only stay here. Do you know Johnny apple seed? (P9; 302: 304)

He acknowledged Christopher Columbus's journey as a historical work for people in the world, emphasizing the information of world map as well as showing a different perspective for Native Americans. He thought Native Americans could use the information of map as well.

Kyle was also motivated to figure out the detailed pictures and why they drew the scary boat, showing his involvement in the story. Jae-min demonstrated his evaluation from simple comments to complicated and informative evaluation.

Kyle also examined the main character in *Follow the Dream* with "Like he was brave" (P8: 202) and "Yeah I think he did a good job" (P8; 211). Overall, Kyle developed positive perspectives on Christopher Columbus after reading the two stories. He identified and evaluated Christopher Columbus's personality as, "I think he was kind of smart boy" (P8; 213) and "Smart, he only had a compass and stars to help him" (P8; 375). He evaluated Christopher Columbus's behaviors and the intention of his journey with high respect. He evaluated the pictures and illustrations while reading the stories, expressing his positive attitude toward Christopher Columbus's work.

K: I learned that he discovered the-he like helped the world, because they all thought that the world was flat and they thought-they didn't know America. (P8; 385: 389)

Kyle evaluated Christopher Columbus's work positively, even though he was very critical of Christopher Columbus's arrival in America with "They shouldn't come to America without permission" (P8; 610). Kyle did not support Christopher Columbus's

landing in the United States, because he transacted deeply with the boy who is the main character of *Encounter*.

When I asked him the difference between the two versions of the Christopher Columbus story, he answered, “I don’t know. It’s kind of a hard question” (P8; 19). He recognized the challenge he faced and evaluated the questions. He answered the critical perspectives of Christopher Columbus with “Good information” (P8; 425).

K: It like shows me like when, where,

R: Kind of like the journey.

K: Yeah like what happened. Like September 16 [one of the dates in the picture].

R: So the exact information, huh? That’s why you like it.

K: Because of the information. I think so. (P8; 464: 476)

Overall, Kyle and Jae-min investigated two versions of Christopher Columbus stories by evaluating the values of stories. Jae-min concluded that the two versions of Christopher Columbus stemmed from the authors’ intentions after figuring out that the two stories were different perspectives on the same Christopher Columbus. Kyle concluded that Christopher Columbus was a historical person who discovered America. However, they did not forget to recommend both stories to their peers because *Follow the Dream* is very informative and historical and *Encounter* is a very nice story for young children.

### *Socioaffective Strategies in a Social Context*

These ELLs came to the classroom with different backgrounds and cultural knowledge as well as different levels of English proficiency. I observed two main themes in their socioaffective strategies. Social interaction strategies and affective domain strategies emerged naturally from verbal reports. The social interaction theme was

divided into three subcategories: *peers*, *teachers*, and *family influences*. The affective domain theme revealed two subcategories: *motivation and interest* and *emotion and feeling*.

For these ELLs, the classroom was a very important sociocultural and environmental boundary. Lilly explained the reason: She liked Ms. Lopez's class.

R: Tell me about your new classroom.

L: Mrs. Lopez's class? It's good. I like it.

R: Why do you like it? Tell me.

L: Because Mrs. Lopez makes hard stuff fun. (P10; 80: 88)

Lilly showed her comfort and feelings of safety in Ms. Lopez's class. Also, she noted that Ms. Lopez made hard subjects easy and fun to understand. When Lilly opened her mind and felt comfortable, she began interacting with peers and teachers in effective and affective ways.

#### *Peer Interaction*

During this study, I observed many interactions among these ELLs and their peers. The participants in this study were very attached to their friends and they showed this attachment openly, implying influences they might receive from friends. Kyle and Lilly both missed their friends from elsewhere and discussed these feelings in depth. Following is a nice description of Kyle's emotion and feelings toward his friends and home culture.

R: You don't know? Okay how about this one?

K: I draw Japan.

R: Why?

K: Yeah I miss Japan a lot.

R: Do you miss Japan?

K: I miss my friends.

R: You miss your friends and what else?

K: I miss my school. (P11; 1219: 1235)

K: In 1<sup>st</sup> grade it was a flat Stanley day and we send in the Flat Stanley,<sup>3</sup> the one's we made, to the place you want to give it to, so I gave it to my Japanese 1<sup>st</sup> grade school. And then I came back with an album of what they did with them. Like giving him a notebook. And they even send me a Japanese Flat Stanley book. (P8; 74: 84)

Kyle missed his hometown friends. Kyle shared his experience with his friends in Japan through the Flat Stanley Book project. It was a good idea for ELLs and other students in the classroom to communicate with peers in a different country. His positive experience was tangible. Yanton also shared a response after reading *I Hate English*.

R: What do you think of the author of *I Hate English*?

Y: I think she is from different country.

R: How do you know that?

Y: She understands me very well.

R: Could you explain to me?

Y: [Speaking to his mother in Swedish.]

YM: He thinks maybe she had gone through the same thing as he did, when she was little. (P6; 375: 391)

Lilly and Yanton identified strongly with Mei Mei while reading *I Hate English*, transacting with Mei Mei's missing her friends. Yanton and Lilly showed their feelings and emotion, reflecting Mei Mei's feelings and emotion. When I mentioned her feelings, Lilly said, "I felt same as Mei Mei. My best friend is in Mexico" (P10; 395). I also noted

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<sup>3</sup> "Flat Stanley" is about a young boy named Stanley written by Jeff Brown. He is flat because a bulletin board fell on him. He discovered advantages to being a flat. One of the many advantages is that Flat Stanley can now visit his friends by traveling in an envelope. Students make paper Flat Stanleys and begin a journal with him for a few days. Then Flat Stanley and the journal are sent to another school where students there treat Flat Stanley as a guest and complete the journal. Flat Stanley and journals are then returned back to the original sender.

her emotional movement from missing her friend toward her father and her first language. She said, “Because I miss my dad and I miss one of my friends, cause I have a bunch. And I speak Spanish” (P11; 498: 503). Her emotion flew to Mexico. Jae-min also explained his emotion and feelings for his friends as well. He also wanted to go to Korea to see his friends.

Their verbal reports showed that the ELLs were attached to their friends. It showed the important factors that influence ELLs’ second language literacy development. They indicated their comfort and safety while obtaining more support from peers than from the teacher or family.

R: What did you used to do?

J: I didn’t used to do it. I just ask my friend, what does this mean and stuff.

R: So do you ask your family?

J: No, my friend. (P15; 68: 73)

Asking friends was easier for them when trying to figure out problems. Interacting with peers supported them to improve their English proficiency as well as their cognitive knowledge, and social skills. Also, along with interacting with peers, Kyle was aware of Jae-min’s preference, and asked me about it. It was very interesting to see his awareness of his peer’s response after reading *Hiroko Makes the Team*.

R: Really? Wow so do you like it? Wow. That’s why you like it?

K: Did James say he liked it?

R: He liked it.

K: Why? (P4; 60: 68)

I observed social interaction in the classroom as key for developing second language literacy skills. As I mentioned earlier, the ELLs and their mothers in this study

acknowledged their language learning and developmental processes were strongly influenced by interaction with peers and teachers in the classroom. They explained that they improved their English proficiency, cognitive knowledge, and social skills by interacting with peers.

The ELLs mostly preferred to have support and care from peers rather than teachers because the channel of communication was more open. I observed that peers are extremely important for them. Usually, capable peers supported them in developing their scaffolding whenever the ELLs needed to learn new concepts in a meaningful context, as mentioned in Vygotsky's (1978) concept of the ZPD. They were ready to ask friends, if they faced new words or big concepts that they could not understand. I noticed that the ELLs interacted with peers, asking for assistance as well as cooperating in group projects. For example, Jae-min and Kyle interacted with other peers freely and naturally. Kyle wanted to joke around with his peers and his peers' responses encouraged him to do more. Kyle wanted to know Jae-min's response, if he had time to do other things. Notably, Kyle and Jae-min frequently interacted, although they sat separately.

Kyle hesitated to talk to Yuko unless the teacher asked him to. Interestingly, Yuko did not like to seek help from Kyle either, despite her need. Lilly interacted with other peers very often. During the last period of research, Lilly and Yuko became "best friends." For example, Lilly invited Yuko while she was engaged in the research protocol. Yanton showed almost no interactions with peers. I think the reason he hesitated to interact with others is because he came to this class as a pull out by himself. He spent a too short a time interacting with children here to be familiar with children in this classroom.



### *Social Interaction and Peer Tutoring*

Ms. Lopez expressed the importance of peer tutoring. The ELLs preferred to ask questions of friends rather than of teachers or family. This section incorporates the ELL's verbal protocols and the teachers' interviews because the topic issues are related to social interaction.

Anyway so if there's a student in the class that understands something really well, I might direct a student and I might say, "go have (name) explain that problem to you." And the reason I do that is because I think peer tutoring really helps. What it does it depends on the understanding of the student explaining it and he can do at their level where I might be missing something that they don't get. And so if I explain something more than twice to a student and they don't understand then I'll say, "Kelly understood how to do that problem, why don't you go work with her." And so then Kelly will explain it to them and then 9 ½ times out of 10, they'll come back and say, "now I get it." (L-10)

And it's good to do that with the kids. Not only the kids that are really smart but kids that—if I see for example that an average student understands something, I'll direct them to them too because then it deepens their understanding and it also is good for their self-esteem to say, "my teacher thinks that I'm smart too and I explain this." So I try to give everybody the opportunity to do that. Not just the same kids all the time. (L-11)

When Ms. Lopez taught the combined 3<sup>rd</sup> and 4<sup>th</sup> grade class, the 4<sup>th</sup> graders supported the 3<sup>rd</sup> graders through peer tutoring. Capable peers could support the ELLs or others who needed support in Vygotsky's (1978) concept of the ZPD. It is important to recognize the specific way she coordinated these peer tutoring sessions. Teachers need to coordinate peer tutoring for all children equally. Everyone needs to be a peer tutor for others for their own empowerment. Ms. Lopez also explained the benefits of pair work and small group work for ELLs.

They're very engaged in this classroom. They're very engaged with each other. We've talked a lot about the diversity in our classroom: the importance about us being a community of learners and how we're a family during the day so we have to honor each other and we have to work together. So in this classroom the

relationship between all of my students is positive. But when it's time to learn, they're all very focused on what they need to do in helping each other. (L-19)

Forman and Cazden (2004) asserted the importance of peer tutoring and collaboration, explaining the term with "peer relationships can function as intermediate transforming contexts between social and external adult-child interactions, and the individual child's inner speech" (p.183). The teacher's role would be important to design this collaboration as an art of meaning making. Teacher's role as a designer as well as facilitator in the collaboration context should support students by guiding and facilitating them and confirming their collaboration. For example, Lilly's support of Yuko was observed in the last research period.

#### *Interaction with the Teacher*

Through interaction with peers and the teacher, the ELLs were exposed to comprehensible input (Krashen, 1982). Ms. Lopez explained how she initiated interaction with the ELLs. She said, "Always at the beginning they're a little bit more shy, but as they start more secure in the classroom environment and they feel safe that it's okay to be who they are, they feel free to come up" (L-14). The safer and more comfortable environment was recommended; the safe and comfortable atmosphere was an important factor to get the ELLs to come to her. She also explained her strategy to interact with the beginner ELL.

No Lilly speaks fluent English enough, so if she doesn't understand something, she'll come over and ask me, if she's not sure and then I'll go over it when I'm one on one with them too. Especially with her and Yuko. The other kids are all fluent enough that they usually understand what I'm explaining. You know Jaemin, Kyle, Ken, Heira, Surtoma, Yanton, they usually do, Yuko and Lilly are usually the one's that say, "I don't understand." If they're not sure about something. And then I usually explain it to them another way. Go over it with

them and then like I said, if Yuko gets lost and then Kyle will come over and translate for me and she doesn't really like for him to do that. (L-8)

She explained about how Yuko, who was a beginner ELL, interacted with her. Ms. Lopez was willing to come to her, or she would come to Ms. Lopez if she needed any help. She approached them in various ways if they did not understand the concepts. Interestingly, Yuko did not want to have help from Kyle despite her needs either.

### *Family Influence*

Jae-min and Kyle expressed and showed their family values and influences, over time. The verbal reports indicated that their identity was built up based on a concrete family foundation. Their social value system corresponded to their family and sociocultural values. Their future career goal was based on their families' belief systems. Jae-min said, "Cause if you read more books you'll get more education. But if you want to visit some places, you can. My dad is the same like me, he reads a lot of books" (P9; 599: 625). He thought his dad followed him, but he was influenced by his dad. He also addressed the social value system that values education.

R: Do you think or who said that?

J: I think it's good education.

R: I see. Education is important.

J: yeah if there wasn't any school, they would be all dumb. (P11; 973: 981)

Ms. Green mentioned that Asian parents are very serious about education. Through my tacit knowledge as a Korean, I can attest to the fact that Asian culture puts education in the center of our lives. Jae-min was strongly influenced by his parents. Ms. Lopez's interview expanded her impressions to ELLs from many countries.

I think it is an influence from the family. I've noticed in particular that the families of students that come from the international countries really want to make sure that their kids are challenged, that they're doing their work, that they're behaving, that they're motivated and they really make a point of saying, "please let me know." They are very involved. (L-5)

Jae-min and Kyle also showed moral judgment and evaluation based on their sociocultural values and career goals, which revealed their family and cultural influences.

The verbal reports showed distinguishable differences from the others in the study.

L: Because it's kind of like, she's from another place and she comes to New York and I'm from another place and come here. (P16; 181: 183)

L: I know how she feels. (P16; 189)

L: How I used to live in Mexico, how I felt in Mexico, how I spoke in Mexico, everything. (P16; 344: 347)

Lilly was very motivated reading *I Hate English* and interacting Mei Mei's feelings and emotions. She also extended her interaction into her memory in Mexico.

Y: I feel good because she learned English. (P6; 146)

Y: I want ask to friend to read this book to my friends. So they can understand how I feel. (P6; 186: 188)

These verbal reports indicated how they were motivated to read and transacted with the stories. Materials which contained their cultural experiences evoked their deeper understanding of the story and empowered them. Cummins' (1996) framework for empowering minority students (1996) reverberates through their verbal reports.

Lilly closely adhered to her family and home culture throughout the study. Her understanding and meaning making from any texts were very related to her family events, culture, and first language. Lilly explained, "Because I could see almost all my family in

Mexico. Cause here I just have my cousins, my uncle and aunt. And there I have my dad, my sisters, my brother, my other brother; I have five people there” (P10; 15: 21).

Lilly’s emotion was agitated whenever she thought of her family in Mexico. She was involved in deep emotion. There was no indication that Yanton’s sociocultural values were influenced by family or culture. I observed his mother’s involvement in his education, but I had no description of his home culture’s influence through his verbal reports.

### *Motivation and Preference*

The ELL’s motivation and personal preferences were one of their key socioaffective strategies while making meaning (Guthrie, J. T., Wigfield, & Perencevich, 2004). Ryan and Deci (2000) said that intrinsically motivated readers readily find and pursue books in their free time. They certainly showed their motivation and interest. Intrinsically motivated students are curious, desiring to gain understanding of a topic or special authors’ intention (Deci, 1992). For example, Jae-min was very interested in his favorite topic, dragon stories, Kyle was interested in adventure stories, and Yanton was interested in bugs. Lilly liked animals including pets and mice. She loved her dog. She also remembered her mouse which she had before my visit by showing a book about a mouse. She also liked drawing pictures and poems.

Their verbal reports also showed their engagement while reading on their favorite topics and story elements. For example, while Jae-min read *Woodcutter and Tiger Brother*, he connected the story to Eragon story [a dragon’s name in another book]. He made connections between them, finding communality in the concept of trick, “This story [*Woodcutter and Tiger Brother*] is about cannot be an Eragon, but Eragon gets free

because he smells something good but he thinks it's a trick. 'Is it a trick or is it not'" (P2; 405: 141). His mother added, "He liked books about dinosaurs and science fiction. I realized that he is just interested in reading these kinds of genres, so sometimes we try to select different types of genres" (JM-3).

J: Sure. I need to check my dragon list, cause they gave me a list of dragon lists. Because there's a bunch of words right there and then the last copy. And it came a lot so I don't know if it's there, cause I was the first one to get one, cause the other children didn't get any.

R: So what is that book, Eragon?

J: Yeah. (P1; 485: 495)

J: Cause they're cool. I just like them for strange reasons. Cause I see dragons in games and other stuff. Like this game that's called spiral, there's lots of them. (P1; 324: 328)

I also observed other factors that influenced their engagement in reading such as culture and cultural experiences, topics of stories, elements of the stories, gender issues, and their personality. The ELLs were also engaged in reading stories about their culture and other culturally relevant stories. Lilly identified strongly with *Family Pictures*. She excitedly described her birthday party and a fair she went to with her father. Her enthusiasm was tangible while reading the book and retelling the story.

R: Do you like this story?

L: Because I like the fair. (P13; 13: 17)

Like Lilly, Yanton revealed his motivation and interest while reading *I Hate English*; the story contained cultural experiences similar to those they had had in the United States. Lilly also showed her engagement in reading the double-language format of the story. Her interest and motivation stimulated her to plan to write a story with a

similar format. Lilly said, “Yeah two stories, one in English and one in Spanish. And it would have pictures inside” (P13; 216).

Lilly and Yanton demonstrated their confidence while reading their stories that peaked their interest in other preferred materials such as culturally relevant stories. They showed their motivation while reading familiar materials or concepts. Concurrently, using Cummins’ (1992) theoretical framework for empowering minority students, I observed their self-esteem and confidence rose along with their motivation as seen in their verbal reports. Their cultural knowledge and areas of interest empowered them as learners.

The ELLs showed their positive attitude and preferences related to their own cultural materials and styles.

J: Because it’s kind of Native American kind, only it’s Korean.

R: What do you mean?

J: It’s kind of like those people, only it’s in Korean drawing. (P14; 244: 250)

K: I just kind of like it. Like the sentences tell me about the ship and stuff. I like chief. (P8; 164: 166)

Most of their favorite parts of the stories were related to their own experiences and preferences. Kyle showed his deep engagement in historical events. He said, “ I want to know about the past and stuff” (P16; 11).

Jae-min, Kyle, and Lilly liked reading *Hiroko Makes the Team* for its swimming theme. They were thinking of swimming while reading the story. The ELLs’ attitude and personal preference were closely related to engagement in reading stories.

K: She won the race.

R: What is your favorite part of this book?

K: When Hiroko gets to be in the team. That's my favorite.

R: Why?

K: Because it's like a good part. (P4; 101: 109)

They also were excited when Hiroko made the team and won a race, openly showing their emotion, "I was so excited when she won the race" (P4; 101). Jae-min and Kyle were very sensitive to winning and competition. These responses reflected the cultural and social values in their home countries. Jae-min remembered his championship soccer. Kyle addressed the importance of the spelling test and good scores in other subjects while reading this story. Their attitudes and preferences influenced their reading and retelling of the stories.

Yanton showed his preference for the main character in *Pettson and Findus*.

R: Okay thank you so much. How do you like?

Y: Findus.

R: Why?

Y: He's little and smart and funny and comes up with crazy ideas. That's all. (P12; 15: 21)

R: Oh I see so you like him, because it's a story from another book. So you can only remember the whole thing about Findus.

YM: Yeah he came up with crazy ideas in every book. It's always Findus who solves the problem. (P12; 35: 43)

Yanton showed his preference clearly, even though he was a beginner reader. He explained that he liked Findus because of his personality and creativity. His intertextuality supported him in understanding the story in English, and he reviewed the detailed pictures carefully and deeply.



### *Emotion and Feeling*

The verbal reports indicated that Kyle's empathy was strong while reading the story *Encounter*. He identified strongly with the nine-year-old boy, a main character in the story. He became a boy while reading the story and was surprised when the boy jumped into the water. He said, "I was really surprised when he jumped in the ocean" (P8; 672). When I asked him the reason, he said he was scared because the boy had jumped into the water. I sensed that he identified closely with the boy's action. He worried about the boy's safety. This empathy showed his strong feeling for the story and how he transacted with the boy. Lilly showed her deep emotion and feeling after reading *I Hate English*.

- L: No. Mei Mei doesn't speak English because she wants to speak Chinese. But everybody is bugging her to speak English. And she wishes she was in Hong-Kong.
- R: So why doesn't Mei Mei want to speak English?
- L: Because it's not her main language. Because she's not used to speak it or maybe she doesn't know how to speak English. (P10; 366: 378)

Lilly agreed with Mei Mei's unwillingness to speak English, and furthermore, she showed defensive emotion for her. After finishing reading the book, she said "I feel sad" (P10; 169), because she understood Mei Mei's struggling in speaking English and missing her friends. She identified herself with Mei Mei, and she felt the way Mei Mei felt in the story. She became Mei Mei just like Kyle became the boy, and their emotions followed the events in the stories.

The ELLs' emotion moved with their reading based on their transacting with the stories. They interconnected with the stories and reflected them in themselves. They became the main characters by dialoguing with them. Their aesthetic stance occurred, in

which they read stories as lived-through experiences. Lilly's emotion and feeling actively moved along with the storyline; she characterized herself in the story. They could be happy, sad, or scared depending on the characters' behaviors or what was happening in the story.

R: So how do you feel after reading this story?

L: Happy.

R: Happy? Why?

L: Because I remember Mexico. (P10; 512: 517)

Lilly was happy, because she remembered the fair and the birthday party she had had in Mexico after reading the story. In the same manner, Yanton reflected his situation onto Mei Mei's while reading *I Hate English*.

R: How do you feel after reading this book?

Y: Good.

R: Why good? Why do you feel good?

Y: I feel good because she learned English. (P6; 140: 146)

He felt very good when Mei Mei started speaking English. Yanton developed community<sup>4</sup> with Mei Mei while reading *I Hate English*. Yanton and Lilly's transaction came up naturally.

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<sup>4</sup> According to McCaleb (1995), community is

the children, the families of the children, people who work in the area and interact in the area and interact in multiple ways with the families; people who create art and make music, and keep the neighborhoods vibrating, the people who live and care and touch the lives of those around them ... Communities are dynamic, which means that they are always changing as they continue to survive. Students can go out into their community and through observation, dialogue, and writing come to understand it better. How does it function, what are its strengths, and in what ways it is crying out for new ideas, new energy, and change? (p. 42)

He tried to define the community in both directions. Community in this study means the place in which learning and meaning construction take place. Learning as a dynamic process occurs through meaningful interaction

Notably, I observed these socioaffective factors while the ELLs were mastering English as a second language or developing their second language literacy skills. I observed social interactions with peers and teachers as very significant moments for them in obtaining comprehensible input. Peers and teachers interacted with them within the ZPD. This interaction supported the ELLs in developing their scaffolding to learn English as a second language while engaging in meaningful tasks.

Overall, the results from verbal reports showed what strategies they used and how ELLs used them while making meaning in literacy events. To extend better understanding of second language literacy as a learning process, a deeper analysis of various data from multiple sources was essential: What factors were included during the ELLs' meaning construction and how did the ELLs learn their second language literacy between and beyond meaning making and literacy in a social context.

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and mutual understanding. Students feel safer and more comfortable within their community. This deeper meaning of community matches with McCaleb's thought, "This ongoing interaction leads to the construction of new meanings, and ultimately to the creation of new kinds of knowledge and understanding" (p. 42).

## CHAPTER 6

### RESULTS FROM THE QUALITATIVE RESEARCH

As was seen in the review of the ELLs' verbal reports, the second language learners used various strategies to develop their second language literacy. They also transferred some of their first language literacy skills to their second language literacy. Cultural orientation, English proficiency, and age of second language learning were examined in chapter 3. The results in this chapter are derived from (a) verbal reports; (b) interviews with the ELLs, their parents, and the teachers, (c) and the participants' documents, and my filed notes from the observations. The results of this chapter are two-fold: The ELL and identity and the ELLs' dialogue in reading.

#### The English Language Learner and Identity

The results of this study indicated that ELLs' second language literacy skills influenced their identity and vice versa. While the ELLs were making meaning in the literacy activities, I observed a strong relationship between English language learning and identity, as defined in chapter 1.

Gee (1996) showed how learners shift their identity positions and discourses to express particular social roles and discursive practices. Learning a second language entails a person's social practice, memberships, and identity. I observed the ELLs' unique identities and watched them shift in this study. *Nationality as an identity, gender awareness, and language and identity* evolved during the formation of their identity and are described in this section. Language and identity included four subthemes: *language*

*choice, Yanton's language shock, first language preference, and awareness of language loss.*

### *Nationality as an Identity*

The strength of Jae-min's nationality identification surprised me: He identified himself as a Korean—even though he was born in the United States and his legal citizenship was American—with “But mostly I'm Korean” (P2; 409: 411). When I asked him again about his nationality, he justified himself as Korean by nature,

I am Korean. This one is nature. It's like the Korean animal and the Korean bird, but I don't know what the plant is. This is an eagle and this is a tiger. You asked me and I told you it was a tiger. So throat of the tiger here. What is this one? (P2; 408: 412)

He identified himself as Korean as a natural phenomenon. He compared his nature of being Korean to that of Korean animals to support his identification. He believed that there should not be any questions on this matter. In the interviews, Jae-min's mother explained that she wanted him grow up Korean with Korean cultural and social value systems. As part of this, she taught him Korean as a first language as he was growing up in the United States. She said,

I think the reasons he likes Korea are that we had some opportunities to contact Korean families and Korean cultures by visiting Korea, and we emphasized that he is a Korean. I don't know exactly. We stressed to him that you are Korean. (JM-7)

Jae-min's national identity was based on his family's influence.

Furthermore, Jae-min's mother added the interesting idea of 100% Korean and 100% American, as mentioned in chapter 4. She said, “he is a Korean forever, wherever he lives. His skin color is different. I want him to be 100% Korean at the same time 100%

American. I want him to be a person that fits to both cultures” (JM-7). However, her discipline focused on Korean culture and social values.

This was very similar in Kyle’s family. Kyle’s mother said, “I wanted Kyle to grow up as a world person” (KM-9). Kyle’s mother thought that she had raised Kyle with American cultural and social values systems. However, when I asked to her specific questions about the differences between Japanese and American culture and social values, she showed her limited understanding of these differences. She thought that she raised Kyle in an American way, but his upbringing was very focused on traditional Confucian Asian cultural and social values. For example, she did not allow him to touch his parents’ face under any circumstances. Touching a parent’s face is considered disrespectful in Asian cultures influenced by Confucianism.

Interestingly, Kyle identified himself as Japanese, just as Jae-min identified with his national heritage. While Jae-min’s mother knew that she was raising him to be Korean, Kyle’s mother thought she was raising him to be a world citizen but was actually using strong Japanese influences. Both mothers had a gap between their beliefs and reality. Kyle presented the reason of his nationality identification with a simple logic, “Born in Japan and I am a Japanese” (P1; 313). However, he identified as Japanese-American after he built up his competence and confidence in English proficiency. He insightfully understood the relationship between identity formation and language proficiency.

Jae-min and Kyle also insightfully applied their origin, culture, and country to understand their identity. From the study, I realized that their identity was enforced by parents and home culture. They missed their own culture and country.

### *Gender and identity*

Jae-min and Kyle revealed their awareness of gender issues in the study. Kyle showed very strong opinions on gender issues while reading. When he read *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes*, he defined the story is for a girl, not for a boy, as already discussed. Furthermore, he evaluated some questions I asked as girly questions.

K: It's gross. Girly kind of story. (P1; 5)

K: Yeah it's a good book for only girls. (P1; 347)

R: So which one, do you like the silver shoes or the glass shoe?

K: That's a girly question. (P1; 229: 231)

I sensed negative connotations in Kyle's comments on *girly*. Kyle showed his strong opinion on gender issues while reading stories. For example, he did not identify with *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes*. He failed to summarize or synthesize it because of his lack of motivation and interest. He evaluated *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes* and *Hiroko Makes the Team* as good for girls.

K: I don't like the end. They get married. Gross. (P1; 27)

R: Why?

K: Cause I don't like marry.

R: You don't like marry? When did you start thinking about it?

K: After I heard that word, yuk! (P1; 503: 511)

The verbal reports showed the significance of gender issues for Kyle. Apparently, gender issues influenced both Kyle and Jae-min while making meaning and evaluating the stories. However, after reading *Hiroko Makes the Team*, Kyle did evaluate the story in a positive way, because the story is not girly story in that sense. The story was about

swimming, a swimming racer, or winning a race, although the main character was a girl, he did not call it a girly story, despite the fact that gender issues were one of his main filter systems when he evaluated the story.

K: I think I might like to be a swimmer or like a swimming racer.

R: Really you want to be a race swimmer? That's great. That's wonderful.

K: I think this wasn't a girly story. (P4; 78: 82)

K: I don't like when they hugged.

R: Why?

K: Gross.

R: Why gross? You don't hug your mom?

K: Girly stuff. (P4; 113: 121)

R: Who said? Who told you?

K: Every boy does it. Every boy hates kissing and hugging.

R: Really. I didn't know that. I thought that every boy likes hugging.

K: Uhhhh! (P4; 127: 132)

The verbal reports indicated Kyle's negative opinion on gender issues.

Interestingly, he often used girly stuff to evaluate or denigrate facts or stories. Jae-min expressed gender issues similar to those Kyle expressed.

R: Okay are there parts you don't like?

J: Yeah.

R: You said when Hiroko hugs his brother. Why?

J: Because I don't like hugging.

R: Why don't you like hugging?

J: I just don't like it. (P3; 343: 353)



Jae-min and Kyle used their gender awareness to evaluate stories while reading. Jae-min was more cautious on body interaction such as *hugging* or *kissing* based on gender differences.

R: Okay so this book is about *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes*. Do you like this book?

J: No.

R: Why?

J: There's lot's of words I don't like.

R: Which words don't you like?

J: M—A—R—R—Y. I just feel this way. I don't like that word. (P2; 425: 435)

Jae-min expressed his dislike of reading about certain types of body interaction such as *kissing*, *hugging*, or *marry*. Noticeably, the 2<sup>nd</sup> graders who had East Asian cultural and social values made strong comments on gender issues, demonstrating their cultural influence.

These responses are apparently distinct from children's developmental stages. First, there is a big difference in the age group. Most studies about the acquisition of gender constancy were done with very young children. For example, Thompson (1975) conducted a study of the developmental gender identification of age groups from 24 months to 36 months. Kohlberg (1966) noted that children's understanding of gender progresses through a sequence of stages in very young children. Slaby and Frey (1975) studied gender constancy using children aged 3 to 6. Surprisingly, research indicated that children began developing their aspects of gender identity and gender constancy at a very young age.

Secondly, reviewing Jae-min's and Kyle's responses carefully, one notices their negative conceptions of gender issues. They obviously also degraded "opposite sex: girl" in their responses. Furthermore, they rejected reading and discussing several terms in the

story. This evidence indicates that Jae-min and Kyle's responses are far from the gender awareness of developmental stages.

Kyle's and Jae-min's gender opinions were related to very traditional East Asian's sociocultural values based on Confucian ideas, which strongly differentiate gender roles. Usually, Asian cultures influenced by Confucianism discriminate based on gender. For example, people in Korea have a proverb, *Nahm-Nyu-Chil-Sae-Bu-Dong-Seock* : 남녀칠세부동석(男女七歲不動席) (*man and woman should not sit together after the age of seven*). The society also differentiated the roles of man and woman clearly with *Nahm-Yeo-Yu-Beol*: 남녀유별 (男女有別) (*Women and men's roles are very different*).

More recently, people in that society do not discriminate between males and females in that way, but the gender differentiation still exists. Also, Asian cultures influenced by Confucianism discourage the expression and discussion of body interactions such as kissing and hugging. Jae-min's and Kyle's responses stem from the influence of their home culture.

### *Language and Identity*

#### *Language Choice*

This study revealed the influence of language and identity on language proficiency issues, awareness of language loss, first language preference, and the connection between first language and second language. As I already mentioned, Jae-min and Kyle based their identity on their English proficiency and their first language skills. They also recognized the significance of language proficiency in establishing their

identity compared to their nationality. In fact, Kyle changed his nationality identification from Japanese to Japanese American as his English proficiency increased, as already discussed.

Reading a Korean folk tale in Korean was more sensible to Jae-min. For example, after reading *Woodcutter and Brother*, he said, “It [written in Korean] makes sense to me more than this one [written in English], doesn’t make so much sense” (P2; 169). He was also motivated to learn Korean. His mode in understanding reading was open to Korean. He pointed out special nuances of the two languages.

R: What do you like? Do you like to read this book in Korean or in English?

J: I like to read it in Korean.

R: Why?

J: Because it makes me learn more Korean words. (P14; 204; 210)

This clip shows that Jae-min was motivated to practice Korean. Lilly also strongly preferred reading stories in Spanish.

L: No quiero.

R: No quiero. What does that mean?

L: I don’t want to.

R: You don’t want to read?

L: I want to speak Spanish. (P10; 242; 252)

R: Is it more comfortable for you to speak Spanish or speak in English?

L: Spanish still.

R: Still? Oh okay. How about writing?

L: Spanish. It’s easier because you just have to sound the letters and it’s right.

I don’t know. Maybe it’s because it’s my first language. (P10; 28; 38)

Lilly's answer of "No quiero," which came out incautiously, was a powerful clue to her identity. She presented her identity by using her Spanish incautiously. She added, "I want to speak Spanish" (P10; 252), expressing her identity with her language proficiency.

### *Yanton's Language Shock*

Yanton's mother said that Yanton was terrified at the beginning of his schooling in the United States because of his *language shock* (Agar, 1996). She said that he was fine with the new culture because he liked to learn new things all the time.

YM: I think so because both Julia and Yanton, they're the kind of person, they like to do new things all the time. They try all kinds of sports. They want to go and see new things and they're very opened to new things and have lot's of friends from different countries. Lot's of different kinds of friends and I think it's just the language and that he couldn't do what—he knew that he couldn't do better because of the language. (YM-6)

However, the new language challenged him. He was terrified at times when he came to the United States. Her explanation insightfully showed Yanton's language shock.

YM: Yeah it was two different times. He just acted like crazy. He was just terrified and crying and screaming, but Mrs. Henry, his teacher, didn't let him go because she thought if she had let him go, it was harder to take him back. So she forced him to stay and tried to calm him down. And after awhile I came there and we spoke to each other. But it happened two times I guess and after that. (YM-7)

YM: Yeah he knew what to say but didn't know how to say it in English. So I think the language was the most important. (YM-8)

She explained that his behavior when he started his schooling was caused by his language shock. She said that he was terrified of others in the classroom because he could not communicate with the other students. He felt completely isolated in the classroom and that scared him. He felt that he could not do better than other students because of his limited English proficiency.

### *First Language Preference*

Jae-min, Kyle, Lilly, and Yanton preferred reading in their first languages, but they had different reasons for this preference. English was easier for Jae-min and Kyle, but Jae-min wanted to read stories in Korean because he was eager to practice Korean. Kyle wanted to read stories in Japanese because he had concluded it was his main language. Lilly wanted to keep her first language proficiency to communicate with her father.

J: The Korean version is better. (P2; 162)

K: It's my main language.

R: And are you comfortable using Japanese language?

K: Yeah. (P11; 1253)

L: I want to speak Spanish. (P10; 252)

Kyle showed his cautious attitude with his first language. He preferred reading in Japanese because of his awareness of his need to keep his first language, despite his challenge while reading in Japanese. He said that English is easier for him, because Japanese uses the Kanji characters. Jae-min and Kyle demonstrated their willingness to practice their first language, pointing to the importance of keeping their first language and their cognitive and metacognitive knowledge. Lilly was also aware of her Spanish loss. She preferred reading in Spanish not only because it felt easier and more comfortable, but also because she wanted to practice Spanish to keep her language proficiency.

R: Which is better speaking English or Spanish, if you can choose one language?

L: Spanish.

R: Spanish, why?

L: I'm good at Spanish.

R: Oh you're good in Spanish? Oh okay, so you'd rather speak Spanish than English?

L: Uh huh. (P11; 177: 187)

R: So which one is easier for you now, Spanish, or English?

L: English, cause I read too much English. (P13; 80: 82)

In her last interview, she expressed her awareness of her first language loss cautiously. At the beginning of the study, she had felt more comfortable reading in Spanish, but by the end she felt more comfortable reading English than reading Spanish. Her confidence and competence had transferred from Spanish to English.

The ELLs had different reasons for practicing their first language, but they were all motivated to practice their first language. For Jae-min, reading stories in Korean was more sensible. Reading Korean folk tales in Korean was especially critical. For Kyle, Japanese was more difficult, but he wanted to practice the language. Lilly wanted to practice Spanish to communicate with her father and friends in Mexico.

#### *Awareness of Language Loss*

The ELLs in this study understood the deeper relationship between language proficiency and identity. They were very much concerned with their first language loss. The results of the study showed an awareness of their language preference. For example, Jae-min strongly showed his awareness of first language loss.

R: One chapter, and one chapter?

J: Cause if you don't read it in Korean, you can forget about it.

R: If you don't read the Korean version, you're going to forget it? Why?

J: Cause sometime when you come back from Korea, you learn some Korean words, and then later on, you really don't know. (P9; 743: 753)

Jae-min addressed the practical reasons for practicing his first language skills. Pointing to the importance of practice, Jae-min read Korean books to practice Korean.

Lilly showed her awareness of English proficiency and her first language loss simultaneously. She identified herself as a good reader in Spanish and not in English. For example,

R: That happens? How do you know?

L: Because it's happening and I keep forgetting.

R: You keep forgetting?

L: Yeah like how to say "roller coaster."

R: Like "roller coaster?"

L: Yeah in Spanish.

R: In Spanish, you don't remember that word?

L: I don't know. I still want to speak Spanish. (P11; 153: 171)

R: You read this story in Spanish first, right?

L: Yeah.

R: And then you read it in English? Why did you choose to read it first in Spanish?

L: Because I want to practice my Spanish. I don't read that much Spanish anymore. Now all my books are in English, not in Spanish.

R: Do you want to practice Spanish?

L: Yeah.

R: Why?

L: So when I go to Mexico I can read good, not like just like read all the words wrong. I talk to my daddy. (P13; 61: 78)

Lilly preferred to read in Spanish rather than in English. She felt proud of herself in her Spanish, indicating her consciousness of losing Spanish. She also recognized the importance of language practice to keep her first language. Jae-min and Lilly were both concerned with the loss of their first language. The ELLs knew how to evaluate language

proficiency. Understanding the reason they were losing their first language, they wanted to maintain their first language proficiency by practicing it.

### *Connection Between First Language and Second Language*

Yanton's responses were very different. When I did the last interview with him, he mentioned that he liked to read in both languages (Swedish and English). He explained that his first language literacy skills had transferred to his second language literacy learning.

R: Could you explain to me?

Y: So maybe understanding or like for example, you know how to sit and then to read or you know how book start, and then the main event and then the ending. It is same kind of books which I read in Swedish and English? Style or... (P7; 111: 119)

Yanton also said that he translated English into Swedish for a couple of months, but later he understood in English without translation. His cognitive understanding of the transfer between the two languages was quite memorable. He specifically explained how L1 (first language) literacy skills transferred to L2 (second language) literacy skills. For example, he understood comprehension of the story and the genre of the story. Also, his verbal reports showed his ability to understand despite the limits of his English proficiency. The verbal reports throughout the study also indicated that his first language literacy skills supported him in developing his second language literacy skills faster.

The ELLs in this study demonstrated their second language literacy skills as they learned their own first language skills simultaneously. They also learned second language literacy much faster because they had the background knowledge from their first language. Yanton said that his first language literacy skills supported him in understanding the second language including the content of the story and rhetoric



knowledge. These findings are similar to Connor and Kaplan's (1987) findings of the considerable influence of L1 on L2 rhetorical thought patterns. The connection between first language and second language in this study supported Ovando and Collier's (1998) conclusions about the interdependence of first and second languages. Studies have shown that cognitive and academic development in L1 has a strong and positive effect on L2 development (Cummins, 1991; Freeman & Freeman, 1994; Ovando & Collier, 1998). The results of this study confirmed how first language literacy offers a critical base for acquiring second language literacy.

### *Summary*

The verbal reports indicated that Jae-min understood and used his two languages separately. This was an example of bilingualism in Korean and English. He did not need to translate either of the languages at all. Jae-min said, "I don't have to mix it. I understand Korean and English separately. I understand Korean if I read in Korean, and I understand English if I read in English. This book is easier" (P9; 684: 686).

Jae-min also specifically pointed out different nuances in the two languages while reading *Woodcutter and Tiger Brother*, "They are the same only in different languages. The sense of meaning is a little bit different" (P14; 192). Jae-min and Kyle also were aware of maintaining their first language. They were willing to practice to improve their first language literacy skills. Their motivation to keep their first language was related to keeping their identity.

Notably, Lilly was closely attached to both the Mexican culture and the Spanish language, but she did not identify herself as a Mexican. However, as I already mentioned, she was very aware of her Spanish loss, although she didn't lose Spanish. She wanted to

keep her first language to communicate with her father and her friends. Yanton and his mother were more aware of his English development than others in this study.

Many researchers have studied the relationship between first language proficiency and second language development. For example, Carson, Carrell, Silberstein, Kroll, and Kuehn (1990) studied Japanese and Chinese ESL students. They found that ESL reading positively correlated with native-language reading.

#### English Language Learners' Dialogue in Second Language Literacy

The ELLs strongly identified themselves in various ways depending on their English proficiency, age, and cultural orientation. Throughout the study, I observed the ELLs identity and its flexibility. The verbal reports showed the ELLs' ongoing dialogue in meaning construction. K. Goodman (1984) defined the reader as follows: "Since comprehension results from reader-text transactions, what the reader knows, who the reader is, what values guide the reader, what purposes or interests the reader has will play vital roles in the reading process" (p. 111). K. Goodman (1984) emphasized the importance of the reader's background and culture in acquiring second language literacy skills and comprehending stories in literacy events. While the ELLs were dialoguing in second language literacy, three main themes emerged: *The ELLs' dialogue in reading*, *reading as a learning process*, and *comprehension styles of the ELLs*. Reading as a learning process included three subthemes: *reading first*, *reading style*, and *reading as a learning process*.

### *The English Language Learners' Dialogue in Reading*

The ELLs in this study expressed their definitions of reading and a good reader, showing a picture of their attitude toward the meaning of reading and literacy activities. Their verbal reports showed their thinking process while making meaning.

#### *Jae-min: Reading as Brainpower*

Jae-min's responses to reading dramatically showed his attitude on reading and his personality as a learner. Jae-min defined reading as "brainpower." The metaphor was of reading as power as he used the word. His concept of reading addressed productivity and contained ideological perspectives. He had a very positive attitude and productive concepts of reading, and extended them to his future life and growth.

- J: Brainpower. Feeding your brain more education. Education for more brain and you don't always have to read books. You can read a few stuff and do something else for a while and then go back to books if you want to and then if you get tired of books again, you can do something else and then do something else again and then go back to reading books again. You don't always have to read books to get education to your brain. You don't always have to do that. Well you could do anything that you like. (P9; 582: 596)

He understood reading as human growth, and believed in his growth in the future. He explained the benefits of reading and the reason why the reading was good for him and others. He also explained the process of feeding one's brain by reading books. He added, "Well could do anything that you like." He also implied that the meaning of education extended to other activities.

- J: Cause when you're a baby, you start off with no brain and then it grows a little and then grows and grows and grows and gets bigger and bigger and when you read more books, your brain gets more information, so it gets a little bigger. But it doesn't explode your head or something. It's like you start off with no brain and the biggest it can grow is this. Not compared to my head but when you grow old, your head gets bigger. So your brain get fit about this big and it gives you a lot of learning. So your head can get bigger and you get information inside your brain,

so you can feed it, so it can grow like us. if you feed your brain, you grow up with it. (P9; 601: 619)

He also used a feeding metaphor to explain reading. His attitude and perceptions gave him a strict ideology of reading. His brainpower and feeding metaphors were well developed and showed his fundamental beliefs in the power of reading and literacy.

He thought that a good reader would not make mistakes when reading. “A real good person at reading. You don’t make mistakes when you’re reading. And read lots of books” (P15; 223: 225). He added, “Read lots of books. Practice reading a lot” (P15; 229). To become a good reader, one needs to practice to reduce mistakes, reading many books.

His insights on reading and education extended to other activities for increasing brainpower. His term, *brainpower*, showed his very positive attitude toward reading and education. He understood that reading and education were very productive activities.

Jae-min’s responses showed his expectation of reading as well as his concern about how to be a good reader. They also implied positive attitudes and beliefs about reading. The ELLs used various examples to explain their own ideas of reading evaluation.

J: I don’t really know about that. but if you want to be a good reader, I think you should read about like 10 books a day. That’s enough for one day but as soon as you get older like one year older, you should read 11 books and then 20 if you’re like 20. (P9; 615: 623)

He showed the importance of quantity of reading as well and recommended that people need to read books daily based on chronological age. This concept related to feeding the brain to get brainpower.

He held a functional view of reading as well. He believed that as people get older, they needed to read more because their brain is getting bigger. This implied that as a

person grows up, he or she might need to have more knowledge or information to feed his or her brain. He developed nice correlations between reading and brainpower to describe the concept of reading.

*Kyle and Lilly: Reading as a Knowledge Process*

Kyle illustrated the importance of reading positively with “So they could get smart or something” (P8; 21). His verbal reports showed that his positive attitude toward reading was similar to Jae min’s. When I asked him about the reason for reading, he said, “To learn stories. So you don’t have trouble when you grow up, reading” (P 8; 23).

Kyle and Lilly viewed reading as a knowledge-gaining process. They believed that they need to read to be smarter and to gain more information and knowledge. Kyle made linkages between reading and practice to his future as a professional.

K: I think that good readers are like people who grow up to be illustrators and writer stuff.

R: How could you be a better reader?

K: Read lots of books and stuff. (P16; 180: 186)

Lilly defined reading as a way “to learn important stuff” (P10; 228) and she illustrated that “people read to learn and learn more stories” (P10; 228). She did not have concrete ideas of reading, but she understood the reading process as a learning process.

The ELLs addressed the importance of practice, reading many stories.

R: Tell me what is reading?

L: I don’t know, maybe like expressing, like to learn more stories.

R: Why do people read?

L: Maybe because they want to learn a story. (P13; 267: 277)

R: How a person can be a good reader?

L: Practice.

- R: Do you think you're a good reader?
- L: No.
- R: Why?
- L: Because I can't read really good. Like even if I know a word, I pronounce it wrong.
- R: You pronounce it wrong?
- L: Yeah and I just have to go over it until I get it. Because I can't read a chapter book. In Spanish I can but in English I can't. (P13; 279: 293)

Lilly also added her evaluation of herself based on language proficiency. She classified herself as a bad reader in English based on two measures, her pronunciation issues and the level of books she is able to read. Expressing her emotions, "A bad reader in English, but in Spanish, I'm a good reader" (P10; 270), she evaluated herself as a good reader or a poor reader based on her language proficiency.

Yanton defined reading in very positive ways. He said books are "interesting, funny, and learn new things" (P7; 51). He also explained the reason people read is "Exciting" (P 12; 59). He had a very positive attitude toward reading.

- R: Do you want to be a good reader? So tell me how you can be a good reader.
- Y: First read easy books and then normal books and then hard books.
- R: Do you do that?
- Y: Yeah. (P7; 63: 69)

Interestingly, Yanton evaluated himself as a good reader, demonstrating his positive attitude. He thought he was able to read chapter books. For the ELLs, reading a chapter book was an important milestone and a boost to their confidence.

### *Reading as a Learning Process*

I observed three categories of reading process, reading first, reading style, and reading as a learning process. As the verbal reports showed, the ELLs mostly read the

text before looking at the pictures and illustrations. Their reading styles suggested ways to develop second language literacy. These factors influenced their learning process in a holistic way.

### *Reading First*

Three ELLs read texts first, before they looked at the pictures or illustrations.

J: I read the words first. In the beginning when you start reading, you will look at the pictures first. (P9; 787: 789)

J: I read the words first but later on I would read the words first so it could help you out. (P9; 800: 801)

KM: He reads first. And we knew there were like a diary so— (P8; 714)

Y: I read first and then I look at the pictures.

YM: He wanted to read the text first so he can (interrupted).

Y: So I understand.

YM: And then he can look at the picture for a long time. (P7; 39: 47)

It was interesting for me to see their reading process because I had expected them to review the pictures or illustrations first. Three participants clearly explained their reading preferences and reading habits. Lilly did not mention this issue in her protocols.

For the participants who read first, pictures and illustrations could give additional motivation and interest, or other information, but did not affect willingness to read. They read the text first, and used pictures and illustrations to confirm their understanding and comprehension. Pictures and illustrations also helped their comprehension when they faced new words or complicated sentences.

### *Reading Style*

The ELLs preferred reading silently to reading aloud. They each offered their own reasons for their reading style. It was very significant for me to understand their reading style as second language learners. Their responses in the verbal protocols described their reading style as a learning process.

R: How do you want to read?

J: Reading silent. (P15; 167: 169)

K: Silent. Because you can read faster. (P16; 133)

L: Read by myself. (P10; 32)

Y: Reading by myself. (P3; 30)

Jae-min preferred reading silently because he could read faster that way. Additionally, he said, "Because it doesn't disturb anyone." He also explained another difficulty about sharing reading that occurs when reading aloud in a classroom. Finally, he added that he could understand better while reading silently, but he did not know how to explain it.

J: Because it doesn't disturb anyone. I prefer read silent. It's better and it doesn't give it away to your friends or anything. If they want to read it, it doesn't give it away to your friends.

R: That's why you want to read silent?

J: It only makes you read faster because if you read out loud, it takes too long. (P15; 167: 185)

Kyle felt as Jae-min did. Kyle liked to read silently, because he could read faster. He also addressed reading aloud in relation to the thinking process.

K: Silent. Because you can read faster.

R: Why?



K: Because when you put things in your mind, if you're like reading to your mom or a friend, you have to stop reading for a second and think. (P16; 133: 150)

Lilly and Yanton also preferred reading silently to reading aloud. Specifically, Lilly did not want to read aloud in front of her mother. Reading aloud in front of her mother gave her pressure. This response indicated her personality.

R: How do you want to read?

L: Read by myself.

R: Why?

L: Because sometimes I want to read something and I don't want anybody to hear. If I'm reading out loud and then there's this part I don't want my mom to hear, I have to say it out loud.

R: So why do you like to read silent?

L: Because if I don't want to like read something to my mom, I can just like read it to myself. Like if I'm reading to my mom out loud and I don't want to read it out loud, mom wants to hear me read, so I would have to say it out loud, even if I didn't want her to hear it. (P10; 37: 57)

Lilly showed a conflict of reading style between her and her mother. She did not want to read aloud in front of her mother at all. Yanton also preferred reading silently. He did not explain his reason, but he was very clear about it, "Reading by myself" (P3; 30). This is good information for educators to understand ELLs. This information may be useful while coordinating a program and balancing teaching methods for ELLs.

J. Richardson (1994) said that 83% of her 10<sup>th</sup>-grade English students rated reading aloud as one of their preferred activities, but surprisingly the results of this study indicated the opposite. None of the 2<sup>nd</sup> and 3<sup>rd</sup> graders in this study favored reading aloud. Jae-min and Kyle addressed the reason they preferred reading silently to reading aloud. They wanted to focus on the content of the story, creating mental images. Especially,

Lilly and Yanton addressed their strong hesitation in reading aloud. They were seriously concerned about pronunciation issues while reading stories.

Worthy and Broaddus (2002) discussed advantages of reading aloud, “Reading aloud exposes and supports students in reading and engaging with texts that they may not be able to handle independently, and it also enhances comprehension development” (p. 337). Ms. Green and Ms. Lopez addressed the reason they practiced reading aloud as modeling, despite the fact that the ELLs did not prefer this activity. The results of the study indicated that 2<sup>nd</sup>- and 3<sup>rd</sup>-grade ELLs preferred reading silently; they enjoyed reading silently and felt more comfortable. Meanwhile, Minichiello-Schmidt (1998) concluded her study by stating, “Reading silently has more advantages for secondary students than reading aloud to them” (p. 12). This discussion gives us significant room to rethink reading practice and coordinate practice for reading process. Educators need to approach these practical teaching methods more carefully and with a sensible understanding of the situation.

### *Reading as a Learning Process*

During the study, the ELLs’ English proficiency, first language proficiency, and cultural background changed. I also observed their reading as a learning process change through the study. Jae-min’s reading process was very concrete and concise in terms of using his various reading strategies. He already had a strong sense of knowledge to comprehend stories. He coordinated his reading strategies depending on the stage he was in.

J: The pictures kind of helped me to understand it. Because if you didn’t know a word, it might help you.

- R: If you don't know the words, a picture can help you out to understand the word? Does that happen to you often?
- J: It happened only a little bit.
- R: So if you read it and you don't understand a word, then the picture will help you to understand the word? For example if you don't understand, woodcutter, how are you going to figure it out?
- J: You can find it in the dictionary.
- R: How do you do it usually, you try to find it in the dictionary? When you read some books and you come across you don't understand what are you going to do?
- J: Or you can ask a friend that knows about *a woodcutter*.
- R: But what did you used to do?
- J: I didn't used to do it. I just ask my friend, what does this mean and stuff. (P15; 54: 70)

He read the text first, using the picture or illustration to get additional information or confirm his understanding of the story. He used the dictionary if he faced new words. Finally, he asked capable friends, teachers, or family if he could not understand words while reading stories. He preferred to ask friends over looking at the dictionary. He also described one of his strategies as "keep reading" using contextuality to understand the meaning of words if he did not know.

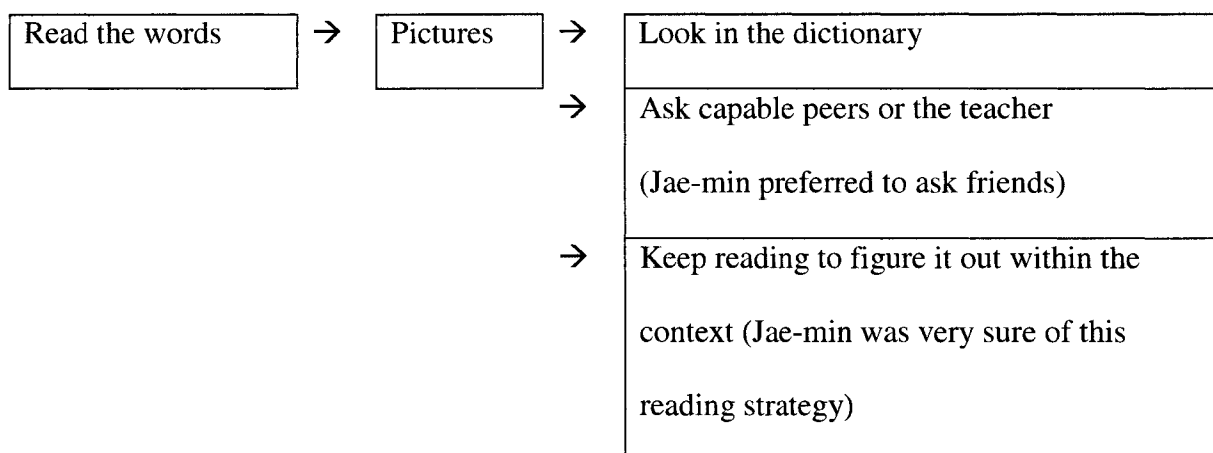


Figure 2. Jae-min's reading process.

Jae-min explained how to read and understand stories using different resources and strategies to get help. He used and combined his different reading strategies to improve his reading process.

If you do your best spelling, you can spell it, but if you don't know it, you don't know what it means so just keep going.

I mean, just don't care about it. Just keep going. (P11; 778: 782)

If you didn't know, you read it, but just keep going and you'll learn it later. (P11 789: 797)

Jae-min also usually asked friends if he failed to figure out meaning of words such as *woodcutter*. He explained contextuality, in which he kept reading stories until he figured out the words in the context. He convinced me that he would figure it out if he kept reading.

Kyle also demonstrated his learning process within contextuality. Kyle deciphered the meaning of *Visa* while reading without asking me,

It's about a family that they're surrounded by people, by the metal gate with all the other people that want help from that husband and that family and he helps. And he has to like sign everybody's—I don't know how to read that word—I don't know, but I understand it. (P16; 14: 31)

He understood the word meaning naturally and spontaneously in the context.

Kyle understood the content of the story without knowing the key word at first, because he understood the key word's meaning within the context. This experience demonstrated his use of contextuality. He said,

I kind of figured it out. It was like this piece of paper that he would sign. Like the part I don't understand is like he signs those pieces of papers that help those other people from like getting killed and stuff. (P16; 14: 31)

His explanation of *Visa* was well developed for understanding the content of the story.

R: So did you have any problems when you were reading this book? You told me you didn't understand some words.

K: I kind of figured it out. It was like this piece of paper that he would sign.

R: So you figured it out while you were reading?

K: Yeah.

R: What helped you figure out the meaning of the word? How did you figure it out?

K: Guessing. (P16; 40: 52)

Kyle explained this process as "guessing" while reading the story. He expressed that pictures and illustrations might support his comprehension process. It was similar to Jae-min's

Jae-min also described that his reading as a learning process included reviewing the book's cover before he read the book. Jae-min usually did not review the cover of the storybook unless he did not know the book's genre. That meant he wanted to know what books are before he read. He read the title of the book to figure out what the story would be. He wanted to be ready to read the book, having his communication mode opened to read and understand the story. It was a very interesting reading strategy as a learning process. Jae-min said, "I read the first page. I don't really read the cover unless I don't

know what book it is” (P3; 283) and “I don’t really look at the cover. I just look at the title so I know what kind of book it is” (P11; 861).

Lilly preferred to use her first language skills, and had sincere consciousness of her language loss. She enjoyed reading stories written in the dual-language versions of *Family Pictures*.

R: Which do you know more words in, Spanish?

L: Yeah. Like if there’s a word I don’t understand, I just look here for the same sentence, I just read it and then I say, “Oh I see what it is.” (P13; 327: 337)

L: I read so much English now.

R: So you read better in English now than in Spanish?

L: Yeah.

R: So what helped you to read in English quickly, because you practiced a lot?

L: Because I heard people say it a lot. So if I heard something, I would ask my mom, “What did they say?” And she would tell me and if I wanted to ask a question she would tell me how to say it in English until I learned.

R: So tell me one more thing, when you are reading and you come to some words you don’t know, what do you do?

L: Just go back here. (P13; 352: 368)

L: I would go to a dictionary. (P13; 369)

Lilly’s reading as a learning process explored her first language, including using such resources as a dictionary. Lilly showed her awareness of keeping her first language throughout the study. Overall, her reading process was similar to Jae-min’s such as using a dictionary or asking her peers or her mother when she faced challenges in comprehending the story. Lilly also mentioned the importance of rich comprehensible input while learning English as a second language, as addressed by Krashen (1985) in his input hypothesis (see chapter 2).

### *Comprehension Styles of the English Language Learners*

The ELLs in this study showed their comprehension styles while reading. There were similarities and differences among the students depending mainly on the materials, their English proficiency, and their cultural orientation. The ELLs used various strategies while making meaning through the stories.

#### *Jae-min as Honest Theory Builder*

Jae-min had a positive attitude toward reading. He understood reading as productive and essential in preparing for the future. I observed his ethnic identity as he made meaning. He comprehended stories based on his cultural and social value system.

Jae-min used various strategies depending on the task at hand. I clearly saw his strong links to personal preferences, experiences, intertextuality, and cultural orientation. His ethnicity initially defined the degree of his engagement, but Jae-min's intertextuality developed as a new matrix, using cultural background knowledge, textual knowledge, and world knowledge. His inference skills also supported using his cognition and knowledge processing while reading, invoking his dialectical thinking experiences.

Through the process of analyzing texts and evaluating stories, he created critical points of view. Based on his theory building, sociocultural values, and prior knowledge, including cognitive knowledge and cultural knowledge, he dialogued with texts. And, he became a rewriter while reading stories, creating new viewpoints of the story following the author's spirit. For example, he represented two authors' intentions and purposes after reading two versions of the Christopher Columbus story. He also rewrote a nice story of Christopher Columbus's youth within an author's spirit after reading *Follow the Dream*.

(See chapter 5.) He also used his content knowledge to establish and support his critical points of view while reading.

### *Kyle as Critical Theory Builder*

Kyle was a critical reader who knew how to use various strategies and his interaction deepened through the study. His ethnic identity took the main role while comprehending stories and he evaluated stories based on his ethnicity and culture. He showed his centerpole ideas of Japan throughout the study. He did not comprehend very well those stories that were not at least relatively acceptable in his ethnic point of views.

His critical thinking processes created empathy while reading. For example, the results of the study showed his critical thinking process while reading the two versions of Christopher Columbus. His cognitive knowledge, metacognitive knowledge, and knowledge processes were well connected and not limited to his thinking processes. For example, Kyle developed empathy while reading *Encounter*; he became the boy in *Encounter*, establishing the aesthetic stance. Transaction occurred through this stance while reading the story. Kyle reflected himself into the boy in the story. He began dialoguing with *Encounter*, and extended his dialogue into *Follow the Dream*. His recommendation of the two stories to friends showed the process of his dialogue. He was dialoguing among the two stories and with himself.

Kyle and Jae-min became thinkers. These strategies made connections to socioaffective strategies. Kyle and Jae-min, with their strong English proficiency, associated with their cognitive and metacognitive knowledge. They evaluated content and style, moral issues, social values, and critical points of view while reading the stories.



### *Lilly as a Cultural Schemata User*

I recognized schema strategies using Lilly's prior knowledge as Lilly's powerful strategies in this study. This prior knowledge motivated her to read *Family Pictures* and *I Hate English*. She identified closely with her culture and cultural experience. She was also aware of her first language loss. She identified more strongly with culturally relevant stories than with nonculturally relevant stories. For example, she transacted deeply with Mei Mei in *I Hate English*. She agreed with Mei Mei, placing herself in that situation, "No. Mei Mei doesn't speak English because she wants to speak Chinese. But everybody is bugging her because they want her to speak English. And she wishes she was in Hong-Kong" (P10; 358). She understood why Mei Mei did not want to speak English, commenting, "Because it's not her main language" (P10; 362).

Lilly also mentioned, "My best friend is in Mexico," when she read about Mei Mei missing her friends in Hong Kong and dreaming of them. She also addressed the reason why Mei Mei did not want to speak English by explaining her situation. Lilly situated her awareness of language loss as well. She wanted to practice Spanish to keep her language to communicate with her father. Lilly totally understood Mei Mei's language struggling and cultural adaptation process. For Lilly, culture and cultural experience was the window to comprehend stories.

### *Yanton as an Elaborator*

Yanton was deeply connected to Mei Mei's personality and experience as an English language beginner in the United States. Yanton showed total transaction with Mei Mei on her language struggles, reflecting on his own experience. He adopted Mei Mei's feeling and struggling for himself. As I already discussed, *I Hate English* was very

powerful for Yanton, as it was for Lilly. Reading *I Hate English* gave Yanton another opportunity to understand a context similar to his experiences. This commonality offered him encouragement. Having time to understand the context with the other (Mei Mei in this book) was very important for him. He felt safer, understanding Mei Mei's experiences through the reading process. He realized that this struggling in language and culture happened to others as well. Lilly and Yanton wanted to ask friends to read this book. They believed that sharing this story with their friends would spread understanding.

Lilly and Yanton, as ELL beginners, made connections to cultural experiences and their background knowledge while reading. This extended matrix of comprehending supported them in developing their empathy in reading. Lilly also made a strong connection to Mei Mei's journey, identifying with her emotion and sorrow.

The results of the study—discussed in three parts in chapters 4, 5, and 6—indicated how these second language learners made meaning by using reading strategies while reading stories and what factors influenced them in the learning process. The major differences between strong and weak English language readers appear to be their ability to identify subproblems and apply strategies as they work to comprehend texts. The next chapter will develop a deeper discussions of the significant results and implications for educators based on results of the study.

## CHAPTER 7

### DISCUSSION AND IMPLICATIONS

The results of the study were analyzed using three planes: A holistic view of the four cases, the analysis of reading strategies via the verbal protocol, and the two main themes from the qualitative research, the ELL and identity and the ELLs' dialogue in reading. This chapter is divided into four sections. The first section provides a summary of findings as an overview of the study. The second section develops the results from three results chapters into the three main themes of the third section, ethnic identity and ethnocentrism through the meaning-making process, the ELL's response to culturally and nonculturally relevant reading, and the implication of second language literacy development for educators. The chapter concludes with recommendations for future research.

#### Summary of Findings

In order to investigate second language literacy development, I developed a main question and three subquestions. Questions are used to focus on the data collection and the interpretation of the data. These questions are analyzed in chapters 4, 5, and 6 through the specific research methods. The main question and the subquestions were answered in the results of the study section: the four cases of the holistic view of second language literacy, the reading strategies of the verbal protocol, and the two themes from the qualitative research. The main question was analyzed in the study, but I address the study's descriptive main focus from an ethnographic point of view with subquestion 1 below because they overlap in fundamental ways. The main question of the study was,

What is the learning process involved in second language literacy development of English language learners in their language arts/literature class in an elementary school setting?

The following three subquestions further enabled me to answer this main question:

1. How do English language learners move toward literacy in English as a second language in the language arts/literature class?
2. What strategies do English language learners use while reading stories?
3. How do English language learners interact with their teacher and peers in acquiring their literacy skills in the language arts/literature class?

### *Moving Toward Literacy*

1. How do English language learners move toward literacy in English as a second language in the language arts/literature class?

In this study, I observed second language literacy development as a learning process. The four ELLs' cases offered a holistic view of the second language learning process in chapter 4. The four ELLs' cases portray these second language learners from different cultures and with different English proficiencies based on an ethnographic point of view. Influential factors for ELLs' second language literacy learning experiences are also addressed.

Jae-min showed his positive attitude and beliefs toward reading, literacy, and education. His case showed how the ELL's belief system is based on family and culture, and how it affects the ELL's literacy learning experience. Kyle, a strategizer, tells us how the ELL uses strategies while engaging in literacy events in the social context. Jae-min's and Kyle's cases also guide us to see why and how ELLs make meaning based on their ethnic identity. Jae-min and Kyle, both from East Asian cultures, also demonstrated how

their ethnic identity and ethnocentrism influence their meaning-making in literacy activities.

Lilly's case tells us how cultural knowledge and cultural experience work for the beginner ELL during meaning construction. Lilly, who wanted to say "No quiero," was very attached to her memory of Mexico and very aware of her Spanish loss. Keeping Spanish was very important to her to communicate with her father in Mexico, because he did not speak English. Lilly's case also shows how her Spanish use transferred to English use in the classroom naturally with support from her teacher. Yanton's case also allows us to observe the ELL's language shock, culture shock, and cultural adaptation. Interestingly, the two cases offered insight into the levels of the second language learning process. Overall, language proficiency was the main role while making meaning in literacy events as well as in the formation of their identity.

In chapter 6, the ELLs' unique identities and their flexibility are observed from the ethnographic or qualitative research point of view. They recognized themselves instead of being recognized by others. Their identities were firmly interconnected with issues about nationality, gender, language use, and language loss. Another theme was the ELLs' dialogue in second language literacy. Jae-min explored reading as brainpower, which implied a positive attitude and productive meaning. He used this metaphor to explain reading in terms of human growth and the idea that one must "feed" the brain for it to grow. Kyle and Lilly agreed that reading is a knowledge process. Reading as a learning process from *read the words* to *keep reading* for meaning making as a process (see chapter 6) was observed. The ELLs' comprehension styles showed how the ELLs comprehend readings from multiple sources. There are significant similarities and

differences among the ELLs depending on materials, their English proficiency, and their cultural orientation. I used the conceptual map in Figure 1 (developed through my pilot studies) to understand the ELLs' learning processes. (See chapter 2.) It was very helpful to me in understanding the context in which second language learning occurred, exploring the complexity of second language literacy development, and investigating the dynamic dialogue among ELLs, the text, and the teachers in the context.

### *Strategies*

2. What strategies do English language learners use while they engage in literacy events?

The results from the verbal protocols indicated that the ELLs used various strategies depending on whether they were reading culturally or nonculturally relevant stories. The verbal protocols allow us to see ELLs' thinking process as a learning process while reading stories. The four ELLs vocalized their thinking process retrospectively with a hint of the think-aloud protocol. Twelve strategies emerged from the data.

The most widely used strategies were the schema strategies, connection to self, intertextuality, and connection to world knowledge. Jae-min supported Tiger's behavior in terms of Bong-Yang toward his old mother after reading *Woodcutter and Tiger Brother*. He was very excited to read these culturally familiar concepts, illustrations, and genre of the story. Lilly identified strongly with *Family Pictures*, which portrayed her culture. For example, she began singing while explaining the piñata, and missed her father, after reading the Birthday chapter in *Family Pictures*. Lilly and Yanton both made a powerful connection with Mei Mei while reading *I Hate English*, revealing their lived-

through experiences. These cultural experiences transferred the story into their experiences.

Jae-min and Kyle linked strongly to the multiple versions of the same story, understanding the author's intention and purpose. For example, they made significant dialogue after reading the two versions of the Christopher Columbus story and several versions of the Cinderella story, contrasting and comparing. Jae-min's response is still in my ears, "They are same? No. Different people wrote stories." The ELLs' use of intertextuality was very pluralistic and showed the complexity of reading to create new meaning of the stories. Using inference strategies, Jae-min and Kyle summarized the storyline and made suggestions and critical judgments while reading stories. Their prior knowledge was crucial to predict new information from the text. For example, Jae-min created a new version of Christopher Columbus after reading *Follow the Dream*. The results indicated that inference skill requires English as well as reading proficiency.

The use of visualization differed for each ELL, but they all mentioned that the level of the story is very important in creating mental images. The ELLs visualized three avenues, corresponding to pictures or illustration in the text, creating mental images and sensory effects from the text, and counting on reading style to create mental images from the text. Also, the ELLs identified the level of text as important for creating mental images. All the ELLs mentioned their experiences while reading *Harry Potter* in English or their own languages.

Rhetoric strategies were often used by the ELLs with good first language literacy skills. The ELLs use their first language literacy to understand second language reading. Yanton made good linkages between the two, and he used rhetoric strategies on genre

analysis and character analysis briefly but well. Comprehension monitoring is used differently depending on the ELL. Yanton and Lilly tried to define known and unknown words. Lilly and Jae-min monitored their comprehension by recounting lessons to themselves. Kyle and Jae-min monitored their comprehension based on their ethnic identity and sociocultural values. Lilly and Yanton comprehended *I Hate English* deeply, monitoring overlapping meaning between Mei Mei and themselves.

The ELLs used questioning to understand the story well. From simple questioning, they extended to dialectical questioning. Lilly and Yanton questioned more words and the contents of the story, and Jae-min and Kyle asked questions to confirm their comprehension and extend their questioning to determine the author's intention and purpose. Using summarizing and synthesizing strategies, the ELLs understood the story based on their sociocultural values, preferences, and interest. Jae-min and Kyle failed to summarize the "girly" story after reading *Mei Ping and Silver Shoes*, despite their prior knowledge and the easy level of the story. Lilly synthesized *Hiroko Makes the Team*, summarizing its lesson to children. Yanton's summary was quite short, but clear.

I observed various evaluation strategies from simple character evaluation to complicated evaluation of the story's genre or content. The exploration of the two versions of the Christopher Columbus story were rich with dialectical thinking skills allowing the ELLs to evaluate two different perspectives on the same historical event. Jae-min and Kyle were challenged after reading the two stories. They evaluated the stories and extended their meaning construction to a new level of creative dialectical thinking.



Socioaffective strategies included social interaction strategies and affective domain strategies in the social context. The ELLs came to the classroom with different levels of English proficiency and different cultural backgrounds. As I already mentioned in chapters 4 and 5, they learned English as a second language by interacting with peers and the teacher in a meaningful context. While they were working on their projects and assignments in the classroom with capable peers, they were able to develop their scaffolding to follow up their tasks within the ZPD. The ELLs' identities were also deeply influenced by their families and cultures. Their identity formation influenced their second language literacy development.

In sum, the ELLs used strategies differently depending on the material at hand, the level of the task, their English proficiency, and their cultural orientation. Culturally relevant stories are very useful for beginner ELLs who had poor English proficiency. Noticeably, stories that contained cultural experiences, such as *I Hate English*, were very meaningful for developing community. Nonculturally relevant stories are valuable for stimulating dialectical thinking skills for those ELLs who have established a certain level of English proficiency. The two versions of the Christopher Columbus story offered Jae-min and Kyle an understanding of two authors' perspectives with different intentions and purposes. It also allowed them to think critically. In addition, through the verbal protocols, Kyle and Jae-min expressed their ethnic identity and ethnocentrism while making meaning.

The ELLs' English proficiency is crucial while making meaning in literacy events. Mostly they are aware of language proficiency in both their native language and their second language. They wanted to keep their first language proficiency as it related to

their identity issues, and they were willing to develop their English as a second language to become confident social beings in the social context. Developing their second language proficiency was empowering and built competence and confidence.

### *Interactions*

3. How do English language learners interact with their teacher and peers in acquiring their literacy skills in the language arts/literature class?

ELLs learn English as a second language well while interacting with peers and the teacher. The results of the study show the importance of peer interaction and support within the ZPD. Jae-min's and Lilly's mother told the story of how Jae-min and Lilly learned English, as interacting with their peers and teachers. Ms. Green and Ms. Lopez mentioned the importance of peer support while working on a project, pointing out that they have the same points of view. Ms. Green and Ms. Lopez also varied their teaching methods and instructions to meet all the students' needs. They integrated the students' funds of knowledge into the curriculum. They also provided the ELLs with more interaction with others in small-group, pair-work, and cooperative learning, offering the ELLs abundant comprehensible input from their peers. Cooperative learning offers ELLs a chance to build up their scaffolding to do their tasks with the support of capable peers in the ZPD.

Interaction with peers and teachers was repeatedly observed throughout the study. Examples include the process Yanton and Lilly followed in getting language support from their capable peers to become independent in the classroom in a social context. There were certain stages during which they needed to have different forms of support from peers to become independent: the dependent period, the preindependent period, the

independent period, and the cooperative period. The language learning process included speaking a complete sentence following the silent period through interaction with peers and the teacher in the classroom in a social context (see chapter 4).

### Ethnic Identity and Ethnocentrism Through the Meaning Making Process

#### *Identity and Ethnic Identity in Literacy Engagement*

The ELLs in this study indicated their awareness of themselves through the meaning-making process. They positioned themselves at the center while making meaning through the reading. They identified themselves based on ethnic identity, language use, and social identity during meaning construction. For example, Jae-min identified himself as Korean without any hesitation. Kyle also strongly identified himself as Japanese. Interestingly, the ELLs preferred their own self-recognition to others' recognition of themselves. For example, Kyle recognized himself as Japanese, partially because he was born in Japan. On the other hand, Jae-min recognized himself as Korean, even though he was born in the United States. They mostly identified themselves based on their own interpretation of nationality and language use.

Gee's (1999) definition of *identity* supported understanding the context and meaning-making process. He defined identity as a recognition by others. He said,

If you put language, action, interaction, values, beliefs, symbols, objects, tools, and places together in such a way that others recognize you as a particular type of who (identity) engaged in a particular type of what (activity) here and now, then you have pulled off a Discourse (and thereby continued it through history, if only for a while longer). ... However, if it is different enough from what has gone before, but still recognizable, it can simultaneously change and transform Discourse. (p. 18)

Gee showed how a person's identity constructs and shifts discourses to express a membership within a certain group; it affects one's social identity by interacting with others in the social context. A person's identity moves, shifts, and transforms based on language use and social memberships and within contexts by others' recognition. For example, later Kyle identified himself as Japanese American based on his language use. It showed that his identity had shifted from Japanese to Japanese American. The ELLs in this study mostly recognized themselves based on the interrelationship between their ethnic identity and language use.

Ethnic identity is defined as "one's sense of belonging to an ethnic group and the part of one's thinking, perceptions, feelings, and behavior that is due to ethnic group membership" (Rotheram & Phinney; as cited in Knight et al., 1993, p. 224). Bernal, Knight, Organista, Garza, and Maez (1993) identified four components of ethnic identity: *ethnic self-identification, ethnic constancy, ethnic knowledge related to behavior and value system, and ethnic effect, feeling, and preferences.*

Throughout the study, the ELLs' identities were influenced by their meaning making as they read the stories. Correspondingly, their meaning construction was influenced by their identities. For example, Jae-min and Kyle evaluated stories based on their sociocultural value system. Jae-min and Kyle did not identify with *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes* because they judged it to be a "girly story." This evaluation was influenced by their cultural background filled with Confucian ideas.

Notably, the content information from these familial and nonfamilial socialization agents influenced the children's self-concept, including their ethnic identity (Knight et al., 1993). For example, Kyle and Jae-min made meaning while reading stories based on their

ethnic identity. Kyle liked reading *Hiroko Makes the Team*, noting that Hiroko and Toshi, two main characters, were Japanese. Jae-min enjoyed reading *Woodcutter and Tiger Brother* because the story was a Korean traditional folk tale and it made sense to him.

Jae-min's and Kyle's verbal reports revealed a strong ethnic identity and social value system formed by their ethnic values and sociocultural concepts. The ELLs recognized their *self-concepts* and reinforced them during and after reading. For them, it is very important to confirm who they are, what they are, and where they belong. They used the reading practice to confirm and reinforce their self-concepts. Based on their confirmation of their ethnic identity, they understood texts and constructed meaning.

Children acquire specific social identity through both socialization practices and the specific content communicated through the practice with family and nonfamily agents, peers and teachers (Knight et al., 1993). Participants in this study mostly practiced their socialization, communicating with family, teachers, and peers. Their ethnic identities were confirmed, reconfirmed, and reinforced by family and nonfamily agents. They mainly experienced ethnic values and social identity with family, especially with their mothers in this study. The results of the study indicated that Jae-min's and Kyle's mothers raised them as Korean and Japanese. Meaning making through literacy activities was influenced by this practice. They made meaning from the ethnic identity formed by family and nonfamily agents.

#### *Favoritism and Ethnic Identity*

Aboud and Doyle (1993) referred to ethnic identity as

a person's knowledge of belonging to an ethnic group and pride in that group. Thus, it refers both to the perceptual/cognitive processes that connect oneself to others of the same ethnic group, and to the affective or attitudinal processes that join one to others. (p. 47)

This is a general definition of ethnic identity. Aboud (1988) indicated that the development of favoritism toward one's own group is more consistent with a cognitive developmental perspective than with a learning perspective. For example, she explained that after 7 years of age children develop more own-group pride. Children also indicate their self-identification (Clark & Clark, 1947), which emphasizes physical appearance as a criterion for belonging and similarity. For example, Kyle said, "Jae-min is my best friend in the United States. I thought he is Chinese" (K-12). Kyle selected Jae-min as part of his Asian own-group based on his similar appearance.

Jae-min and Kyle thought they belonged together in terms of self-identification because they had similar appearances and had similar cultural background. Kyle also favored Hiroko and Toshi while reading *Hiroko Makes the Team* because they were Japanese. He said, "She looks like Japanese." This response revealed his self-identification. Furthermore, they understood *identity constancy*, which refers "more to one's understanding of ethnicity than to one's personal identification" (Aboud & Doyle, 1993, p. 50). Jae-min and Kyle felt more comfortable together based on *identity constancy*, sharing a communality of cultural concepts.

Knight et al. (1993) explored *ethnic identity* as it related to other self-concepts, including the gender issue. They noted that "A gender issue was considered one of nature's self-concepts. The gender-related to schema develops as children process information according to the gender schema and incorporate incoming stimuli relevant to gender such as sex stereotypes" (p. 224). Kyle and Jae-min showed their distinguishable gender issues in the study. Kyle very strongly addressed the gender issues while reading *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes*. He did not like to read *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes*, as

reflected in his incomplete summary of the story. His gender issues led to a lack of motivation, which hindered his comprehension of the story. As he developed his self-concept as a boy, he evaluated the story as a girly story. He also did not identify with the contents of the story, even though he had background knowledge of the Cinderella story. When I asked about the different style of shoes between Chinese version of the story and American version of the story, he refused to answer the question, commenting “stupid question.”

In the beginning of the story, Kyle did not identify with *Hiroko Makes the Team*. However, he did not mind reading it because the main topic of the story was swimming and competition and because it was a Japanese story. Also, he liked Toshi’s character, Hiroko’s brother in the story. It was very interesting to see the process of his association with the story. He thought Toshi was a very cool boy because he was very mean.

As did Kyle, Jae-min mentioned his gender issue. He did not like reading *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes*, but he was very polite and tried to read it. However, his summary showed that he also neglected to comprehend the story. The book was well below his level, but he was inattentive to summarize the story because of his unwillingness to read it. I realized that this weak motivation is related to gender awareness from his ethnic background and family influence. He did not want to read some words such as *hugging*, *married*, *love*, and so on. These concepts are taboo in Asian cultures based on Confucianism.

Although Kyle’s mother denied her influence on Kyle’s social value system, her interview script showed her limited understanding of both cultures. As I explored in

chapter 3, she did not know the difference between social values in Japanese and Western society.

Jae-min identified himself as Korean, and was proud of being Korean. Kyle identified himself as Japanese. Their ethnic identity was very firmly developed. In the same way, Lilly identified strongly with Mexican culture and her first language, but she hardly expressed her ethnic identity. Lilly only understood her ethnic identity as it related to her language proficiency. She understood why Mei Mei (*I Hate English*) did not want to speak English, expressing her awareness of her Spanish loss. In the same sense, she wanted to keep her Spanish, because she missed her father, other family members, and friends in Mexico. She mentioned that they do not speak English. She was more concerned with how to communicate with her friends and family than with her identity.

Yanton's ethnic identity was also not examined through the study; he was still struggling to express his emotion and was only barely coming out of his culture shock. In sum, Kyle and Jae-min's strong ethnic identities which stemmed from their family influence, were also related to their language use.

### *Ethnocentrism in Meaning Making*

Self-concept is central to social development (Aboud & Doyle, 1993). The ELLs in my study revealed their strong self-concepts and their ethnocentrism concurrently. They built up meaning from their background and cultural schema, and composed new meaning centralizing themselves. Kyle's reading response indicated his ethnocentrism, "He was lucky he got to the right place he wanted to go. He even get what he wanted. And my favorite part was that he thought AMERICA was JAPAN" (K-1) His short response to *Follow the Dream* indicated his meaning construction. He highlighted the



reason he liked the story and why it gave the literacy activity meaning for him, by emphasizing the names of the places. The corresponding value system is central to their self-concepts and their ethnicity, and the verbal reports demonstrated their favoritism (Kohlberg, 1969). Educators are coming to realize that a children's ethnic identity must be considered and appreciated in the school setting in order to gain equal opportunity in their academic success.

Kohlberg (1969) described age-related changes in in-group favoritism and out-group prejudice. Piaget explained that children's favoritism and dislike in the 4-to-7-year age group was inconsistent because they are egocentric and unaware of national or ethnic groups (Piaget & Weil, 1951). He also said that from 7 to 10 years of age, children become ethnocentric in that they should show strong favoritism toward their own group and should dislike other groups. Aboud and Doyle (1993) argued with Piaget's statement of ethnocentrism related to age groups. In their own view, children of 4 to 7 years are both egocentric and sociocentric and are highly ethnocentric. They also said that their biases were maintained by an attachment to familiar, similar, or important people and by an exaggeration of superficial group differences. They also expected that children of 7 to 10 years become less biased because their cognitions become more differentiated with respect to groups and individuals, and because these cognitions become more powerful in guiding their preferences.

The ELLs in my study appeared to be quite different from both Piaget and Weil's (1951) and Aboud & Doyle's (1993) conclusions. At the time of the study, Jae-min, Kyle, and Lilly were 8 years old and Yanton was 9 years old. Jae-min and Kyle showed strong ethnocentrism along with high cognition. If I reviewed my results from Piaget's

perspective, they should be ethnocentric without cognition. However, the results of this study showed their high level of cognition. Viewing the study from Aboud and Doyle's perspectives, they should have less ethnocentrism because they have a high level of cognition.

The ELLs in this study built up their strong self-concepts from their own culture, and they connected from what they already knew to the unknown. This study showed insightful room for the connections between two main domains, ethnocentrism and high cognition.

#### *Ethnocentric Filter System: What Is Very Meaningful?*

Children in a family and community develop an ethnic identity that is peripheral in their self-concept. For example, they know who they are, where they came from, what value system their culture had, incorporating ethnic-values, ethnic behaviors, and activities.

For example, Kyle used Japan as a center pole while making meaning and demonstrated the route of the Cinderella story from his perspective after reading *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes*. He believed that the Cinderella story was originally from Japan. Interestingly, Kyle explained the route of Cinderella story as originating in Japan, going to Korea, moving on to America, to France, and finally to China. He placed himself at the center of the story.

New knowledge and tasks were filtered by the ELLs' ethnocentrism while they were doing their own task (reading a story in this study). They would accept or reject the task or information depending on the degree of their *ethnocentric filter system*, while they were engaging in the tasks. I noticed the most ethnocentrism in Jae-min's and Kyle's

cases. Jae-min's and Kyle's major identity, which is ethnic identity, filtered new information to create meaning while engaging in meaningful tasks. Some information failed to reach them, if the information was extracted by this filter system. Based on the results of the study, I call the filter system an *ethnocentric filter system*. The ELLs who had strong ethnocentrism filtered new information while comprehending or evaluating tasks. The ELLs made meaning based on the discourse between their ethnocentrism and their cognition. Due to their high degree of ethnocentrism and cognition, Jae-min and Kyle interacted, comprehended, and evaluated stories through their ethnocentric filter system. The filter would include the ELLs' ethnic identity and gender issues.

#### *Classification System of the Ethnocentric Filter system*

Gender issues were derived from their ethnic identity. Many Asian societies differentiate between male and female roles based on Confucian ideas. Discussions of issues on different genders or body interaction between the genders are generally taboo. Examples from the study included *hugging* and *kissing*. Jae-min and Kyle showed negative responses when they faced these terms, concepts, and explanations while reading stories. With their term, *girly story*, they expressed their self-concepts in differentiation of the female, expressing their own group pride. In East Asian societies, parents teach young children what boys can and cannot do through the *ethnocentric filter system*. A proverb from Confucianism shows an example of the society: *Nahm-Nyu-Chil-Sae-Bu-Dong-Seock*: 남녀칠세부동석(男女七歲不動席) (*man and woman should not sit together after the age of seven*). These societies clearly differentiated between the roles of men and women with *Nahm-Yeo-Yu-Beol*: 남여유별 (男女有別) from

Confucianism. The results of this study showed how Jae-min and Kyle were influenced by this societal culture.

Kyle was challenged to comprehend *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes* because of the gender issues. This could be explained based on this filter system. He had difficulties comprehending and summarizing the story, although the story was not difficult and he had fully enough schema for the story. The application of ethnic identity was very obvious throughout the study. Jae-min and Kyle comprehended and evaluated moral and gender issues through this filter system. Furthermore, they developed their new knowledge based on their ethnocentrism, such as the route of the Cinderella story.

However, Kyle liked the story of *Hiroko Makes the Team*, despite some parts related to hugging in this gender-related story. He said, “Because maybe like—I think because she’s the main character, Hiroko. Maybe she’s like Japanese, maybe. I think so. Look at the face” (P4; 27). He addressed his preference of the book based on his ethnocentrism. In his huge awareness of gender issues, I assumed he would dislike the story, but he understood the story well. He learned that Hiroko and Toshi, the main characters, were Japanese. He also liked other topics of the story such as *swimming* and *winning*. His ethnocentrism related to his ethnic identity overruled his gender issues in this case. The classification of his *ethnocentric filter system* and the importance of story topics was clear in this case.

An important implication of the study is that we as educators should pay attention to children from East Asia. They have a strong *ethnocentric filter system* or high level of ethnocentrism. We as educators must work hard to support them in learning values from different cultures and ethnicities. We can extend this idea to provide an atmosphere of

openness and support for other cultural and social values and other ethnicities as well as an effective curriculum and efficient teaching methods. Their family members are so focused on their own culture that we as educators should be approaching them with the values of others. The curriculum and teaching methods should be provided to stimulate their critical thinking skills. With their cognition and critical thinking skills stimulated, they will be ready to accept other cultures and ethnicities.

### *Language Use and Identity*

The main theme of language use I observed was ethnic identity, which the ELLs considered in terms of who they are, what they are, and where they belong. The multiple identities are interrelated and ethnic identity and social identity may have important links to other identities and may affect behaviors in relatively complex ways (Knight et al., 1993). Based on the results of this study, language use was interrelated with the ELLs' identity.

As mentioned earlier, Kyle showed the flexibility of his ethnic identity based on his English proficiency. Language skills and language use influenced Kyle's self-concept development. When I asked the reason for his shift, he responded calmly, "Because I was born in Japan and I speak American and Japanese" (P4; 204).

Also, Lilly represented her identity based on her language skills and preferences for language use. She answered "No quiero" incautiously. She said, "I want to speak Spanish" (P10: 252). Her answer of "No quiero" was powerful to understand her identity. She represented her identity using her Spanish. This response also expressed her adherence to her first language use. Lilly was aware of Spanish itself to communicate with her friends and family in Mexico.

Finally, Jae-min indicated the importance of practicing Korean while reading stories. For him, it made more sense to read the Korean folk tale in Korean, although it was easier for him to read in English. He noted, “We know how to say it better. You know how to say it better when you’re an American person, you can say it better in English” (P9; 757). This statement explained his cognitive comprehension skills as well as his use of the two languages. He added that he remembered the stories better in Korean than English, because Korean is more meaningful and sensible for him.

#### *Discussion for Educators*

One of the big tasks in this study was to describe what was happening in ELLs’ reading process and how they make meaning during and after reading the stories. The ELLs, with different English proficiency and different cultural origins, identified differently with the stories based on their ethnic identity and their ethnocentrism. Children from Asian societies develop their ethnic identity very highly in the process of meaning construction. Expectations of parents’ ethnic identity influenced the formation of their children’s ethnic identity, comprehension, monitoring, and evaluation of stories in their *ethnocentric filter system*. They decided how to comprehend and transact with stories based on this filter system.

Meanwhile, the ELLs from all the cultures and backgrounds in this study identified strongly with culturally relevant stories using their cognition. English proficient readers such as Jae-min and Kyle extended their association to nonculturally relevant stories successfully. We as educators should be aware that ELLs who are 8 to 9 years old have very concrete ethnocentrism and a high degree of cognition. The materials should support these ELLs in thinking critically. Two versions of the Christopher

Columbus stories represent good materials for the critical thinking process. Selection of materials should be considered carefully for each ELL depending on cultural background and level of language proficiency.

It could be a big task for educators to create a curriculum for ELLs from very different cultures and countries. However, the information I obtained through this study should help in that process. For example, Moll (1992) suggested ideas of *Funds of Knowledge* would be very useful to invite the ELLs' strengths into class. If the ELLs are encouraged to share with others, they will be empowered and the whole class's curriculum will be enhanced with critical thinking skills. Critical consciousness of words and the world (Freire, 1970) should be enhanced for ELLs who have a strong *ethnocentric filter system*.

If educators are willing to elaborate their curriculum to enhance the critical thinking process, ELLs' ethnic identity as a concept will help to develop the new curriculum. We as educators are cultural workers and can position ourselves well with a critical thinking curriculum based on creating critical consciousness (Freire, 1970) for all of us.

Ethnocentrism might be reexamined for educators while developing a new curriculum for ELLs. Reexamining ethnocentrism might be a good way for educators to understand ELLs and guide them in more efficient and effective ways. The issues we face with their ethnocentrism guide us to appreciate other cultures with a global perspective. When we stimulate them to think critically, their *ethnocentric filter system* will be reduced. Teaching how to think critically integrated into a curriculum for all students (Freire, 1970) is critical. To temper a strong *ethnocentric filter system*, they must think

with consciousness. When they appreciate others and think with consciousness, their ethnocentrism will not hinder their comprehension of stories, and their second language literacy will be stimulated, reducing the *ethnocentric filter system*. Furthermore, it will support the ELL to be a world-conscious person with a global perspective.

The ELLs were especially influenced by their parents. Family agents and nonfamily agents should carefully consider these issues for supporting the ELLs' growth as a social being and stimulating their second language literacy development. Otherwise, it may be difficult for them to become a good social being as a minority in the mainstream classroom. Also, parents need to be educated in terms of ethnic identity and ethnocentrism, because the results of this study showed their ignorance in these areas. The parents assumed they were already aware of these issues, but the study showed a huge gap between their beliefs and the reality of certain concepts.

The ELLs in this study had multiple identities with their strong ethnic identity. Gee (1999) said, "Discourses are ways of being in the world, or forms of life which integrates words, acts, values, beliefs, attitudes, and social identities, as well as gestures, glances, body positions, and clothes" (p. 127). This study showed their multiple identities with a strong ethnic identity. However, their identity shifted for various reasons. As the ELLs talked, interacted, wrote, and dialogued with others as well as the texts in the social context, they grew and changed and were recognized by others.

Meanwhile, family agents and nonfamily agents should be aware of instilling in ELLs an appreciation of various languages, cultures, and cultural value systems. We as educators should guide ELLs to bring their cultural strengths and share them with others



in mainstream classroom. ELLs might need to have a discussion of the differences and similarities among different languages, cultures, and societies to be critical thinkers.

In the same sense, Hall (1996) explained that identities are transforming processes of “becoming rather than being: not ‘who we are’ or ‘where we came from,’ so much as what we might become, how we have been represented and how that bears on how we might represent ourselves” (p. 4). Identity shifts and transforms in language use, attitude, values, and beliefs in social contexts. Miller (2000) extended Gee’s (1999) ideas to understand identity, language use, and social interaction.

Much research has investigated culturally and nonculturally relevant materials to enhance ELLs’ curriculum. One of the main reasons the culturally relevant materials are more effective and efficient for ELLs relates to their ethnic identity.

#### English Language Learners’ Responses to Reading Literacy:

##### Culturally Relevant or Nonculturally Relevant

The results of the study demonstrated that the text itself leads the reader toward a self-active processing. Individual experience was the sum of this transaction and the continuous processing of this transaction is the increasing enlargement of experience. ELLs responded somewhat differently depending on the texts while meaning making. As I already explored in chapter 4, they used different strategies depending on the texts while comprehending stories. This section describes how ELLs responded to reading culturally and nonculturally relevant stories written in English.

Flores-Duenas (1997) explored four Mexican students’ second language reading based on culturally and nonculturally relevant stories. Her finding was that culturally familiar literature for 5<sup>th</sup> grade Mexican students in the regular classroom empowered

students and provided a means to invite students to read other literature. There were considerable differences compared with the Flores-Duenas study. Her participants were 5<sup>th</sup> graders, while participants in this study are mainly 2<sup>nd</sup> graders. Also, participants in this study were from various cultures including Japan, Korea, Mexico, and Sweden, compared to Flores-Duenas' participants who were Mexican students.

Reading stories is an event occurring at a particular time in a particular environment at a particular moment in the life history of the reader (Rosenblatt, 1978). Rosenblatt accounted for the two different kinds of reading: the efferent and aesthetic forms of reading. The differences between these two forms of reading are based on the degree of dialogue between the reader and the text, and dependent on that degree, ELLs encountered meaning construction and they understood and transacted with stories.

My questions went deeper to understand the way ELLs responded to culturally and nonculturally relevant stories during meaning making in a literacy event through verbal protocols. The results of the study showed that they made meaning based on what they already knew and what connection it had to them. (See chapter 5.) They successfully connected themselves with their background and cultural knowledge, connected to the text and connected to their world knowledge. All the concepts they considered through the study were related to their cultural and background knowledge, experiences, and preferences. Also, they placed themselves firmly in the center of their meaning making.

Culturally relevant materials make available strong aesthetic lived-through experiences (Rosenblatt, 1978). For example, Lilly identified strongly with *Family Pictures*, a culturally relevant story for her. She remembered her personal experiences, a fair and a birthday party, from Mexico. She showed her enthusiasm in explaining these

events. Especially, her eyes were sparkling when she explained her birthday party at her grandmother's house in Mexico. She said, "I had same party in my grandmother's house. I had piñata." She started singing a song while hitting the piñata. This engagement gave her motivation to read the story and retell the story very nicely. She was very interested in the book format as well. The book was formatted with two languages, Spanish and English. She wanted to be an author in the future, and wanted to write a book using a format with two languages. She thought this format would be helpful for other ELLs in the future.

The ELLs in this study also connected with nonculturally relevant materials using their efferent stance (Rosenblatt, 1978), generally used to obtain new information and knowledge. For example, Kyle and Jae-min were strongly engaged while reading two Christopher Columbus stories. They explained that these texts were helpful to obtain new information about Christopher Columbus's history, which they studied in social studies class. Kyle recognized that *Follow the Dream* was very informative. They identified so strongly with these stories that they recommended the two stories to their peers and they spent a great deal of time dialoguing with the stories.

### *Culturally Relevant Stories*

#### *Interaction With the Text*

The ELLs' verbal reports in this study showed various responses while reading culturally and nonculturally relevant stories. I include culture and cultural experiences into the category of culturally relevant stories. While reading culturally relevant stories, they developed their self-esteem and competence because of their rich prior knowledge. The ELLs mostly used aesthetic stances while reading culturally relevant stories. Their

cultural knowledge stimulated their motivation and interest to read and comprehend the stories. Kyle, Jae-min, and Lilly showed great enthusiasm while reading culturally relevant stories. Jae-min enjoyed reading *Woodcutter and Tiger Brother*; Kyle enjoyed *Passage to Freedom*; and Lilly and Yanton identified strongly with *I Hate English*. Also, Lilly was very taken with *Family Pictures*. Yanton read *Pettson and Findus* with a positive attitude.

The ELLs understood two types of culturally relevant stories: These types are stories that include characters and events from their ethnic background and stories that include experiences similar to those they had gone through. The first group of materials consisted of *Woodcutter and Tiger Brother*, a Korean folk tale with traditional illustrations; *Passage to Freedom*, a story with a Japanese hero about World War II and a less-known piece of Japanese history; *Pettson and Findus*, a Swedish story of an old man and his cat; and *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes*, a Japanese version of Cinderella. The second group of books consisted of *I Hate English* and *Family Pictures*. Culturally relevant stories were observed as powerful materials for ELLs to utilize their various strategies.

Reading culturally relevant stories also revealed how the ELLs' use different strategies compared to reading nonculturally relevant stories. They used various socioaffective strategies such as interest and motivation, social interaction, and emotion and feeling to a high degree. Also, schema strategies including connections to self, intertextuality, and connection to the world were used highly and frequently. Cultural background knowledge especially empowered the ELLs, and they felt more comfortable and safer in the social context while reading culturally familiar materials.

### *Making Connections to Prior Knowledge*

Reading culturally relevant stories stimulated the ELLs to integrate prior cultural knowledge and first language literacy skills into their second language learning. Knowing the content of the stories empowered and comforted them while reading in the social context. They understood and transacted with the texts well, although they were at a different stage of English proficiency. Familiarity with culture was a very strong advantage for them, especially for a beginner ELL, to improve self-confidence, self-esteem, and feelings of safety in the social context. It also supported engagement in the literacy event.

For example, Yanton was very much an English beginner in reading stories when he entered this study. When I first met him, he had a hard time reading a couple of words at a time. Thus, his mother had to translate for me what he was thinking while reading the stories. In his third verbal protocol, his mother brought a book related to Swedish culture to do her own research. His facial expression showed me his enthusiasm and excitement in reading *Pettson and Findus*. He voluntarily wrote a reading response after reading the story. He wanted to explain the story to me. He showed his competence and confidence in explaining the story. His knowledge of the culture made a great difference in his attitude while reading stories.

### *Ownership*

The ELLs in this study were eager to share the culturally relevant stories with their peers in the classroom. They wanted to show their willingness and ability to read stories. They were engaged in the aesthetic stance while reading these stories. They wanted to develop advocacy in their community, and they wanted to use their ownership

of these stories to do this. They were willing to retell the stories after reading them. For example, Lilly started singing the piñata song while reading *Family Pictures* despite her quiet and shy personality. Furthermore, taking ownership, their tone of voice got stronger while explaining their own culture and cultural experiences to me. Lilly and Yanton thought it would be very nice if their friends understood them, asking other students to read *I Hate English*. The ownership of knowledge of content may support the beginner ELLs in building their ownership in the classroom.

### *Making Connections*

The ELLs made many connections, including connections to self, connections to the texts, and connections to the world. Making connections was central to the ELLs. The text had to make connections with them to be meaningful. Jae-min and Kyle, who had high English proficiency linked to their personal preferences or experiences, whereas Lilly and Yanton made connections to their culture and cultural experiences. In addition, Jae-min and Kyle made meaning and evaluated stories based on their ethnic identity. They made connections to their first language learning experience while reading for second language literacy. Notably, Yanton made good linkages from his first language literacy skills to second language reading.

### *Inferring Meaning*

Jae-min inferred meaning based on his cultural background. Jae-min liked *Woodcutter and Tiger Brother* because of the story's content and illustrations. He also addressed *be nice to your parent*. This concept is related to Bong-Yang, a strong cultural concept discussed in chapter 4. In Korea, all offspring are expected to serve their parents when they grow up. He inferred the concept from his cultural values while reading this

culturally relevant story. He also made good inferences while reading *Follow the Dream*. He made a nice story about Christopher Columbus's youth by inferring from the text. Kyle inferred the route of Cinderella stories based on his ethnocentrism.

Lilly and Yanton showed similarities in their reading responses while reading *I Hate English*. However, there were considerable differences among the ELLs. Each of the ELLs had not only a different cultural background and background knowledge, but they also had unique characters based on their English proficiency and cultural orientation.

#### *Recounting Information*

I asked the ELLs to summarize and synthesize the stories after each reading. If they were involved in the reading, they summarized and synthesized nicely. Their degree of engagement while reading the stories showed when they recounted the information. Jae-min and Kyle neglected to comprehend *Mei Ping and the Silver Shoes* because of their ethnocentric filter system. This system kept them from engaging in the story. On the other hand, Yanton voluntarily wrote a response after reading *Pettson and Findus*. It was very nicely done, demonstrating his high degree of engagement in the story.

#### *Motivation and Interest*

The ELLs' emotions resided in their own cultures or countries; they still missed their friends and relatives. This emotion motivated them to read culturally relevant stories, remembering their culture, first language, and cultural experiences. I watched their eyes sparkle while retelling the culturally relevant stories. For example, Yanton's motivation was very tangible as he retold *Pettson and Findus*. The ELLs were motivated to read materials that included their schema knowledge and personal experiences. Lilly's

motivation and excitement were very touching while reading *Family Pictures*, as she remembered her experiences with her father.

#### *Identifying with the Author*

After reading *I Hate English*, Lilly and Yanton thought the author had an experience similar to what they had been through in coming to the United States without knowing the language. Yanton and Lilly understood the author's intention and purpose. They realized that other people are having experiences like theirs. This understanding of commonality supported them and made them feel safer.

#### *Connecting with Characters; Mei Mei, Lilly, and Yanton*

Lilly and Yanton transformed Mei Mei's feeling to themselves while reading *I Hate English*. They evoked their special experiences through reading this special and unique story. Yanton and Lilly transacted with Mei Mei while reading the story. Yanton said, "She couldn't speak English and she wanted to come home to Hong Kong" (P 6; 43). From their aesthetic stance, they truly understood how Mei Mei felt and her struggle. Lilly showed her excitement when Mei Mei started speaking English, just as she had. She expressed her excitement with it, "Because then she starts speaking English" (P10; 500). They felt the same as Mei Mei, were having transaction with Mei Mei.

#### *Error and Mistakes*

The ELLs in this study were well aware of their errors and mistakes while using their second language. For example, Lilly frequently showed her English usage errors while talking to me, mixing *he* and *she* and *yes* and *no*. For example, when I asked whether she liked the grandmother's ideas, she answered "no" (P11; 69) when she meant



“yes.” Ms. Green also mentioned that Jae-min showed his confusion a few times despite his English fluency.

Lilly also explained her confusion between English and Spanish. She was aware of differences between the two languages. She understood her problems with reading in English. Her judgment of her own language proficiency was related to her pronunciation. For example, she said of her mispronunciations, “Because I can’t read really good. Like even if I know a word, I pronounce it wrong” (P13; 289). She was concerned about her mispronunciation throughout the study. Interestingly, Spanish had more similarities with English than the other languages in this study, Korean, Japanese, and Swedish. However, Lilly considered herself at a disadvantage because of her Spanish while learning English as a second language. Jae-min, Kyle, and Yanton did not address any confusion between their first languages and English. Perhaps because the differences are so great, they did not expect a relationship between the two languages at all. However, Yanton did mention that he had learned how to read in Swedish. The first language learning experience helped him to learn English better and faster. Ms. Green told me that ELLs who had mastered a first language have knowledge of how to learn a second language and understand the relationships between symbols and abstracts of meaning.

#### *Using First Language Skills*

Lilly used her first language skills despite her claims of confusion between the two languages. Yanton showed his first language skills while reading for second language literacy. He identified the main ideas and determined the importance of reading nicely, although he was a beginner ELL. I saw how he used his first language literacy

skills to enhance his second language reading. He also summarized stories briefly but nicely, and he knew how to use rhetoric strategies in reading stories.

### *Nonculturally Relevant Stories*

#### *Interaction With the Text*

The participants interacted with the text, focusing their dialogue on information-driven texts. The choice of text depended on their level of English proficiency and experiences and responses varied depending on their comprehension of stories. They interacted with the text and identified the content and genres of the stories and the author's purpose. They were motivated to comprehend the stories and engaged in self-lessons after reading. They were also aware of the levels of text. Jae-min and Kyle preferred chapter books to the easier books. They used their cognition to comprehend nonculturally relevant stories. The proficient readers, Jae-min and Kyle, were engaged in reading these nonculturally relevant stories, but Lilly and Yanton were struggling to comprehend any story and were unsuccessful in developing much critical thinking.

#### *Awareness of Level of Texts*

The ELLs often discussed and addressed the level of the books. Jae-min and Kyle wanted to read chapter books rather than picture books. They enjoyed reading the more challenging stories. They felt more competent as readers while reading chapter books.

The ELLs were mostly very cautious on the level of the books they read. They evaluated themselves as good readers if they could read chapter books. Lilly mentioned that she is a good reader in Spanish but not in English because she could not read chapter books in English, "Because I can't read a chapter book. In Spanish I can but in English I

can't" (P13; 293). It was clear that they preferred to read chapter books because it improved their self-esteem.

Reading chapter books was very meaningful to them. For example, Jae-min said, "It better be a chapter book" (P3; 309). He and Kyle were willing to read chapter books, recognizing themselves as good readers. Also, they were proud of themselves, increasing their self-esteem. Jae-min and Kyle were very discouraged when they read books at an easier level than their reading level. They specifically addressed the importance of the level of a book. They were also excited to read stories that challenged them. As mentioned earlier, they could also better imagine when they read chapter books. This finding has strong implication for educators. They should always maintain high expectations for ELLs.

The level of a book stimulated their motivation, interest, self-esteem, and confidence. The ELLs also included the length the book and its level of vocabulary in evaluating the level of a book. Jae-min and Kyle were especially excited to read chapter books for the extra challenge and for the confidence it gave them.

### *Topic Preferences*

The topics of a book were related to their preferences and supported or undermined the ELLs' engagement in reading. They each had their favorite topics. For example, Jae-min liked the Dragon topic. Jae-min and Kyle were very interested in reading their personal preferences and interests, such as dragon stories, adventure stories, or Japanese cultural books. Lilly and Yanton associated with culturally relevant stories such as *I Hate English*. They identified strongly with stories that were related to their cultural knowledge, personal interests, and experiences. While retelling stories, all the

children were willing to make any connections to other topics, such as sports, animals, or dragons. For example, Jae-min liked to make connections to a “dragon story” while retelling stories. Kyle was very interested in history and adventure, as expressed by his engagement in reading the two versions of Christopher Columbus.

#### *Author’s Intention and Purpose*

Jae-min and Kyle were challenged while reading the two versions of Christopher Columbus from different perspectives. Through dialogue with themselves and the two texts, they extended their understanding of the author’s intention and purpose. Jae-min expressed different author’s intentions and attitudes while reading the two stories.

#### *Avoiding Mistakes and Errors*

The ELLs tried to avoid mistakes and errors while reading. They paused while reading if they could not understand words or meaning. Sometimes they used other words or sounded out a word in a very low tone, so that the audience could not hear their mispronunciation. Lilly was strongly aware of her English pronunciation. Yanton frequently showed his avoidance of errors. He sometimes looked to me or his mother for help. However, he was very upset if his mother helped more than he wanted. He wanted to show his competence in reading.

#### *Requesting Support From Family or Peers*

Lilly and Yanton requested assistance during and after reading if they were faced with challenges or difficulties. They did not use their prior knowledge because the content of the stories was new to them. They often stopped reading and looked to me or their mother for assistance. Kyle explained his challenge while reading *Encounter* because he did not understand the meaning of *encounter*. He asked his mother to explain

the word. However, they obviously preferred to have support from friends rather than from family members.

### *Identifying the Text Style*

The ELLs showed their interest in identifying the text. Jae-min and Kyle identified the text style while reading nonculturally relevant stories. Kyle recognized the importance of informative stories such as *Follow the Dream*. He said *Follow the Dream* is a very good book for children to learn from. He also recommended *Encounter* as a good fiction story.

Jae-min identified *Woodcutter and Tiger Brother* as a Korean traditional folk tale. He made connections between this story and another story of the genre, based on his background knowledge of the genre. Lilly showed her interest in the dual-language format while reading *Family Pictures*. She mentioned that this format might help ELLs like her. She showed how to use the format and its advantages. She wanted to write a book in the future using this format for other ELLs.

### *Discussion*

I examined the ELLs' practice of cognition throughout the study. They were very interested in culturally relevant stories as well as nonculturally relevant stories. My assumption had been that culturally relevant stories would be much more interesting to them than nonculturally relevant stories, but they identified with both differently, but critically. The results of the study indicate that the ELLs' associations with culturally and nonculturally relevant stories depended on their experiences in the United States as well as their English proficiency.

The beginner ELLs associated more with culturally relevant stories, whereas the proficient readers associated with both story types to a high degree. Jae-min and Kyle opened their modes to use their strategies for comprehending stories. They used more cognitive and metacognitive strategies during and after reading nonculturally relevant stories. The ELLs also used different modes and strategies depending on the materials. It was very interesting to see their use and application of the strategies. For example, they used schema strategies while reading culturally relevant stories, but they used inference, questioning, and monitoring strategies while reading nonculturally relevant stories.

Therefore, before we as educators prepare curriculum for ELLs, we should answer the following questions for ourselves. “Who are they?” “What value system do they have?” “What historical and cultural background do they have?” “What language proficiency levels do they have?” This is the first commitment to reaching them. However, for beginner ELLs, culturally relevant materials should be encouraged for them to develop their content competence, self-esteem, motivation, and interest by using their prior knowledge. Using various cultural materials is also recommended for other students in the classroom context. Yanton mentioned that he wanted to let his peers read *I Hate English* to share his feelings and experiences from when he could not speak English. He thought that his friends would support him better if they had a chance to learn and to understand his experience. Sharing experiences through literacy activities is a very meaningful task, and it should be recommended to educators. Building up advocacy in the community is an important topic for ELLs. They are better involved in their tasks in a safer environment. To coordinate better curriculum for meaningful tasks for ELLs and their peers, the understating of ELLs’ learning context should be put forward to educators.

According to R. T. Vacca (1988), positioning is shaped by differences among people, including race, ethnicity, class, gender, ability, age, language use, and religion. The constructs of identity (Gee, 2002) and subjectivity are important in literacy and language and can influence how people are positioned as well as their access to further literacy and language learning.

According to Smith (1997), good readers activate prior knowledge of the text topic by imagining what they know and do not know about the topic, predicting what the text will be about, and generating questions the text might answer. Reader-response theory (Rosenblatt, 1978), with its clear focus on readers, has had a profound influence on the way many researchers and teachers approach students' interactions with literature. The work of Rosenblatt has been especially influential in helping us to understand the various stances readers may take in relation to texts. The ELLs ranged on a continuum from reading solely for the purpose of gaining information to immersing themselves in the story world for a lived-through experience.

## Second Language Literacy Development

### *Review of Second Language Reading Process*

As discussed in chapter 2, to better understand the second language literacy process, the second language reading processes of this study were theoretically derived from schema theory (Rumelhart, 1980), intertextuality (Hartman, 1995), reader response theory (Rosenblatt, 1978), dialogic discourse (Bakhtin, 1986), and critical literacy (Freire, 1970). These five theoretical second language reading processes are explored in chapters 5 and 6 through the findings of the study. Schema theory was investigated through the verbal protocols in chapter 5. As Carrell (1987, 1988) and Steffensen (1982) discussed in

exploring the use of cultural content and the role of schema theory in second language learning, ELLs in this study used schema theory in various ways while making meaning from the text. For example, they made connections to self, within the text, and to world knowledge using their schema strategies. As beginner ELLs, Lilly and Yanton made strong connections to their cultural knowledge and cultural experiences while reading stories. The ELLs' complex set of cognitive structures clarified information about events and the contents of the story easily using their schema strategies (Anderson, R. C., 1994; Rumelhart, 1980). This was confirmed through Jae-min's and Kyle's verbal reports. They comprehended the content of the story, comparing and contrasting their pre-existing knowledge in acquiring new information. Furthermore, they constructed meaning critically.

Intertextuality (Hartman, 1995) was observed through Jae-min's and Kyle's verbal reports. The ELLs made strong connections among stories while reading. Three types of textual resource locations were observed during the study: primary endogenous, secondary endogenous, and exogenous (Hartman, 1995). Jae-min and Kyle made connections between stories by openly considering and constructing meaning through various sources. The beginner ELLs, Lilly and Yanton, made very linear exogenous linkages from each story's content to their cultural knowledge. As mentioned in chapter 5, the results of the study were slightly different from Hartman's. He evaluated the reader identified as Diane as *a resistant reader* based on her exogenous linkages to textual resources in his study. My findings indicated that Lilly, who mostly used exogenous textual resource, did indeed follow the author's intention and purpose while reading.



Rosenblatt's (1978) reader response theory was clearly observed throughout the study. (See chapters 5, 6, and 7.) Beginner ELLs, Lilly and Yanton transformed Mei Mei's feelings to themselves while reading *I Hate English*. They become Mei Mei. Lilly and Yanton transacted with this story with an *aesthetic stance* through their *lived-thought experiences* (Rosenblatt, 1978). Kyle and Jae-min identified with *Follow the Dream* with an *effluent stance*, but transacted with *Encounter* from an *aesthetic stance* based on reader's engagement.

While reading the two versions of Christopher Columbus, Jae-min and Kyle demonstrated strong *dialogic discourse* (Bakhtin, 1986) through their verbal protocols. (See chapters 5 and 7.) Jae-min and Kyle dialogued by themselves (an earlier and a later self; Bakhtin, 1986) and with the text in their understating of two different perspectives of the same historical event. They identified *Follow the Dream* as a very informative and true history and *Encounter* as a well-written story, identifying with the boy in the story. Jae-min concluded that the two versions of Christopher Columbus stemmed from the author's intentions and supported the authors' different purposes. Kyle's dialogue indicated that he associated with *Follow the Dream*, emphasizing Columbus's discovery. However, while reading *Encounter*, he dialoged, "they shouldn't come without permission." Bakhtin's (1986) dialogic discourse was embedded into the study as I analyzed the data and reconstructed the participants' voices in the study.

The ELLs had culturally and historically different backgrounds and cultural knowledge. The ELLs associated with culturally and nonculturally relevant stories significantly. Critical literacy (Freire, 1970) was observed through the study. Jae-min and Kyle become "rewriters" after reading the two versions of Christopher Columbus,

making a determined effort not to betray the author's spirit. Overall, the theories of second language reading processes were clearly seen in my study.

The results of the study showed second language literacy development comprehensively. In order to describe second language literacy development in a holistic view, I discuss five themes: (a) reading process in oral language development, (b) second language learning development and the capable peer's support, (c) second language learning development, (d) literacy as dialogue, and (e) reading as a thinking process.

### *Reading Process in Oral Language Development*

My data stimulated a discussion of the interrelationship between second language literacy and oral language development. When I interviewed my participants' parents and their teachers, I had profound answers to my inquiry related to second language literacy development. In the research, there was a positive relationship between second language literacy development and oral language development in one study with 1<sup>st</sup> grade Hispanic ELLs (Lara, 1991). C. E. Snow (1991) studied this relationship from kindergarten through 8<sup>th</sup> grade and found a positive relationship as well. However, Devine (1987) and Carrell (1991) did not find any significant relationship between the two.

Carrell (1991) concluded that there is an overall strong positive relationship between ESL reading proficiency and ESL oral proficiency and between ESL and native-language reading. An understanding of second language oral development could be extended to second language reading process. Devine (1987), on the other hand, did not find any significant relationship between the two. Guarino and Perkins (1986) also addressed awareness of parts of speech in relationship to ESL reading comprehension after conducting their research with 35 participants and six different native languages.

In the interviews, Lilly's and Yanton's mothers demonstrated the issues of their children's second language development processes. They both said that their children began speaking English in complete sentences rather than in choppy words.

Yanton's mother also said,

No he isn't but I think he tries not only a one word, he waited until he could say a whole sentence. I think again therefore he wants to do everything perfect. He waited until he could say a whole sentence. (p.11)

Lilly's mother concurred.

The represented data showed that ELLs knew the language structure and the functions of language. They also knew complete sentences, because they had already mastered their first language skills. It was difficult for them to use choppy words because of their knowledge of language structure. Yanton worried that his friends might laugh at his English. Lilly and Yanton naturally became silent, refusing to speak English instead of speaking in choppy words.

Therefore, they had a silent period without speaking English in a social context. Igoa (1995) explained the silent period with "In the silent stage, immigrant children may appear to be retiring, moody, fearful, even terrified" (p. 38), and emphasized that the silent period is not a negative period. In fact, it might have advantages. She mentioned, "While some students are trapped in helpless silence by inability to communicate in the dominant language, they become insightful observers of their own human condition and of life around them" (p. 38). Lilly and Yanton became very good observers, integrating their first language knowledge into second language learning.

Igoa (1995) regarded the silent stage as

a period of incubation during which the child must be provided with a warm and nurturing environment that makes it safe for him or her eventually to break out of a shell as well as to accept himself or herself as belonging to a diverse society.  
(p. 38)

She emphasized that the psychological traumas of uprooting are less visible and less easily measured than the child's language proficiency, using the example of transplanting plants from one place to another. Shock occurs in the plants, it happens similarly to children where they experience a degree of shock in a new culture and new language. She explained the silent period as coming from the culture shock, indicating the uprooting phenomenon.

This silent period could be very different for each ELL based on his or her personality, knowledge of language structure, and social environment. The data indicated that they wanted more assistance from peers than from the teacher. After they felt safer, they began talking to peers. However, they were still aware of peers' responses; negative responses such as laughing at their English would cause a longer period of silence.

The second language learners who were in 2<sup>nd</sup> grade already had strong cognition of their first language; they knew the general language structure and function. Their self-esteem did not allow them to speak with choppy words. They already had the self-esteem and confidence of a fluent first language speaker; they wanted to speak perfect sentences. However, they had not mastered the second language yet; they got more frustrated and felt less safe. Reading and oral language proficiency were very connected and reinforced each other. Practicing or using words and language that they acquired in reading activities for oral language contexts could be one means to improve their second language development.

### *Second Language Learning Development and the Capable Peer's Support*

Lilly's and Yanton's mothers pointed out the period of the peer's language support for the newcomer in the class. Four periods clearly emerged from the study: the dependent period (when the ELL needs peer language support), the preindependent period, the independent period (when the ELL needs little peer language support), and the cooperative period. For example, when Yanton came to the new class, there was a boy named Simon from Sweden. He supported Yanton, because Yanton could not speak a word of English. The teacher asked Simon to support Yanton. Yanton's mother said,

The first month they did because Yanton depended on Simon and he wanted to be with him all the time because he didn't know what the other kids say. So he asked Simon and Simon translated but I guess it was too much for him, for Simon to take care of Yanton and do his work. (YM- 6)

However, Simon got frustrated with taking care of Yanton and doing his own work; it was not easy for a 3<sup>rd</sup> grader. At that point the teacher separated them after a month.

Yanton's mother explained that the separation helped Yanton to become independent in his work. Yanton's mother said,

No I spoke with Yanton's teacher and she told me that she felt the same way. So she separated them and put Yanton like right in front of her in the classroom and Simon in the back. And after that it was much better for Yanton, I guess, because he had to depend on himself. (YM-6)

In the beginning, Yanton's mother was nearby to give him safety and an environmental boundary. However, she tried to not to be in the classroom very often to let him be independent in his class. This worked and he made friends and became independent.

Ms. Green imparted a similar story of Lilly's learning experience. When Lilly came to the class, they had a girl named Alvida who was from Mexico. Alvida supported

Lilly in translation between Spanish and English. Ms. Green said, “Alvida would translate for Lilly.... But then Alvida left in November, which caused Lilly to really have to focus more. She had to learn English because there wasn’t anybody here to translate for her” (MG-3). When Alvida’s family moved to another state, Lilly had to communicate by herself without Alvida’s support. Lilly needed to be independent to communicate with peers and the teacher. She faced the need to learn English to communicate as well as to learn the subject matter.

Ms. Green explained that the change in Lilly’s learning progress was very visible.

Now she’s just telling all sorts of stories. She’s writing in English, which she was not doing in English before. She was writing her stories in Spanish and then we would translate them and then she would rewrite them in English. (MG-3)

The same story came from Yanton’s mother; “Yeah he had to speak. Because when he didn’t have Simon” (YM-6). He had to communicate with others without the support of his capable peers. His mother added, “He was afraid that the other kids would laugh at him if he said the wrong words” (YM-6). The teacher said, “Just try. I don’t think the other kids would laugh at you” (MG-4).

The results of the study showed that the ELLs usually passed through four periods of the learning process in the ZPD when they came to a new culture without knowing the local language: *dependent period*, *preindependent period*, *independent period*, and *cooperative period*.

#### *Dependent Period*

The ELLs with no experience in the local language generally started in a dependent mode. During this period, the ELLs benefited from the support of a capable

peer who could speak their first language. This support greatly enhanced the comfort and feelings of safety in the new environment.

#### *Preindependent Period*

After a certain period (3 to 4 months in this study), they benefited from being separated from the capable peer's language support by a physical distance in the same class. In this period, the ELLs move toward developing their own scaffolding from what they had learned toward what they need to know. When ELLs realize this need to follow up with their tasks in a meaningful environment by themselves, they are motivated to practice their second language literacy. It offers them a chance to accelerate their language learning process and stimulates their motivation to learn. They also feel safer with the capable peer's presence in the same room. However, during this period, the ELLs interact with other peers frequently and the teacher more frequently to follow up on their tasks.

#### *Independent Period*

They become independent successfully. They do not need to have language support from the capable peer, because they are able to communicate with others. They have capable peers for each particular task within a group work. This becomes cooperative learning. They feel safer and more comfortable working tasks by themselves at this stage.

#### *Cooperative Period*

This is the final level for the ELLs. They interact and work with capable peers for each learning task in a cooperation mode. They become independent from language support. As they become capable peers, they are able to support others in doing tasks.

ELLs need to have concrete peer support in the language learning process. We have to consider these four stages from the stage in which they seek assistance to the stage in which they are independent as a capable peer to assist other beginner ELLs. They need to be immersed and they need exposure to comprehensible input. If they have constant assistance, they will be less motivated to practice and may not progress. The implication of this discussion is that educators need to understand the four periods of getting assistance to developing independence to becoming a capable peer for others. Educators can consider this matter and apply it to manage or organize their classroom arrangement for ELLs.

### *Second Language Learning Development*

Second language learning development was explored throughout the study. Lilly's and Yanton's cases presented good examples of the learning process. Their second language learning development could be highlighted within four development stages: the *babying stage*, the *peer interaction stage*, the *silent stage*, and the *full sentence stage*.

#### *Babying Stage*

The first stage was the babying stage. Lilly's mother recounted an interesting story of Lilly's experience in her first period class. She said, "Lily was a little scared, but all the little girls kind of adopted her and they all babied her and because she's so small also, she's shorter. And her language. They all treated her like a little baby" (LM-4). Ms. Green's explanation was similar to Lilly's mother's explanation. Lilly's mother explained that Lilly was very assertive and sure of herself before she came to America. However, she noticed Lilly's regressive behaviors after she started at the new school in the United



States. She said, “But when I heard her at school with her friends and she would go, (squeaky baby voice) like a little baby” (LM-4).

Like a baby, Lilly regressed because of her language proficiency. Lilly’s mother said, “They mothered her. I think she just felt younger again” (LM-4). Lilly started answering like a baby. She added, “It was funny and I noticed it at very times.” Ms. Green confirmed this and said that she was going to talk to the girls and tell them not to baby her anymore, because her whole role at school was like a baby, as if she were the youngest. “And she was acting much younger than she normally does. Because of the language” (LM-3). That was a very interesting stage in the language development process. Notably, Lilly was a girl; her gender role influenced her language development and vice versa with other girls’ responses to her. Interestingly, Yanton did not show this stage in his second language literacy development. I noticed that he was a boy and a 3<sup>rd</sup> grader in a 2<sup>nd</sup>-grade classroom.

### *Silent Stage*

The silent stage took place for four months (August, September, October, and November) in Lilly’s case. Lilly’s mother remembered that she did not speak for all of December. As discussed earlier, Lilly and Yanton had background knowledge of the structure of a full sentence. They could not just say *water* to get a glass of water. They already had knowledge of language structure such as *Could I have a glass of water?* The main reason Lilly and Yanton went through a silent period was their background knowledge of language structure. They avoided speaking in choppy words to express their thoughts because they were already able to distinguish between full sentences and choppy words. They may feel hopeless of ever catching up in subject matter or belonging

to the classroom, as in culture shock and language shock. However, they became good observers in the silent period as Igoa (1995) predicted. Lilly's mother said, "She didn't really even speak at all until like December. She wasn't speaking. I didn't hear her speaking and then over vacation—And she just started talking and speaking and saying all kinds of things" (LM-5). Lilly went through her silent period listening intently. Her mother added, "She was like silent. She wouldn't speak to anybody in English" (LM-36). She remembered Lilly's silent period exactly. When Lilly had received enough comprehensible input from peers and the teacher and felt safer, she began speaking English. Yanton went through the same process as Lilly in this stage. In his explanation, he was afraid of speaking wrong and aware of peers' responses. He declined to speak English until he could get it right.

#### *Full Sentence Stage*

It did not take a long period for Lilly to produce full sentences in English. Lilly's mother said,

She comes out with full complete sentences, conditional sentences, she makes the same mistakes that I hear normal native speaker kids making. So I mean I hear all the other kids, they don't conjugate verbs perfectly either. She was silent but then she started speaking complete sentences. Not choppy sentences. (LM-36)

Lilly's mother was surprised that her speaking in English was full sentences instead of choppy words.

Lilly's mother was wondering how she was able to produce full sentence without practicing choppy words first. Her second language development might be understood relative to her native language proficiency. The ELLs' background knowledge of language structure stopped them from using choppy words. Infants do not have any

concepts of the full structure of language. If they say, “water,” it could be meant to say, “Could I have a glass of water?” However, Lilly and Yanton knew the difference between “Water” and “Could I have glass of water?” Their cognitive and metacognitive knowledge stopped them from saying “Water” instead of “Could I have a glass of water?” Also, saying incomplete sentences would affect their self-esteem. Lilly’s mother added, “Well because she has the capacity to understand the complex sentences from her own language. She has a certain language level in her own language. She had the whole idea she wanted to express” (LM-36).

Lilly’s mother believed that she learned English fast because of her immersion in context. She thought, “She needed to be immersed in the language enough to where she felt she thought she could produce it. But she produced like complete sentences” (LM-36). Ms. Green explained Lilly’s language learning process in her classroom.

She definitely understood what they were saying, but I don’t think the confidence level was there. And then all of a sudden—in fact when she did start talking, it was complete sentences. She just started talking and would say a complete sentence and we were just like; “You said it in a complete sentence.” So it was very exciting and her mom even said it. It was just like over night, she just—it was just like, “boom.” (MG-7)

Lilly had waited until she was confident enough to speak her second language using her first language skills. Her first language skills made her stay in the silent stage, but it reinforced her speaking complete sentences after she got enough comprehensible input from her interaction with her peers and teacher. Also, her first language skills supported her developing the second language skills.

Table 8

*Comparison and Contrast of Lilly's and Yanton's Second Language Development Process*

| Stages              | Lilly | Yanton |
|---------------------|-------|--------|
| Babying stage       | O     | X      |
| Silent stage        | O     | O      |
| Full sentence stage | O     | O      |

O: The stage was observed through the participant's language learning process

X: The stage was not observed through the participant's language learning process

Lilly went through three language learning stages, the babying stage, the silent stage, and the full sentence stage. However, Yanton did not exhibit the babying stage. I assumed this was because he was a 3<sup>rd</sup>-grade boy in the 2<sup>nd</sup>-graders' classroom.

*Sociocultural Constructivism Through the Study*

As the basis for this study, the sociocultural perspective was a valuable lens through which to view the second language literacy process in its sociocultural context. This perspective was very useful in investigating the complexity of ELLs' second language literacy with various cultural backgrounds and first languages.

The results of the study showed that ELLs interacted and dialogued with peers and the teacher within the ZPD. This perspective helped me to understand not only the context of the interaction and dialogues among ELLs, peers, and the teacher, but also the interaction between the reader and the text. For example, the ELLs' second language learning development as well as the capable peers' support (see chapter 7) were observed within this perspective. The results of the study indicated that the ELLs felt safer and

built up their scaffolding easily and successfully when they had capable support from peers, the teacher, and family in context. They also learned their second language successfully in the immersion context with plenty of comprehensible input (Krashen, 1985). The results of the study indicated that ELLs who were immersed in the context learned English in efficient and effective ways.

The sociocultural perspective in meaning making was critical to the study, because ELLs made meaning while reading stories based on their sociocultural and historical background. The results of the study indicated that the ELLs comprehended and evaluated stories based on their sociocultural values and perspectives. The study indicated that the ELLs' meaning making could be critically associated, but might be hampered by their sociocultural values. *The* ethnocentric filter system was observed from this viewpoint. Jae-min's and Kyle's verbal reports indicated how they comprehended the stories based on their own ethnocentric filter systems.

Jae-min identified with *Woodcutter and Tiger Brother*, but he claimed Woodcutter's lie in the content of the story, although he strongly associated with the concept of Bong-Yang while reading the story. The sociocultural perspective was very practical in understanding the ELL's meaning construction throughout the study. It showed that, within a sociocultural perspective, literacy became a cultural practice and product of cultural activity.

### *Literacy as a Dialogue*

I examined reading as a dialogue in chapter 3. Throughout the study, I confirmed reading as a dialogue. As mentioned in chapter 2, Bakhtin (1986) explored how dialogue could be external, between two persons, or internal, between one's earlier thoughts and

later thought. Rosenblatt (1978) emphasized the active reader who responds to the text with external and internal responses.

In fact, Kyle and Jae-min dialogued with themselves, with the characters, and with the authors. Reading could be considered a dialogue, a way to understand, respond, and interact with text in a context. As Bakhtin (1986) expressed, dialogue is an embedded natural stance of cultural and political communication. Reading begins with dialoguing with the text to some degree, depending on one's cultural background, personal experiences, and background knowledge.

Lilly and Yanton dialogued with themselves, with Mei Mei (main character), and with the author, while reading *I Hate English*. Lilly totally understood why Mei Mei did not want to speak English and overlaid her consciousness of losing her Spanish. She dialogued with Mei Mei, empathized with herself, situated herself with Mei Mei, and wanted to speak Chinese. Yanton's dialogue with Mei Mei was similar to Lilly's. It was a whole process with a high degree of dialogue. Transaction occurs when readers engaged their own interpretation of the text and delved into the story using a total picture of the story and the logic of their interpretation (Rosenblatt, 1978). Mei Mei, Lilly, and Yanton dialogued together based on having had the same lived-through experiences. This involves reflecting, revisiting, and resynthesizing the emerging meaning of the lived through experience.

Lilly transacted with Mei Mei's struggle, completely understood Mei Mei's resistance to speaking English, and connected her awareness of her Spanish loss. She was very much concerned about her Spanish skills. She said "I understand why Mei Mei

didn't want to speak English, she wanted to be Chinese not American" (P10; 579). She addressed the significant relationship between language and identity.

Jae-min opened different dialogical stances while reading *Woodcutter and Tiger Brother*. He liked reading the book, but he criticized it as well. He noted that the story was more sensible for him in Korean. Also, he already had a schema of the story and he supported Tiger's behaviors toward his mother. He identified strongly with the story and its message of Bong-Yang. However, he criticized the content of the story after reading, by referring to his moral evaluative system in spite of his identification with the content of the story.

The story included Woodcutter's trick to survive the danger of the tiger's attack; otherwise, Tiger would kill him. Tiger believed Woodcutter's lie, which meant they were not real brothers. Tiger brought dead animals for his mother, because he believed that she was his real mother. However, Jae-min mentioned that it is very problematic because of Woodcutter's lie. He said in his critical point of view of this story, "Yeah. And it's a book about don't play tricks. Yeah because the woodcutter played a trick on the tiger. It's still bad because tricking is kind of bad, because they might fall for it" (P14; 103: 109). His aesthetic stance moved toward a critical stance.

There is a degree of dialogue between the reader and the text (Bakhtin, 1986). Jae-min's and Kyle's reading stances are different when they read stories in different modes. These modes depended on text style, author's intention, and reader's purpose. Kyle used different reading stances while reading different stories by dialoging with himself and the two versions of Christopher Columbus. For example, he developed an efferent stance while reading *Follow the Dream*. He evaluated Christopher Columbus as

a great explorer who discovered America and recommended it as an informative story. In contrast, after reading *Encounter*, Kyle began wondering about Christopher Columbus's journey. Kyle identified strongly with the main character in the story. For example, he was surprised when the boy jumped into the water. The aesthetic stance occurred as he transferred himself to a boy in the story. He became scared while referring to himself as the boy, responding to the emergency when the antagonists were coming. He dialogued with a boy, and a boy became himself. This became a lived-through experience. The dialogue was established in an aesthetic stance. Kyle said, "They shouldn't come without permission" (P8; 610). His dialogue stance was shifted while reading the two versions of Christopher Columbus stories, supporting K. Goodman's (1984) ideas that meaning is created by the reader. However, his dialogue approached an understanding of the two accounts of a single historical event based on the authors' intentions. He was dialoguing while meaning making and he became a critical thinker.

### *Reading as a Thinking Process*

Kyle kept questioning as an inquiry as well as dialoguing during and after reading stories. Notably, his questions evolved while reading *Follow the Dream* and *Encounter*, as he compared and contrasted them. This reminded me of Freire's concepts of reading literacy. Freire dealt with transaction insightfully in political, historical, and cultural contexts. Following Freire's (1998) interpretation of transaction, a new concept of reading evolves. Participants in this study became recreators of the text while they read. According to Freire's interpretation of reading, there is a new composition between the reader and the writer in which the reader rewrites the text, making a determined effort not to betray the author's spirit. With political, historical, and cultural backgrounds different



from those of the first language learners, the ELLs were ready to become new composers throughout the reading process.

Kyle and Jae-min became rewriters through the reading process. K. Goodman (1984) advocated Freire's idea,

The answer is that the reader is constructing a text parallel and closely related to the published text. It becomes a different text for each reader. The reader's text involves inferences, reference, and co-references based on schema that the reader brings to the text. (Goodman, K., 1984, p. 97)

Kyle and Jae-min composed a new understanding of the story from their own political and cultural situations.

Kyle and Jae-min were interested in reading *Follow the Dream* because of the informative story of history and the map. However, they began questioning and dialoguing after reading *Encounter*. This could be evidence for understanding their cognitive development. Furthermore, they recommended both stories to their peers, emphasizing the importance of each one. One was a very informative story, and the other was a very well-written story for children. The ELLs became recomposers through reading stories. They made beautiful harmony and became meaningful composers, being aware of audiences as well as not betraying the author's spirit. The audiences could be by themselves or others when retelling stories.

This study reflected my and my children's journey as English language learners. This is a dialogue between the study and me. My two children came to the United States knowing neither the language nor the culture, as did Lilly and Yanton. While concluding the study and developing its results, it was natural for me to dialogue, reflect, and rethink on my children's language learning journey as ELLs in the United States. It has been a

truly honorable time for me to mirror and revisit my personal experience observing their second language process during the research period. Interestingly, most of the results are similar to my children's learning behaviors and second language literacy development process. Also, this process made me rethink my discipline for my children in regard to how I can support my children in becoming world persons, remembering how my and their identities are shifted through the process.

This view helped me think about social identity and second language learning. Norton (2000) defined social identity as, "how a person understands his or her relationship to the social world, how that relationship is constructed across time and space, and how the person understands possibilities for the future" (p. 5). The results of my study will deeply influence my position as a parent to children, and will make me a critical thinker for raising my children. We are positioned in multiple and often conflicting discourses in our daily interaction, but we actively play out our critical discourses to solve these conflicts. Discourse positions us, and we position our discourses. Our identities are recognized by others (Gee, 1999), but we also recognize our identities through the discourse process. Critical thinking practice is essential to create critical discourse, which is similar to Freire's (1970) *praxis*.

In order to implement *Critical pedagogy*, Giroux (1983) stated that we as educators "must provide the conditions that give students the opportunity to speak with their own voices, to authenticate their own experiences" (p. 203). McCaleb (1995) advocated for Giroux's (1983) critical pedagogy and explained how to create a transformative classroom for learners, stating, "In a transformative classroom, students are encouraged to develop their own voices in interaction with the voices of others and to

participate in the democracy of the classroom” (p. 13). The teacher needs to bring out students’ voices in the classroom and conduct harmony in learning and sharing. He or she should also be aware of how to facilitate a critical thinking practice for students, inviting family, community, and world to integrate their knowledge of the world. Learning to read and reading to learn are more than learning English as a second language. Learning a second language can be viewed as building a community for all; it may support ELLs and others in the classroom in thinking critically, and it excels at helping them to become good social beings, world people.

### Recommendations for Future Research

The ELLs’ reading strategies are incorporated into teaching. Second language instruction might be different from that of first language reading because the ELLs’ learning process differs from that of first language learners. The teaching of reading strategies should be integrated into the ELL teaching curriculum. A second recommendation is to perform a similar study in a low socioeconomic community because this study was conducted in a middle-to-high income range community. Comparing and contrasting between studies might present considerable dichotomies and similarities from these two communities and family backgrounds.

Ethnic identity might also be reexamined for ELLs based on cultural orientation. Especially, the process of the formation of Asian children’s ethnic identity might be reinvestigated in relation to family and community. The ethnocentric filter system might be reexamined in different ethnic groups. Methods to reduce the negative impact of this filter system might be investigated in detail.

## APPENDIX A

### CONFUCIANISM

The Confucian tradition had a long historical legacy in East Asia extending from China across Korea, Japan, and Vietnam. According to J. Lee (1998), Confucianism is “the practical moral guide and rite derived from the teaching of Confucius in the 6<sup>th</sup>–5<sup>th</sup> century BC, maintained both in philosophical and religious traditions. It is a norm for individual cultivation, social ethics and political philosophy” (p. 35). The influence of Confucianism had been significant in political thought and institutions, social relationships and ritual exchange, educational philosophy and moral teaching, cultural attitudes, and historical interpretation including the embeddedness of each person in concentric circles of relationships and ethical responsibilities, the importance of the family, the hierarchal social system where loyalties to elders and to teachers are critical, and the political order (Tucker, 2005).

Two important concepts in Confucian thought are *tao* (the way) and *te* (virtue, morality, power, and potency). The keynotes of Confucian ethics, “Jen” in Chinese and “Ye” in Korean, can be translated as *humanity*, *goodness*, and *benevolence*. There were nine ancient Chinese philosophical works handed down by Confucius (K’ung Fu-tuz: K’ung’s master, Latinized as Confucius) and his followers—five classics and four books. The five classics are the Book of Changes, the Book of History, the Book of Poetry, the Book of Rites, and the Spring and Autumn Annals. The four books—compilations of the sayings of Confucius and Mencius and of commentaries by followers on their teachings—are Analects (a collection of maxims by Confucius that form the basis of his

moral and political philosophy), The Great Learning and The Doctrine of the Mean (together containing some of Confucius's philosophical utterances arranged systematically with comments and expositions by his disciples), and the Book of Mencius (containing the teachings of one of Confucius's great followers).

In Korea, the representative Buddhist and Confucian thinkers ... utilized their independent intellectual abilities to elucidate religious ideas within the context of their unique historical reality. This intellectual attitude had formed the basis of Korea's ancient classical culture. From the Three kingdoms through the Choson period, countless Buddhist and Confucian thinkers have left their legacy of refined philosophical works as well as beautiful, practical examples of their search for human ideas. (ASIANINFO, 2005, p. 3)

According to Confucianism, it is supreme virtue to represent human qualities at their best and to be faithful to oneself and others. A major book in Neo-Confucianism (a new system of Confucian thought based on a mixture of Buddhist and Taoist elements by the Song dynasty, 960–1279) is called the Book of Self-Cultivation. Neo-Confucian ethics dealt with three cardinal principles, called *samgang* (in Korean): (a) loyalty to ruler; (b) filial piety to parents; (c) and faithfulness, chastity, and fidelity. In addition, five ethical norms called *oryun* (in Korean) dealt with human relationships: (a) righteousness and justice between rulers and ministers, (b) cordiality and closeness between parents and children, (c) distinction between husband and wife, (d) order between elders and juniors, and (e) trust between friends (Chan, 2002a). We still hear his voices around us.

- Do I regard myself as a possessor of wisdom? Far from it. But if even a simple peasant comes in all sincerity and asks me a question, I am ready to thrash the matter out, with all its pros and cons, to the very end.
- What I do not want others to do to me, I do not want to do to them.
- Those who, when young, show no respect to their elders achieve nothing worth mentioning when they grow up. And merely to live on, getting older and older, is to be a useless pest.

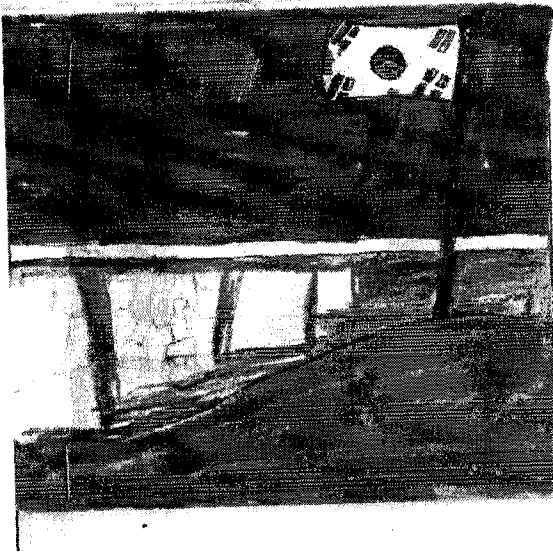
- To listen silently, to learn untiringly, and to teach others without being wearied--- that is just natural with me.
- Is it not pleasant to learn continually and put it into practice? Is it not delightful to have friends coming from afar? Is one not a gentleman if he does not feel hurt even though he is not recognized?

## APPENDIX B

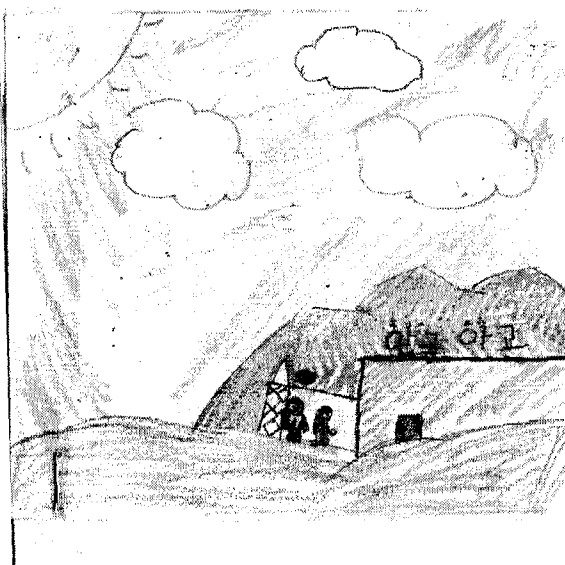
### STUDENT SAMPLES

Jae-min's reading response

*The Wall*



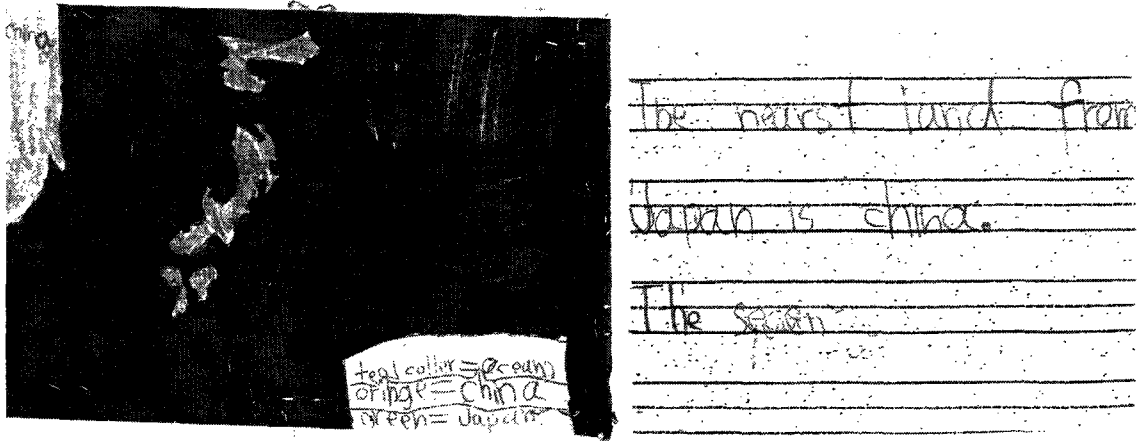
The sky is blue  
and the flag is  
standing on the s  
y so blue.



The kids go to  
school so they  
can learn.

Kyle's reading response

*The Wall*





Lilly's reading response

*The Wall*



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mexico escuela  
a escuela de mexico

Kyle's reading response

*Follow the dream*

FOLLOW the  
DREAM

He was lucky he got to  
the right place he wanted to

go.  
He even got what he wanted.

And my favorite part was  
that he then got AMERICA  
was JAPAN.

Kyle's reading response

*Encounter*

ENCOUNTER

In this book I wondered  
why they took the Americans.  
I thought the pictures were  
famous.

I wish I could draw pictures  
like that too.

Lilly's reading response

*Hiroko Makes the Team*

Name \_\_\_\_\_ Date 5-20-04

Book Title Hiroko makes the team



**Reader Response**



Answer the questions below in complete sentences.

1. What is your favorite part of the book? Why?

When the race.

2. Are there parts you don't like? What are they?

When the brother said she  
couldn't win the race.

3. Write your favorite sentence.

Toshi and his friends came to  
see what Hiroko was doing.

4. Who is your favorite character in this book? Why?

Hiroko

5. What did you learn from this book?

Not to hurt other people's  
feelings.

Level 9 • Writing



Level 9

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